

Soulstream

Return of the Witchbreed

Book II

GEO IVERY

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Prologue to Book 3

One Year Later

Prologue

THE VOTE

Nothing could have prepared us for that day. The decision was made so fast, and all of the covens were expecting us to fail. I tell this not as a story by the campfire, but as a true event. My name is Kaery, and I was as much to blame as any Mancers who was responsible for the fate of the world. This is what happened so long ago. This is what started Earth's first war.

It was a beautiful day, like every day that came before it in Pangaea. The world was new and full of possibility. Humans lived among Supernaturals as they belonged. Mancers ruled both factions. Witchbreed were the sages and teachers of all. My coven was a new coven, and we were chastised every turn we took for our former allegiances to the covens we broke off from.

"I can't do this anymore, Kaery," Ewm said frantically to his audience of eight, "I have to go back to my coven or they will curse you all, and I can't have that. Anshar of all people was happy we got chosen, and he's just waiting for us to fail miserably. Did you see that look in his eye? I'm blind, and even I saw it!"

His blood-red eyes were very peculiar. He was blind to most things that were not Supernatural or Magickal by nature. His black hair was always kept neat and shorter than that of the other boys, even though the style was to wear it slightly longer. Ewm paced back and forth in his ornate robes with his large book of spells not too far from his reach.

Kaery was getting ready to speak when she was interrupted by Ahlina. Of all the people on the planet, these were the ones she trusted with her life. Ahlina had been Kaery's best friend since the day she saved her from being eaten by a prehistoric beast. Ahlina was a wild nature girl with exotic green eyes and grand thoughts of unifying all of the covens, like she had done with her best friends.

"You don't think we all want to just call it quits and go the easy route?," Ahlina asked Ewm directly, "We can go back to being belittled within a large coven instead of being bullied by the ones much older than ours. We have proven ourselves time and again that, with our combined Magicks, we can do wonderful things, have we not?"

“Well, yes. But—” Ewm was interrupted by Ahlina’s lecture.

“And we have stood together against Battle covens that were out to teach us ‘lessons on spellcrafts.’ We’ve defeated them all every time, have we not?”

“Yes, barely a couple times. But—”

“And we have broken the oaths that we pledged to the covens we were born into, so that we can form our own sanctuary. We are a coven that even the Grand Mancers have noticed. Today they made a decision, charging our Coven with the creation of the most amazing spell the world has ever known. Not too many Witchbreed get this opportunity. This is what we’ve dreamt of: recognition. I say we should take it.” Ahlina smiled righteously as she looked over her unique friends for approval.

Khenebu was from a coven of Witchbreed that had mastered the Necromantech Spellcrafts. These monks mimicked powerful dark Magicks that they saw the most powerful Necromancers and Technomancers use. They also used abilities from other planes of existence, which they believed would benefit the world at large. Because their methods were clouded by mystery like all other covens, Khenebu chose to be the first Witchbreed to break away and expose many of their secrets.

“Though I agree with both sides, I would like to say my piece,” Khenebu said, “Ewm is right, assuming it is easier to crawl back to our original covens, for they would protect the secrets they have built their very foundations upon. To answer your question, Ewm, yes, I saw that exact look in Anshar’s eyes, and I don’t trust it at all.”

Ewm smiled, nervously awaiting the continuation of Khenebu’s diplomatic speech.

“Ahlina is correct in assuming the sanctuary and eternal bond which we have cast upon each other as the new Coven of Unity within the Great Circle,” Khenebu said, “There are twelve other covens out there that have time and again wished for us to fall flat on our faces. It is our perfect love and perfect trust that keep us victorious.”

Ahlina smiled at Khenebu’s agreeing words, awaiting the climax of his speech.

“I, however, believe this spell is disgustingly wrong!,” he said, “It is a blasphemy against the balance of things and has nothing to do with our integrity as users of Magick or our bond as a coven. It has to do with our role on this planet. To

give humans our powers would be to go against everything we have been taught as Witchbreed, keepers of the planetary balance.” Khenebu concluded with resolve, calmly leaving the speaker’s circle to sit next to his beloved Kaery.

Ewm couldn’t help but agree with Khenebu, who seemed to be correct most of the time, even though he was the least outspoken of the coven.

“I support Khenebu,” Ewm said, “I mean, I understand that no one’s ever attempted such a spell before, so I get that it’s a big deal. However, a spell of ultimate Enlightenment would be catastrophic for those who have no control, don’t you think? Cause and effect to Gaia would be devastating.”

The youngest of the coven said this so matter-of-factly that the others took a moment to ponder.

“No I don’t think it would,” Scape said, siding with Ahlina, “Have you seen how many Witchbreed inhabit the planet and how many Mancers control the Armies of Jreamers? We all have, and I think we’ll have it under control.”

The Shaman’s low-cut robes exposed an ever-changing mural of tattoos that twisted and swirled over his body, giving him an air of mysticism as he appeared in the center of the speaker’s circle.

“My old coven could control the very elements themselves, even morphing into them at will. Though we don’t generally try to control the fate of the world, preferring to live peacefully as nature intended, we are still hypocrites. We have altered the elements on this planet so that the weather is always beautiful for humans and Supernaturals alike. We have purified the air and water to make the planet habitable for everyone. We have provided them with fire and metal so they might invent and evolve. What is another alteration in the planet’s fate?”

Scape sat down next to Ahlina. His handsome face accompanied his objective words perfectly.

Kaery stood up to enter the speaker’s circle, and all went silent.

“We have argued this point many a night,” she said, “As a matter of fact, it was a split decision even when we heard such a spell was going to be demanded of the Wicasht by the Mancer years ago. One thing we will not do is cast a spell before considering the repercussions. I love you all and will always love you until the end of time, no matter the outcome. We are to perform a task that will, as Scape so eloquently said, alter the planet’s fate. I will say this: We are on this planet to serve the greater good. We all have the ability to see the code of Magick that is ever-confusing and ever-amazing. We chose to be the readers of that code,

and with the responsibility of deciphering it, we also chose to teach others the meaning of Magick. This includes our masters and mistresses, the Mancer.”

Kaery looked each member of her coven in the eyes as she continued to speak while walking around the hall.

“Ewm, you came from a coven that has been nicknamed the Warlocks. They practice destructive and offensive Magicks as if our planet were on the cusp of war.

This coven practices malevolent curses that cast fear into the hearts of most, but how can we fear an intellectual so committed to what’s right?” Kaery petted the youngster on his head, assuring him that she was not being judgmental.

“Ahlina, you come from a coven known for disrupting the physics of a world that thrives on order. The other covens have nicknamed you the Chaos Kids for that very reason. We here embrace your chaotic nature and welcome you with open arms.” Kaery smiled at Ahlina from across the sacred hall.

“Khenebu, you left a misunderstood coven nicknamed the Gore-hounds, who revel in the darker side of the universe, playing with the dead and unknown like children play with dolls. Yet in our midst, you are one of the wisest and most innovative beings the planet has ever seen. Because you had the courage to leave your coven first, we have gained the strength to follow suit.” Kaery looked across the hall, her eyes falling on the white hair, pale skin and timid demeanor of Never, who lowered his head in self-conscious embarrassment .

“Never, you left a coven of Wyrms worshippers also known as the Dragons, the most feared Dehmn beasts of all realms, yet you are one of the gentlest spirits to walk the earth, your kindness rivaled only by that of Scape.” Kaery turned to Scape and brushed his hair from his eyes.

“Scape, your spirit is as wondrous and free as the elements your old coven mastered. However, people still label them as Beasts because they are so close to nature.” Kaery noticed Scape wince as she uttered the derogatory name.

“I’m sorry for the crass words, but I must remind you all for the sake of the inevitable vote.”

“Heaven and Star come from twin sister covens that split into two completely different entities. Heaven’s coven preferred the company of the Fae to that of their own kind, which resulted in the nickname Faerykin. Star’s coven preferred their own looks and solitude to the world at large, earning the title of The

Misunderstood Bitches.” Kaery closed her eyes, trying not to grow enraged at the stupidity of these stereotypes and prejudices.

“Last, but not least, Ssiah, oh beautiful celestial girl! Coming from a coven of Aenjelhn who were born with the ability to summon their own relatives and protectors, who lost their founder in a war with the Dehmn, they have been called the Orphans. This name is not very becoming for such a pure heart, and it was meant to break your spirit.” Kaery walked over to Ssiah and held her hand, the delicate girl’s blond locks falling as she turned her gaze to the ground.

“I myself have left the first Witchbreed coven to ever grace Earth, the Anu, who have been nicknamed the Banshees for the truth we tell. It’s not usually something people want to hear, so they compare us to creatures from another realm whose voices are capable of making innocent listeners die of madness.”

Kaery looked around the room, confident that the honest critique of her own ex-coven had gained everyone’s attention.

“So you all see this is not a matter of where we come from, but where we’re going. Blue and Sky have chosen us over the most powerful Witchbreed on the planet to perform a spell that the Mancers believe will help them reign. They are our Kings and Queens, and it is our sacred duty to follow their orders. We have ignored our duties before, and we can choose to do so now, but it is up to you all to vote on the fate of the planet tonight and not turn back. For if we decide this night to conjure a spell of this magnitude, we will have to take ownership of it.” After a careful look at her coven and quiet understanding of the severity of this decision, Kaery broke the silence with a thunderous voice. “It is time to vote.”

Chapter 1

HEAVEN SENT

My Spellcraft was perfected through the song and dance of many lifetimes. I found that I was able to look into the depths of the Soulstream and use enchanting Magick. Through movement, I can change the environment itself, and with song, I can open portals in time and space, summoning ancient supernatural beings and harnessing their abilities. I am Heaven, and I belong to the Coven of Unity.

Ever since I was a young girl, I've known I was a Wicasht. For some reason, our beautiful name was butchered into an aberration that even the Supernaturals use: Witchbreed. I guess it means the same thing through rough translation, but it still makes me cringe. I love my coven, even though I've yet to meet them in this lifetime.

I know that sounds weird, but I've dreamt of them my entire life. I still remember the first dream I ever had of them. We all were in Pangaea and having an amazing time, laughing. It was a bright sunny day, and we all had just finished swimming when the world changed. Well, all of us but Never and Star, who sat on the bank, and Khenebu, who was nowhere to be found. Six of us were splashing around that day so long ago.

(Pangaea: 250,000,000 B.C.E.)

Heaven swam through the clear lake as if she were one of the primitive life forms that dwelled in the depths of the New World's magnificent oceans. Her bright purple hair gracefully floated around her chocolate skin in long strands that looked as if they were part of the blue water itself. They seemed to change color with every inch she swam toward her friends. Heaven was an extraordinary specimen as Gauntlets would often tell her.

She could use powers from other dimensions as if she were actually present in them. The Fae's dimension was where she manipulated Magick, and it was marvelous. By accessing this dimension, she could alter her personal attributes on planet earth with every movement she exerted, such as the color of her body or

hair. Most of the time, she used this power in friendly games of stealth. This was one of those games, and she was positive that no one would be able to see her.

She watched her friends floating on the surface of the lake as if they were using Magick, though she could tell that they weren't. They were all simply relaxing in the sun and talking. Kaery swam on the surface, not knowing that Heaven was but a few feet below, watching her mischievously.

Kaery looked about at her friends and wondered what new mysteries this world called Earth would have in store for them in the many years to come. It just seemed so perfect. In the midst of deep thought, she looked at her friend Ahlina and sensed an aura of anxiety. Scape, Heaven and Ahlina had always been the playful and unpredictable ones in the coven. Kaery had watched them play games of stealth and Spellcraft for many hours at a time, all while amusing the younger Ewm and Ssiah, who currently liked to swim closer to the shore. With Ahlina's anxiousness as well as Scape and Heaven's absence, Kaery knew that a game of stealth had already started. She was excited to see how this would play out as the Witchbreed attempted to catch each other off guard.

Never was a quiet man and didn't like water, so he would sit this game out, but he looked forward to the upcoming flight and combat games. He was exceptionally cunning and introverted, yet still very competitive, and knew that Kaery's enforcement of the games would benefit each Witchbreed when the time came to use their powers on the fly. This day, he sat not too far from where Star was sunbathing.

"Why must they play these idiotic games with their Spellcrafts?" Star asked, not bothering to make eye contact while tanning, "You'd think they were human or something."

Her glossy lips and milky skin gleamed as the sun rolled over them flawlessly. She flipped her silky red locks and turned over to let the sun warm her back.

Kaery overheard Star's complaint while floating on the surface of the water. She knew the Witchbreed were just having fun practicing their Spellcrafts with each other and dismissed the cynical words. Maybe Ahlina was just worried about the backlash of the ex-covens, who now despised them all for divulging secrets that were ten thousand years old.

"Is something on your mind, Ahlina?"

Just as Kaery finished her question, Ahlina suddenly yelped and slipped into the water as if something were pulling her under. Kaery yelped almost instinctively and began to propel her naked body toward the shore. Ewm and Ssiah started laughing, as they knew the game had begun. According to their ever-changing rules, Ahlina had lost because she cried out when she was taken by surprise.

Khenebu must have been at the Temples, probably lost in study or still in the midst of diplomatic discussion, but Scape was nowhere to be found. He had not come to the lake with them, so Kaery assumed that Heaven was the culprit who pulled Ahlina under the water. She almost stopped swimming toward Ewm and Ssiah when she heard a high-pitched noise.

Heaven was screaming as she flew through the air and landed on the shore with incredible grace despite her surprise. Her violet hair splashed the already annoyed Star, who responded with an irritable groan. Overwhelmed by his own astonishment, Never went to aid Heaven.

“Are you alright, Heaven?” Never asked as he looked into her purple eyes and marveled at her brown skin, noticing that she was battered from the high fall. Heaven simply laughed and smiled playfully.

“I’m ok, Never,” she said, “but you’re sweet. They caught me off guard.”

Heaven’s voice was among the planet’s most beautiful sounds. Consisting of three distinct vocal tones at once, each with its own frequency, her singing was music to anyone’s ears. Never smiled every time he heard it.

“They?” asked Never, looking over the still waters, confused that Kaery, Ewm and Ssiah were the only Witchbreed in sight.

The waters began to swirl inward, forming a whirlpool. The currents pushed and pulled at the shores. Kaery pulled Ewm and Ssiah safely to shore as Star stood up in protest. Ssiah’s wet blond ringlets covered her hazel eyes as she ran onto shore while looking over her shoulder, giggling. Ewm squeezed Kaery’s hand tight as he watched the event.

“I’m not amused,” Star said, pausing mid-sentence as she walked toward the cyclone of water.

Ahlina started to emerge from the center with a proud grin.

“We *so* caught Heaven trying to lurk on us.”

She was walking across the water toward shore while Scape materialized from the passing waves. His flesh formed from the liquid, its sacred markings a moving tapestry as he stepped comfortably up to Ahlina. The pair walked across

the top of the water, pointing and laughing at Heaven on the shore. When they reached the warm sand, Never put his arm around Heaven as he stared at the show of Scape's new Shapeshifting Spellcraft. It was astonishing to see him shift from one elemental to the next, from fire to water, from wind to earth.

"It's ok, Heaven, you always win anyway—" Never's words were cut short when he looked down to see that his arm was wrapped around a large fish with seaweed hair. He spun around to see Ahlina and Scape on the water, high-fiving each other a little too prematurely, Heaven standing behind them, blowing a kiss toward shore. A double dropkick launched them into the air, their bodies flailing about until they landed directly on top of Star.

Heaven flipped into the air and performed a back handspring off of the water as if it were solid ground and stood victorious on the surface of the lake. Her hair was as long as she was tall, draped over her body like cascading water.

"You all fell for a simple illusion. By the way, nice new Spellcraft, Scape."

Heaven floated toward the banks and helped her friends up, relieving Star of the excess weight.

Ewm let go of Kaery's hand and brushed his black hair out of his crimson eyes. His pale skin showed goose bumps, either from lack of warmth or from the excitement of the battle itself; either way, he was entertained as always.

"That was absolutely impeccable," Ewm said, "Two new Spellcrafts and Ahlina acting like a damsel in distress!"

"I don't know why you're so excited," Ssiah said, "I was terrified when Heaven flew out of the water. How did you do that, Heaven?"

Ssiah helped Star out of the sand, who slapped the girl's hand hard enough for it to sting.

"I can help myself up." Star hopped to her feet, ready to berate her insubordinate friends.

Kaery looked past Star and saw Khenebu riding toward the lake on one of his coven's technologically advanced contraptions. It was made entirely of planetary minerals, and it flew at speeds that rivaled those of the most advanced flying Spellcrafts. As he got closer, Star almost forgot why she was upset, gazing up at the machine fueled by Magick.

"I'm sorry to intrude on your games," Khenebu said, "I bring dire news. The Mancers are making a decision as to which coven will perform the Spell of Enlightenment."

The friends looked at each other with a new level of understanding that relieved all ill will and brought the realization that the games were over. They scrambled to retrieve their robes as one by one, they all climbed into Khenebu's flyer and traveled toward the pyramids in the distance with a mix of anxiety and awe.

*

(Present-Day)

Heaven woke from the dream and gazed into the sky at the stars and the moon in a moment of clarity.

"I have to find my coven."

*

Scape sat up from a good night's sleep, gasping a single word: "Heaven!"

Chapter 2

ANSWERS

Gemini, a tall dark tower of a man, stood near the Port Rune and watched the glowing mark of Magick as it transported his students to this safe haven, the forbidden city of Zalomoni. As the wind blew his long black hair and charcoal cloak around him like living shadow, he pondered his next move in this struggle against Neflym and OZONE. He knew there would be consequences for bringing so many of the Supernaturals to his Pagoda, and it was surely compromised, but in his mind, the sacrifice was worth it. OZONE was definitely setting up an ambush for the children, but they hadn't anticipated the use of this Port Rune. Gemini knew he was one step ahead, as they had yet to discover countless other Port Runes that could be accessed for inter-dimensional travel.

There was a small window to save the children, but enough time to make OZONE believe they had won some glorious battle this evening. In actuality, Gemini got more than he once expected with the arrival of Juno, the assassin and OZONE double Agent who tracked down a lover from another lifetime, the Neuromancer, Ninala. A new Mancer and a most intriguing one, Surge-Overload, who was instrumental in saving many Supernaturals, never really saw herself on the run from the threatening organization, but here she was coming through the portal. Finally there was Maia, the coy oracle whom Gemini personally escorted from a home where she was going to be studied then murdered after manipulation at the hands of OZONE.

The moment of Blue's realization that Sky wasn't going to come through the portal was what Gemini braced himself for. He knew that Sky would have to go back to Braintech; her father would stop tracking them as long as he had his daughter back. According to Maia's visions, it was the only way to get OZONE off of their trail once and for all.

Blue sat on a stone awaiting his friends. He saw Maia trying to regain her composure, but Nina and Surge-Overload seemed to be having the hardest time. He remembered the feeling when he was first teleported here. It seemed like several days ago that he traveled to this place for the first time, a city that looked

like it had been uninhabited for millions of years. Though it had only been a matter of hours since his first visit, Blue struggled to place the experience in relation to other recent memories. After arriving in Zalomoni for the first time and engaging in a long meeting with Gemini, Jayde and Juno about betrayal, love, responsibility and destiny, Blue sort of checked out as the conversation was too deep for him. Despite losing track of time, he was able to gather that, in a previous lifetime, Juno went AWOL after Nina's death in Egypt, slaying countless Supernaturals out of blind vengeance. Apparently, Nina and Juno had been watching each other die for many lifetimes already. Something about this most recent death of her lover had made Juno snap, and she had been known as a cruel assassin of Mancers, Witchbreed and Jreamers ever since. Jayde didn't like Juno at all. Gemini was playing peacekeeper because if Jayde killed Juno, then Nina wouldn't have a chance to use her full potential...or something like that.

Blue was eager to see his friends again and stirred in his seat. He finally stood up and walked over to Surge-Overload. "You'll be ok, little girl. The Port makes everyone feel like they're being torn apart, but your body gets used to it eventually. You do look kind of frail though, even by human standards."

He looked over to Gemini and asked, "What's wrong with her?"

Gemini calmly walked over to Surge-Overload and placed his dark hand on her pale forehead.

"Her body isn't used to the shock of Port Rune traveling. We expect everyone to be sick the first few times, and yes, Surge-Overload looks a bit sicker than most, but this is completely normal. Your body has been trained by Jayde to endure such pains as these and regenerate a lot faster than the rest. Surge-Overload, however, has not experienced such physical stress before. She will recover in due time."

"Where is Sky?" Blue looked around as if he'd somehow missed her high maintenance, fashionably late entrance.

"She will not be joining us tonight," Gemini flatly stated as he signaled for Jayde to come take Surge to a bed.

"Wait, I think I heard you wrong. Sky *won't* be joining us?" Blue screamed. He watched Juno nurse Nina to a smile and Maia sit up after a long cough.

"That is correct, Blue. OZONE has her."

"Oh, no. Oh god, no. Okay, we can save her. I'll go back through the Port Rune and—"

“You'll do no such thing. The Pagoda is no more. She will be saved another day when it is her time.”

“That's all wrong! Sky needs me! She saved my life!” Blue protested his mentor's decision-making for the first time. He knew it was like talking to a marble wall, so he stopped.

Jayde walked over to the small teenaged girl and picked her up as easily as a baby.

“I rarely question your judgment, Gemini, but I am with Blue. Why here and why now?” Jayde shot Juno a glance that could kill.

“You know how I feel about her and the Forbidden City, Zalomoni.”

Gemini looked into the shining emeralds that were Jayde's eyes before turning his attention to the dark sapphires that were Blue's.

“You will have your answers soon enough. Just trust me.”

Blue couldn't take any more bad news and ran into the city before anyone could see the tears streaming down his face. He was frustrated for feeling so helpless in this game of cat and mouse. The lack of control he held over his own destiny infuriated him so much that he just ran as fast as his Supernatural speed would carry him, and he didn't stop.

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“I think we have all of the answers we were looking for, Commander in Chief,” Grin said, broadly showing his broken yellow teeth. “The girl's memories, as hard as they were to pry from her head, were validated. All of the fugitives were killed in Japan. She will have no memory of the last few weeks as if they never existed, thanks to Post-Traumatic Amnesic Response.”

“You'd better be right, Grin, or this is the end of your career!” The Commander stormed out of the room with a smirk before turning to his assistant with a hardened scowl. “Call the leaders and give them an answer! Tell them mission complete.”

Grin slicked his greasy hair back and bent forward so that his face hovered over Sky's sleeping body in creepy observation. "So, you all had a mentor named Gemini," he whispered, "an ancient immortal. I'd love to meet someone like that and pick his brain." His phlegmy laugh was so alarming, the Commander peeked into the room to make sure Sky was still in one piece.

"Return the girl to her father and keep a close eye on her. According to you, she has no memories, never had powers to begin with, and was only being used for ransom purposes because of her father's association with the company, so she's harmless. Besides, we need that crackpot of an inventor to keep making our weapons. Don't think about touching her. Send his precious daughter back to him under surveillance. Am I understood?"

"Sir! Yes Sir!"

Chapter 3

ROLE CALL

Gemini is the self-proclaimed advisor to the powers that be. In this life, it happens to be a group of misfit Mancer kids and their old friends, the Coven of Unity. He is a Duomancer, an elite Supernatural with unknown powers of both destruction and creation who can split his form into two separate beings. He is a mastermind with an agenda that has yet to be uncovered, though his allies seem to trust him implicitly. He is as old as Planet Earth itself.

Jayde is the right hand enforcer of Gemini. Her long black hair, milky Asian skin and green eyes only distract her enemies. She is one of the most dangerous beings to ever walk the earth. Once revered as the Goddess of Martial Arts and Grace, Jayde is a Metamancer, a Supernatural with control over every cell in her body. She taught the world the very first forms of martial arts, now called the Lost Arts. Currently, Jayde must rethink the vows of peace she took in Zalomoni as the war to save the world approaches.

Blue is a Soulstreamancer, also known as a Bad Boy and high school drop-out who killed his family by accident when his powers were unlocked. Now he is being trained by Gemini for a vital role in the fight against OZONE, though he doesn't know exactly what this role will be. His abilities include hyper speed, regeneration, and immortality as well as the unique power to open the Soulstream. He finds out through memories and meditation that he is one of the gods responsible for the destructive world today and the creation of OZONE itself.

Maia is the intelligent home-schooled girl from a religious family. Through her worst nightmares, she has come to understand her identity as the only Celestiamancer, but the very one responsible for the disappearance of an entire civilization. She has been working closely with Gemini, developing her psychic and oracular abilities, which include telepathy, scrying, healing and clairvoyance. While her powers have yet to show any limitations, Maia suffers from self-doubt

like many other sixteen-year-olds. She possesses a mysterious metaphysical connection to blood that she has yet to understand, but it has served as one of her greatest strengths.

Sky is the spoiled and beautiful fashion icon born into a life where there is no limit to luxury. Her Jewish father is the founder of the most technologically advanced company in the world, and her African supermodel mother is the heiress to a throne of diamonds. Sky has found out that she is a Spheromancer who can see in all directions at once while controlling anything within the biosphere she creates, including weather, sound, gravity, time, space and health. However, she doesn't believe her identity as a Supernatural, which stunts her progress. Recently, after understanding her culpability for the fragile state of the world today, she has been suffering from Post-Traumatic Amnesic Response. She believes she was kidnapped by an unknown terrorist organization and has subsequently pushed the memories out of her head in order to live a normal life again.

Kaery is the sixteen-year-old, golden-eyed all-American girl next door. She transferred from New York to San Francisco where she met the people she now considers her best friends. Recently, she and her friends were faced with danger as they fled a night club and found themselves in a Japanese Pagoda where they all discovered their identities as Supernaturals. Kaery has the ability to see, hear and speak the truth, no matter the circumstances. She is also a Witchbreed with oracular powers very similar to Maia's, as well as immunity to Magick. Her dreams have revealed that Blue was her lover in previous lifetimes.

Star is one of Kaery's best friends and a recent addition to the narcissists of the world. She found out she is a Witchbreed with the ability to change her appearance and that of anyone near her for a temporary amount of time with Glamour Magick. Her six-foot frame and red hair stand out as she stomps around like her idol, Sky. She is a member of the Coven of Unity, though she doesn't seem to be concerned with the war between Supernaturals and OZONE. Currently, she is far more obsessed with Sky's appearance and the latest fashion trends than she is with the wellbeing of the planet.

Crux is a young Magnemancer and Gypsy from the Petsha family. He was born into a life of mystery and intrigue, but it all came to an end when his recently murdered uncle, Loiza, saved him from being sacrificed by their own people before his thirteenth birthday. He has been saved by Blue and well-trained by Jayde, but now that he is squatting at Star's house, he doesn't know what to do next. One thing he knows for sure is that all four Gypsy families, including the Shandor bloodline of Vampyl, are hunting him down in order to fulfill an ancient prophesy. He has refined his powers to control the density, velocity and momentum of small bits of matter. He can essentially turn any minute object into a missile of deadly force, and with his limited control of probability, he can strike targets that would otherwise be impossible to hit. With his unique combination of powers, he seems extremely lucky to be surviving the war that is in his midst.

Ahlina is the sixteen-year-old punk rock computer hacker, best friend of Kaery, Scape and Star. She too has learned of her identity as a Witchbreed and one of the nine members of the Coven of Unity, though she doesn't yet know what kind of powers she possesses. All of her regained memories are full of adventure, martial arts, explosions and mayhem. She has dreamt of Jayde and the other kids in previous lifetimes for as long as she can remember.

Scape is a seventeen-year-old member of the Coven of Unity and a close friend of Kaery, Star and Ahlina. He has been regaining his memories of other lifetimes in which he was a powerful Druid and Elementalist, serving the gods as a mentor and peacekeeper. Currently in high school, he takes his job as Student-Faculty Welcoming Committee President very seriously. His dreams are so vivid that he is reluctant to share them with his friends.

Surge-Overload is a fourteen-year-old Technomancer with unique and unparalleled powers over any and all technological devices. The strongest Technomancer to ever live, she has tormented the secret society that currently rules most of the planet, OZONE. She recently stole a laundry list of their files, including conceptual designs for technological advancements as well as her favorite hack, a complete list of OZONE Agents and their information. When she found her parents and uncle on this roster, her world came crashing down, and OZONE tried to exterminate her. After her rescue by the Supernaturals, she is now

with Gemini and his followers, learning how to use her abilities properly in order to fight OZONE once and for all.

Guardian is the world's number one secret agent and assassin for OZONE. His high marks have time and again validated his status and title. Demonstrating the prowess of his enhanced strength, catlike agility, predatory stealth, Olympic speed and unparalleled marksmanship, Guardian has secured his position as the most deadly human being on the planet. This unique skillset supported his undying faith in patriotic American life until OZONE sent him on a mission to kill an innocent Supernatural, Isja, which caused him to question his employer for the first time. It happened once again when they sent him to kill the international terrorist threat, Surge-Overload, who turned out to be his niece. Guardian has been hiding his own secret from everyone, including OZONE, his identity as a Jreamer capable of adopting a limited range of supernatural abilities from each victim he eliminates.

Juno is the deceptively beautiful super assassin who earned her title as the second most deadly agent in the world until she went rogue on OZONE. Having murdered countless Supernaturals to appease OZONE in previous lifetimes, she is now trying to redeem herself in the eyes of Jayde and Gemini. She is a Witchbreed who concealed her true identity from her employers while spending countless years in search of Nina. Now that she has found her Mancer lover, she will do her best to help Nina harness her supernatural abilities to fight against the threat no one understands quite as well as she does, OZONE. She has mastered her Spellcrafts to mimic the natural abilities of a Jreamer almost identically.

Nina is the innocently naïve Mancer in the group thus far with the power to control the emotions of others. Being a Neuromancer comes with an appropriate cost, as she barely has any control over such an ambiguous power. She doesn't know why she seems to be the only one who trusts Juno, but she does, and that is something she will have to explore in the future. She is currently a refugee living in Zalomoni with other the other kids who escaped an OZONE assassination.

Ewm, pronounced 'Oh-M,' is the youngest member of the Coven of Unity. He is an extremely intelligent nine-year-old with a knack for anything Magickal. He was born blind, but with his enlightenment came a blessing: anything Magickal he can

see and understand, never forgetting a Rune or other entity created by or blessed with Magick. His black hair and red eyes are slightly creepy in contrast to his pale skin, and he is obsessed with any Magickal tactic that is offensive in nature.

Ssiah is Ewm's twin and elder sister by one minute and thirty seconds. Her parents adopted her because she was the loveliest looking baby with beautiful hazel eyes. She almost seemed like an angel, and this wasn't too far from the truth. She is a member of the Coven of Unity who can read the secret language of the Aenjelhn, or as humans call them, angels. She has been able to summon and control powerful Aenjelhn throughout many lifetimes.

Khenebu is a Witchbreed member of the Coven of Unity who has learned the Necromantic Arts as well as the Quantum Shadow Arts. He lived in Egypt until he accidentally released a creature that led him to San Francisco where he meets Kaery, Ahlina, Star, Never and Scape. This mysterious teenager is a lot smarter than he lets on, as he has been enlightened since his fifteenth birthday.

Never is a part of the Equality Program as a low income student at the same prep school that Scape, Ahlina, Star and Kaery attend. He is teased and ignored by most of the students in the prestigious school until he finds out that he is a member of the Coven of Unity. He is able to morph into a dragon of epic proportions and use Dragon Magick.

Heaven is one of the nine members of the coven of Unity who can use the powers of the Fae to control her own physical shape as well as the conditions of the environment in close proximity. Her extraordinary urge to be with the Coven of Unity caused her to flee her utopia, Ballade, the eighth continent and homeland of the Faeries. She was washed up along the coast of Europe where she has been held captive by the Shandor, a bloodline of Vampyl Gypsy assassins and reality shifters.

Prince Lord Ka is the ancient King of the most deadly Vampyl on the planet, including the Shandor, and also one of the masterminds who rule OZONE. His dark power and presence is felt and feared among the shadows across the planet.

Chass is the Vampyl Prince and Executioner for none other than Prince Lord Ka as well as leader of the Gypsy family known as the Shandor. His assassin skills are known throughout the world, and his equally charismatic personality serves him well. This relentless predator has been sent on many missions, and his current objective is to find and eliminate the Mancer Crux. After intercepting the boy's whereabouts, Chass almost met his own death when he clashed with Mancers he thought had long been dead, Blue and Sky. Among his most trusted Shandor Generals are Sasha, Emilian, Jilian and Poet.

Deme-God is the human Technomage and self-proclaimed ultimate hacker. This teenager was adopted by OZONE at an early age and now spends his time hunting down terrorists and other threats to the organization. His most recent triumph was the alleged murder of his Nemesis, Surge-Overload. He is a Broken Human with the power to use Magick over the ether as well as technology itself with specialized Spellcrafts and rituals. He leads a surprisingly terrifying group of Technomages, a recent phenomenon in Supernatural society.

Neflym is one of the masterminds behind OZONE. He is a timeless Immortal with unimaginable battle prowess. His schemes are said to be the very ones that caused OZONE to emerge in the first place. For countless millenniums, he has been lurking in the shadows, hunting any Supernaturals he deems a threat.

Grin is a Broken Human known as a Psiel. His abilities to read minds, cause hallucinations and melt brainwaves are frightening to humans and deadly to Supernaturals as he tracks and hunts both populations for the glory of OZONE. A devout elite Agent and equally creepy partner to Guardian, Grin stops at nothing to fulfill his objectives. His latest assignment is to observe Sky under the guise of a bodyguard.

Narles was one of OZONE's rising stars until he recently botched a mission, losing all of his limbs in an explosion. His heart is devoted to the glory of OZONE, and he wishes for nothing more than to be Guardian's equal. His military background and well-rounded skills on the battlefield have won him many awards, and he considers himself OZONE's ultimate soldier. With his Christian worldview,

he hunts down anyone and anything to appease his Commanders in the name of Christ.

Loiza is the uncle of Crux and a Gypsy assassin from the Petsha clan. His abilities to cleave through any known target brought him notoriety from all four Gypsy families. Recently he was killed by his cousin, Chass Shandor, while trying to protect Crux.

Reynolds and Lisa are the parents of Surge-Overload and covert spies for OZONE. This power couple lays claim to master's degrees, PhD's and hours of rigorous training as well as diverse experience in the field, making them a partnership to beat. They take their job seriously and to this day, don't know that their daughter, Cindy, is actually Surge-Overload. They continue to work their hardest to complete any mission set before them or die trying, according to the OZONE creed.

Samuel Bradford is the CEO and founder of the world's most technologically advanced empire, Braintech, which manufactures and creates everything from cell phones to rockets. Having believed there was no task too difficult for him to accomplish until his daughter Sky came along, his goal is to keep her safe. He is a genius from a long line of Jewish scientists. His skills have been commissioned by corporations all over the world, including OZONE, to develop equipment and weapons that will destroy Supernatural threats.

Orchid Bradford is the supermodel and heiress to the largest diamond mines in Africa who married Samuel Bradford and bore their child, Sky. She has taught her daughter that etiquette, fame, style, glamour and luxury are not just gifts, but ways of life. Ruling her household with an iron fist, this savvy business woman loves to be underestimated.

Aiel is the thirteen-year-old who, through Immaculate Conception, bore a child named Isja. She thinks that the baby is dead, but he has actually been given to another family who will raise him as their own. Aiel feels deep in her heart that Isja is still alive, but she doesn't have the proof just yet.

Isja is the only Mancer with power over Groves and sanctuaries. He is that baby born into a world of war time and again, yet he is always raised to be peaceful. He has recently been murdered by Guardian and reincarnated as Aiel's newborn son.

Chapter 4

YOUR LIPS TO MINE

(Pangaea: 250,010,000 B.C.E.)

Blue kissed Kaery as if she were the only girl in the world, his arms wrapping around her like a blanket of protection. The weather was perfect, but he shielded her from any cold that might have come between their bodies. His lips were soft yet strong, and Kaery loved every second of their touch to hers. She reached up and stroked Blue's cheek while kissing him. If she stopped thinking of where she was and who she was, she could easily get lost in his embrace.

"I can't do this anymore, Blue. The world knows you as Aegis, the almighty Mancer, but I know you as my secret lover. You kiss me like we're the only thing that matters, but we both know that's a lie."

Kaery made a futile attempt to pull herself away from the strong embrace of her lover, though she didn't want to be away from him at all.

"You *are* all that matters, Kaery. You know I would change things if I could."

Blue leaned toward Kaery's lips for a short kiss, and as his breath passed over them, a chill rippled down her spine.

"It would change the world if I told them that I love you, Kaery."

"I don't want you to do that for me. I'm not worth the trouble," Kaery said defiantly as she pushed Blue back and turned to walk away.

Kaery almost turned to face Blue, but knowing his eyes were always her weakness in the past, she decided against it.

"I wouldn't want your perfect world to be corrupted by the truth."

In the corner of her eye Kaery saw Never staring at her from the edge of the forest. She gasped in horror. Now she knew she had hurt Never's feelings. He was quiet, but always looked at her with endearment in his eyes. She simply did not feel the same way. He must have been told to get her for the ceremony. She had to see Blue one more time before telling him that she couldn't be his mistress anymore. He was married to Sky, and though he claimed it was an arranged

marriage to keep the world balanced, she wanted to be the woman at his side. Even worse, she also knew that he did in fact love Sky.

Kaery could only stare into the pain-stricken black eyes of her long-time friend, Never, and hope that he understood she didn't mean to hurt him. For a brief moment that seemed to last lifetimes, his pain was reflected onto her soul. She wanted to reach out and say something, but before she could say a word, Blue's hand was on her shoulder. She turned to face Blue, staring into his sapphire eyes so that he would not see who it was that had truly startled her.

"I don't mean to hurt you, Kaery. I just want us to be together. I know you want to be with me, but this is all I can do," Blue said with sincerity as he caressed her soft tanned skin. His touch and his handsome face made Kaery drop her guard for only a brief moment before she looked back to see that Never was no longer there.

"I can't do this anymore, Blue! Maybe we'll be together in another lifetime!" She pushed him away and left the shadows of the forest for the warm sun, crying, not looking back this time.

*

(Present-Day)

Never woke in his room and looked around to see posters of rock bands and movies. He instantly realized he had been dreaming of Kaery and Blue again. He was immediately aware of the present with the absence of beautifully crafted stone walls and perfect weather, now replaced with smelly clothes and stale air in this small stuffy room. Even though he was a bit of a hoarder, Never knew where everything was in his room. It was messy by definition, but he managed to reach over to find the exact black t-shirt he was thinking about wearing today.

His motivation to go to school had nothing to do with academics. In fact, he only went to school to see the girl of his dreams, quite literally. Kaery had been going to his school for over a year now. She had transferred from New York, and he had been studying her every move since, thinking that her existence was a

hallucination until he heard her laughing with her friends at their usual spot in the courtyard.

Never turned to look at his cluttered room, the video games piled on top of fantasy books piled on top of half-eaten bowls of food. He half-heartedly wanted to clean the room, but thought against it in a millisecond and closed the door behind him as he crept through his stepfather's apartment. His mother was asleep in the room, while his stepfather was half-perched on the couch, an open can of beer in the clutches of his fat grubby fingers.

Never did his best to walk through the creaky apartment with as much stealth as he could. He had enough practice dodging his new stepfather that it was almost a skill. He didn't even bother to go near the kitchen because more than likely, there was no food. He'd make it to school for breakfast and hopefully get a glimpse of Kaery. He thought about quietly closing the door behind him, then smiled deviously and slammed it on purpose. He could hear his stepfather drop the can, which sounded more like he was throwing it across the room in alarm that the police were busting the door down again.

This wasn't the first morning Never ran to school with the simple amusement that the slob had beer spilled all over his face, which was enough to make him smile. It took his thoughts off of the pain he woke up with after having his heart broken countless times in his dreams. He thought about how silly he must be for feeling betrayed by a girl he had never seen before, a girl who had transferred to his school about the same time that violent grease monkey disappeared.

He wasn't even sure Kaery had met Blue until the day he overheard her talking to Ahlina and Star. She was asking about the cute boy with blue eyes sitting in Principal Hatcher's office. Never stopped running and gasped as he missed the BART train in the subway.

"That was when the dreams started. The day I saw her get out of the car with her mom," Never said to himself aloud.

He looked around, realizing he wasn't the only person standing on the subway platform, and pulled his hood over his blond bed head.

He was looking down at his skater shoes that were in dire need of a cleaning when the door to the train opened and a nostalgic dreamlike feeling hit him like a slap to the face. He looked to see Kaery's face as if he'd dreamt her up. It really was her, walking off the train toward him. He didn't know what to say or do,

unable to keep himself from looking into her golden eyes, reveling in her Asian-Caucasian features and smooth skin.

Kaery looked at Never as if she didn't know who he was, but somehow recognized him. She was in a hurry to meet her friends at the diner a few blocks away. She was skipping school because she had been told that one of her best friends, Star, would be providing them with an update on her recent and mysterious disappearance.

Never didn't board the train like the others on the platform who walked around him as Kaery brushed past, smiling politely. He could swear that God was playing a trick on him at this exact moment, so he decided to do what he would normally do: follow her.

*

Kaery was not in the frame of mind to pay attention to anything or anyone as she rushed past the busy morning commuters. Most of the people in San Francisco at this time of morning were either en route to their favorite coffee shop or just leaving their favorite coffee shop before a long day at work. Either way, she was focused on meeting with her friends, who would never in their wildest dreams believe her vision from last night.

The walk was only a few blocks, but it gave Kaery time to gather her thoughts. Last night, she dreamt that she was out at the Forbidden City nightclub with Ahlina and Scape when she saw Blue and Star walk in with V.I.P. status. The sight wouldn't have been so bizarre if her nerd friend Star didn't look like a supermodel and if Blue was actually still alive. He had been reported dead after a freak accident over a year ago. To make things weirder, Kaery had been talking to the newly glamorous Star in the restroom when guns started firing and a martial arts juggernaut went 'all action movie' on the club's bouncers. When they fled, Kaery and her friends ended up in a Japanese pagoda, running into the most popular girl in school, Sky, who had been reported missing on the news.

The more Kaery thought about the dream, the less she thought her friends would believe her, knowing they would be prone to laugh while asking what she'd been smoking.

"It really happened!" Kaery exclaimed while navigating the crowded sidewalk. As soon as the words left her lips, she noticed a mop of messy blond hair in the corner of her eye. *Is that the skater boy I just saw in the subway? Never mind, just keep walking. Everyone's waiting at the diner.* The more she thought about the feelings and the progression of the night, the more she began to realize, *if it wasn't true, then I wouldn't be able to say it.*

Ever since she'd come to California, she'd been unable to lie. She couldn't even hear lies from other people most of the time. She didn't try to do this, and it had been more of a hindrance to her social life than anything else. These days, she only spoke to her best friends. Like some kind of crazy psychic, Kaery had been having dreams that kept her in a daze. It'd been harder than ever for her to concentrate on tasks at hand in the present, and her mother was beginning to think she had ADHD.

She suddenly had the distinct feeling that someone was watching her, so she stopped mid-stride to turn and look. The tourists and commuters walked at their usual fast pace, ignoring the homeless panhandlers near the building entrances. She looked past the crowded street to see the skyscrapers in Union Square, gave a little shrug and turned in the opposite direction to continue her trek. She could see the diner, and the thought of being near her beloved friends brought a smile to her face.

Kaery could feel it happening again. Her memories came flooding back, her steps growing lighter with each passing second. She was losing touch with reality, and she was deep in thought, even though she was only a few steps from the door of the diner. She was standing in the crosswalk, and her vision was beginning to blur. She knew this feeling of *déjà vu*.

*

Kaery opened her eyes from what seemed like the most bizarre dream ever. She didn't want to move because, despite all of its craziness, she still wanted to remember every bit of it. This was something that had to be recorded in her journal as soon as possible, but first she wanted to bask in the excitement of it all. *When I tell Ahlina about the dream, she's going to freak out and probably make me write a blog about it on Surge-Overload's hacker site she made me sign up for. There was the Forbidden City, Star all gorgeous, guns, escape, a pagoda and Blue. Ahlina will never believe this!* The flashback of ancient times seemed like something out of a fantasy novel that had never been written, yet Kaery somehow knew it was all true.

It was too early to reach over and grab her cell phone, but Kaery could hear it vibrating on the small table next to her bed. The room was messy, which was the usual indicator that Ahlina had visited and gone through her clothes again, trying to make sure she grabbed the most appropriately inappropriate outfit to wear. Kaery looked away from the clean clothes mingled with the messy ones. Her hands instinctively grabbed the phone and touched the screen to activate the monitor. Almost a dozen text messages were in her inbox and just as many voicemails. This was weird, considering the only people who ever messaged Kaery were her mother and best friends.

She opened the first text in her inbox which, as expected, was from Ahlina: 'Girl where you at???' This message wasn't out of the ordinary and neither were the ones that said 'wake up' or 'look we need to talk lol.' The message that sent a tingle down her spine was the one that read, "Ok so I had this dream—I think you're gonna want to hear about this one." Kaery immediately sat up in her bed.

What almost made her scream was the tight and way-too-short silver dress she suddenly realized was covering her body. Even more surprising was the moment she jumped out of bed in stilettos she must have forgotten how to walk in, tripping over the pile of clothes on the floor. *Who in the world made me wear these things? Ahlina!* Kaery tore the shoes off. Now barefoot and running to her bathroom, she looked in the mirror at the purple bangs flowing in front of her face and the bumped up-do of her brown locks in the back that made her hairstyle look like the work of a professional, just as Scape would've recommended. The dress was way too tight and pushed things way up. Her mom would kill her if she saw her looking like that. She turned the handle to let water flow into the sink, glanced up and noticed the massive amounts of eyeliner and lip gloss on her face.

“This couldn’t be right. That totally happened? It wasn’t a dream,” Kaery whispered to herself, almost horrified that she knew the truth.

“Kaery, is that you?”

Oh, shoot, my mom can’t see me like this. Kaery scrambled to take the tight dress off and even tried to rip it off. Ahlina was going to pay for making her wear this outfit. She couldn’t get it off in time for the inevitable invasion that her mother was notorious for, considering she was an only child with a control freak for a single parent.

“Yes, Mom, give me a minute, please.” She knew she hadn’t bought herself more than three seconds, so she pulled the thin straps over her golden tanned shoulders and quickly wrapped a bath towel around her body while washing her face.

Almost on cue, her mother burst into her bathroom with her business suit on and a fresh glass of lemonade in hand because she knew Kaery didn’t like orange juice.

“I didn’t even hear you come in last night. And I have to say that little punk rocker friend of yours surprised me. I thought you were staying over at her house, but when she called to tell me she was going to drop you off, I simply didn’t believe my ears. Oh, and don’t think this gets you off the hook for skipping class, young lady.” She stopped in her tracks as she looked her daughter up and down.

Kaery’s heart almost stopped as her mother stared at her. She just knew she was caught. It would break her mother’s heart to know that her only daughter was out and about like some prostitute, dodging bullets at a gangster’s hangout. The guilt of it all almost made Kaery confess her sins to her mother, who had been raised in a church that condemned divorce, yet had ended the marriage to her Southeast Asian father. Her mom was beautiful in all of her business attire that Kaery could never see herself wearing. She stood and stared silently, holding the glass of lemonade.

Mo, as her colleagues called her, was known for her quick assessments of people. Maybe she had passed that gift to her daughter, who could profile someone in a matter of seconds without second-guessing her judgments. She stared at her daughter in awe.

Kaery could barely take the anticipation of the situation and started to tear up, as she wanted to spill the details of what seemed like a dream.

“Mom, I’m sorry. We went to this club, and then these people started to shoot, and right as that happened, this Kung Fu lady saved us, but we were driven to this creepy warehouse where the doors opened to a Japanese castle, and it was so beautiful that I had to walk closer, except I had this dream about Pangaea, but I don’t know if it really existed at all because I caused the end of the world...”

Kaery barely got to take a breath before her mother smiled.

“Why are you smiling?” Kaery said, looking at her mother with an extremely puzzled expression.

“I didn’t hear a word you said young lady, but I do know that my little girl is a grown woman now. You’re even wearing your hair up like me.”

Mo was proud of her only daughter, and it would seem that Kaery’s confession had just fallen on deaf ears. Her mother didn’t or couldn’t understand Kaery’s ranting. Her Irish-German features softened as she walked into the bathroom to give Kaery a hug.

“I, um, don’t know what to say.”

Kaery hugged her proud mother, who stood considerably taller than her on a normal day, but towered above her when wearing heels. She was still confused. She knew she’d told her mother the entire truth, and on any other occasion, she would be riding her about everything from grades to tardiness, but this honest confession of last night got her a hug. She must have been dreaming, and even if by chance she hadn’t, Ahlina definitely wouldn’t believe this.

“Mom, I need to take a shower.”

“Oh, of course, sweetie. Go take a shower and hurry up for breakfast. I’ll drive you to school.” Mo sauntered out of the bathroom and into the messy bedroom, regaining her perfectionist’s eye for detail.

“Wash the rest of that eyeliner off, and clean this room as soon as you get home.”

Kaery looked down at the mess, then back at her mother and gulped.

“Ok, for sure.”

She watched her mom close the door and ran into the bedroom, the towel almost slipping off as she grabbed her phone. A new text message from Star: ‘So I have this grungy kid here —with Ahlina and Scape at the diner on Mission—meet us here in an hour.’

Kaery replied as quickly as possible with a simple ‘kk’ and returned to the bathroom for her shower.

*

“Dude, for you being so small, you sure can grub,” Scape said approvingly to Crux.

His handsome Native American features were almost hiding behind the long black hair draped across his right eye.

He called for the waiter, “Please give him anything else he wants. You want something else, little man?”

Crux smiled up at Scape and looked at the menu again.

“I would like a piece of pie with ice cream...and another burger...and fries, oh! And a cookies and cream shake, please,” Crux said with a bright smile, half pointing to the menu and half looking up at the confused waiter.

“I’m sorry, but can you guys please translate what the kid just said?”

The waiter wore an anxious smile on his face, trying to understand the kid’s genuine excitement.

Ahlina’s green eyes glanced quickly at Scape, and her brow dipped as she watched the whole event.

“Yeah, he wants this, this and this.” She pointed at the menu, the waiter smiling brightly.

“Okay, I’ll be right back!”

The man took the menu in disbelief that the thin twelve-year-old could eat so much, but he smiled, nonetheless. Scape pushed his hair out of his face, but to no avail. It just fell right back into place as he watched the waiter hurry for the kitchen.

“Ahlina, did you see that? I told you. For some reason, we can understand him, but no one else can.”

“It’s the Veil of Ignorance,” Crux said with a mouthful of fries, “All humans suffer from it. Anything Magick they can’t understand. They don’t even notice simple things right in front of them. And guessing from the flashback, you all are the reason for it.”

“Shut up, kid,” Ahlina said, “You don’t want everyone to hear you. Be a little more discrete.”

She looked around the crowded restaurant at the patrons who didn’t seem to care what they were talking about, even if they could understand the boy.

“Unless they speak the Language of Magick or Petsha,” Crux said, “I don’t think they’ll understand me, Ahlina. All things Magick can understand each other ‘cause we speak on a different frequency. Humans are pretty much dumb. This is funny—I’m the one teaching Witchbreed about Magick! What would the crone have to say about me now?” Crux chuckled and sipped on his soft drink, winking at the green-eyed Asian tomboy.

Ahlina’s Japanese-Chinese face flushed with annoyance at Crux for knowing more about this situation than all of them combined.

“Where is Star?,” she asked, “She’s been in the bathroom for way too long.”

As Ahlina turned around in the 1950’s-themed seats to check the restroom doors, Star walked out into the crowded room as if she were making her debut on a catwalk, settling for the jukebox as her background music while she strutted over to her friends. Ahlina ogled at her drop-dead gorgeous best friend who had looked like every other nerd in the reject hall just a couple weeks ago.

“I still can’t believe that’s Star,” Scape said with his mouth open in awe, “She could be in a Victoria’s Secret fashion show right now.”

Ahlina nodded as she noticed the entire restaurant staring at this sexy spectacle. Star’s red hair bounced, the blond highlights shimmering through. Her pink glossed lips reflected light like glass, while her well-endowed chest bounced rhythmically to every step she took in her high-fashion six-inch stilettos. She looked like a top model with perfect lighting, even though everyone else was sitting in a terribly dim restaurant.

Star enjoyed the attention, especially when it came from jealous lovers. Her sequined mini dress showed off her long legs and tiny waist. She sat down, knowing everyone was staring at her.

“God, I love Glamour!,” she exclaimed, “I almost feel like Sky.”

Ahlina turned away from Star as soon as the name left her lips.

“Yeah, well you should in your uppity new look. Speaking of Sky, do you think she’s still in that pagoda?” Ahlina almost whispered the last few words.

“Don’t worry, they can’t understand most of what we’re saying,” Crux said as the waiter walked up, almost dropping his tray full of food while looking down Star’s top.

“Watch it, man. And I mean the table,” Scape said slyly, winking at the embarrassed waiter who hurried off with a red face.

“How do you know they can’t understand us?,” Scape asked.

Crux took a huge bite of his burger, and it seemed for a moment that the ravenous boy didn’t hear Scape at all because he was so engrossed in his meal. Star and Ahlina watched him eat with disgusted expressions on their faces. Ahlina grabbed a couple fries from the gluttonous boy’s plate.

“Look, all of this is crazy! I could’ve sworn I saw an ancient ancestor, Jayde, who I’ve only known through dreams my whole life. That’s the reason I was so tripped out when she went all ‘Kill Bill’ on the Forbidden City. I can’t believe I just admitted that, and I’m still not sure any of it was real.”

Star laughed at Ahlina’s confession and continued to look in mild disgust at the little boy who had shown up on her doorstep as he wolfed down more food. He’d been eating non-stop for the past hour.

“It’s about as real as that burger he just devoured,” Scape said, laughing while reaching over the table and rustling Crux’s Mohawk, “Cool hair by the way, kid.”

“We have more important things to talk about than hair, guys,” Kaery said, “Magick is real.” She stood next to the table, her golden eyes gleaming at her best friends and their hungry new guest. “I got here as soon as I could. We definitely need to talk.”

*

Maia’s brown eyes opened as she woke up from her dream. She must’ve gone right to bed as soon as she got back from San Francisco. The vivid dream of Crux and the Wicasht kids made her smile. She knew it wasn’t just a dream, but a real event that happened just a few days ago. Crux was in good hands, and that’s

all that mattered. In the dream, she and Kaery were alike. They both had the basic ability to see weaknesses and flaws in each person they interacted with, though their respective ranges of powers differed in some ways. *Kaery sure is a powerful psychic, but it'd really suck to have to tell the truth all the time.* She liked Kaery already.

Maia realized she was wearing pajamas again and refused to be caught in them by Blue or anyone else. Her thick blond hair blew down her back as she walked out of the room and into the breezy hallway. She put on a pair of jeans and a small T-shirt with a crying skull graphic. Recently admiring Sky's provocative wardrobe, she decided she would show a bit more skin when greeting everyone today, even though it was cold out. She could hear chatter coming from the room down the hall.

"What do you mean you helped people get away from OZONE with your computer?"

The words barely left Sky's mouth before she looked Surge-Overload up and down. Surge looked similar to the rebels and outcasts at her school, the ones she missed at the present moment because they reminded her of her life outside of this place.

"Yep, and you would've died that night if I didn't tip Juno off to saving you," Surge said proudly, looking for Juno but finding Nina's gaze instead. "And you, Nina, were pronounced dead. It was kind of tricky finding you. Juno had to go all undercover within an undercover base to find evidence that you existed. She was totally bummed when your file said you were dead." Surge snickered nonchalantly at the expression on Nina's face.

Maia sighed at no sign of Blue and made her presence known to the rest of the room. She knew Sky had seen her lurking in the hallway.

"Hello," she said awkwardly, subconsciously grabbing for the sweater that she wished she were wearing, then sitting down on the nearest seat in Sky's room as she tried to get out of the limelight.

"Hello. Did you sleep well?" Nina asked, turning to Maia with a warm smile.

Maia nodded again awkwardly as she listened to Surge-Overload continue.

"So I have this site up for refugees, like myself now, I suppose. But they are all over the world in safe havens. I erased their existence from OZONE's databases and allowed them sanctuary with high-level friends who technically have no clue

as to who I am. Well, maybe they do now after that little stunt in Union Square, but, oh, and the best part about OZONE is I have their Agent list!" Surge tapped her head. "Memorized."

A sullen expression crossed her face as she thought about the list. *I can't believe Mom, Dad and my Uncle are all on it.*

Maia took note of Surge's sudden lack of excitement, but said nothing.

Surge jumped over to her motorcycle backpack that was lying on the floor. She unzipped it, which made Nina look down at her own worn-out bag.

"I can order you another one online," Surge said, looking at Nina.

Nina looked a little embarrassed, but was happy to be wearing a new outfit custom-made by Sky. She wondered what Juno was doing in the other room besides talking to Gemini and Jayde.

"I'm in their system! Check this out!" Surge shrieked.

*

"Gemini, this is the first time we've disagreed in centuries," Jayde said, looking at him while keeping her attention on Juno, "But you know I can't allow her to take Nina. You know as well as I do what she's done to her own kind. She's a murderer who can't be trusted."

Gemini looked deep within Jayde's eyes to assure her that he knew exactly what he was doing. He gave her his usual warm and collected smile, then looked over to Juno.

"You know that her concerns are valid. You have made many mistakes in your many lifetimes, Juno, and you deserve the atonement we all are subject to." Gemini walked toward Juno so smoothly, he seemed to float.

"I understand. I would never hurt..." Juno stopped speaking and gathered her thoughts, knowing every word would be scrutinized by her present company. Gemini, Jayde and Blue all stared at her silently.

"I love her," she said, "and there is nothing that will come between us again. I'll protect her with my very soul."

Blue had never seen anyone confess their love for a person with this much conviction, not even his parents, whose voices he could still hear when he awoke each day. He could almost feel the love emanating from Juno's skin, as vivid as the uncomfortable atmospheric hum that was inevitably a part of his abilities. Juno's love for Nina was a real energy, one that he didn't quite understand. Lately, Blue didn't understand much about the Supernatural world, but he knew that he was definitely a part of it.

"I believe her," Blue said aloud, even though no one had asked for his opinion. He simply said what he felt.

"As do I," Gemini said, smiling, never taking his eyes off Juno. "Wicasht, I give you Nina as your ward. If you fail this quest, then you fail us all."

Juno felt tears about to spring forth, but knew that this was her time to be as strong as possible, not only for herself and her dignity, but for Nina, who she would protect with her own life. If anything in Juno's past was evidence, her impartial massacre of the Supernaturals in response to Nina's death was enough to convince everyone of her commitment. Most of those gathered in the room knew that she would tear the world apart for her lover. The conversation was somehow familiar to Blue, who understood Juno's pain. He subconsciously touched his lips for a brief second and thought of Kaery.

Chapter 5

CENTER OF THE STORM

Sky walked out of the room, not so much frustrated with Maia and her doomed visions as she was weary of her own fate. She walked to the courtyard where many of their endless training sessions had taken place. The stone garden was rearranged in small ways that Sky wouldn't have noticed before she arrived at Gemini's lair. Now she was able to see the entire reconstructed stone garden as if she had created every grain of sand and rock within it all at once. She knew everything that was out of place. As uncanny as this ability was, she was not able to fathom how Maia could see the many different versions of the future, and she was upset that all of the training for the last few weeks seemed to be for nothing. There was a beautiful mountain range in the distance. As fast as she could think of it, she appeared on her favorite perch high on a mountain top, happy that she was able to use her powers so effortlessly.

Ok, this is how Maia can do it, just like the rest of us, with a thought and a feeling. I still don't understand a lot of this Soulstream stuff. It makes me mad that I'm forced to be this Mancer thing, but according to Maia, we are all going to die anyway. Why don't I just go home and take my chances with OZONE, considering it doesn't matter if they kill me. At least I'll be able to see my friends again, and as much as school was an anxiety attack in a bottle...I miss that place too.

Wow, the clouds up here are so gorgeous! It's so peaceful, and to think, this is all I had to do back in Cali to clear my thoughts. All that money spent on yoga and meditation masters was for nothing. I miss my Mum and Daddums. They must be worried sick. I recorded a video, and Surge sent it to my Dad's private files to let them know I'm ok. I know I must have put us at risk, but I couldn't help it after she saw me trying to call him on the global phone Dad customized for me. I can't just act like my parents don't exist, as these guys seem to do. I really want to go shopping. I'm so tired of being here.

"I wonder if I can sit on the clouds?" Sky asked herself out loud.

“Of course you can!” Blue said, slightly panting. He had run up the mountain and was climbing the last set of stones. “You know I hate heights after falling off that stupid mountain a couple times.”

“You mean knocked off. And how did you know I was up here?” Sky laughed. She had almost forgotten how fast Blue could move.

“As much as you want to be this unpredictable trendsetter, you’re pretty easy to read. You’re a big softy, and you come up here and stare at the clouds when you’re frustrated.” Blue smiled.

“Oh, so now you know me?” Sky crossed her arms and rolled her eyes as she turned away from him dramatically.

“I never claimed to know you,” Blue said, “but I have noticed you like the scent of Jasmine and the color green. You look at old pictures in the phone you think you’re hiding from Gemini to make yourself happy. You like this spring breeze at night, but in the morning, you like it slightly warmer after your bath. You make those outfits out of the dresses in your room when you can’t sleep. Oh, and you think I’m a loser because I don’t have a trust fund,” Blue said, chuckling.

Focusing on Blue’s profile as he looked off into the distance of the endless clouds, Sky blushed. A moment later, she looked away and refrained from meeting his gaze as she watched a storm forming over the ocean in the distance.

“I wonder what’s in the center of the storm.”

*

(Pangaea: 250,000,000,000 B.C.E.)

“I think they should show us what they can do,” Sky said to Blue as they looked over their vast kingdom from their elaborate pyramid temple.

“What do you propose?” Blue asked, smiling at his wife.

“I want to see just how crafty the Wicasht are! I mean, their spell combinations are so much more interesting than the predictable hack and slash Jreamer battles in the arenas. I know you’re into that stuff, but I want to see the Magick.” Sky smiled excitedly.

“Ok, my love, then it shall be.” Whispering to the wind, Blue summoned one of the most favored generals in his vast army.

A muscular man of large proportions appeared in the chamber fully dressed in his blessed armor. The gold seemed to reflect sunlight that was not in the room. The beautifully ornate armor covered the huge man’s body like Dragon scales as it flexed with his every move.

“You summoned me, Lord Aegis.” Crux kneeled in respect.

“No need for formalities, dear Crux.” Blue walked over to his friend and placed his hand on his shoulder. “Please stand.”

Crux was one of the most powerful warriors in all of Pangaea. He was undefeated in the gladiator arena and had been appointed as Blue’s general after singlehandedly defeating a dozen Jreamers with nothing but grains of sand and his bare hands.

Blue didn’t consider too many people his friends, yet was proud of his immortal comrade. He had been raised to know only the hierarchy of the Supernaturals. He definitely didn’t have any human friends himself, but Crux seemed to take a liking to them.

“I apologize for summoning you from your human audience, but I need to ask you for a favor, good friend. We are starting a new arena!”

Crux clenched his fists and smiled a large grin that Blue knew all too well.

“Before you get too excited, please tell Hermes and the other messengers to gather the Wicasht covens and Mancers at once. There will be battles, and my wife will announce the rules.” Blue stopped himself from laughing as he saw the disappointed expression on his friend’s face.

Sky saw the same look.

“I’m sorry, Crux,” she said, “but these battles will be about Magick and mastery over it. I grow tired of the gladiators who have only mastered the body.”

“I understand, milady.” Crux kneeled again before Sky.

“Please don’t do that. You’re a Mancer!”

“Yes, milady, I will go at once.”

Crux stood, towering over the most powerful couple in all of Pangaea. He smiled, as he respected them more than they knew.

“Thank you for trusting me with this news first, for I will not fail.”

*

“Ahlina, why can’t you get it right?” Khenebu said, frustrated with his student. “You can’t even summon a simple spiritual energy field. The other covens already laugh at us for being so weak compared to them and all of their structure and technique.”

“I don’t care about stupid structure or technique, and I definitely DON’T care about them laughing at us. They can all kiss my—” Ahlina was cut short by the ever-kind Kaery.

“I know Khenebu is tough on you,” Kaery rubbed Khenebu’s back lovingly as she walked towards Ahlina. “Probably a little tougher than he should be, but he is correct in his efforts. We must prove that we can succeed in Magick. We are just as worthy of great power as they are. We are all so highly capable, and so are you.”

Kaery stood behind Ahlina and lifted her friend’s thin arm.

“Ahlina you must focus all of your will on opening the Soulstream through your right palm. It seems to be your focus point, according to the stars.”

Kaery smiled as Ahlina focused on the lesson.

“Say, ‘spiritus continius pandamonius,’” she whispered into her ear.

Ahlina’s choppy black hair covered her slanted green eyes. She squinted while concentrating, then whispered, “Sprite-us con-timinus panda-money-us.”

Khenebu shook his head in disappointment, but before he could scold her mispronunciation, something miraculous happened.

Ahlina thought, *Work, you stupid spell! Open the Soulstream!* She squeezed her forearm as hard as she could, and a light blue flame engulfed her arm. *I did it! It’s flaming spirit energy surrounding my arm that can burn even Mancers. Oh my God, I can’t control it.*

“Kaery, please move back. I can’t stop! I don’t wanna hurt you!” she cried.

A blast of powerful blue flames shot from Ahlina’s palm into the lush forest, disintegrating all life that came into its path as it burned through the trees. Khenebu shouted a spiritual shield spell just in time as the blast poured over him in a relentless conflagration. Kaery held her friend’s wrist and pointed it upward.

“Ahlina, you must focus on my voice. Remember the lake and the swim with the coven.” The flames burned Kaery’s robe into nonexistence. Kaery’s skin seemed to be immune to the heat as she continued to hold her friend and calm her.

Ahlina cried as she thought of Kaery being harmed by her first spell.

“Hurry and stop the flames!” Khenebu screamed through clenched teeth as he concentrated with all of his willpower to protect himself from doom. His shield of liquid shadow energy was being overwhelmed, and he stared in shock at Kaery holding onto Ahlina as if the flames were as harmless as a morning breeze.

“You must calm your nerves, Ahlina,” Kaery whispered, “You didn’t hurt me. I don’t know how, but I am safe. You can stop now.” Kaery smiled as she stood naked, face to face with Ahlina. The fire was still surrounding both of them and still blasting into the open sky.

Ahlina stopped squeezing her forearm, even though the pressure under her skin made her feel like it was going to explode. The clouds above parted, and Ahlina thought, *Water and my friends*. Suddenly the flames stopped bursting forth, engulfing only Ahlina and Kaery.

“You did it!” Kaery said, hugging her friend. “I’m safe, and you did it, Ahlina!”

“I’m so sorry, Kaery, I almost hurt you and Khenebu. I’m sorry.” Ahlina cried as she sobbed into Kaery’s shoulder. The light blue flame was slowly extinguished as Ahlina wrapped her arms around her friend.

“I couldn’t live with myself if you...”

“I’m fine, Ahlina, and I’m proud of you.” Kaery pulled away slightly, smiling. She looked around to see Khenebu lowering his shield.

He stood still with a confused expression, staring at the marvel of what had just happened, memorizing the blue Rune code written on Ahlina’s arm before the Magick faded away.

“That was...complex and amazing!” Khenebu said as he ran over to Ahlina. Khenebu’s dark skin and embroidered robes were untouched by the onslaught of Ahlina’s Spiritual Flame Blast. He couldn’t say the same thing for Kaery, as she stood with her soft bronzed skin exposed in all its beauty.

“What was that?” Star ran through the forest with a sword in her hand. Her red hair flew from side to side as she looked around puzzled, expecting a battle. Her beauty was only matched by that of Heaven, who sat next to her, riding a horse

with strangely colored iridescent fur and a horn that seemed to shine a myriad of colors all at once.

Heaven jumped off the beast.

“We came as fast as we could. Are you all okay?”

Her skin was only slightly darker than Khenebu’s, but the length of her purple hair put his dreadlocks to shame as it cascaded around her like the horse’s mane, all the way down to the ground. Her robes were cut in a way that made her appear almost naked.

“Kaery, I barely have more clothing than you!”

“Is this your new look?” Star asked as she walked past Heaven and up to Kaery.

A large white Dragon swooped down and landed with a thunderous crash, causing the horse to flee in terror.

“Great, Never, do you know how long it takes to summon a Unicorn?” Heaven asked the Dragon towering before her.

The large scales began to contort and twist into soft flesh. The once gigantic creature was now a lean short man with pale skin and white hair. His black eyes scanned for enemies on the ground because he had not seen any from the air.

“Scape, Ewm and Ssiah are right behind me. Who attacked you?”

Floating down on a disc of light came Ewm and Ssiah.

“Wow,” Ewm said, “A spell of spiritual conflagration is written on the countryside. Khenebu, did you unleash such destructive force?” His neat black hair made his red eyes stand out so much more.

Within the next few seconds, all nine of the Coven of Unity were standing in the crop circle of Ahlina’s blast, surrounding Ahlina and Kaery.

“We are fine!” Kaery’s voice boomed so loudly it sent a windy wave of force throughout the surrounding forest that almost knocked everyone in the Coven off their feet.

All of the kids looked at Kaery with a surprised stare.

“So, wait, you have a new spell of the Mancer Voice?” Scape asked as he emerged from a cloud of mist.

“You guys really don’t ever want me to find my unicorn do you?” Heaven pouted, “Poor horse must be scared half to death.”

Ssiah giggled, and her golden curls shaped her young face like sunlight on the edges of clouds. Ewm and Scape joined in her contagious laughter as they

watched Heaven's frustration, who turned her gaze from the forest, unable to withhold a giggle.

"So is anyone going to tell us what happened here?" she asked.

Ssiah looked into the rays of sunlight piercing the sky. "Mancer!"

All of the Coven of Unity turned their attention to the Mancer flying toward them at a dangerously high speed in the form of a meteor. A few of the kids took the initiative to prepare protection spells, which were stopped by the words of Crux in a booming crash nearby.

"Sky is summoning all of the Witchbreed Covens to battle in her arenas. Prepare yours." Crux was nice, but direct.

"Since when does Sky have battle arenas for Witchbreed?" Ewm whispered to Never and Scape.

"Where are we to meet?" Kaery realized she was naked as soon as she asked the question and quickly hid behind Khenebu.

"Follow the thunder and lightning, the products of clashing Magick." Crux pointed to the clouds in the distance. "The center of the storm."

Chapter 6

DREAMS ARE MEMORIES

When we were all in the Soulstream, we were able to create and destroy worlds with but a thought. These worlds still exist across the planes of existence, but we choose to forget them when we enter another world as an inhabitant. When every Shard, or ‘soul,’ of the Soulstream choose to be born human, they choose ignorance over the omnipotence they once had in previous lifetimes. While Mancers choose to hold unlimited power, Witchbreed choose to remember. Witchbreed are unlike other Supernaturals for the simple fact that we remember every lifetime we’ve lived up until this moment. We have dreams much like a human would during sleep or meditation, except we open the floodgate of remembrance. Our past reincarnations make it hard to discern this lifetime from others. The visions we see at night are not fantastical depictions of subjective experience, but true historical accounts.

Once we are enlightened, we retrieve our memories of all past lives before this one. The more powerful we become, the more memories we retrieve. Wicasht is our true name. Witchbreed is the translation.

Many Spellcrafts are directly linked to memories of the past. Our understanding of the code known as Magick makes us both dangerous and necessary. Even the newest Witchbreed have the potential to do things that Mancers can only imagine. An intimate connection to the Spellcrafts follows the Witchbreed in the Soulstream throughout the ages, from one life to the next.

Some of us gain our memories from other lifetimes simply by touching a familiar object or seeing someone who brings a sense of nostalgia. Though some would say it is a curse to remember so much, others say this historical experience of *déjà vu* is a blessing.

Most of our past lifetimes were filled with moments that store themselves on our Shards as codes. A code written on the soul of each person is easily seen by other Witchbreed and explains the unique Spellcrafts and knowledge developed by that individual.

Humans mistake the realms they once created or destroyed as dreams and nightmares. Witchbreed know these dreams as memories, parts of each person that are as real as the world around us.

Underestimation of the Witchbreed's link to these memories has been the downfall of countless other Supernaturals.

~ Ssiah

Chapter 7

SECRETS

Scape was enthralled by the entire situation. He was best friends with three of the outcasts in their prestigious prep school, Drakehawk Academy. Ahlina, whom he'd known the longest, was the rambunctious and fiery Asian girl with the green eyes. Though Ahlina was suspected for being linked to the triads, Scape didn't mind because he loved her 'do-what-I-want' spirit.

Star was previously the nerdy, wannabe diva with the hunched-over walk and the low self-esteem to go with it. Her obsession with Sky, the school's most popular girl, had resulted in a dramatic physical transformation, as she was now a red-headed bombshell glamazon with an attitude that rivaled those of the tabloid divas.

Then there was Kaery, the sweetest girl Scape knew. She was the most honest person he'd ever met, a true friend who would much rather not say anything than hurt someone's feelings. Scape adored her. If he wasn't gay, he'd have a tough time trying to decide which one of these girls he'd try to sleep with.

Recently they'd found themselves in more of a mess than the time Ahlina got caught shoplifting at the mall while skipping fourth period. Thanks to the ranting of a little boy who claimed to be a Mancer, or the storybook equivalent of a God, they all seemed to be convinced of their part in some supernatural community. While this boy seemed to be nothing more than the God of hamburgers at the moment as he stuffed his face, he insisted that Witchbreed are supposedly Magick-wielding badasses from all throughout history, responsible for advising the most powerful of kings, chiefs, Gods and immortals.

Somehow, through the immense burger scarfing, they were supposed to believe that the cute little kid, Crux, was not lying to them or making them look like fools. He really had no perceivable motive to lie to them, and his story was surprisingly convincing. Scape couldn't help but think about all of the dreams he'd been having lately. The expressions on his friends' faces confirmed they had been having similar dreams as well.

Scape sat quietly at the table in the busy restaurant and watched as Kaery, Ahlina and Star listened to the boy, who continued his tale as if he weren't in a restaurant full of potential eavesdroppers.

“So, as I was telling you, the humans cannot understand a word I’m saying. As the Petsha Crone would say, ‘they are not on the same frequency.’ This would explain why I speak a language of thieves and mercenaries that none of you have ever heard, yet you all can understand what I am saying right now.” Crux dipped another French fry into ketchup and ate while looking at the faces before him.

“Ok, so say I believe you,” Ahlina said while the boy chewed his fries, “That doesn’t explain why I’ve been having these strange dreams.” She moved her hair from her eyes and shot the twelve-year-old boy a skeptical stare.

“I’ve been having funky dreams too,” Scape confessed, leaning forward, listening more carefully,

“Me too,” Star grudgingly admitted.

The entire table turned to Kaery, who looked into the eyes of each of her friends and said, “Ok, I’ve had some wicked case of déjà vu, and for some reason, I know you all believe that Crux is telling the truth.”

Scape looked at Kaery with the same mystified expression as if she’d caught them all in their most intimate and vulnerable thoughts, but brought them to the surface for judgment. His black hair shined in the dimly lit restaurant as he turned to look at the patrons. Somehow, they didn’t understand the conversation. It was unsettling at best to watch the oblivious people eat their breakfasts while smiling at one another. Scape caught the glance of a familiar face following a waiter to a nearby booth. For a second, he was sure that this hooded profile before him was that of Never, the loner from school, but there was no way he too was skipping class. Scape turned his attention back to the table and shook off the coincidence of the skater look-alike who now had his back to them.

“You all must’ve been Witchbreed in the past as well,” Crux said, looking around the table, “Supernaturals know that there is no such thing as coincidence. When Blue found me at the docks, I knew he was Supernatural, even though he didn’t know he was. The same when I saw you for the first time, Star.” Crux took another bite of his huge burger in the 1950’s-themed diner as he fidgeted with the jukebox on their table.

“I think this kid is a complete homeless scammer,” Star interrupted, “and maybe his stories are kind of catchy, but seriously, guys, this is all becoming a bit much. Like we’re really supposed to just accept we’re some elite witches and warlocks? Yeah right.”

Ahlina looked Star up and down and purposefully said, “This, coming from the pale version of Sky.” She rolled her eyes and looked at Kaery, “I know what I saw, and Jayde has been in my dreams since as far back as I can remember. All of a sudden, she’s real—and kicking more ass than all of us combined.”

Star rolled her eyes, smirking, crossing and re-crossing her legs.

Kaery half-consciously twirled her pale purple bangs in her fingers. “I know there is some truth to all of this. Star, you’re just scared, but you remember as well as I do; the flashback at Gemini’s castle was our past. It was our memories. It wasn’t some fluke or some scam. It was truth, and we were the ones who cast the spell that made people the way they are today.”

There was a fire that burned in Kaery’s rich hazel eyes, every word she said making the entire group gasp at once in realization that she was incapable of lying. They all had to deal with the truth.

Never’s spine tingled as he heard the entire conversation. He tried to remain inconspicuous while they were so deep in conversation; Scape was the only one who seemed to notice him at all. Scape was Kaery’s cool best friend who always seemed to be the mellowest of their misfit group. He was lucky to be able to hang out with Kaery every day and have such passionate conversations. Even with his back to the kids, Never still gasped on cue like they did as he remembered his own dreams of past lives. He was still convinced they were true events by the way they made him feel.

When a loud gasp suddenly reached his ears from across the restaurant aisle, Scape looked over his shoulder to see the back of the hooded skater kid sitting in a booth behind them.

“Are you sure we’re the only ones who can understand this language or whatever?” Scape asked, “Because I swear these people are all up in our convo.

“Yup,” Crux said, taking another bite of his burger.

“This is all just becoming too awkward for words,” Scape replied, “And by the way, Crux, I don’t think I’ve seen a football player eat as much as you do.”

Star nodded in agreement, “Yeah, it’s kinda making me sick. I was full three burgers ago. And where the hell does he fit it all?”

Crux smiled. “I’m growing, ok? Besides, this isn’t about me. This is about the lot of you who haven’t been completely enlightened yet. Once that happens, I’ll be asking you all for tips.”

Ahlina batted her sparkling green eyes and took a condescending tone.

“I’ll give you a tip now: Chew.”

Star let out a boisterous laugh, Kaery nearly choked on her sandwich and Scape turned around to see the skater kid squirting milkshake out of his nostrils, giggling to himself.

“I knew it!” Scape cried, “He *can* understand us!”

Everyone turned to study the eavesdropper’s back as he frantically attempted to wipe the mess off the table. Kaery looked at the boy with her head slightly tilted. He was very familiar. She stared silently until Star walked over to him.

“So you’re ear hustling?” she asked, “Hey, Kaery, it’s your stalker from school.” She grabbed the boy’s hood and pulled it off, revealing a mop of spiky platinum blond hair.

Never, looking down in embarrassment, saw the long slender legs standing next to his booth. He could only imagine how severe the punishment would be for what this girl had just called ‘ear hustling,’ and knowing that he’d surely been caught, he impulsively looked back over his shoulder. Kaery was staring back at him.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to. I just…” He stopped himself from speaking as he saw the look of concern on Kaery’s face. She was as beautiful in person as she was in his dreams.

Crux stood up and squinted into Never’s onyx-black eyes.

“Yep, he’s definitely Supernatural.” He sat back down and sipped his shake loudly through a straw, now focused on finding the cookies at the bottom of the silver malt cup.

Ahlna turned to Crux, keeping her voice at a near-whisper. “So, how many other people heard our entire conversation? We so need to get out of here before we’re like—on the news or something.”

She grabbed her backpack and walked past Never, looking into his dark eyes. She did remember him, though she didn’t know how. He was attractive in a grunge boy sorta way, though kind of short for a guy. However, his continued fixation on Kaery was enough to make a girl shudder.

“Creeper much?” Ahlna whispered to Star.

Scape walked over and offered Never a friendly handshake, who awkwardly accepted the gesture.

“I’m Scape, and for some reason, I think you already know that.”

He felt bad for exposing Never's eavesdropping and displayed his infectious smile to lighten the mood, taking the opportunity to flirt a little.

"You go to our school, right? I think your name was Never?"

Scape continued to hold the nervous boy's hand, still smiling, and gave him a once-over. For a brief moment, it looked as if Never had obsidian scales underneath his pale skin. Never blushed and looked away, his focus still on Kaery.

"Obviously the secret's out," Scape said, "Well, yes, the fact that you stare at Kaery, but also—you're Supernatural like us."

*

Nina didn't have a name for what she was, until recently. 'Supernatural,' Gemini called her. She grew up in a small town in Oregon, and she'd visited the big cities growing up with a father who quit working as a truck driver in favor of carpentry. She'd never been able to appreciate the beautiful architecture of these cities because whenever her father would take her on a tour, she would become overwhelmed by the presence of so many people in one area. At an early age, she became aware of the strange ability she had to influence and manipulate the emotions of other people in her presence.

Now she was inside a Japanese pagoda, somewhere she'd only imagined. What she didn't know was that she was a Neuromancer, one of the most powerful beings on the planet, who had been revered as a Goddess in other lifetimes.

She sat in solitude wondering about her life's sudden change, but after speaking to the cyber-hacking Surge-Overload, the introverted Maia, and the beautiful Sky, she realized her life wasn't so much different than theirs. Of course, she didn't have the religious background that Maia came from, the eccentric suburban life of Surge-Overload, and most definitely not the trillionaire stardom of Sky, but like them, she had been thrown out of her comfort zone.

This was the first time Nina had been able to sit by herself, though she was supposed to be sleeping. For some reason, she couldn't make herself doze off, too busy thinking of Juno, the woman who had rescued her. Juno was gorgeous in the 'murder-you-for-breakfast' kind of way. She seemed to make the kids uneasy. Sky once said Juno had tried to kill her, but Surge argued it was a test. Sky didn't seem

so amused, but Nina remembered seeing Maia chuckle for the first time at that conversation.

Nina could sense the emotions of the kids very easily. Blue was hard to read though. He was the bad boy with the attitude, but underneath his hard exterior was a nice spirit. He had a conscience that was as obvious as the nickname for his bright blue eyes. Sometimes Nina felt as if she knew Blue just from being in the same room with him, but she felt the same way about Sky and Juno as well. She felt the *déjà vu*, especially about Juno, as if she'd been waiting her whole life to see her for just one moment.

When Nina was around Juno, she felt as if the world were stopping, as if she was supposed to focus on everything this woman said and did. Nina had never felt this focused on anything before, but it seemed Juno already knew that about her. She could feel Juno's raw emotions of longing and protection all around her, even now as Juno was in conference with Gemini and Jayde.

Blue advised Nina to sit tight. It didn't seem very likely they would be leaving anytime soon. Juno looked slightly worried as she looked back at Nina while walking away with Jayde. Nina felt something she hadn't felt from another woman in a long time, since her mother in fact; she felt loved. Her nerves were starting to get the best of her as she felt for Juno's presence while closing her eyes. She felt the presence of Surge-Overload, who was wide awake, judging by the excitement in her emotional waves. Surge had a definite emotional signature that Nina would never forget. It was both human and sterile like a machine, which was extremely unfamiliar, but also refreshing because it wasn't as complicated as the others. Surge-Overload must have been some cyber-handle because no mother in her right mind would name her daughter Surge-Overload. But she was so smart, it was almost scary.

Earlier that night while Nina was visiting with Maia and Sky, they looked through hacked files on Surge-Overload's laptop. Nina found out that Surge was the one who had changed her information in O.Z.O.N.E's files, labeling her as 'Deceased' to the world. As unsettling as that may have seemed for most, Nina had considered herself dead to the world many years ago at the moment when she crawled across the asphalt toward the car where her parents were burning to death. The gruesome sight she saw that day made her get up and run. The pain and suffering she knew her mother felt during the accident was enough to make Nina

feel sick years later as a young adult. Her father had died instantly, but she still cried because she felt like the accident was somehow her fault.

As Nina sat up and wiped tears from her face, she heard the door open. A silhouette stood on the threshold, staring at her. She didn't have to ask who it was because she recognized the somewhat shelled emotional state of the popular beauty queen, Sky.

"I thought you'd definitely be asleep by now, considering all you've been through today," Sky said, concerned. "I mean seriously, a sniper in the woods, a sniper in Union Square, a dying girlfriend and a riot." Sky sighed.

"I don't have a girlfriend," Nina dared to say meekly as Sky sat next to her on the bed an arm's length away.

"Sure you don't. The way that psycho—I mean—the way Juno looks at you," Sky corrected, "you'd think you were in some romantic novel."

Sky shook her head as if to remove the mental picture she had just thought up. Nina felt the embarrassment slip through Sky's shell, she herself feeling the same embarrassment simultaneously.

"Where is Juno? I mean—she's been gone for a while, you know?"

"Yeah, she's still talking to Gemini and Jayde. Thank God we didn't get caught hacking into O.Z.O.N.E's files with Surge earlier. It was close, but I think Surge blocked our transmission. You do love Juno, don't you?" Sky popped the question so quickly, Nina almost didn't hear it.

Blushing, she turned to Sky and sat with her back straightened. "How can I love her? I don't know her. And that's really personal."

"In the socialite world, that's what we call a 'Yes,' my shy Nina. Oh, and by the way, I dreamt about you and how we used to be besties in another lifetime," Sky said, attempting to lighten the mood and change directions.

Sky had been born into a family with so much power that she the world was without boundaries, besides the invisible ones she created. To watch Nina squirm was not her intention, so she wanted to talk to this woman whom she felt a sister-like bond to. She didn't have any siblings, so this was as awkward a conversation for her as it was for Nina.

Nina turned her head to look out the window where she saw a breathtaking view of the moon. She didn't know how she got to Japan, but apparently she had teleported to San Francisco, then to Japan with the rest of the kids after the riot.

Nina had been so scared that night she was found by Juno. Dodging bullets

from an OZONE helicopter in the process, Juno told her how to touch a ‘teleportation Port Rune,’ as she called it. After pronouncing a Magickal word, Nina was whisked away to a cave. By the time Juno made it through the Port Rune, she had already sustained multiple gunshot wounds. Nina remembered the pain and the horror she felt that night, much like the night her parents died.

“Ok, so maybe I like her,” Nina said, looking down at the scar from a cut on her hand, “but I just got out of a terrible relationship with—well never mind.”

“So I’m guessing your ex was abusive?” Sky asked, “Not only by the pause in your words, but by the way you talk about him? Or maybe her?”

“Her.”

“I thought so, but I didn’t want to offend you or assume anything, and you don’t have to be an empath, or whatever you are to feel that tension,” Sky continued, “Juno comes along and saves your life, and you feel a bond of protection and adrenaline you’ve never felt before?”

“Well, yes and yes, but maybe my feelings are wrong. I tend to be extreme with them. When did this become ‘Profile Nina Day,’ and why do I feel like such a moron?” Nina asked, standing up.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to pry, but I like to see things work out the way they’re supposed to. You two seem pretty amazing together, and it’s sorta special, so I would totally hold onto it if I were you.” Sky stood and gave Nina an awkward hug.

“Besides, in my dreams, you two were married.” She looked into Nina’s blue eyes and said, “Happily, I might add.”

She turned on her heels and walked out of the room into the hallway of the giant Pagoda where she’d been a resident since the night Juno kidnapped her. Nina thought about the deep conversation she had with Sky. Now she knew why Blue was so distraught about her missing the Port Rune to this ancient city.

“Happily?” Nina repeated to herself. She planned to hold onto the word like her greatest secret.

Chapter 8

SO WE'VE HEARD

"I want to go shopping!" Star said as they walked out of the diner. "I mean, since I'm never going back to that god awful school, and you guys are skipping, we might as well go do something fun."

"That's actually a good idea." Ahlina stopped herself to think about the fact that she agreed with Star. "Wow, I really just said that."

Scape looked at Kaery for approval. "Ok, maybe not shopping, but maybe let's go party at the beach."

Crux stood next to the eavesdropping teenager that wasn't so much taller than him, Never. "You didn't know you were Witchbreed either, did you?"

Never looked down at the boy and asked, "What's a Witch-bee?"

"'Witchbreed!' And never mind." Crux looked at Ahlina and asked, "When can we eat again?"

"You don't need to eat anymore, kid," Ahlina sighed. "You ate enough for all of us to last a week! So, Kaery, shopping it is, right?"

Crux pouted, then perked up as he looked around for the food he smelled in the air.

Star said, "Union Square is right around the corner, but we might not want to go there after that cop who got fired went all psychotic on the crowd last night, but the mall is safe across the street. Oh, and high fashion from the Castro—not to mention local designers in the Haight—we've got so many choices!"

Pedestrians walked past the kids as if they were too busy to try and figure out what language they were speaking. Scape noticed some people gave a puzzled expression while others simply ignored them completely.

"Umm, kid, is it going to be like this always? I mean, the part where people kinda leave us alone like crazy bums."

"Pretty much," Crux replied simply. "When you're completely enlightened, it'll be much worse. You'll find it hard to relate to a human, let alone communicate with one. Well, unless they're Broken, but that's a whole 'nother story."

"Ok you lost me at Witchbird," Never said, in his confused quiet tone that was almost unheard over the noise of passing electric busses and city traffic.

“He said ‘Witchbreed,’ and who said you can tag along, stalker?” Star towered over Never in her six-inch stilettos. “Last I checked, you were not part of the clique.”

“Oh, I’m sorry.” Never began to walk away with his head down.

“Wait,” Kaery said, grabbing Never’s arm. “I’m sorry for my friend. You should totally come shopping with us.”

“Score!” Ahlina and Scape said simultaneously as they high-fived each other.

“Wait who has money?” Scape asked Ahlina.

“Who said we need money?” Ahlina said, “I’m the queen of ghost touching.”

“You mean money like this,” Star said, as she showed the kids her empty hands. She pretended to reach into her clutch bag as Crux stared intently. Pulling her hands away, there was a handful of one hundred dollar bills.

“Glamour, gotta love it.”

“Whoa! Score!” Ahlina and Scape said, again high-fiving each other.

Kaery only saw the receipt from the restaurant. “I don’t get it.” She realized she was still holding Never’s arm and let go as she looked up to see his dark eyes staring at her.

Crux shook his head. “You all really have no clue. The more you use your Magick, the more you’ll attract other Supernaturals. Some are not so nice. And apparently OZONE isn’t so keen on Magick either.”

*

Deme paced back and forth in his minimalist apartment. The cold interior was set to the same temperature as the OZONE lab where he spent countless hours researching his greatest enemy, Surge-Overload. He finally got a glimpse of this infamous hacker, but only a fragment of her face. After all of this time, a teenage girl was the one eluding Deme and his legion of the world’s most elite Hackers and Technomages.

He couldn’t possibly fathom how Guardian missed the target, and then he heard that the Super Soldier was manipulated by one of the rarest forms of Supernaturals, a Mancers. The report said that Guardian was forced to jump off a

fifth story balcony to his doom. Fortunately he landed in a half-filled dumpster where all he ended up with was a bruised ego.

That was the one time Deme had Surge-Overload cornered, and the entire operation was messed up by Narles, the Assassin with an outstanding military record that garnered the interest of the OZONE Recruiting Department. The only reason Narles survived was that he rolled under a mailbox after the rioters stole his C-4 explosives. That was easy enough to cover up in the media, but no one expected Surge-Overload to be friends with Mancers.

“I’ve underestimated you for the last time! Next time, you’re as good as dead!”

*

“I’m as good as dead, I suppose,” Narles whispered to himself through the pain and needles in his busted body.

“Please don’t try to speak, Agent Narles,” a nurse said to him. He could only hear her because he couldn’t see through his swollen black and blue eyes.

“I’m Janie, your personal nurse deep within the Under-Base. You’re lucky you made it out of that riot with the injuries you have. But then again, I don’t expect any less from you Agents or Soldiers.” The woman spoke in a confident and friendly tone.

Narles tried to piece together what she was talking about. The morphine was extremely strong, and he could feel himself going into a dream state.

“Prepare for the amputation,” a masculine voice said.

Wait did you just say amputation? Narles thought desperately.

“Yes, Doctor Rin. The procedure has been prepped. Your tools are there,” Nurse Janie said.

“You’re sure he’s sedated?”

Narles let out a muffled groan as Doctor Rin clicked on the bone saw, a mechanical screech filling the room.

“Absolutely. He’s out.”

No, God damnit, I’m still awake! Don’t cut me the fuck up!

“Okay, Contact.”

The blade sputtered as it ripped into the flesh of Narles' right leg.

I felt that! This is not sedation!

"Watch the artery!" Nurse Janie cried.

What is that smell? My blood! My bones are being grinded!

She stumbled back and held a hand over her mouth as the amputated leg flopped onto the floor.

"Too late!" the Doctor replied, moving onto the left leg, "just get me a tourniquet! We'll make a clot until the prosthetics arrive!"

This is fucking awful! No one deserves this. Why am I still awake? Nooooo!

"He's losing a lot of blood!" Nurse Janie ran out of the operating room, wiping vomit from her lips.

"And a lot more blood to come," the Doctor said to himself, "this is just the beginning, poor fella."

I didn't check the fucking donor box on my combat release form, you sadistic freaks!

*

"No way in hell am I wearing that!" Ahlina said in her best Kaery imitation. She laughed with Scape, and even Crux joined in on the mocking as they sat in the lobby of the Twelfth Boutique, Star busy trying on racks of clothes in the dressing room.

"Hey, guys, aren't we supposed to be doing something good, like, I don't know, homework?" Crux laughed as he effortlessly dodged a swat from Kaery.

Never walked over to Kaery and saw her blush slightly from being mocked. He desperately wanted to calm her and hug her while her friends teased. It just didn't seem so funny to him because he knew Kaery was shy, and she truly was a good person.

"Hey, guys, stop making fun of her!" Never shouted louder than even he expected. His black eyes looked infuriated as if he were protecting a baby from lions.

"Ok, so what kind of drugs did you wake up and take with your bottle of Jack?" Star said, walking from behind the veil of the dressing room. She was looking at Never as intently as all of the other kids. "Now that you've ruined my

debut, well, how do I look?” Star said sarcastically, looking at Never with pursed lips.

“Alright, I’m out,” Never said, noticing the awkward silence from the group. He picked his backpack up and ran out of the boutique. His embarrassment wasn’t due to the fact that he’d just made himself look like a jealous boyfriend, but rather that Kaery had looked at him with such a puzzled expression.

Kaery wanted to follow Never out and tell him that it was ok, that she was used to the jokes of the kids. Besides, she liked when they all were together having fun, even if it was at her expense. The only thing she could think of was the all too familiar energy he gave while protecting her. She knew him, somehow.

“Crux, what did the Tarot lady say about déjà vu?” Kaery turned her attention from the fleeing Never to the small preteen. “Tell me.”

“Cool out,” Crux said defensively.

“Correction, its *chill* out. If you’re going to use slang, please use it, well—” Ahlina was cut off abruptly.

“Whatever!” Crux said with a wrinkled brow. “Anyway, Kaery, she said that Wicasht don’t have déjà vu. They only have memories and Enlightenment. Whoa, look at me, all Knowledge-boy, as if I paid attention to all of that crone’s lessons.”

Noticing no one was excited about his recollection of the lesson, Crux straightened up his posture and stopped smiling so big. “Erm... she also said that when Witchbreed come together, it is no coincidence, but an...”

“An what?” Scape asked, “You can’t just leave a cliffhanger like that!”

“Yeah, this kid is starting to get on my nerves with the cryptic speech.” Ahlina said.

“I don’t care about the kid. How do I look, damnit?” Star did a fashion spin in the middle of the huddle, pushing Crux to the side.

Crux took this opportunity to pick-pocket the glamorous teenager in her expensive dress. The clutch was in her hand, but it was an easy swipe, just a trick of the fingers if she could only get in reach. He knew the kids were focused on the black sequined mini-dress as Star’s red locks flew about her like a commercial on TV. As she got closer with her ballerina grace in heels only professional models wore, he lifted his arm only to feel the sudden clasp of Kaery’s hand over his wrist.

“When Witchbreed come together, it is no coincidence, but an Omen of the Covens!” Kaery said, with her eyes hauntingly wide, turning a fiery molten gold. “That’s what you were going to say, right?”

“That’s exactly what she said. How did you know that?” Crux asked quizzically. For a brief moment, he forgot his mission to steal Star’s purse.

Chapter 9

RUINS OF ZALOMONI

Surge had never hit the ground harder than she did at the outskirts of the Forbidden City of Zalomoni. She took a moment to regain her thoughts and made sure she wasn't dead. *So that was the second time I teleported in one day. Stuff of sci-fi fantasy just got real! It sure isn't what I expected and, oh my god, I'm throwing up again. 'Stargate' makes it look so easy. I feel like my insides were thrown in a blender to make smoothies for hungry zombies downtown. Wait, where am I? This place looks like an ancient city that an even more ancient bomb went off in and killed all its citizens! Oh look, there's Maia. How come she's walking around as if she didn't go through the same teleportation portal I did? I was almost this sick the first time I traveled with Sky and the others to the Pagoda. Wow, Maia's hair is bouncy!*

She's coming closer, and this is embarrassing, crouched over my own lunch. Why are all the Mancer girls so pretty, and I'm just so plain? Why do I feel like I'm the only one that's ever sick? Where are we? Why can't I feel my hands? Queasy. Great, she's helping me up.

"Hi, Maia," Surge muttered miserably. Her face was more pale than normal and had a slight hint of green undertones. She knew that she was easily prone to car sickness, but this was the worst feeling she'd ever felt.

"Hello, Surge-Overload," Maia said, smiling as she helped the young teenager to her feet. "I have to show you something, and even though we let you regain your composure for a few hours, I think it's time I helped you get over your sickness. Gemini says it's quite normal for first-time port runners. Well, in my case I didn't so much feel sick as I felt disoriented from the constellation shift..."

"Ok, I get it. I'm the weakest link here. Why did they rush us in that room to port anyway?" Surge asked with some irritation. "Oh, wait, never mind, it's all coming back to me now. The OZONE task force was coming for us. Somehow they tracked my laptop. My laptop! Where is it? Did anyone get it before we rushed into the portal?"

"You were there, Surge. Jayde showed up out of nowhere when you were hacking OZONE, then picked us up as if we weighed nothing and ran to the

meditation room. We didn't have time to get anything. When we came to the other side, we all were in this ruined city.”

Maia looked up at the broken structures in awe. She realized this was an ancient civilization that even OZONE had yet to uncover. The architecture looked nothing like the buildings of modern times or the pyramids of cultures long past. These were domes of gold, metal and stone. They were gigantic in height. Most of them had been broken and shattered, as if explosions happened from both inside and out. Standing almost as high as the towers were status of champions, warriors and monks with ornate armor. They must have taken centuries to carve out of the mountains that surrounded the outer parts of the city.

The once-immaculate streets were shattered in most places by what could have been an earthquake. Many vines choked the life out of the temple walls, and huge leaves the size of cars shaded the grounds where Maia and Surge walked slowly toward a temple. Runes of Magick could be half-read under the vines and thorns that covered them like a blanket of the forgotten.

There were gashes on the ground as if huge claws had ripped at the very stone of this place. Maia was fascinated by the flaws of the city. The closer she looked, the more intriguing the story became. An epic battle had been fought here. Anyone could see that, but the fight had been devastating for the two sides who had clearly underestimated each other. Judging by the sharp wounds in the stone foundations, guards had been fighting off giant creatures, attempting to prevent destruction of the city, but to no avail. The guards themselves must have held great power to keep such gigantic creatures at bay.

Surge could feel her senses regaining some sense of normalcy. As she felt her health being rejuvenated, she saw something miraculous. With every step she took with Maia, the stones in the ruined city began to reform into smooth streets, and the vines retracted into the ground from whence they came. The ancient structures were being brought back to their former glory as people began to fill the streets in a panic. Most were dressed in garb that Surge hadn't seen referenced in any book or file OZONE kept.

Surge looked at Maia. Her hands were shining light, and her eyes glowed a faint blue. Everywhere Maia looked, it seemed she was uncovering the truth of what had happened here. Surge wondered if Maia was aware of her powers. Maia's hand was still on Surge's waist as they walked toward the temple in front of them. It was the largest and most elaborate one in the city. A carving of a Dragon had

been ornately crafted on the outside of the temple, its tail and body coiling around the building all the way to the top. It made the skyscrapers downtown look like a playpen.

Surge continued to view the chaos. Men and women, clad in armor, carrying dangerous looking weapons, ran past the two Mancers as if they didn't exist, determined to stop the horde of creatures from destroying the city. Surge's heart almost stopped as she saw a familiar face. He was just as handsome in this vision as he had been in others. Her Uncle was clad in armor that looked so fierce, she stepped out of his way, though she assumed this was just a realistic vision that couldn't hurt her. The ground rocked back and forth as an earthquake rumbled. Maia didn't seem to lose her footing as Surge almost did. Her Uncle ran at inhuman speed, a group of men and women close behind him, all holding their weapons fast.

"Maia, what's going on? What is this?" Surge asked, "How did the city go from desolate to raging with armor-clad characters from a good MMO game?" Surge knew that Maia was in a trance and would not answer her. She still hoped to get the answers she longed for.

"This building is huge!" Surge yelled, "What could possibly be in this thing? Who could have built it?" Surge looked up until her neck couldn't stretch back anymore. *Whatever it is, these guards surrounding it lost their formation and are headed that way.* Surge looked behind her for the first time to see a wall situated between two large mountains. Bordering the wall were two male champions, wearing distinct suits of armor, but both equally regal-looking. On the wall itself was a female wearing a combination of a suit of armor and a dress. The garb looked like that of a warrior queen. None of these statues looked remotely familiar, yet the place was definitely somewhere that was loved by many. The wall was being punished on the other side by who knows what as the dust from the warrior queen poured onto the city she protected. *Holy crap! That warrior queen is Jayde!*

Roars filled the air thicker than the dust as the wall continued to receive punishment. The guards that stood on top of the wall shot a myriad of arrows and projectiles onto the other side. The howls continued as the onslaught moved the very foundation of the beautiful city. Surge stopped moving the moment she saw hundreds of giant beasts tearing their way over and through the beautiful wall like a flood, destroying everything in their path.

Surge felt a fear she'd never felt strike the core of her existence. Something primal was destroying this city, and it was as well organized as the chaos that

created the planet. It ripped relentlessly through the warriors that stood in its way. Monsters appeared, seemingly from fairytales. These looked like werewolves, werecats and other beings Surge had only seen in files from OZONE. Her uncle was wiping out waves of them with his oversized sword as Surge grabbed Maia's hand and rushed her into the temple as if they were living in the moment of the great battle. She was lost in the vision at this point, forgetting when and where she was from.

“We have to get out of here, Maia,” Surge said hurriedly as she ran for safety in the temple. She tried not to cry as she thought of her Uncle and his army being overwhelmed by the sheer numbers of the creatures attacking. As they entered the temple holding hands, they both looked around for answers and safety. They noticed a set of steps that split and spiraled toward the top of this temple.

As Surge and Maia got to the base of the steps, another familiar face was present. Jayde was stepping down the stairs as if the roaring and earthquakes were as insignificant as a fly buzzing past her ear. She was adorned in armor that resembled the army fighting for the very life of the city. The metal looked almost like reflective glass with crystals and runes glowing in different areas. Maia was used to seeing Jayde's hands bandaged in monk wraps, but now they were soft and deadly-looking, nothing touching them but the bracer resting on the top of her hand.

Jayde's hands seemed to tremble slightly as she looked back up the stairs one last time and said aloud, “Ahlina, may I see you next lifetime, little sister. I wish I was able to let you travel the world as you always wished instead of letting my world dictate your path. They have a fight ahead of them if they plan on getting through me!” She turned to walk toward the entrance to the Temple. “May Kirari protect us in our time of need—if we need him?” Jayde said a final prayer as the dress she wore seemed to move on its own behind her.

A beautifully woven silk was intricately sewn into the armor which looked like nothing Maia or Surge had ever seen. The perfect blend of feminine and masculine protective gear safeguarded the juggernaut known as Jayde. The metallic breastplate was adorned with golden illuminated runes that seemed to gleam brighter with every step Jayde took toward the entrance. Her black hair was in neat braids that spun in two halos behind her, the rest of her long silky locks hanging down to her knee caps.

Jayde began to pick up her pace, stalking like a force of nature on a warpath as she approached the battle. Surge couldn't help but see the charging mob of beasts that was about to get in the Asian woman's way. She looked as if she could take on OZONE armies by herself. Her enemy, however, was something more unimaginably terrifying than any creature Surge or an armor-clad OZONE Agent had ever seen.

Maia's eyes widened as she watched Jayde palm strike a Spiraar in the chest. The anthropomorphic beast writhed in pain, its eyes glowing with a crimson haze that was extinguished in a split-second as the impact from Jayde's blow caused instant death and launched the carcass into the distance much like the boulders she struck in the courtyard during her training. She tucked and rolled on the ground, breaking the limbs of six more giant beasts before rising to her feet and destroying their skulls with her bare hands. The physical appearance of the Spiraar from one to the next represented every species in the animal kingdom. Some exhibited a clash of human and canine attributes, while others were products of more heinous combinations. Almost every chimera imaginable was on a rampage toward Jayde. Various combinations of mammal, insect, bird, reptile, amphibian and marine traits were seen in each macabre figure.

Her movement was so agile and fluid, it scared Maia. For the first time, she saw Jayde's true skill, which surpassed the training dummy martial arts drills that had gained the Mancers' attention at the Pagoda. Maia could not see a weakness in Jayde's technique.

"Flawless," she said aloud.

Surge nearly jumped as Maia spoke her first words since they had walked into the temple. As Jayde left a trail of carcasses on her trek to the main wall, Surge completely agreed with the descriptive word Maia used for the Asian warrior Goddess' attack:

"Wave of Mutilation," Maia said.

The roars from Spiraars did not stop, and the more she killed, the more flew over the wall. Jayde walked like a panther, taking down each beast with little effort. She used lightning-fast kicks against twenty-foot-tall Spiraar, breaking their jaws as effortlessly as if she were stepping on flowers in a field. Punches that struck four creatures at once with an invisible force seemed to drill through anything in their path for a hundred feet. Jayde met with what was left of her

guards. Her presence seemed to give them all an air of rejuvenated warrior instinct as they began to fight for the lives of all they loved.

*

Blue walked along a worn-out path alone. His short black hair was as messy as it normally was after all the climbing and running. Gemini had told him to explore when he got to Zalomoni, and he'd already seen a great deal of this ruined city within some canyon. It was long-abandoned, and the air was a lot cleaner than any he'd ever breathed. The moment he arrived at a lake with odd-shaped stones protruding out of its still waters, he could hear his sister's voice as if she were standing next to him.

“So what have you got yourself into now, Blue?” Charity asked, “This place is pretty in a cryptic way. Do you know who lived here?”

“I don't know, you're right—and no clue.” Blue answered with a smirk on his face as he realized that if anyone might be spying on him, it would look like he was talking aloud to himself, but he didn't care.

“Look over there, Blue. Those rocks are beautiful. I wonder what those markings are? Check it out!”

He took a breath and walked so fast, he seemed to appear in front of the stone in a split-second. It reminded him of Sky's blinding speed of thought. *I hope Sky is okay.* His hand rubbed the old mossy stone and moved a couple vines to the side. The sun shone on the ageless rock as if it were waking an old friend. Blue noticed the Runes under the moss begin to glow in the sun rays.

“I've seen these before. The flashbacks in Pangaea had them. They were so hard to read. Wait, this one says, ‘Wicasht,’ and this one says, ‘Jreamers.’ ”

Blue pointed at a three-dimensional hieroglyphic eyeball and the Runes spinning around it. He tilted his head slightly and took a step back slowly.

“What, Blue? What do you see?” Charity asked impatiently. “You Mancers tend to zone out if you haven't noticed.”

Blue pondered this idea of ‘zoning out.’ *I have lost track of time lately. How long has it even been since I killed my family?*

“This place...It’s a little over a million years old, protected by Supernaturals,” Blue said, “very old and powerful ones who mastered the Soulstream. If I’m supposed to master my powers, it’s going to be here!”

*

Maia and Surge gasped aloud as they saw the relentless onslaught of beasts overtaking the entire city. Thousands were dead from both sides, yet the chaos continued. Jayde and Guardian's forces were no match for the constant waves of creatures that ripped at everything in their paths. Taught by Jayde herself to protect Zalomoni at all costs, the elite army of martial artists, monks and priestesses was being overwhelmed, and she knew in her heart that this was the end of the peaceful nation of warriors.

Jayde said a silent prayer for the fallen warriors at her feet as she fought with every bit of energy she could conjure. Her dress was shredded, and the armor, though still polished, was covered in blood, saliva, venom and tears. Suddenly a dark shadow was looming over the city, threatening to block out the sun. She looked high in the sky to where she knew the one being dwelled who could save her city. The clouds covering the mountains cleared for only a brief second, and Jayde took in a deep breath as she stared up at one of the most magnificent spectacles she'd ever seen in this lifetime.

“Kirari has awakened!”

*

Guardian believed in Jayde with all of his heart. His whole life had been made for this moment. He was only twenty-five years old, but he had fought thousands of battles with Supernaturals and creatures from beyond the walls of Zalomoni. His heart was racing with every swing of his heavy sword. Sweat blended with blood, dripping into his weary eyes. He was born to fight, and with all of his power, that was what he was going to do.

“Fall back, Eight Heavens strategy!” Guardian screamed out to the men and women of his elite squadron. Jayde was behind them fighting her own battle of

sixty or so Spiraar, and she was doing quite well as expected. Guardian knew that these gigantic creatures were warriors of Gaia. They were huge in every sense of the word, some of them much bigger than the Spiraar he hunted daily for food and clothing, but never before had he seen them attacking a city as a single unit. They were clearly in some sort of trance, and murder was all that they knew.

Guardian remembered the old tales about the first war called the Great War, when man was made supernatural for but one day by the Coven of Unity. That same night, the spell was reversed, and man was stupefied with a Veil of Ignorance. Needless to say, before humans were changed back into simple mortals, they nearly destroyed the planet with uncontrolled and clumsy Magicks conjured by their imaginations. The once peaceful Pangaea then broke into continents, and billions of lives were lost.

Gaia was on the verge of death when she created her own warriors of justice to fight off the Earth's impending doom. With every earthquake and storm, millions of Spiraar were born from the soil and pure mineral landscapes all over the world. With nothing but murder on their minds, the beasts were bewitched by Magickal instincts to destroy everything in their path until Gaia was pure again. These enchanted beasts cared not for their own lives, nor did they fear pain. They were gifted with accelerated regeneration, super strength, uncanny flexibility and heightened senses among other abilities by the Mancer that is the spirit of the planet, Gaia.

Guardian had known this story his whole life, yet he had only encountered a few dozen Spiraar up until this moment. He knew them as primitive, but it was expected. They usually ran in small packs, not more than the four to twelve he'd usually seen. They protected the groves which they held sacred, and they hunted small game much like the other carnivores in the area. The Spiraar were able to shape shift into any of the indigenous creatures, which made it hard to hunt them down. Weaker versions of these extremely powerful beasts were being born as the Spiraar mated with less volatile wildlife. Spiraloupe, also known as werewolves, now ran wild, hunting throughout the plains. Spirafel, also known as werecats, were now stalking prey in the shadows of the forests. Many other new breeds of Spiraar cubs had emerged these last few decades, but either way, they were never organized enough to launch a full-scale attack. As head of the Elite Royal Guard, Guardian should have seen this coming and better prepared his soldiers.

His men backed away from the waves of Spiraar and their offspring as the glowing eyes of these creatures proved there was no reasoning or peace to be made this day, only annihilation on one side or the other. The warriors strategically placed each of their comrades in peripheral vision and made an octagon formation with their backs toward Jayde as they had been trained to do. Using each other's strengths and falling on their peers' formal training, the soldiers trusted each other with their lives as they sliced methodically and gracefully through the raging beasts. What they lacked in numbers they made up for in skill and discipline that not a single Spiraar could comprehend.

The members of the Elite Royal Guard had been hand-picked by Guardian himself as some of the most promising Jreamers he'd ever seen. They were sent through extensive spiritual training by the Wicasht Priestesses and Monks as well as decades of rigorous martial arts drills. None were accepted into the Elite Royal Guard unless they had successfully fought through a trial with Guardian and Jayde as the final test. From one obstacle to the next, these soldiers proved themselves as the most amazing martial artists with killer instincts and laser precision. Guardian would lay his own honor on the line for each and every one of them.

Being proficient with many weapons was a prime requisite, but complete mastery of at least one was expected. Most of these warriors learned how to use weapons from the moment they could lift them. Guardian helped them develop love for their weapons as if each one were an extension of the wielder. Jayde blessed each of the warriors' weapons as she witnessed the strength of each perfect union. Her blessings were never flawed because she seemed to see deep within each soldier's heart. The city was full of noble and skilled fighters, but the Elite Royal Guard was by far the best of them all.

"We are being overrun, sir!" Melviel said to Guardian as he used his twin swords, Poseidon and Neptune, to cut a Spiraar's head in half. His heavy breathing was wracked with pain from the chest wound he had sustained after being surrounded by six Spiraar and still coming out alive.

"They heal as fast as we cut, sir. What are we to do?"

Guardian knew what Melviel meant as he sliced through the Spiraar. He closed his eyes in the midst of the chaos, took his helmet off and stabbed the ground with his oversized broad sword, called Oblivion. *This is the end of my life, but it will not be in vain. I will fight until these monsters are pushed out of our city. If I don't try, then my life was for nothing. I have fought too hard to let it end this*

way. Please, Gods and Goddesses, grant me the strength to purge these lands of this great evil! Once I have done that, you can take me back to the Soulstream.

Jayde watched from across the battlefield as her Elite Royal Guard was being backed into an eight wall impenetrable formation. Guardian was praying, and his men and women were being overwhelmed by thousands of enormous man-beast predators. *Redirecting my Chi I will grant Guardian strength. Take this with you, most honorable warrior.* She turned in a whirlwind form and sent Guardian a renewed vigor, then smiled and returned to the fighting. Changing her arms into pure titanium rods of impenetrable force, she pulverized every opponent in her path as if they were the test stones her warriors crushed in the practice courts. Jayde had unparalleled control over her body as a Metamancer. She was able to control her metabolism to grant herself superior agility, strength, flexibility, speed and grace. This level of self-awareness allowed her to intercept and disembowel each Spiraar in one fluid motion before moving on to the next.

Yet her power was limited, and she knew better. She had complete control over the Chi within her own body, but she could not control the Chi of anyone else without severe consequences. She weakened her own abilities dramatically whenever she attempted such a feat. Her beautiful black hair cascaded down her back in its pristine braids and loops as she fell to one knee from the loss of energy. She saw the enemy surrounding her, much like Guardian's squadron had. She looked at her hands that symbolized the power of this great nation, and for the first time, they shook uncontrollably. Her green eyes sparked with an undying silent defiance as she focused to regain strength. She refused to cry or give up hope. *I may not be enough to hold these beasts back.*

*

Ahlna looked at the Magickal binding on her bandaged hands and asked for forgiveness, knowing that she had to leave this place in order to find her coven. She took the bandages off slowly, even though she knew it was forbidden, and stood in the dusty room that held the pride of her hometown, Zalomoni, the Dark Prism Dragon, Kirari. Her short black hair covered her green eyes that were the only similarity she had to her older sister, the Goddess of these lands, Jayde. Jayde

never wanted her to leave because she said the world was dangerous and full of too many variables.

She caught herself smiling in the candle-lit room, looking up at one of the most incredible creatures she'd ever laid her eyes upon. She heard of Dragons in old tales, but she also knew they had fled Earth after the Great War. There were very few left on the planet, and one of them was but a few feet from her touch. Ahlina took a step closer, knowing that Jayde would kill her for disrupting Kirari's slumber. Her whole life, she'd been taught that most things, especially Magick, were forbidden. To awaken the Dragon was forbidden. To leave the City was forbidden. Hell, the name 'Zalomoni' meant 'the Forbidden City.' Ahlina hated it. This was her time to defy everything forbidden and to do what she wanted.

After a long pause, Ahlina reached her palm toward the sleeping majestic beast. The sweat from her brow wouldn't stop, even though she was telling herself that she wasn't nervous. This was the moment she'd prayed for, but she just couldn't force her muscles to touch the Dragon. Ahlina was a Witchbreed able to see not only the Runes, but also the very code that makes up the Magick present in all creation.

With the bandages removed, she could see the Runes spinning around her palm and wrist. The words 'chaos' and 'disruption' glowed brightly. She knew the warnings Jayde berated her with, and she knew that everything she touched somehow changed, sometimes for the better, but most times for the terribly worse. She didn't want to hurt Kirari like she had hurt so many other people in Zalomoni, so she hesitated and stood there shaking.

At that moment, a loud blast came from outside, and Ahlina snapped to her senses. She turned to run toward the large door to see what exactly could be causing the alarm. Ahlina was horrified to see large Spiraar eating people alive, destroying everything they touched. They were making their way deep into the city, and the Elite Royal guard was not going to be able to hold them for very long. Ahlina ran back to the Dragon, and this time, with tears in her eyes, touched the scales. "Wake up! We need you!"

*

Juno woke up from her nap, gasping as she looked at Nina, “I just remembered that little brat Ahlina got me killed!”

Chapter 10

EXPENDABLE

Narles lay in bed hooked up to a machine that had just awoken him from his coma as he quietly tried to understand his current predicament. His pain was not unbearable, so he must have had some interestingly strong prescription medicine in those IV's. He didn't move as he controlled his heart rate to stop the panic and looked at all of his limbs in casts. The last thing he remembered before waking up in the bed was shooting Surge-Overload in the head.

He knew that he was in bad shape. If he could see himself in the mirror, he'd probably cry, and he wasn't much of a crybaby. OZONE was his employer, and he was willing to die for the organization. Apparently he was good at a lot of things, and dying wasn't one of them. He remembered that he had shot the wrong guy, but his memory was hazy, and he couldn't get his thoughts to stop jumping from his childhood to exploding battlefields, from trials for excessive force to the moment he tried to commit suicide surrounded by beer cans and bullets.

Sharp pains surged through Narles' eyes like pricking needles as he tried to look in one direction too fast. He couldn't stop a tear from falling as he slowly closed his eyes while a fierce headache formed. He wanted to go to sleep and possibly never awake. He couldn't think of anything more painful than the thumping behind his eyelids and under his swollen temples. The incessant beeping of the machine sounded like a jack hammer piercing his skull every second. Narles could no longer control his heart rate. He would've screamed if it weren't for the oxygen mask attached to his mouth and the tube shoved down his throat.

Dear Lord, what have I done to deserve this? I went to church. I voted for the guy who supported state religion and opposed women's rights. I hate the gays for you, Lord. More than that, I hate the Supernatural scum who disease the planet and prey upon your children like animals. What am I talking about? I don't have a fucking clue what's going on. I can't even tell where I am or how I got here. I'm supposed to be dead. I'm supposed to suffer for what I did to those people. No, I was doing your will, right?

I was all for this new job after I got discharged. I knew it was a sign from you, dear Lord, as I received that call with the barrel of my Glock in my mouth. I've done all I can to serve and protect people from terrorists. They threaten

America and our freedom. They know I'm weak, and they try to take advantage of me, Lord, but I still fight. I'm your mortal instrument. Do with me as you will, but PLEASE stop this fucking pain. Please, Lord, make them give me more morphine or some shit because my head is killing me, and all of my limbs sting like a bitch! I'm sorry I'm swearing, dear Lord, but I can't help it. I'm a Soldier, and it's all I've ever wanted to be. I don't know what to do, and I don't know what to say, but I am here to serve you in any way I can. I promise if get me off this bed and put a gun back in my hand, I'll shoot all those liberal godless bastards.

I'm sorry, Lord, for being sexually confused when that freak, Agent Zeer, was interrogating me. He has delicate hands, dear Lord, and I didn't know what he did to my prostate, but I sure didn't mean to feel that way when he whipped me for information. I'll go to church even more than I did last week.

I've always heard that people get religious when they are in these situations, but I didn't know I'd be one of them. I always prayed for a swift death by a gunshot or plane crash—or maybe something cool like being cut in half by a Katana. I never knew an explosion felt like this.

That's right, some little fairy boy with a girl's haircut is the reason I'm in here. He took my C-4 and detonated it on the mob. Why did the mob attack me? I was dressed like a cop. Even undercover, that was pretty fucking strange. Whatever, I still killed Surge-Overload. I'm a national hero. No, an INTERNATIONAL hero! They'll decorate me with all kinds of awards. Damn, this headache is killing me. Why do I feel like I'm on fire?

*

“Agent Zeer, checking in to the Receptionist.”

“Proceed, Agent Zeer.”

“I have information on the condition of Soldier Narles.”

“Continue with your report,” the Receptionist said coldly.

“He's still in the induced coma. His memories are still muddled at best, but he truly believes he killed Surge-Overload. His thoughts are a chaotic prayer, and his self-loathing is...”

“I don't care about that. Stick to the facts.” The Receptionist cut him off abruptly.

Agent Zeer had jet black hair that he subconsciously slicked back with his pale fingers. He knew that the Receptionists were not interested in feelings or intangibles, but in cold hard facts.

“We don’t have any more information about Surge-Overload due to his memory confusion, but we Psel are making progress on the reconstruction of his limbs. The neurocybersynthetic implants are adjusting well to his body as if he were born with them.”

“When will he be fit for discharge back into the field?”

“Within a month.”

“If he does not give you the results you need, kill him.”

“Roger that.”

“Over and out.”

“10-4”

Chapter 11

BUILDING A MYSTERY

Witchbreed, also known as Wicasht, are the ‘Keepers of Mystery.’ Having taken an Oath to uphold the balance, we all keep our secrets close to our Spellcrafts. Each Coven does their due diligence to keep this Oath intact. We must not break the Veil of Ignorance! Those that breach the covenant are subject to harsh Judgment from the Great Circle.

Most Covens hold their Spellcrafts in the highest regard, which are therefore the most mysterious of all secrets on Earth. Since mystery and secrets are the very backbone and foundation of Wicasht society, it is no wonder there are hidden groves around the world. Some of these sacred groves are so secret that even other Witchbreed have lost the maps and all recollection of their existence.

I am from a sacred Grove far from the likes of humanity. It is filled with creatures long forgotten by the outside world. The beasts are my friends, and the Fae are my family. I was born able to wield the powers of the Fae and am surrounded by their graces with every song and dance. Though this Lost Continent, named after our matriarch and founder, Ara of the Ballade, is my home, I feel alone and lost.

There are many Wicasht, Spiraar, prehistoric monsters and mythological beasts on this Lost Continent, yet they look at me as though I am an outsider. It is not like the Monoceros Coven is a malicious branch of the Wicasht; it is not in our nature to be so. However they look at me differently. Glancing at me with ever-judging eyes, they keep many secrets from me. The Queen mother has taught me what it is to be a Wicasht.

Queen Mother, Amarantine taught me that there was a Great War at the beginning of the planet’s early life. This war almost destroyed the fabrics of reality and tore Pangaea, a once peaceful continent, into pieces. The Monoceros Coven was nicknamed the Fairy Kin because the other covens believed we abandoned the war and choose to evacuate with the Fae. The Queen Mother did not deny the claims, for our first ancestor, Ara, was the twin of a self-obsessed Glamora. While Glamora stayed in the lime light of the other covens with her league of superficial Glamori, Ara used her powers to manipulate the environment and shroud the eighth continent in potent Magicks, protecting it forever from harm.

The Lost Continent and its founder disappeared from the rest of the world that day. It would seem the place I call home would be lost forever, only found by accident or by summon. Some sailors have crashed to their deaths while listening to my sisters, and some have never left, dying a blissful death but thought lost at sea. While some dream of a mystical place such as this and how they would never want to leave, I dream of the day I can be free of it.

Ever since I was a small girl, I was enlightened by the Queen Mother who told me to always stay true to my heart and never be ashamed of my purple hair, for it is the mark of the Fae's favored. I love my hair, and I am ready to fulfill my destiny, to leave the Lost Continent and reunite with my true coven, the Coven of Unity.

~ Heaven ~

(Written in hieroglyphs on the walls of the Holy Temple of Ballade)

Chapter 12

HAVE A LITTLE CHAT

Crux stood in front of his target with a new-found resolution. He looked the Shandor directly in his cold unblinking eyes and breathed deep. In the next moment, it was going to be either the Shandor's unlife or his own immortal shell, but either way, someone was going down. His hand shook slightly as he remembered the last time he had to fight the Vampyl on the docks.

"So you've found me, huh?" Crux whispered defiantly, "I hope you didn't hurt the girl because she's innocent. Oh yeah, you don't care about that, do you? You'll drink Star dry and move on like the monsters you are!"

The Shandor stood perfectly still and stared, smiling without a word.

"You know it doesn't have to be like this. You can leave now, and I'll act like you never saw me. That way you don't have to die here and now." In the palm of his hand, Crux unfolded a paperclip into as straight a line as he could finger. "I won't just pierce your heart—I'll make it explode!"

He knew that eventually he'd have to fight the Shandor, so he was going to practice. If there was one Vampyl, then there were definitely more on the horizon. Crux closed his eyes and did a spin. He heard Star in the hallway singing and knew she'd be opening the door in a matter of seconds. He tried to concentrate on the paperclip weighing 30 pounds with the probability that it would strike the target's heart with the speed of an airplane soaring through the sky. As the door turned and Star's terrible singing got louder, his heart skipped a beat, and his projections were skewed slightly. He threw the paperclip with all his might and watched it fly through the air.

With nearly flawless aim, the paperclip pierced the target's heart, and the loud boom of an explosion came after, followed by a scream from next door. The weight might have been off by a few hundred pounds.

"Crux, you little mental patient!" Star shrieked, "You have to stop this. It's the third time this week!" Star yelled at the twelve-year-old as she looked at the collage Crux had built on her wall of a hot model that looked like he could be a vampire. "Either you have something against really hot male models, or I'm missing something. You keep making these pieced-together men out of my magazines and using them as target practice. It's getting old."

“I'm going to be thirteen this week, and I know they'll be coming for me. I can't just hide here in your room and not be practicing how I'm going to take them down.”

She lifted the sheet of paper where the heart was, looked underneath and gasped. “It went all the way through the wall and through the neighbors’ houses too! If you don't stop throwing stuff in my room, I'm gonna take you down!” Star straightened her dress and regained her composure. “Look kid, we need to have a little chat.” She patted the bed next to where she sat.

Crux skipped over to her smiling and sat down. “But you saw my aim. It's gotten a lot better, and I know I can protect you.”

“Ok, kid, here's the deal. If a girl like me is running from a guy like that—” She pointed to the wall where Crux’s collage of supermodels-turned-Shandor-targets was hanging. “—Then I'm the one with the problem, not him.”

“But you don't understand. They're not good guys like Blue and Gemini; they're killers, and so what if they look like that? They can rip you to pieces with their bare hands.”

“Don't threaten me with a good time,” Star said as she licked her lips and shook her hair.

“I don't get it,” Crux said, looking thoroughly confused.

“You wouldn't!” Star said with a quick rebuttal. “Anyway, we need to find you somewhere else to do your throwy thingy, so I'll have to chat with Kaery about it.”

*

Kaery sat on the phone with Scape, silent for a few minutes after listening to him describe his dream. She had loved Scape ever since the first day she met him, and the more he opened up to her, she realized why.

“So, basically, we're soul mates,” Scape said over the phone after a dramatic pause. “What do you think, Kaery?”

Kaery took a deep breath. She knew he was speaking the truth. “Um...wow.”

“Well, not just you and I, but I think the animal spirit guides in the dream meant that there are nine of us who are soul mates. I'm gonna guess the little monkey was Ahlina.” He giggled to himself.

Kaery chuckled as she answered, “Do you realize that our conversations have gotten stranger and stranger since the day we got back from the diner with Crux?”

“I was thinking the same thing, but I like it. My ancestors say that sometimes we come across an unlikely guide to a spirit journey we can never return from. Maybe that's him?”

“Scape, you're a lot wiser than you let people know, with all of your Native American mojo.” Kaery smiled as she lay back into her soft pillows.

“Awww, well don't tell anyone that part. Hey, I um, gotta go. My ‘rents are acting all watch dog totem. See ya later, and sweet dreams. Hope you get back from New York soon. We miss you.”

The phone hung up before Kaery could answer, but she said her goodbye anyway, “I can't wait to get back home and give you all a hug. Goodnight, Scape.”

She pushed her purple bangs from her eyes as she placed her cell phone on the night stand next to her bed and stared a long time in the mirror.

“Nine of us?”

*

Heaven swam faster than she ever had in her life. She even spell-crafted a Mermaid's fin and gills to aid her getaway. It helped her glide across the waters three times faster. She knew that she'd be banished forever from the eighth continent of the Ballade. She was recently enlightened and knew that she had to get to her coven no matter what. The dreams had begun and now would never end. She was flooded with memories of her coven members living among the mundane humans. All of her life she was raised to believe the world outside of Ballade was mad. She was completely willing to undergo the risks, as long as the empty spot in her heart was filled by the energetic bond to her coven, even if that meant banishment and imminent danger in the world of man.

Heaven had a long wave of hair that resembled a violet tsunami that was easily the length of her body, including the fin. Her chocolate skin and purple eyes

were also a contrast to the foreign blue seas she had been traveling for over seven days now. Swimming while asleep and staying below the surface for most of her journey, she tried not to alarm any of these people she had heard of only through campfire song and lore from the Oracles and Priestesses. The Fae did not speak highly of the humans, as they had lost favor many lifetimes ago.

Heaven was hungry but continued her trek. She knew she needed to hit the shores of some land before she could stop. She knew she was being followed by her Fae cousins, but she couldn't let them bring her back. This was the longest amount of time Heaven had ever spent without singing. She swam in silence so that she wouldn't summon her cousins to her location. The Fae were known to hear the unique hymns of their kin across time and space.

This all seemed so futile. She knew they'd eventually catch up to her, but what she'd do to send them away was what she knew would be the hard part. Even before she was enlightened, Heaven trained with the High Priestesses to exercise her powers to the fullest. She opened up her chakras and found that she has a gift of the nine voices. Quite literally, she could sing in nine different octaves all at once, becoming her own choir. The Fae nicknamed her 'exalted,' as she was gifted with a heavenly voice that could summon higher levels of Fae if taught properly; her voice could bring about chaos and destruction if used improperly. The Fae nicknamed her 'exalted,' as she was gifted with a heavenly voice at birth. This meant that her voice could summon higher levels of Fae if trained properly, yet it could bring about chaos and destruction if trained improperly.

As Heaven floated along the dark seas, watching the whales and sea creatures in a blur beneath her, she began to remember that last conversation she had with her mother, Queen Amarantine.

"Mother, I must go!" Heaven pleaded.

"I cannot stop your heart once it's made up, Heaven, but know that you are walking a path to doom. You are meant to mate with a Fae and continue the tradition of connecting our kind to this universe." Her mother's voice was soothing and peaceful. The Queen looked at her rebellious daughter with all the love a mother could muster. "If this is the journey which you choose, my beloved daughter, I cannot stop your cousins from hunting you."

"I know, Mother, and I don't want you to risk all that you have worked hard to sustain for so many millennia. This is my dream, and this is my life! I must be with my soul mates, the Coven of Unity."

Heaven remembered how she cried as she spoke and how her hands were trembling then just as they were now while she swam, thinking of this memory that would haunt her forever.

"I may not be able to stop them, but I can delay them, my daughter. Here, take this."

"The Wax of Atlantis?"

"Yes, dear, after dusk you must stand in the moonlight and put a bit in your ears if you want to resist my lullaby during your escape. Once you hear it, I want you to swim as far and fast as you can through the East gates." The Queen's radiant pink locks were straight, unlike Heaven's curly mane, but just as long. Her hair seemed to glow brighter as the Queen pulled Heaven close for a final hug, whispering into her daughter's ear so that no one could hear.

"You have a gift that they cannot take away nor control. I know you have mastered only three of the nine voices, but use the multi-casting Spellcraft of the High Sirens. I remember the first time you sung with your second voice, and the ears of every Fae in Ballade heard the perfect harmony. I knew that day you were destined for a path all your own."

"But—Queen Mother, I was never as gifted a dancer or singer as some of my cousins." Heaven's voice wavered with doubt as she realized that this was the last time she would see her mother.

"The last Fae who harnessed all nine voices summoned an army that saved our coven from extinction. Yet that same person also had to banish the army to save the world. Summon creatures that will make your cousins flee to the shadowy reefs if you have to. Take my jewel to protect you, my love. This is all I can do." The Queen took her necklace off and handed it to her daughter.

A sharp pain brought Heaven back to the present. She found herself subconsciously holding the necklace as she reached down and noticed she was wounded on her rib. Her purple eyes glanced across the ocean in all directions.

"Show yourself!" The three voices spoke as if harmonizing the threat.

"It is your cousins, the Cetus. You didn't think you'd escape, did you?" Two gigantic forms peaked from the ocean, speaking in unison. Heaven watched as these beasts, who had not shown themselves for hundreds of years, appeared before her in all of their elaborate pomp. One took the form of a shark of enormous proportions with six glowing blood-red eyes. His white blade-like scales looked as if they were alive and moving in all directions, seeking blood. The other looked

like a cross between a green dragon and a giant black squid, his scaly tentacles dangling high above the water.

“A little dramatic, don't you think?” Heaven said as she floated in the center of the circling predators. “I'm not going back.”

“We were hoping you'd say that so we'd have no choice but to feast.” The Shark said.

“Don't do this, cousin. I don't want to hurt you.” Heaven spoke calmly as she watched both of the huge creatures carefully and began to hum as she spoke to them, “It doesn't have to end like this.”

A shriek and roar of a laugh belted throughout the sea for miles in all directions. The Shark circled so fast, a whirlpool began to form, and the Dragon-Squid made himself invisible with a cloud of ink.

Heaven knew there was definitely no turning back as she sang three songs while swimming directly upward to the surface as fast as she could. She felt a lash on her shoulder, the work of a tentacle no doubt, as she slammed against the side of the Shark, nearly tearing her scales off the fins. The pain was obnoxious but bearable as she continued to sing.

“Your lullabies won't work on us, Witchbreed. You're nowhere near as talented as your mother. You should know that we've heard your Siren songs and are immune to all of them. They taint only the hearts of man, not those of we Fae.” The Dragon-Squid lashed out at Heaven with another phantom tentacle, but this time she was prepared and dodged the blow easily.

Heaven reached the surface and watched, the whirlpool around her appearing inescapable. She looked at the sky as she continued to sing, floating in the center of a trap that only a miracle was going to get her out of.

“Nowhere to run, and your blood is filling the water, cousin. Oh, it smells so heavenly.” Her cousins taunted and laughed. The Shark raced upward at Supernatural speed toward Heaven, planning to swallow her whole.

Through the clouds, a thunderous squeal parted the silver linings as an otherworldly-looking bird dove toward the water.

Knowing that the bird could scoop the giant shark in its talons as easily as it scooped up sea predators for breakfast, Heaven smiled as she watched the golden feathers on its back move in unison and then separate into a thousand Harpies diving towards the ocean. She sung simple commands for the winged creatures to eat the Cetus, then swiftly jumped to the side as the Shark rushed toward her so

fast, he couldn't stop himself from flying out of the water and into the air where he was most vulnerable.

“You wouldn't? You bitch! You summoned the Harpies and their goddess to eat us!”

The large bird scooped the equally large Shark out of the water as he reached up to bite his attacker. The claws began to shred the Shark as if preparing a meal in midair. The whirlpool continued to swirl to the detriment of the Dragon-Squid, who couldn't escape the funnel. Each feather in the colossal bird's wingspan was actually an individual Harpy, and they made themselves recognizable when they separated in fleets toward the sea.

The Harpies were scary-looking beings. They resembled muscular women: sculpted upper bodies and the huge feathered legs of their goddess. Their vicious talons were the same fiery orange as their eyes, and their golden feathers looked like a wave of flying piranhas as they dove into the water. They targeted the would-be invisible Dragon-Squid with telepathic eagle eyes until they all carried him out of the water together, the creature writhing in pain and anguish.

The Harpies were agile swimmers just as they were agile flyers, and their screams were both melodic and terrifying, reminding Heaven that her voice was capable of great entertainment and great dread, equally.

She watched as the Harpies clawed and bit into the flesh of the Dragon-Squid while flinging him into the beak of the enormous bird. An air battle ensued as the Cetus tried their best to thrash about and break free that they might swim in the ocean again. The gigantic bird and the Harpy legion that served as its feathers, however, flew higher into the sky. With another song, Heaven opened a portal back to their home world. She heard her cousins' screams and curses as they were eaten alive in front of her. Heaven turned away from the horror, feeling responsible for the suffering of the Shark and Dragon-Squid, but knowing that she had tried to warn them. She fought back the tears as long as she could to no avail. Singing a soft prayer for her cousins, she waited for the whirlpool to stop so that she could continue her trek across the sea.

Wounded, weak and weary, Heaven was in need of land to properly heal herself. The whirlpool was still swirling around her like a barrier she could not surpass. With no other options, she decided to swim straight through it. Defiantly she flared her nostrils and charged the whirlpool.

The water was a relentlessly dark bubbling abyss that blinded her as she tried to focus. She suddenly knew she couldn't make it through the crushing torrent of spell-breaking Magick. Heaven cried into the water. This was the end. *I'm sorry I couldn't make it to you, Kaery!* Her eyes closed, and she let the water take her.

*

“We're patrolling the ocean, but this feels a lot like a date, right Jillian?” Melviel smiled to the porcelain soldier of a Vampyl next to him. She reminded him of Alice from the fairytales for some strange reason.

“Look, Melviel,” she replied, “I really like you, but I want you to know that it's impossible for us to have any kind of relationship. I mean, you're from a weaker Western Vampyl bloodline, and I'm Shandor. You have to be a little more *special*, if you know what I mean, to captivate my attention. We're from two different worlds, and as romantic as that date kinda sounds, my answer's no,” Jillian said to Melviel flatly as she watched his expression shift from optimistic to defeated in seconds.

“Maybe you're right,” Melviel agreed strangely and coldly. “Can I have a moment please?”

“Sure. Take your time. I'll be back to check on you before we return to the Shandor castle,” Jillian answered.

Melviel allowed blood tears to roll down his cheeks. His black hair covered his eyes in the darkness. He was disappointed at the politics of Vampyl society. Different bloodlines hated each other much like the clashing spiritual perspectives that fueled the religious wars of humans, no worse. *I won't give up on love.* He walked down the dark beach with his head up high, looking off into the horizon at the large moon, searching for a sign.

“Help me,” three voices sang out.

“Who's out there?” Melviel asked the darkness, wiping the tears away as he pulled his dagger out and walked toward the voices. He crept along the Portuguese beach as if it were a jungle, using what little stealth he knew.

“Please help me. I'm here.”

Melviel put his dagger away immediately and gasped as his eyes took in a creature he'd never thought existed. Yes, he was a vampire, and he had seen some

crazy things during his few hundred years of unlife, but this was by far the most intriguing. He was staring at an otherworldly beauty, a Mermaid with endless curly violet locks and aquamarine scales. Her nude upper body was that of a beautiful black woman, but her eyes were a glowing alien purple. He couldn't formulate words until she spoke again.

“I don't care that you're not of living flesh. You're special; I can see it in the Runes of Magick written on you. Please help me,” Heaven sang angelically just before she fainted.

Melviel looked around and called out for Jillian to come to his aid. He knew that she would have the answers, especially after their little chat. *She is not going to believe this, but hell, I barely do. On the bright side, at least one person thinks I'm special.* Melviel smiled to himself as he held the Mermaid in his arms and wondered why she smelled so delicious.

Chapter 13

FIRST DAY BACK

Her anxiety was all but gone; however, Sky screamed inside because she felt like she was missing something. She had forgotten the last few weeks of her life, and she didn't know how that was possible. The therapist told her it was post-traumatic stress disorder and retrograde amnesia, due to all the shock of her recent events. The doctors tested her for all kinds of diseases and mental ailments because of the kidnapping. Braintech labs gave her special devices to make her feel more safe, and they even secured her room with the latest technologically-advanced security and cameras.

After a few restless nights, she was finally able to go to sleep. Last night she dreamed of flying and floating in a bathtub; nothing a normal teenager wouldn't dream of. She shrugged. Her sleep was where she found the most peace these days. It was like she was in her own world within her head where no one could violate her. The doctors said it was normal for people to withdraw the way she did. Though she seemed to be back to herself for the most part, deep down she just wanted to remember what happened while she was gone.

Why would a kidnapper leave me without so much as a bruise and give me such nice clothing? Thank God my Daddums was there to find me! The reporters said he was on a mission to get me back with bulletins and developing technology that could search for me, the same technology the government just passed as the Eye in the Sky law.

It's all some satellites and artificially intelligent birds that travel across the world tracking people. I guess my absence brought about something good. Mum seems to be doing okay. She only remembers leaving me in the house as she rushed to Dr. Hill's the night I was

kidnapped. I tried to tell her it's not her fault, and she almost burst into tears! How would she know some random guys looking for my dad's secrets would come into the house? Makes me wonder what, or why Daddums has to hide...

“Sky, it's time to get ready for school,” Sky's mother said as she spoke through a monitor on the flat screen next to Sky's bed. Her beautiful dark skin looked exceptionally comforting to Sky as she opened her caramel eyes fully. Sky subconsciously reached up to close the blinds above her bed. She looked at her mother for a moment longer before her mother continued, “We have talked about this day for the past few weeks. Are you well-rested?”

“Yes Mum, I'm well-rested and ready to get out of the house and back to my life.” Sky smiled and looked at her closet for a long time.

“Is everything alright, Sky?” Her mother sounded concerned as she stared at her daughter's countenance.

“I'm just tired...of all the tests and questions,” Sky whispered. “I'm great. I'm excited to get dressed is all.”

“Alright, love, I'll leave you to your closet,” her mother said in a sweet tone as she turned the monitor off.

“Since when did she call me from the kitchen and have a full conversation over a monitor?” Sky mumbled to herself. She thought everything seemed to be back to normal, except for little details like that and the camera in the corner. Though virtually unnoticeable, Sky knew it was there, somehow.

It feels like someone is always watching me. Meh. I guess it's for the best, considering all that's happened. Ok, so here is the fun part, clothes!

Sky opened her closet, and for the first time since she'd been back, she smiled with pure happiness.

*

Dear Diary,

It's Kaery, again. Today will be my first day back from visiting my dad in New York. Things were a little strange, and I feel like I don't know him anymore. He wants to move on with his new family. But that's not what I wanted to talk to you about. I couldn't stop thinking about Blue. Ever since the night at the Forbidden City where we almost got shot by the Triad, the cops or the Mafia, I'm still not sure. I saw Blue protecting a boy named Crux and his best friend Tommy was dead. We somehow got to Gemini's Pagoda; I can't take my mind off what happened. But I wrote about all of this months ago. Today I just want to write about that moment between Blue and I in the hallway of Gemini's Pagoda.

To most people it was simply a glance, but we shared a moment that made my heart stop. Everything he said to me was in his indigo eyes. He looked at me as if for the first time and the last time, but I didn't say a word with my mouth, however my eyes said it all. I wanted to be with him. I wanted to kiss him. He was a pure light in the strange scene that made me feel like this was home.

Blue said to me with his glance that he recognized me, and though we don't know each other, he knows me. He wants to know me better. He wants me to kiss him and hold him to share my warmth. He's lonely and tired, but he will fight for what he believes in. He trusts Crux, and he won't leave the boy's side. Blue wants me. He thinks I'm beautiful. He wants to be my lover.

I can't stop smiling, and sometimes I cry when I think of that moment. I can't stop thinking about it when I'm alone.

Something else happened that day. My friends, Star, who was transformed into a glamazon using a power she calls Glamour, Scape, who is now wondering if he's schizophrenic because he can speak to plants and animals as well as Ahlina, who has to wrap her wrist because it's constantly bothering her, were all placed safely in their beds but had the same dream. We know now that it wasn't a dream but an actual event, as crazy as it all sounds. My issue with only hearing and speaking the truth is getting tolerable, but I don't know what I'm supposed to do beyond this.

I know, Diary, this is a strange letter to you, but you have to believe me. I think we're all going slightly insane, but I think it's a good thing. I tried to confess to my mom, and she didn't seem to understand a word I said, as if I spoke another language.

So I was told there was a rumor that Sky was going to be back in school. I can't fathom how she is going to return to her life as the most popular girl in school while dealing with all the rumors. Maybe she can handle it, considering she has been dealing with public appearances her whole life. I heard her father paid for meditation specialists and yoga masters...

That's it! Thank you, Diary, for listening to me. As usual you've made me see things from another perspective. I am grateful to have you.

Till next time with love,

Kaery

Sky's closet had vastly improved since the last time she saw it. It was a lot larger and there were amenities within the large room which could accommodate the spoiled teen for weeks, like a safe room. She noticed the clothes were very similar to the ones she told her doctors about in the hospital while being rehabilitated. The French haute couture that she so loved blended with the finest fabrics money could buy, but also black and pink cashmere sweaters, t-shirts and leather pieces that she didn't have in her previous selections were found in different parts of the large closet.

The room was separated in sections based on her aesthetics, and she could easily find anything with the touch of a button on the new holo-screen that replaced the flat screen she once had near the door. The holo-screen could appear in mid-air anywhere in the closet with a hand gesture. Being one of the prototypes in new technologically advanced software/hardware, it ran on a platform that Sky wasn't familiar with, but she picked up the functions as if it were catered to her very own whims. She loved her father for such extravagant gifts and felt so lucky that she was a Bradford.

As Sky pranced around her closet with wide-eyed anticipation of what to wear and touch, she felt a sense of nostalgia that plagued her like a family member's burden spying on her from heaven. She knew in her heart that something was missing. She wanted none of this fashion more than she wanted her memories.

With all the money her family made, her father being the CEO of Braintech, the most influential and successful software/hardware company on the planet, and her mother being the heiress to the largest chain of diamond mines in Africa, Sky only wanted them to retrieve her memories of the few weeks she was abducted.

The holo-screen popped up and told Sky that she had a message. She approved with a simple nod as she kept browsing her very important

debut outfit. It was Sky's father cheerfully saying in a prerecording, "Now remember, Bunny, you don't have to go through with this. The first day back was your mother's idea, but don't tell her that I said that. She still has the notion that you'll need to be around all those people in order to feel 'normal,' but baby, I know and you know that you're not normal!" Sky turned to look at the hologram intensely, breathing hard for no apparent reason.

What does he mean by that? Sky thought.

"I mean that you're my Indigo child, and no one can change that. I've always known you were slightly more intelligent than most, and no one ever had to tell me that you were going to be this beautiful, not to mention your taste for fashion resulting in your own fashion line by the time you were in middle school. There doesn't seem to be anything my beloved Sky can't do," her dad said with the most proud smile she'd ever seen.

Sky sighed with relief from her father's confession, but felt an undertone in his words that she couldn't put her fingers on, as if she knew he was hiding something. She shrugged the feeling off as soon as it had appeared and turned back to the selections chosen by some perfect stylist she had yet to meet.

"By the way, Sky, in your new holo-screen is a program called Distinctive Ideatum Veritas Assimilation—for short, DIVA. Simply ask for Diva, and she will appear to you. Her choices are based on all the information stored on your selections in the past eighteen years, including seasonal wear, music, art and school subjects you've researched. She can be quite useful to you. You can speak to her like a normal person without the entire invasion of privacy issue. It is a program that only you and I have access to, so feel free to adapt your DIVA as you see fit," her father said with a loving smile as he stood silent for a moment.

Sky looked over her shoulder to see the recording still staring at her. She could do nothing but smile back at him even though she knew he couldn't see her. "I love you, Daddums," she said in a whisper.

"Just know that I love you, Bunny, and that if you want to reach me, all you have to do is the swipe hand motion that I taught you, and a hologram will appear as long as your phone is near you, say, if you were in this closet. Eventually I will release some similar technology to the public, but in the meantime, you're my special child who deserves the one-of-a-kind version. Tell me how your day was. Bye for now."

"Bye," Sky said smiling. "Okay, so how is this gonna work? I just have to say DIVA?"

"You called, Sky." A hologram of a beautiful brunette slightly shorter than Sky appeared next to the clothes that she was viewing. Her brown hair and brown eyes were striking, as if she were Mediterranean. Her purple dress was fitted and matched her heels perfectly. With the body of a runway model and the walk to match it, the illusion intrigued Sky.

"So you're my stylist, huh?" Sky asked, still looking at the hologram with intensity as if she were trying to adjust to the idea of sharing her sacred space.

"Yes that is correct, milady," Diva responded in a British accent.

"Don't be so formal," Sky commanded.

"You got it," Diva responded in an American accent.

"A test. More like a fashion test," Sky said squinting, "Who is my favorite style icon?"

"Michelle Obama."

Sky's brow lifted as she smirked. "Who is a close second?"

"Marie Antoinette."

"What's my favorite fabric?"

“Egyptian cotton sheets.”

“Count?”

“1000 plus.”

“Brad and Angelina?”

“Hot celebrity couple that came to your sweet sixteen. What about them?”

“Nothing,” Sky said, turning away from the hologram with a grin. “I think you’ll do.” As she looked over the last three outfits, she said aloud, “I’m not sure which one I want to wear.”

Diva walked to Sky’s other side and looked at the three collections.

“They’re all nice.”

“But?” Sky asked.

“Well, the pleated skirt is very Japanese schoolgirl chic, but the top is too much. And this dress looks like you’re going clubbing after school. But this last dress is perfect!”

Sky agreed and took the blue dress off of the rack. The details were so nice that it looked expensive, but the cut was so whimsical that it looked ready-to-wear. It wasn’t too formal, and it was definitely appropriate for school. “I like you, Diva, but something is just off.” Sky held the dress in her left arm while staring at Diva’s face. “May I?”

“You can customize me as often as you’d like,” Diva responded coolly.

“Okay, cool.” Sky raised her right hand and squeezed Diva’s nose slightly, shrinking it and raising her cheekbones. “Now grow about seven inches, and change your hair to red. No, it has to be a lot shinier, and put blonde highlights. Now change those heels to blood-red, and the dress needs to be way shorter. French manicure. Perfect. Now add sequins to the outfit. Bigger boobs.”

“Is this to your liking?” Diva responded as Sky smiled at her very own replica of Star.

“Now you're perfect,” Sky said as she walked out of the closet.

*

Kaery met up with Ahlina outside the auditorium. She was feeling better now that she was at school, which was ironic considering she'd just gotten back from one of her favorite cities, New York, but she'd rather be here with her friends. Ahlina had changed her hairdo in the time Kaery had been gone. She shaved one side of her head and dyed the shaved side pink while coloring the longer side blond.

“Hey, Ahlina. I like it!” Kaery said, smoothing her fingers through her best friend’s hair. “So you're going for Punky Asian girl Brewster meets Rihanna?”

“OMG how'd you know?” Ahlina giggled.

“Well, the jean jacket and leg warmers gave it away,” Kaery said, pointing at Ahlina's outfit. Kaery then looked at her own outfit and said, “you don't think I look too...”

“Safe. Yes.” Ahlina interrupted nicely. “But the snug purple t-shirt and blue jeans fit you. You're like the cute tanned girl next door with really perky boobs. I'm more of the random rocker chick with piercing green eyes that everyone thinks are contacts, but are indeed my biological color!” Ahlina gave an exaggerated expression, trying to widen her slanted eyelids to give Kaery a better look into her bright green emeralds.

Kaery looked into Ahlina's eyes and instantly was taken back to images of an ancient city, Zalomoni, including a dimly candle-lit room, then a large dragon waking up. She gasped and took a step back.

“What?! Is it my eyeliner?” Ahlina said hurriedly as she looked around for a mirror. “Oh, please don't tell me I have eye gunk!” Ahlina desperately scrambled to find a reflective surface in her backpack.

“No. No, you look fine. It’s just that I saw an ancient city with a dragon and you smiling like a mad woman. Like a dream, but not,” Kaery explained without looking at her friend.

“You’re creeping me out, Kaery,” Ahlina said with a slightly worried expression. “Besides, I’ve been having those dreams again,” she whispered.

“Me, too,” Kaery said, her brown bob hairdo and violet bangs blowing in the wind. Kaery’s honey eyes shut as she thought about her trip to New York. “I mean, the entire time I was visiting my dad, I was dreaming about past life stuff and even told my dad the day he was going to die when he woke me up.”

“#Morbidmuch?” Scape walked behind Kaery and gave her a big hug. His masculine cologne reminded her of a day at the beach. His strong arms surrounded her, and he knew it was the easiest way to make her smile as he dramatically spun her around to face him. “You guys have got to stop talking about such heavy stuff on your first day back. Relax and just breathe in the gloriously diminishing pollution of San Francisco.”

Kaery loved her best friends, Scape being one of them. He was a full-blooded Native American from the Blackfoot tribe. His features were so strong and handsome that he would stand out in a crowd, even if he were wearing a simple shirt and jeans. Luckily, Scape happened to be gay and had an eye for style, his own style at that. Scape inspired Ahlina to be random, to dress how she felt—as he sure did. Some days he’d be dressed in hippie attire with his shoulder-length hair covering most of his gorgeous face, while other days he’d pin his hair in a messy pony tail on top of his head with torn skater jeans. Today he was wearing his hair slicked back neatly, and he had black hipster glasses covering his dark

brown eyes along with a striped collared shirt, black wool pants and really worn skater shoes.

“Wow, Scape, you look so nice!” Kaery said as she looked him up and down. “Are you going for a job interview or...”

“I wish. You know my parents won't allow me to work. That's why I volunteered to be Principal Hatcher's assistant,” Scape answered.

“Speaking of Mrs. Hatcher, she has the entire office dressing up for some guy that's coming from the school board. Apparently after Sky's disappearance, the school has raised the bar on security and hired some special people to the faculty.

Ahlina sighed, “First of all, she was kidnapped at home. And second, don't you think this is a little weird? I mean like conspiracy type weird. Sky gets 'kidnapped,' but we all know that's not true because we were in the same place as her.”

Kaery shushed Ahlina and looked around, suspecting eavesdroppers, “We don't even know if that was real.”

Ahlina tilted her head to the side. “So I'm supposed to believe that all of us shared the exact same dream on the exact same night in that strange pagoda, and Gemini's speech about the Soulstream, and us being Supernaturals that brought you to tears as you held on to Blue's arm like he was your bf?”

Kaery blushed and looked at the ground for a brief moment. “I know we've talked about it until we were convinced it must have been some hallucination, and yes, I agreed that it must have been true, but we don't have to... we cannot say that aloud here. We have no proof, and people will think we're crazier than we already come across. So deal, we leave that talk for *us* in private, ok?” Kaery smiled at Ahlina and Scape.

“I agree,” Scape said with a big smile as he hugged Kaery and the silent but brooding Ahlina. “I think it's about time we all got back to normal. If that's at all possible.”

At that moment, a red convertible sports car pulled up in the parking lot. The loud blaring club music disrupted the small meeting between the friends. They all turned to see who was responsible for the intrusion. Ahlina glared at the obnoxious entrance as Kaery and Scape looked in wonder.

“Let me guess, Sky is back?” Ahlina asked condescendingly, then suddenly clasped her hands over her mouth in awe. “O. M. F-ing G!”

“Star!” Scape and Kaery said in chorus.

Star's healthy head of red hair blew in the wind as if she were in her own video shoot. She stepped out of the expensive car as if it were a consolation prize from a game show that she could care less about. Her six-inch stiletto heels looked like they cost a fortune as they touched the black top. Star stood up and took the breath away from the onlookers. The little red dress was barely appropriate as she walked towards her friends with long porcelain legs that were the color of milk as she strutted.

“I take it you like?” Star said in a pompous voice as she beeped the alarm with her kitten key chain. “Judging by the huddle, I missed some boring heartfelt conversation about our dreams that we can't seem to stop talking about?” Star looked at her silent friends while they stared at her as if they'd never seen her before.

Ahlina broke the silence. “I seriously can't believe you showed up as if you're the next Sky Bradford! And what happened to laying low and blending in so we don't attract too much attention after all that happened?” Ahlina grabbed the tight fabric of Star's dress. “Can you even breathe in this thing?”

“You better work!” Scape simply said, as he gave Star a hug.

“I agree with Scape. I think you look great,” Kaery said in shock as she smiled up at her tall glamazon of a friend. She caught the look of disapproval from Ahlina, but ignored it as she knew Star needed a self-

esteem booster. Even though she didn't agree with the current outfit for blending in, Star definitely made a statement. "I'm just glad you feel better about yourself. So does this mean no more skipping school?"

Star almost teared up but caught herself getting emotional and automatically reverted back to her new personality. "I know I look good, thanks. And I can't skip anymore school this year, or Mrs. Hatcher will expel me. And before any of you lecture me about the clothes, it's my first day back. I'll tame it down tomorrow, but today it's all about me!" Star said as she flipped her hair and looked off into the horizon as if she were posing for a picture. "Look at the secret service caravan. Isn't that Sky?"

*

The trip to school was definitely different from her usual routine after her yoga and bath. Instead of driving the electric car that she had gotten for her birthday, Sky was being escorted by bodyguards that her dad had hired. She was confused by the entourage, considering they all looked like they had stepped right out of an action movie set. They were nice enough to her, even though they didn't speak much.

Sky sat in the back seat of the large SUV and wondered what the first day back would be like. Her anxiety was starting to rise with anticipation. She would normally listen to her favorite music when this happened and breathe like her meditation coach told her. These guys were playing some music, but she didn't bother telling them it was all wrong. She reached into her purse and grabbed what looked like a see-through crystal but was actually the cell phone her father had created especially for her.

When Sky's thumb touched the phone, it scanned her clothes, and the back of the phone camouflaged to match the same color as her blue

dress. The screen's menu showed her playlists. Sky chose a nice relaxing dance mix and put on her head set so she could listen in peace. She noticed the driver glancing at her to make sure she was okay. She gave a cordial smile and looked out the window. The music was soothing to Sky as she watched the city's buildings pass by and the locals walking as if life were so simple. *It must be nice to not be known. They can do anything they want; it's not fair.* Sky tried to smile but couldn't force herself to.

The security guard in the front seat began to whisper to the other, "How long do you think we have to babysit? I mean we're highly decorated Agents. Don't you think this is a little remedial?"

The other Agent smiled a grimacing yellow flash of broken teeth and said telepathically, "*Watch your mouth, Agent Stone, the young lady can hear you.*"

Agent Stone looked into the rear view mirror as he drove to see that Sky was still listening to her music and looking outside the SUV. He whispered, "Are you sure? She seems deep in thought."

"*Trust me, you know what I specialize in, the thoughts of others.*" The Agent reached for his pack of cigarettes but stopped. He knew Sky despised cigarette smoke. He covered his fingers in a gob of sticky spit and ran them through his greasy hair.

Sky was already subconsciously removing the cigarette smoke that had been hanging in the car when she got in, focusing her energy to push it out of the windows. One of the Agents reeked of nicotine and bad breath, but none of that attacked her senses anymore. She could hear them whispering and wondered when she could talk to her father about dismissing them. *Finally we're here at school.* Sky took her headset off and fixed her beautiful locks of hair. She took a deep breath to prepare for her exit from this car.

Agent Grin spoke for the first time after realizing he no longer smelled like a cigar shop. “We have to escort you to the Principal's office and discuss security parameters, Ms. Bradford.”

“What?! You mean you have to follow me into school and make me look like the President’s daughter? Oh no, that's not gonna work!” Sky reached for her phone. She remembered all she had to do was a simple motion with her palm as long as the crystal cell phone was near her. She swiped her arm in the air, and a holographic screen appeared. She tapped her father's office. The ringback tone reminded her of her childhood.

“Yes, Bunny, are you alright?” Her father answered anxiously in the middle of some project she could see in the background.

“Sorry to bother you, Daddums, but I wanted to let you know that I'm ok, and I don't need these guys ushering me around the school as if I'm some sort of ambassador. Can you please dismiss them?” Sky said in one hurried breath.

Her father looked at her for a brief moment and said calmly, “Bunny, this is for your own good.” After seeing the look of disappointment on her face, he followed up with, “I sent them a text to leave you after your meeting in the Principal's office okay, Love?”

Sky began to smile, then said, “Thanks, Daddums. And no offense, but can you get security Agents who don't smoke? I mean this guy smells like he eats cigarettes, not just smokes them.”

“I take it you've met Grin.” Her father chuckled jovially with his contagious laughter Sky loved so much. She saw that he had aged a little. His once flawless head of brown hair was now specked with gray, and a couple crow’s feet were gently resting on his weary eyes.

She smiled as she said, “Oh, and I love my new Diva!”

“Did you need more fashion tips, Sky?” Diva asked as the hologram appeared next to her in the backseat, almost startling the teenager.

“I see you've customized her appearance,” Sky's father said as he watched Diva appear next to his daughter.

“I forgot she can show up anywhere,” Sky said in awe. “I'm not sure if I should disable her at school or what? But thanks again, Dad.” Sky looked down for a moment. “For everything. You really do spoil me, and I'm not sure I deserve it.”

“Anything for my Sky.” He smiled. “Now I have to get back to work. Remember to speak to Principal Hatcher about your makeup work and your new accommodations. I love you.” His holographic image vanished.

“I love you too,” Sky whispered to herself. Then she looked over at Diva, who sat poised with her legs crossed next to her. Sky noticed how long her legs looked in the small dress, and when she looked past Diva and outside the car, she was in shock to see the real Star standing with the other misfits. “Diva, go away for now.”

“Of course,” Diva replied and vanished.

Sky opened the door of the car and stepped out. The guards told her they chose the back entrance near the auditorium on purpose for a less dramatic debut than usual. Sky agreed because she knew it was an easy walk to the Principal's office from here. Stone held the door open as the light breeze blew gently across the young woman's face.

In the sunlight, Sky's skin looked even more beautiful. Her caramel skin was a perfect blend of her Jewish father and her West African mother's genetics. She never had to tan, though she loved the sun and had that perfect sun-kissed look year round. Standing up proudly and with her usual poise, Sky began to walk toward the school, not caring that the security was following closely. She tried not to make eye contact

but couldn't help looking at the kids she had been forbidden to speak to freshman year. Estar had blossomed into a ravishing beauty who could definitely make it a career if she so pleased. Kaery was always so nice, and her warm energy made everyone, including Sky, smile. Ahlina scowled from behind Scape who was as handsome as the gay guys in the school came. Sky raised her hand to wave, then looked away slowly as she proceeded to walk into the school.

Kaery and her friends looked at each other and said, "Did she just smile and wave?"

"Did you see her outfit?" Star asked. "She's going to set yet another trend!"

"Yep, she's still the undisputed queen of trendsetting." Scape high-fived Star.

"Do you hear yourselves? Talking about her as if she were some sort of goddess! Pfft, I'm over it!" Ahlina stormed off, put on her oversized headphones and blasted her music, walking away.

"I hope she's ok?" Kaery said, starting to walk after Ahlina before Scape grabbed her arm and stopped her.

"Remember how Ahlina was when Star was all defensive about Sky?" Scape started his story with a sigh. "Well it's just her way of saying she doesn't want to see any of us hurt. A long time ago before the reign of Sky's high school years, Ahlina actually liked Sky, but they were forbidden to talk to each other after Ahlina got in trouble with the police and Sky's father did a background check on Ahlina's not-so-clean family records. Well needless to say, that was a wrap!" They both watched Ahlina walk around the corner.

"Well I have a feeling that we're supposed to be friends with her," Kaery said as she looked in the other direction to see Sky disappear into the school.

Chapter 14

SPELLCRAFTS

Heaven sat in the dark room alone and heard the dripping of water. Her senses were on overdrive, and she awoke in a place other than her homeland. It smelled of death and fear all around her. She wouldn't allow herself to think about how she had assisted her cousins in meeting their deaths. Heaven had never killed a bug, let alone an animal, or any creature for that matter. Her strict moral code that all life had a right to be had not been compromised, but she was in survival mode and knew that many of her cousins did not carry the same ethics. She doubted she could even physically kill anyone, and whoever owned the dungeon she found herself in most definitely did not agree with her code.

She tried to stand up and realized she was walking through water. There was not enough to submerge herself in, but enough to glide across the top with her mermaid's fin. Heaven studied her surroundings. There were scratch marks and what looked like teeth marks on the rusted stone walls. The random chains hanging throughout the room no doubt had held captives at some point.

I can only do so much with movement and muscle memory. I must use my Spellcrafts in order to see the room for what it truly is and find a way out. With a soft hum, Heaven remembered that she had minor control over her environment by simply moving within it and singing. She cleared her thoughts and imagined the mermaid's fin falling from her legs. Each scale that fell from her flesh became a glowing blue flower in the ankle-deep water. Her hum swelled to a full wave of harmony as her voice mimicked instruments and drum beats.

The flowers glowed brighter as Heaven belly danced across the dimly lit dungeon. Hundreds of flowers floated over the top of the slowly draining water like a happy algae that belonged far below the ocean's depths. Heaven's touch of the once-putrid water had now purified it enough to be drinkable. Her smooth dance moves were not yet up to full potential, and when Heaven bent backward, she felt the wound on her ribs so acutely that she almost toppled backward into the water.

She didn't stop dancing because she wanted to complete her environmental spell. She knew that Spellcrafts allowed Magick users to weave reality as they saw

fit. There was not much time for her to create an environment that would let her heal herself. The plants had not fully bloomed, but when they did, they would spread more spores in the darkness that reacted to her music. She glided so gracefully across the room that you'd think she was in a dance studio and not a cell used for unspeakable crimes against humanity.

I'm not dumb; this is a torture chamber of some sort. I have to keep dancing if I hope to summon any more energy that will heal me. That's right, a well-placed garden of Arcane light specter blossoms, and this room will never see darkness again. With a little more light and a lot of love, I should be able to grow Elixir berries that will heal these wounds. Just keep dancing and singing, Heaven. This will have to do as a makeshift grove for now.

*

“So, you're saying that we need a grove,” Kaery asked inquiringly to Crux, “in order to practice magick because it will help us learn Spellcrafts faster?”

“I'm not sure how all of it works,” Crux answered uncomfortably as the kids stared at him, waiting for answers, “But that's what I heard from the card handlers, and my mom is one of the greatest. If you find a grove, it's a purified place where Mother Gaia has allowed Magick to flow freely with no blockers. Such Magick will fill the senses and allow for creative energies to rejuvenate. Or something like that. Whatever.”

Kaery's long purple bangs and light brown locks in the back were very nice distractions, and Crux chose to focus on her hair as he answered. She was very easy to talk to. He hadn't stayed anywhere for very long, but for some reason he liked these teenagers. They didn't have any of the answers, even though technically they were supposed to as Witchbreed.

Crux ate the fruit snack that Scape gave him with a smile as he spoke to Kaery, “I think Witchbreed use Spellcrafts. It just means each of you will learn to use Magick in a different way, even if you all get the same results.” Crux combed his fingers through his freshly-cut mohawk that Ahlina and Scape had styled for him. He looked around the room at Star, Scape and Ahlina. *I bet they know I'm winging it. I wish I'd spent more time actually listening to my occult teacher. This*

stuff was always just so boring! I mean, Mancers do what we feel, and Witchbreed read and rewrite the code. That's it!

“Okay, I think I may have an exercise that will help.” Crux scrambled around the room like a mad man.

Star shrugged silently as she shook her head at the obnoxious boy. She really hated kids, but this one was growing on her. He had an air of confidence that was a cover up for all the pain, and she felt that. At least he refused to be a pity party. Star respected his ridiculous version of wisdom, as he was clearly winging the whole thing, but it was adorable that he at least cared enough to teach them anything about Supernaturals at all.

Scape was as handsome as ever in his cool demeanor as he sat in a yoga position and watched Crux run around Star's room. He'd grown to think of the boy as a spirit journey host, an honor that was given to the highest of Shaman in Scape's Blackfoot Native American culture. He didn't understand where this journey would lead, and he didn't care at this moment, but he was excited to know what the future had in store for them all. He also wondered about the other soulmates.

Ahlina tried to act as if she were annoyed by sighing aloud, pushing her curly bangs out of her face and into a head band. Her Asian features were smooth, thin and tom-boyish. She was very happy with her appearance but wasn't happy with the current uncertainty. She looked around the room to see what the boy could possibly be scrounging for. “What are you looking for?” she asked impatiently.

Crux smiled as he found what he was looking for. It was a glass of water he had been drinking a couple days before. He turned, and with a flourish, presented the unimpressive object to his audience. His excitement raised the intrigue of the four Witchbreed in the room. “This is it. Half a glass of water.”

Star pouted, “If this is some stupid half empty, half full philosophy...”

“Let's hear him out, Star,” Kaery interrupted as Scape smiled, silently agreeing.

“Thanks, Kaery. So the trick is to first read the code. The next step is recreate the code,” Crux said as he looked at the puzzled expression on each of the teenagers' faces. “Really take a deep breath and focus on the water. You should be able to see the code that makes it water in the first place.” Crux was definitely winging it, considering he had always failed this assignment in the occult class. But he knew the basics behind it. Witchbreed should be able to see the code easily.

Kaery stared at the water in the glass. She saw the clear fluid and thought about how thirsty she was. She took a deep breath as instructed, and just as she opened her mouth to ask for more instructions, she began to see small blue runes floating in the cup. Her mouth gaped further in wonder as she read, 'Hydrogen,' 'Oxygen,' 'Life,' 'Liquid Essence' and 'Water' runes floating harmoniously together in the glass. She looked over at Scape, who seemed to be focusing hard on the glass, and Ahlina, who looked extremely bored. Star was leaning close to the glass, then yawned, flipped her red hair and leaned back into her seat.

"Okay, so I see the code or whatever," Star said aloud. "What do you mean recreate it?"

Kaery looked at Star, amazed. *Is she really able to see the code like me, or is she just trying to speed the lesson along? This looks like a dream. How come we haven't been able to see the code before this point?*

Crux smiled and sighed in relief, not knowing beforehand if his little experiment would work. "So, who all can see the code?"

Kaery raised her hand as she looked at the glass one more time. Star raised one hand as she looked at her nails on the other. Scape slowly raised his tanned hand as he concentrated on the glass in awe.

"So I'm the only one who can't see some random virus in the glass?" Ahlina asked, more frustrated than anything because she really couldn't see the code at all. She didn't even understand the lesson. "This sucks."

Crux smiled. "Trust me, that's a good ratio. I wasn't able to see the code for years, and you all can see it in seconds. I'm a really good teacher, I guess." Crux sighed, and his smile grew. "Ok, now for the recreation part. Don't feel bad if neither of you can do this. Basically, you see the code, and you can make the code in your own way using your Spellcrafts." Crux realized he had lost his audience and began to back-peddle. "Like, for example, if I asked either of you to go get me water. One might go get a glass from the faucet, another might bring me a bottle of ice cold water and another might turn on the shower. All water, but different interpretations. Witchbreed can remake any code they've seen if it's up to their power levels, or something like that."

Star placed her hand on the small oak table where the glass was sitting, then raised it, and a glass of water identical to the other was conjured into being.

"Whoa!" Scape and Ahlina yelled simultaneously as Kaery reached to grab the glass Star had made.

Kaery grabbed the glass and crushed it in her hands. "It's not the same. It's fake. The code was wrong. It lacked the rune Life."

"That was awesome though! Star used Glamour to recreate an identical glass visually, but not in reality. I almost forgot that she was in the Glamouri coven at one point and is able to conjure such perfect illusions. Kaery was somehow able to tell the real cup from the Glamoured one quite easily." Crux clapped happily.

"Kaery, you try to recreate the code. Remember it probably won't be the same way Star did it. Maybe you need to snap it, or blink or say it out loud."

Kaery looked at the glass and snapped, but nothing happened. She looked at the kids as they stared back at her with wide eyes. She blinked really hard, thinking of the water filling the cup, but nothing happened. "Focus, Kaery," she told herself as she read the runes aloud. Every rune she read began to glow, then multiply, and the water started to fill the cup until it reached the brim. Kaery sat back and stared at the glass in disbelief, then amazement, and started laughing uncontrollably.

"You've got to be kidding me? It's that easy."

Ahlina didn't know what to do, but she did stand up and look at the glass as if it were an alien thing. "So we can all do that?"

"In one way or another," Crux answered simply.

Scape got close to the glass and put his finger in the water. He stared for a long while.

"Are you trying to pee or something? 'Cause I heard that if you..." Star was interrupted by a shush from everyone in the room as they stared at the glass with Scape.

The water began to slowly leave the cup as if his finger were absorbing every drop. Scape smiled as he concentrated harder until there was no water left. He pulled his finger out of the glass and looked at his friends with a gleeful grin on his face.

"That was awesome, Scape," Kaery said as she clapped.

Scape looked up at the ceiling, and everyone followed his gaze. They saw nothing but the lumpy paint and more pictures of models pinned to the walls. Then all of a sudden, the room began to rain. Literally, water dropped from nowhere as if they were all standing outside in an afternoon April shower.

Star screamed as the water flowed into her room. She desperately tried to cover her clothes, and then she stopped and looked up again, wondering why it was raining in her room.

Ahlna stood up with a haunted expression, then she started laughing aloud for the first time. “OMG! Now *that* is epic!” She spun around in the rain and laughed.

Kaery sat in her seat and smiled at what was happening. At that moment, she realized they were able to perform miracles. The dreams weren't just fantasy, but their real memories. They all had been extremely powerful at one point or another, and this was just a taste. Now they needed to actually learn how to master these Spellcrafts, and life would be so much more interesting.

“Get out of my room! My place is officially off limits,” Star screamed as the rain stopped abruptly, leaving the room soaked.

Crux giggled until a smack came to the back of his head from the heavy-handed Star. “That was for all of your stupid throwing.” She then smacked the laughing Scape on the back of his head. “That's for the rain!”

“She's right. We do have to find somewhere else to practice this,” Kaery said in a haunting voice that made everyone stand at attention, drawn into her glowing golden eyes. “There is a grove nearby guarded by Spiraar. We have to find it, then use it to become stronger.”

Crux smiled then said aloud, “Cool!”

Chapter 15

FALL OF OLYMPUS

(Mount Olympus: 391 B.C.E.)

We will always be young and beautiful, but is it enough? We've done everything that we can to appease the Mancers and self-proclaimed Gods of the court. This is Mount Olympus, and we are to obey them. Or is that our purpose? They mock the very humans that worship them and respect no one outside of their social circle. Today will decide if Olympus will fall or rise to glory.

Kaery sat up from her meditation and smiled, waiting for her friends to enter the room. Her golden eyes turned to the entrance where the tall and statuesque Star walked in, disappointed. Ahlina's much smaller frame followed her, sighing. Star looked at Kaery's patient face for a few seconds then said, "Aren't you going to ask me why I'm so disappointed, hence the expression on my face?"

"She worked hard on that expression," Ahlina said, rolling her eyes.

"Shut up, Ahlina." Star glared at her friend, then looked back to Kaery. "Ok, fine, you won't ask." Star pouted and looked out the window to see the clouds below the great city of Olympus.

Kaery was about to give in and ask what was bothering Star, but she didn't have to proceed as Star impatiently broke down and confessed her qualms.

"So, the reason why I'm so down is because today is very important." Star was interrupted by Ahlina.

"Yes! It's the day when Nina decides which Supernaturals are to have children in the new season!" Ahlina said, excitedly.

"She wants to be called Aphrodite, and eww, no, that's not what I was talking about, but it does have to do with her decision," Star said.

"You mean the decision of who is to ride with her to Sky's Kingdom in Egypt?" Kaery said, taking the wind out of Star's intriguing conversation.

"Way to use your foresight to tell what I was going to say," Star pouted.

"I'm sorry Star, I did see this happening, but I didn't have to use my powers to do so," Kaery said, walking over to her tall friend and placed a hand on her milky arm.

"Bam! I knew you were predictable, Star," Ahlina said, chuckling.

“That’s not what I’m saying at all, Ahlina,” Kaery said after looking at the pout on Star’s face. “What I’m saying is, after today’s events I will let you take my place in case Nina, I’m sorry Aphrodite, chooses me to accompany her on the trip to Sky’s kingdom.”

“*She* likes to be called Isis, and wow, you’d do that for me? You’re the best, Kaery.” Star smiled so big it looked as if she had won some grand treasure. She hugged Kaery with a quick big hug and spun away from her as she began to recall the last time she went to Sky’s court. “There was so much gold dripping from every corner of the room, and her court wasn’t so boring and full of long-winded blowhards.”

“Star!” Ahlina reprimanded, “That’s blasphemous. Don’t speak of the Gods in such a way.”

“Whatever, you don’t need to kiss our asses. We’re not the ones responsible for you having a kid. And since when did you become such a kiss up?” Star said. “Anyway, I love her kingdom. It’s so free, and the clothes are to die for! Sky’s so ahead of her time, I swear.”

“Star,” Kaery cautioned in her loving voice that was meant to be nice.

“What? I’m serious. These Mancers have been walking around here with their heads in the clouds—no pun intended—they insist that we call them by the names the humans call them. Ugh! And you guys call me narcissistic?” She looked in the mirror at her long, healthy red hair as it perfectly sculpted her face. Her mane complimented her glossy rubies for lips. She insisted on making kissing motions to adore herself.

“Excuse me, not all of us are so self-obsessed that they can forget such a special day,” Ahlina said in contempt. “The Supernaturals of Olympus have waited for this moment for centuries. Nina, I’m sorry Aphrodite is the only Mancer in the court who has the power to open the Soulstream within the womb of a Supernatural so that they may bear children like the humans.”

“All I hear is womp womp womp womp womp.” Star said, making a sock puppet motion with her hands and bobbling her head. “Bore someone else with all that. Besides, I hate kids. I could care less about some fertility ritual and parade that always leads to an oversized orgy.”

“Star,” Kaery warned again.

“Fine. I wish you the best. Hopefully, Nina picks you.”

At that moment, a soft voice entered the room. “I prefer if you call me Aphrodite.” The goddess glided into the marble-floored palace, barefoot and smiling. She seemed to be in an extremely good mood, and she took a moment to smile at each of her advisors. “And hopefully I pick who for what?”

Kaery was the first to kneel. Ahlina and Star quickly followed suit. They knew that Nina had been very temperamental lately, ever since Juno took off with the Amazons to ward back a Mancer in the Southern kingdoms. Everyone had been walking on eggshells around her so that her ceremonies ran smoothly.

“Is anyone going to answer me?” Nina was naturally a very pretty specimen with her long blond locks and blushing cheeks that accented her ice blue eyes. She glanced back and forth at each woman in the room.

“She only meant that Ahlina would be so lucky if you picked her to be one of the chosen Supernaturals who will become a mother,” Kaery said smoothly and diplomatically.

Nina knew that of anyone in Olympus, Kaery was the most honest Witchbreed Oracle who never lied; she was even positive that Kaery was incapable of such a feat. For that very blessing or curse, Kaery was her most trusted ally and advisor. Star was the most useful in the public eye, for she used potent Glamour Magick to create perfection when it came to the image of Aphrodite. Ahlina was the most loyal. She spoke with and prayed with the mortals of the temples built in Aphrodite’s honor. These three were her Witchbreed council, and they were an irreplaceable source of Nina’s true power. Even Zeus was jealous of them.

“About that. I will make my announcement soon. But first I would like to speak to Athena,” Nina said, prancing over to the same ornate mirror where Star had been admiring herself earlier. The mirror looked like any other mirror in Olympus, however it was special. This mirror was one of the relics these three beauties created specifically for Nina. It would allow her to see anyone she had ever touched at any given moment, unless they were somehow about to block Scrying Magick.

“Of course, Mistress.” Ahlina stood up to help with the mirror.

Star hurriedly ran after Ahlina and said, “Oh no, you can’t go into the mirror with this morning’s hair. Let me touch you up just a little.”

Kaery stood slowly and glided gracefully over to the goddesses. She knew that Nina would want to see Juno as soon as possible before she went deep into battle with the invaders, rumored to be led by an immortal named Enoch. This was

a serious ordeal, and Nina hated violence, preferring the sultry and slippery love parties of Olympus where there seemed to be no shortage of affection due to Nina's ability to change everyone's emotions. Kaery was one of the few people in Olympus who was immune to her powers. She wondered how much of Nina's anxiety was rubbing off on the frantic sisters of hers, Ahlina and Star.

Nina stood in the mirror and took a deep breath as Star used her Glamour Magick to coil her hair from long cascading locks to a beautiful wreath of golden braids. Ribbons of her hair fell freely like waterfalls in very flattering places. Star skillfully changed Nina's makeup to glow like the morning sun as it kissed her eyes, lips and cheeks astonishingly. She now looked like a goddess, and the mirror showed her just why the people adored her so much.

"Ok, I think we're ready," Nina said impatiently, smiling at the reflection before her.

"But your Majesty, I haven't changed the dress or the..." Star was interrupted.

"Enough! Juno doesn't care about that stuff. You all know this better than I do," Nina demanded, "Just show me my goddess, Athena!"

Kaery shook her head, thinking: *One minute Nina doesn't know whether to call Juno by her true name, the next minute she's calling her by the humans' name. Mancers are always so confused. And yet they seem to hold humans in contempt for being in the same state. No wonder they have Witchbreed council in every successful court.*

"Please, Ahlina, activate the mirror."

"Thank you, ladies." Nina smiled over her delicate shoulder, then looked quickly back to the golden circlet that, as soon as Ahlina touched it, began to swirl like a pool of water. As if it were her first time seeing the artifact that the Coven of Unity made for her, Nina gasped, then tried to retract her awe and seem nonchalant. It didn't work; she knew the girls were amused. She stood upright when Star nudged her back.

The mirror was a fantastical item that many in the court of Gods envied. It was unique, however, like the three Wicasht who took care of her at every beck and call. This mirror allowed her to see anywhere on planet Earth, including Groves,

an ability that even powerful Mancers like Sky didn't have. She shook in anticipation as the swirls smoothed out quickly and became a clear picture of

Juno's war camp. She seemed to be meeting with the beautiful queen, Andromeda, over a map. They both wore armor blessed by the Mancers and the Witchbreed alike. The sculpted weapons on their hips and backs carried the same Runes of Magick that exposed many bonuses to their already mighty fighting styles.

Juno could have easily used Glamour to cover the smudge of dirt on her cheek, but everyone in the court knew she didn't use her Magick in such ways. She preferred to use Magick to aid herself in battle and hunt. Even covered in dirt, she would be stunning with her long chocolate braid and raspberry highlights that didn't seem to match the silver armor she wore, but stood out on their own. Her mismatched eyes of sea-blue and stone-brown stared at the battle plans fiercely. Nina cleared her throat. She knew she was, in a way, inconveniencing Juno before battle. "Hello, Athena. Hello, Andromeda." Her greeting startled both women, but they regained composure the moment they realized they were staring too hard at the map.

Juno turned to see an image of Nina in all her Olympian glory, standing as if she were in the same room as the huntress goddess and the warrior queen. "Hello, love. As you can see, we are preparing for war. What is it I can do for you?"

Nina smiled almost apologetically and blushed. "I just wanted to give you my blessings before such a brutal event. You know how much I disdain violence."

"Yes, I know. This is why I would never let you come to such a place." Juno spoke to Nina as if their lives depended on this battle, as if she was performing all of these duties for her. "I know the fertility parade happens to be this very day, am I not correct?"

"Of course you are. I make my announcements soon. By the way, have you encountered any Supernaturals on the battlefield thus far?" Nina sounded worried, which made all three of her Witchbreed stare at the mirror in wide-eyed anticipation.

Juno felt her concern, even over the ether in an astral form. She would give Nina a full report, but she was needed, so she kept her answer short and to-the-point. "Yes, we've killed many of the Vampyl and their undead hordes. They seem to be consorting with powerful Wicasht and the Immortal, Enoch. These human armies are not being led by Mancers that we know of, but they are hostile, and if we do not push them back, they will take over the Southern regions of Zeus' Kingdom. Now I must go before the sun falls. As you know, I hate Vampyl because they are so tough to kill at night."

“I understand. Please try to...” Nina almost forgot she was among onlookers when she let her guard drop. She was truly worried about Juno’s wellbeing. She continued, “Please try to stay safe, and come back to me. I can’t bear you in danger. After the ceremonies, I will fly to Sky’s kingdom. She seems to have something important to show me.”

Juno nodded and sent an emotion of love so that Nina would know how she felt with unsaid certainty.

“I just can’t believe we must take more lives in such modern times when we have civility,” Nina said. “Andromeda, please watch over Athena.”

The Queen bowed respectfully and said, still looking at the ground, “It is Athena who watches over me, your Highness. I will do my best to assist her as you wish.” Andromeda looked like a warrior queen as she showed her scars from battle proudly. Her sandy hair was pulled back neatly, and like Juno, she had no makeup on. Fatigue was starting to show on her naturally pretty Jreamer face.

“Thank you. You shall be in my favor,” Nina said calmly.

“The pleasure is all mine.” Andromeda stood up and smiled at the goddess’ astral form.

Juno said aloud so that the Coven of Unity could hear, “Protect Nina from any harm. You know what I mean, and you all know the skills. I taught you how to fight. I’m sure you’re more than capable of this task, whomever she takes with her to Sky’s court.”

Nina didn’t bother correcting Juno’s use of the human names, instead turning her head to see the loving smiles of her advisors, then looking back at the mirror where she said, “I’m in good hands. I trust no one more than these three, and you of course.”

Juno gave a final nod, then turned to address the soldier running into the tent with awful news. “What is it, Zeer?”

The tall thin man was wearing uncomfortable-looking heavy armor, and his eyes were those of a scholar. “The sun is setting, and the dark forces have already started eating away at the camps. What are your orders, your Majesty?”

“I hate vampires!” Turning abruptly to the image of Nina, Juno smiled lovingly and said, “I have to go. Enjoy your vacation.”

“I will.” Nina was unable to finish her statement as Juno ran out of the tent with Andromeda only a step behind her.

Ahlina touched the mirror, and as if her contact disrupted the image, it was gone as soon as her finger lifted from the reflective surface.

Nina stood for a shocked moment. “There’s coldness in the air. Where have I drifted to be so disconnected from what goes on below the Mount Olympus?”

“The forces keep us and your liege safe. Zeus controls Olympus, which is the largest of all Mancer kingdoms, so there is no way you can know everything outside these safe walls. You are not disconnected, but protected,” Ahlina said carefully.

Nina had no expression. She could still feel through the mirror as if she were standing in the war camp with Juno; the fear, pain and confusion blended with hatred, angst and anger. It was the same feeling she felt in every battle. Nina knew the reason Juno would prefer that she be surrounded by powerful allies was because she didn’t want her lover to be subjected to such violence. Nina felt powerless in her moments of separation from Juno. She wasn’t there to help her in case she was needed, even though Nina had been known to walk onto a field of killers and make them all bow down in a peaceful resolve within seconds. Some of the Gods of the Court preferred to teach the enemies a harmful and unforgettable lesson, which always meant the loss of life, both mortal and immortal. This was the reason Nina was so torn about bringing more Supernaturals into a world that seemed so content in the taking of life.

“Are you okay, Nina?” Kaery asked while touching her shoulder with a warm hand. She had never called Nina ‘Aphrodite,’ and for some reason it was fine when Kaery addressed her this way. Her tanned skin was a lovely contrast to Nina’s fair flesh, but the touch was what Nina needed to snap her out of her entrancement of inner thought. Kaery could see the emotions Nina emitted in her aura as if they were waves of water. She knew Nina felt every mixed emotion from the battlefield.

“I zoned out again didn’t I?” Nina said apologetically.

“Yes, you did, but we understand the Mancer time paradox. You can’t help it if we don’t assist you in focusing on the here and now.” Kaery had bronzed skin that only amplified her natural beauty and golden eyes. She was not extremely exotic, but she was amazingly warm and soft, which made everyone feel safe around her.

Nina appreciated these young women more than they knew. As she looked at them all so carefully, like looking at dolls, she thought, *I know what I am going to*

do will hurt them because they have been so loyal, but I cannot do what they will expect of me; I'm not strong enough to feel more Supernaturals die. Not with a clear conscience can I allow more blood to be on my hands at the mercy of these warring gods. "What time is the fertility ceremony starting?" she spoke softly.

Star, anxiously, ruby-red lips sparkling, answered, "In the next hour, the humans will sacrifice the bull and expect you to bless them. Then the Supernaturals will await your decision of fertility, which is what the festival is truly about, but the humans are so dumb and just want an excuse to make out. My favorite part is when you decide who is going with you to Isis' court!" Star realized she seemed overzealous, but she didn't care. Everyone knew how much she adored fashion and the ways of Sky's court over the clean and functional courts of Greece. The statues and columns of Greece were nice, but in their own way boring, dripping with egos larger than hers and deep-rooted traditions that made her cringe.

"Yes of course. I'll need a bath, and we must prepare for the ceremony. Ahlina, please tell the Priests and Priestesses to prepare the services. You are the High Priestess, and I appreciate your loyal work." Nina smiled favorably at Ahlina, who seemed touched beyond words as she slowly bowed and backed away smiling.

"At once, Mistress Aphrodite," Ahlina smiled and turned immediately, catching a warm smile from Kaery. *She's like a female phenomenon. She holds me in her favor. I'm definitely going to be one of the chosen to bear a child. I must keep her favor and make sure everything is perfect.* Ahlina left the room and began to run once she was out of sight.

Nina began to walk toward her bath, letting the drapes of her dress drop to the ground with every step. She knew others would pick them up. She continued to give orders while stripping, "Star, I will need more perfumes to bless for the parade. We shall give the humans love potions."

"I shall have the servants bring the perfumes to the steps of your castle," Star said as she walked in long strides out the room. "I'll meet you at the baths to prepare your makeup and wardrobe."

Nina did not reply. She knew Star was the best in the kingdom at such a task as Glamour. Deep in thought, she could not help but to think: *Am I too lost to be saved? Will they hate me for the next thousand lifetimes? This is going to be the hardest decision I've ever had to make, and for some reason, now I know what Zeus must feel with all his laws and courts that he governs. My Magick is not*

strong enough to shield me from the storm that is definitely going to need to be cleaned up.

Kaery guided Nina into the large room that was full of water. With a silent prayer, Kaery walked ahead of Nina saying, “May the warm waters cleanse as the cool wind guides my true breath.” In a second, the water began to steam, and Kaery’s breath was visible as she walked across the water like it was stone. Nina stood in awe of the Witchbreed who effortlessly warmed an entire pool of water just for her comfort. She’d seen Kaery do such a task thousands of times, but she noticed today that Kaery smiled the entire spell. Though Kaery was immune to Nina’s ability to control emotions, this was an obvious sign that the maiden was pleased with her work. “Why do you smile so gleefully?”

“I am honored to be part of such a court. You respect and love me and my sisters as your own. We are not worshipped as Goddesses, yet you treat us as such. I would not ask to be in anyone else’s court.” Kaery smiled and spoke truthfully as she walked across the water and back to the marble floor where she reached her hand to Nina to guide her into the pool.

Nina’s hand was warm, and she loved her baths, the water blessed and enriched with herbs, minerals and crystals on the floor that glowed once her foot was submerged in the water. With every step, she felt relaxed and rejuvenated, wiping away the anxiety she felt just moments before. “Are you sure of that statement, Kaery?” Nina said, smiling mischievously as her naked body sank into the pool, only allowing her breast and upper body to be touched by the cool but steamy air.

“Whatever do you mean, Nina? I am in the court that I love the most.” Kaery spoke, slightly confused. She knew that Nina was a jealous Mancer, yet she’d never shown such a side to Kaery until today.

“I mean, I am no fool. I see the way you look at Aegis—I’m sorry—Zeus.” Nina made sure she was facing Kaery when she spoke his name so that she could witness the expression for full effect.

Had I been sloppy? How did she know that I was seeing Blue? This is embarrassing. “I adore the Mancers. I still would not want to be part of his direct court.” *This is only because he’s married to Hera, and she’s a wrathful Mancer.* “I understand you love him, though. Not as your master, but as your husband.” Nina smiled as she turned to lower more of her body into the water. “This is a secret I will hold until I die, so stop worrying so much, Kaery.”

Kaery sighed softly, but knew she couldn't hide much from the mistress of subterfuge herself, who not only read emotions Magickally, but also interpreted them through any and all expression. Kaery blushed as she spoke, "Thank you, Nina."

"Not to be mentioned again. But I have a secret I would like for you to keep." Nina sank into the tranquil waters slowly and then emerged after a long breath. Her eyes were the same color as the pale blue crystals underwater. She spoke in a voice that was so sure of itself, it made Kaery shiver a little. Nina was notorious for changing her mind and being indecisive. "Today at the ceremony, I will announce that there are to be no more Supernatural births this cycle." With a wide-eyed stare and shocked expression, as if she'd heard the most horrible news in her life, Kaery could do nothing but listen for a hint of a joke. She knew otherwise as her senses told her this was the absolute truth. Nina had made her decision and was planning on sticking to it.

Nina noticed Kaery's predictable response and replied with a confident rationale. "Before you think this is an attack on you or anyone specific, it isn't. I know how much you and your Coven of Unity have done, not just for my court and the courts of all the gods, but for the courts of Mancers and of other nations, equally."

"Yes, but if you know how loyal we've been, and with all that you've asked, we've answered your every request, why would you make such a decision that will undoubtedly make many suffer?"

Kaery dropped to her knees as if pleading with the bathing Mancer.

"I do not intend to make anyone suffer anymore. That is exactly the reason for this. I must put an end to the wars. We should love one another, not fight," Nina said with a peaceful sparkle in her eyes.

"Not all Supernaturals fight. Most of us live in peace among the humans or in castles, such as this one in the sky. Our Magick aids both cultures without prejudice. We have created pools such as the one you bathe in, weapons that make the Mancers of Blue's court exceptionally powerful—channeled the very elements and asked for their divine blessings to carry the castles on the clouds and even crafted mirrors and garb for your vanity." Kaery spoke so passionately that her voice was starting to become louder, deeper, even booming and rocking the foundation as her eyes began to glow.

“Kaery, calm yourself!” Nina said to her, subconsciously using her powers, even though she knew they had no effect on this individual. “This is my choice, and it is done. You will carry on as if you know nothing and as if everything is perfectly fine with my decision. The other Supernaturals look to you for guidance, and I am counting on you to calm the waves.”

Kaery’s eyes continued to glow a molten gold as the Runes of Magick spun in all directions within her pupils. She could not fathom how this Mancer had grown so egotistical that she could stop the progression of the Supernaturals for something as inevitable as war. It was unacceptable, and Kaery knew that in a single word she could reduce this castle to rubble. She shook as she clenched her open hands into fists. It took every ounce of willpower for her not to say another word but she succeeded. Her eyes stopped glowing as she realized she was floating high in the room. She willed herself to settle down on the ground.

Nina smiled valiantly as she said, “I knew you’d see things my way. There is too much violence in the world, and we can put a stop to it. The Supernaturals of the most powerful kingdom in the entire world shall feel my real power, and they shall understand that I won’t condone war.”

Kaery could not smile or bring herself to speak without some sort of judgmental comment, so she stood quietly as Nina spoke. In a single decision, this woman had broken the trust that Kaery had instilled in her. Kaery had countless conversations with her coven, telling them all not to worry; this would be the thousand-year cycle when Nina would finally bless them with children. She would look like an idiot to her coven, as well as a hypocrite, if she gave her blessings to such a fool. Kaery was livid but held her composure close to her heart.

“I see you are struggling with this, Kaery, but I trust you will say nothing to anyone, not even your Coven of Unity. I have an announcement to make soon.” Nina knew the world would never be the same. She spoke aloud, mostly to herself than to Kaery as she walked past the edge of the baths toward her quarters. “I have warned the Mancers of this kingdom that I will not participate in their warring games. I told them they will not overlook my power ever again.”

This is something she had planned for many moons then, making us do these ridiculous tasks and wait on her hand and foot like slaves. We were never her equals. Not in her mind. She was using our kindness and loyalty to her benefit. Now that she’s the most revered goddess in the court, she spits in our faces. What will I ever say to my coven? Kaery’s thoughts were so sporadic that she barely saw

Nina's hand approach her. Flinching away out of reflex more than anger or disgust, she looked into Nina's blue eyes.

"I promise this pains me more than you'll ever know, but it must be done," Nina said, retracting her hand from Kaery, knowing her feelings were hurt. Kaery wasn't very good at subterfuge, and her emotions were written all over her face and divulged through her body language. "You'll do as I have requested, right?"

After a silent stare and a conscious decision to do something even worse, Kaery answered while bowing. "I will not tell anyone of your decision before the announcement."

Nina's large smile was a sign of her true happiness as she hugged the Wicasht lovingly, though no hug was returned. "You will not be sorry." *I will still help her and her coven have children, just not now. She has to trust me; I want to see who in the court has underestimated my power.* "Trust me," Nina said before walking her naked body down the long marble hall adorned with artistic replicas of her own face along with paintings of her many exploits in the myths and scriptures of diverse cultures.

Kaery could not bring herself to move after recognizing the monster she had helped create. She was still holding her clenched fists behind her back, and they lowered slowly to her thighs as she thought. *This pains me more than you'll ever know, but Olympus must fall!*

*

Blue stood in the center of his courtyard speaking to ten of the most powerful members of his court. His golden armor was handcrafted by the Coven of Unity, and his love, Kaery, had personally blessed it with her scent so that when he wore it he'd always know she was near. Of course this was something no one knew, and it was subtle enough to give him hope that he'd be with her someday. He'd married Hera to appease her followers many decades ago, but he was not in love with her. His power over the people was unchallenged, yet he seemed to think it was necessary to exercise his might every so often. "What do you mean they will not pray to my altars anymore? I am Zeus! Do the humans no longer fear me?"

"It is not that, my King," Hera said coldly. "They have not seen your presence in so long, they have lost some of their hope."

“I shall renew their hope, and they shall replenish their fear and respect for my great kingdom,” Blue said as he slammed his spear on the ground, cracking the foundation and the marble in five different ways. “We are the Immortals of Olympus, and they will know how displeased I truly am.”

“What do you plan on doing?” Hera’s intricately curled hair hung in loops that made her look more regal than she anticipated. Her silky skin was untouched by blemish, and she wore a revealing goddess dress that draped her curves. Her plum lips showed no expression as she asked her question.

“After today’s fertility parade I’ll let them make love and sleep well into the morning in a Dionysus drunken stupor as they praise Aphrodite’s power. They will remember my power when I release the Kraken!” Blue’s eyes did not flinch, and his expression was daring someone to question his judgment.

The entire court gasped dramatically as they whispered to one another. The Mancers of this court had a healthy fear of the God of Gods. He had the ability to send any of them back to the Soulstream with but a thought. The painfully beautiful hum of the Soulstream meant that he was channeling his unmatched power. He could open a portal and send raw Magick to disintegrate any mortal or Immortal alike just as easily.

“My apologies, but don’t you think that is a little harsh...” Hera couldn’t complete her words that she would dare only to utter.

“If any of you challenge my word, you’ll see the Soulstream up close and personal!” Blue said, provoked. “The humans may not be blessed with the sight to see my power the way you all do, and thanks to the Veil of Ignorance, they have already forgotten that I reign supreme. They will no longer forget this after tonight. I suggest you gather your favorites, mistresses and demigods, then bring them to Olympus because tomorrow will be nothing but my wrath.”

His court fell silent. Every member knew he was going to unleash one of the world’s greatest terrors on his own kingdom to teach them a lesson. This was not going to end well, no matter what anyone said or did. Zeus was given a lot of gifts in his many parades and shrines; one of them was the artifact, which allowed him to control a Dehmn that came through the ocean from another realm like the Supernaturals used Port Runes.

The Kraken was a beast that was so destructive, it was banished by the Great Council to a dark realm where it could destroy to its endless tormented content. To have such a creature released upon earth was chaos incarnate. Only the most

powerful could stop it, and it wouldn't be until the creature touched their kingdoms far from Greece or Zeus stopped the violence with the artifact.

In a booming voice, Blue asked, "Where is Aphrodite?"

Hermes was as handsome as his intimidating father. He dared not interrupt such a speech and awaited his moment to speak: "She is preparing for her parade of fertility, Father. Would you like me to deliver a message?"

"Tell her to hurry and make sure to use her powers of love and persuasion so the entire kingdom is under her spell." Blue waited for his son to leave in a rush before continuing, "I expect even the Supernaturals she blesses with children will be busy mating tonight, only to be hit with a rude awakening. None of you shall say a word. Save your own, and the rest I will handle." *I'm tired of these warring kingdoms getting more respect than me. No longer will they forget my wrath. The Titan shall be released upon this world, and they will remember who put him in the Dehmn realms in the first place.*

Chapter 16

HISTORY

In the beginning of creation, Aenjelhn and Dehmn, also known as Angels and Demons, were created by the Soulstream. Their missions were polar opposites. Aenjelhn were the bringers of order and light while they traveled across time and space. Dehmn were the pioneers of chaos and darkness as they ventured throughout the cracks of reality. When both forces inevitably met, there was a clash of true power that lasted anywhere from a flash to millions of years. In the end of their battles, a large Grey area of new matter, a Grey area that neither faction wanted to venture into, was created. This Grey area is known by humans as the big bang theory, the means by which a universe is born and with it, potentially life.

By the power of the collective souls within the Soulstream, this grand plan has destroyed and created countless universes and multiverses. No one knows what the point of the plan is unless they are within the Soulstream themselves. Those few who are given a glimpse of the grand plan are called Wicasht or Witchbreed. With this enlightenment comes the most responsibility a mortal shell can obtain. The Witchbreed are meant to teach parts of the plan and maintain the balance that is the foundation for all reality.

Essentially, anywhere there is life there will always be a Supernatural hierarchy to maintain a balance. The Mancer or Gods were created to rule, as they chose to be leaders. The Witchbreed were created to teach Mancer, Supernaturals and humankind alike how to maintain the balance through Magick. The thin line between chaos and order is Magick, which is the foundation of all energy. Some Witchbreed have simplified the code of Magick for humans as science, while others have enlightened the Supernaturals with the highest levels of specialized Spellcrafts.

There were twelve main covens on the planet Earth, and with each coven came a specialized and secretive mastery of Spellcrafts that were overprotected and highly dangerous in their own rights. The separate covens made sure to keep their secrets so that too much power wasn't held in one place. They remain neutral to one another but maintain prejudices and stereotypes of each other's covens, as each one doesn't fully understand the complexities of the others. Each coven is so

extremely powerful that they can break down the very fibers of reality in one form or another. This has led them to a governing system called the Great Council. All of the leaders of each coven make a presence for all to hear the direction of their individual coven, and new information which can assist the others in maintaining the balance.

One coven was formed from nine members of the other great covens. Their allegiance to and love for each other was formed in a Magickal bond that could not be denied as well as an oath to maintain the balance, thus giving them the thirteenth seat on the Great Council. Calling themselves the Coven of Unity, they have become one of the most renowned, feared, loved and hated covens of the Great Council. The reason why there was so much mistrust and interest in this coven was because of their blend of traditional Spellcrafts never seen before by the other more conservative covens. Though they are by far the smallest coven, they are downright formidable as they do what was once forbidden: master and cross-train each other in their uncanny Spellcrafts.

Kaery was appointed as the leader of the *Coven of Unity* after leaving a coven of oracles called the *Anu* that mastered the oracular truth of the code. Their point of view was quite literal and so were most of their Spellcrafts. By reading the runes of the code and using her *Spellcraft called Veritas*, she was able to recreate reality as she saw it. She was also able to see future outcomes of any adjustment to the code as well as heal others by rearranging the runes of the code and restoring the order. Because people are fearful of the truth, the *Anu* were nicknamed the *Banshees*, and the masses fled from them when they arrived in council meetings. Kaery's gift was that she was born with *Avatar's Armor*, a natural immunity to others' Spellcrafts and anything Magickal. However, thanks to her only flaw, the *Soulstream's Beckon*, the more she was within her trance-like state, the more she lost touch with reality and became more of the true form of the Soulstream.

Scape left his coven of beings called the *Gaian* that studied, worshiped, respected and summoned elements and animals from Gaia herself, the first Mancer on earth and true spirit of the planet. This coven was nicknamed *the Beasts* for their obvious love of animals. Scape was able to reach within the instinctual side of the psyche and communicate with Gaia and the elementals who form the surface of the planet. His mastery of each elemental resulted in the birth of a living tattoo on his skin,

which allowed him to summon their energy at any moment for his own unique *Spellcraft* called *Acat*. His Gift was also his flaw, called *Totem*, which allowed him to take the form of the Elements he had mastered. The longer he was in the form of an elemental, the harder it was for him to return to his original form.

Ahlina was linked to a coven called the *Children of Daeva*, also known as the *Chaos kids*, that mastered control over the Dehmn and their purely chaotic natures, yet were shunned for their fearful displays of raw destructive power. Ahlina had a *Spellcraft* that she had never truly mastered, but she displayed more control over her erratic powers than most of the other Chaos kids did. When she became a founder of the Coven of Unity, she learned to mimic other *Spellcrafts* like they were her own using *Parallel Spellcraft*. Ahlina's gift allowed her to cast powerful Magicks without the lack of control that other focused Witchbreed had spent lifetimes mastering. Her flaw was called *Disruption*. Even though she could cast powerful Magicks, she could barely read the code that made up reality, and her touch could rearrange the code chaotically, leading to strange and unexpected effects. Basically, she was almost Magickally illiterate.

Star was part of a coven known as the *Glamouri*. Their leader was a beautiful identical twin who wanted her own identity and to be known as the most beautiful woman, so she mastered a form of illusion so real that even Supernaturals couldn't tell the difference in the code of Magick, a form of illusion called Glamour. It was a purely selfish and narcissistic coven, and their members were nicknamed the *Bitches* for their attitudes and roles as Supernaturals. They were meant to be the mothers of Supernaturals, but changed their focus to altering their appearances as they saw fit. Star's gift was called *Jreamer's Birthright*. She was able to hold, create and wield items that were powerful and normally unobtainable. Her flaw was called the *Void Trap*: the more powerful she became, the more enemies she would attract. This flaw was marked by her eyes, which were two different colors.

Never is one of the last descendants of the *Wyrms*, a coven of Dragon-riding and *Dragon-Blooded* Magick users. Most of them decided to leave earth along with the Dragons that once inhabited the planet after the Great War. He was able to use the long-lost powers of various beasts that could melt rock and metal just as easily as ice. He could also change his form to that of the Wym. His gift *Dragon Form*

allowed him to teach others the abilities of the Dragons while granting him near invulnerability and great strength. His flaw was *Disconnected from the hive*. Once he decided to leave the Wyrn coven, he lost his link, the hive mind of the Dragons, which allowed him to master abilities very easily. He had to learn them the hard way through trial and error, acquiring a *Spellcraft* called *Rage casting*, which allowed him to cast under extreme pressure, pain and anger.

Heaven was from the *Monoceros* coven, also known as the *Faery kin*, whose leader, Ara, was the twin sister of Glamouri. Her coven formed and protected the eighth continent, Ballade. The Monoceros had mastered abilities that were from other mystical realms of Gray called Fae Magick. Instead of being self-obsessed like the Glamouri, the twin sister became obsessed with anything Fae. Heaven was able to summon beasts that are only known on earth as mythological creatures. She was also able to permanently change her physical features to match those of the beasts she could control and summon. Heaven's gift was called *Nine Voices of the Sirens*, which allowed her to high summon, speak and cast multiple spells at once. Her unique *Spellcraft* was called *Multicasting*. Using her multiple sets of vocal cords, she was essentially her own choir and could cast more than one spell at once while singing and dancing. She could change her very environment as if she were using Glamour, but on a dreamlike and sometimes permanent scale. Her flaw was *Elven aura*. No matter what she tried to do, she would always stand out in a crowd, never able to adopt the plain features of her peers.

Khenebu was a prodigal master of the *Necromantech* *Spellcraft* that is unique to the coven known as the *Fen Ying*, or the *Gorehounds*, as they have been nicknamed throughout the Great Council. They reached deep within dark matter, opening portals to realms mainly controlled and/or inhabited by the Dehmn. They brought back alien technology and codes that gave them mastery over the use of dead flesh and souls. His gift was *Humanity's Touch*, which allowed him to somehow maintain his humanity while practicing his dangerous *Spellcraft*, as others from his coven resembled Liches or undead sorcerers after mastering the dark arts. His flaw was that he was a *Dark Conduit* for higher levels of Dehmn, which made his soul an easy target for possession by these beings who longed to enter his plane of existence.

Ewm was from the esteemed *Clandestine* or *Warlocks*, a coven of males who harbored knowledge and secrets as intelligently as they mastered high levels of offensive Magick and acted on their ambition for power. They held considerable power and influence over the Great Council after the banishment of the Sin Chimes. Ewm broke away from the Warlocks with a curse that forbid him to enter the Coven's Grand library, the Celirdor, no matter what lifetime he was reborn in. The young Witchbreed didn't seem to be bothered by the curse, as he had a gift of *Magickal eidetic memory*, which prevented him from losing all codes he ever read and/or mastered. He also had access to the *Spellcrafts* of eight other covens that the Warlocks could only wish they had information on. His *Spellcraft* that he mastered was called *Battle Casting*, which allowed him to cast spells and curses without much concentration, even while fighting under extreme duress. His flaw was that he was not proficient at defensive *Spellcrafts* at all, as if the universe would not allow someone so gifted in offensive Magick to master both.

Ssiah was the coven of Unity's beacon of Aenjelhic light. She was from a coven called the *Llabrat* who later deemed themselves the *Orphans* because they were abandoned by their Forefathers, the Aenjelhn, after the Great War. Despite this disconnection, they continued to remain noble and ever-present in their search for order and all things light. Being able to see Aenjelhn and Dehmn alike, Ssiah was able to learn potent Magick from beings that are older than our universe. She could summon Aenjelhn to do her bidding as well as use a collection of celestial *Spellcrafts* known as *Enochian Magick*. Her spells were so strong that she was thought to be otherworldly. In truth, her gift was *Binding of Enochian Magick*, which allowed her to cast spells very much like a Mancer casts Magick: by pure thought and feeling. Her flaw was that she was *Warded*, which meant that the Aenjelhn were overprotective of her spiritual vessel and wouldn't allow her to learn certain types of Magick, even from her own coven.

It is not certain how so much diversity and power bonded, but the Coven of Unity has been under my watch per the request of the Great Council. Each lifetime we meet, they seek my services to teach them how to use their Magick. Every lifetime, I've known them all to have nothing but the purest love for each other. Our paths have crossed many times, and it is my spell that has shielded them from the ever-watching eyes of OZONE and much older enemies. There is no such thing

as coincidence, and these kids will soon find this lesson as important as any mistake they may have made in past lives.

The Coven of Unity is responsible for some of the most powerful spells that have ever been cast, the *Spell of Enlightenment* and the *Veil of Ignorance*. They were commanded to cast a spell so true, it would grant humans the same power as the Supernaturals; the *Spell of Enlightenment* would have been impossible for any other coven to complete. The results were so devastating that the Earth erupted with its first war called **the Great War**. The war almost tore the world apart, literally, which forced the Coven of Unity to cast a reversal spell that would forever make humans Magickally blind, the *Veil of Ignorance*. For with ignorance, the soul remains humble and innocent, unable to see Magick and therefore unable to change the code in any way. Of course, no spell is perfect, and a lot of new Supernaturals were born on earth. I have to make sure that nothing like that happens again.

This is the brief history of the Coven of Unity as I have witnessed it, for I was one of their most prized mentors and Wicasht elders, *Gauntlets the Avatar of Earth and keeper of wisdom*. When they meet me in this lifetime, I will have to steer them towards a more peaceful means of *Spellcraft*. Unfortunately, I don't believe I can even stop them from the impending doom that is fated for this planet. And if the Coven of Unity isn't at full power, there will be no one able to stop the Mancers and OZONE from destroying the earth.

Chapter 17
DEJA VU

Okay, I can do this, Scape told himself in the bathroom mirror, I have maintained a great GPA, I have sick friends, I'm the head of the new student greeting program and I'm a fairly attractive guy. So why can't I find time to get a boyfriend?

Scape pointlessly messed with his sculpted hairdo. He knew there was just enough product to look like a rocker, but not too much, so he still kept his approachability. His tanned skin was a compliment to his athletic physique that fit his earthy and comfortable clothes, which had only taken him a few minutes to choose.

Maybe I spend too much time putting my look together, or maybe I'm just not looking in the right places, but I swear I would be a good boyfriend. I spend so much time making sure everyone else is happy that I have been neglecting my own spirit. Of course, I've never had a boyfriend, so this will be tricky. I don't know what spirit guide to pray to, but here goes nothing. Just send me a cute boy that I can take care of who has great hair. Ok, I don't mind his hair so much if he is really cool. Thanks, spirits of the land.

Scape took a deep breath and closed his eyes while the water from the sink flowed over his fingers. He didn't notice the sudden transparency of his hands as they assumed the properties of the stream that flowed from the faucet. His mind kept wandering, but he had to go back to the admissions office to show a new student from Egypt around the school. He had chosen to help new kids become more comfortable with the school shortly before his friend Kaery had transferred from New York. It served as a credit on his transcript, and he would get a killer letter of recommendation. It'd been almost two years, and he was excited about the position, even though Principal Hatcher was tough and always on his case. He opened his eyes when the restroom door slammed. Scape instantly stared at the pale face of the strange loner, Nevin, who looked shocked to see someone meditating in the restroom.

"Umm... hi," Scape said, taking a gulp, "I was just...umm. Well, hi Nevin. Oh wait, you like people to call you Never, right?"

“Yea, that's right.” He lifted his hand to shake Scape's. “Since I didn't officially introduce myself to you, I'm Never, and you're Kaery's friend Scape, right?”

Oh, yeah, he is the punk rocker kid who stares at Kaery a lot. But he's so cute. I didn't really pay attention to his hair before—it's so blond it's almost white! And he may be shorter than me, but he has skater boy features. Cute! “I know I haven't spoken to you much since the day at the diner, but I wanted to tell you I'm sorry I never took the time to get to know you.” Scape raised his hand up to shake Never's hand. “I'm Moon Scape Mahkan, but everyone just calls me Scape.”

“Oh, ok, Scape,” Never said as he touched the warm hand. Never looked into Scape's familiar brown eyes, and a sharp gasp filled the air along with a desert-dry heat.

Scape gasped simultaneously as he held onto Never's hand. The hot air filled the room and invaded their lungs as they were brought to another time.

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“Don't fall, Never! Just hold on,” Scape screamed desperately as he held onto Never's hand while the pale teen hung over the side of a cliff. “Just let me get my footing and I'll pull you up!”

“Don't tell me, just get me up!” Never cried, looking down at the rocks hundreds of feet below. “This is what I get for trying to run from those pirates. I knew they'd find us.” He felt his hand slipping from sweat.

“Shut up and hold on,” Scape said, kicking his simple leather boot off his left foot and touching the rock with his toes. The rock fused with his flesh, and his leg became as solid as the stone. Now that he knew he wouldn't fall, he pulled Never up to safety. His long hair blew in the wind, and he ignored the dust as it swirled around the cliffside and into his eyes. Instead he used all of his strength to pull Never up over the cliff where they collapsed onto each other and lay there for a long while, breathing heavily and staring up into the sky.

“You know we have to stop meeting like this,” Scape said as he laughed while his heart tried to stop racing.

Never stopped looking at the sky and stared into Scape's brown eyes, "It would take all the adventure out of it." He smiled and rolled slowly off Scape's muscular chest and arm.

*

"Whoa, what was that?" Scape said, lying on the floor of the restroom with Never next to him, staring into the void created by the boy's dark eyes.

"I don't know, but I don't think I have to pee anymore." Never got up quickly to his feet and looked down at Scape who was smiling peculiarly at him. "I... umm, gotta go." Never practically ran out of the restroom.

Scape lay back onto the cold tile, smiling as he looked up at the ceiling. "So that's what Deja vu feels like." *I wonder what lifetime that was 'cause we looked like pirates, or worse.* He looked down at his hands and smiled. "I saved him?" Scape continued smiling until the bell rang, and he remembered he was supposed to be in the office helping the new kid get to classes. He jumped to his feet, dusted his pants off and barely looked at himself in the mirror before he ran to the office.

*

"Your guide should be here any moment," Ms. Hatcher said impatiently, looking down at the impressive transcript from the exchange student. "Khenebu Anwar, is it?"

"Please, call me Ken," he smiled graciously.

The charming white smile almost caught Ms. Hatcher off guard, considering this teen had not made many facial expressions since entering her office.

"Well, *Ken*, you will not be given any special treatment here at Drakehawk Academy. Do I make myself clear?"

"Yes, of course, Madame." Ken spoke smoothly.

"It's just Ms. Hatcher," she responded quickly. "As I've told you before, we have a large student body of well-to-dos and wannabes of the high society and elite class. Even with this exceptional transcript, I still can't believe the admissions board let you in so late in the school year, especially with all of this Sky business."

The last part Ms. Hatcher was mostly saying to herself, but realized Khenebu was lost when she saw the expression on his face change. “So no funny business. I’ll be watching you.”

Running into the office panting was Scape, who ignored the secretary and barged into Ms. Hatcher’s office. “I’m so sorry, Ms. Hatchet; I was talking to a student and...”

“Silence!” Ms. Hatcher interrupted rudely. “I don’t have time for your insubordination. And if you want to be replaced, Mr. Mahkan, then trust me, I can make it happen.” She knew Scape hated being called by his last name.

“My apologies. It won’t happen again, Ms. Hatchet— erm, I mean, Ms. Hatcher.” Scape cringed at the mishap of calling her the teasing name. She reminded the students and teachers alike of a serial killer the way she cut people down in her school.

Khenebu smiled as he looked at Ms. Hatcher’s face becoming slightly red. He stood up and spoke, “You are my guide, I assume?”

Scape barely looked at Khenebu for the first time, but grinned automatically. “Yes, I sure am. Let’s get you to your classes right away.” Scape tried to avoid the glare from his principal, but couldn’t take his eyes off her for some reason.

Khenebu walked out of the office politely and into the hall where Scape hurriedly paced behind him.

“Thanks for that,” Scape said, “I owe you.” He finally got to observe the new student properly. “Wow, you’re attractive! Oh my gosh, I’m becoming Kaery. I’m sorry, I’m Moon Scape. You know what? Just call me Scape. I’ll be your guide in the harsh social jungle known as Drakehawk Academy.” Scape looked into the light brown eyes of the strange new student.

“Please, don’t be sorry. Thank you, Scape. You’re handsome yourself,” Khenebu replied politely.

Like the earlier run-in with Never, Scape felt a familiarity that he couldn’t shake. There was also a slight chill to this handsome newcomer though. He had neatly-twisted dread locks that cascaded down his back. His smooth dark-brown skin revealed strong, masculine and modellesque bone structure. His walk was that of a noble aristocrat with etiquette, though he smiled as if he were happy to be free of some unknown burden.

Scape watched him closely as he described the history of the halls and paintings while also offering small tips on not getting bullied and surviving the classes. “The eldest prep school in California, Drakehawk Academy is housed in a historic castle with origins dating back to the Sixteenth Century. After hundreds of rooms and passages were restored in the late Nineteenth Century, the grounds became an epicenter of academic achievement and have continued to produce visionary leaders ever since. We pride ourselves in giving our students freedom of expression while maintaining high standards in curriculum. Okay, this speech is too boring for me to continue without asking you about yourself.” Scape smiled as Khenebu turned to him, interested.

“What would you like to know?” Khenebu asked, taking a step closer to Scape.

Scape became slightly nervous and uncharacteristically shy all of a sudden, so he looked down at the documents he had grabbed on the way out of the office. “Well, Khenebu, I see here on your transfer papers that you're basically an academic guru. Trigonometry, AP Physics, Excel English, Latin, Excel History and Excel Engineering. But you look like, well, a stud.” Scape looked down.

“I assume you calling me a horse is a compliment, so I will take it as such. I like to study is all. And you can call me Ken if Khenebu is too much for you, though you said my name perfectly.” His warm smile was comforting. He raised a hand to shake Scape's. “This is your custom, right?”

Scape slightly lost track of what he was talking about as he looked at the tall dark teenager smiling like a prince. He looked down at the hand in front of him and said, “Oh, yes, of course it is. A... umm, custom to shake hands.” Scape smiled genuinely back up at the tall Khenebu. He reached his hand out to shake as they stood in front of the trophy case in the East hall.

The moment the two shook hands, the lights flickered in the hallway, and the trophy case exploded around them like a wave from the ocean. A salty breeze filled the air, and both of them were taken to a different time where they sat side by side in what looked like the bow of a slave ship.

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“Tonight Ahlina will get us out of here, and we'll be free, Khenebu,” Scape said to the dark muscular man next to him as their arms were clasped.

“I hope she doesn't take it as an opportunity to run for her own life,” Khenebu said to the Native American next to him. “You know I trust *you*, but she's too...”

“The spirits tell me that tonight is the night we will be freed,” Scape said to comfort his fellow slave.

They stared at each other for a long time as they held hands. The shackles clanked in the dark pit of the stinky ship. They could feel the water shaking the vessel side to side as it splashed through the cracks of the putrid wood. Other slaves continued to row. The overseer looked in the direction where Khenebu and Scape were whispering and twirled his whip to strike the backs of both slaves, “Get back to work!,” making them release the grip of each other.

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“You're a Witchbreed!” Khenebu said aloud to Scape as they stood among the shards of glass from the shattered trophy case, alone in the silent hallway of the school.

Chapter 18

THE CODE

Gemini stood next to Jayde as the last of his students walked into the courtyard. He looked at each of them as if he were looking deep into their souls. It was very much possible for this powerful Mancer to perform such a feat, however he was simply looking at them with a proud smile. He knew that the next lessons he'd teach them would change their entire perspective of the world, but he knew they were prepared for this lesson no matter how long it might take.

"I had Jayde gather you all here for the next lesson I must teach you in order to control your powers," Gemini said clearly into the warm morning air. "You are all Mancers, as you know, and therefore have a responsibility that no one else can share." He paused for them to take in his words as reality. "Mancer is synonymous with the words leader, king, queen, ruler, etc., and with the existence of such a being comes power drawn from the Soulstream that cannot be rivaled by any other single creature or Supernatural. Yes, I just called you the most powerful beings on the planet." Gemini watched the looks on each of their faces change from frowns of confusion to broad grins of excitement. "With that being said, there are others who have more control over the Soulstream than any of you because they understand and respect the Code."

Blue looked at Maia, who shrugged. He was going to interrupt Gemini to ask why he wasn't trying to come up with a plan to save Sky and teach her this lesson. She would probably be the one who could use this information more than any of them, but he stopped himself, and for the first time, decided to not be a rebel. Nina stood close to Surge, who seemed to find comfort in being near her. Juno was perched in her OZONE-issued armor on a stone nearby, watching and listening carefully as Gemini spoke, even though she was not one of Gemini's students.

"As you all know by now, we are dwelling in the Ruined City of Zalomoni. To a few of you it may seem familiar, while to the rest of you it is just shattered stone and earth-covered temples with scars from an unknown battle. However, I would like to give you all a challenge: find the Code of Magick written on the foundation of this place and study it until you can show your peers what you've learned."

Blue raised his hand as if he were in high school again. He didn't know what this was all about, but he knew that it would be like all of Gemini's other cryptic lessons, important for future battles. He also remembered that the first time he was able to see the code on anything was in Union Square when he focused on Nina and Surge-Overload. He looked up and saw the same code illuminating several large stones near the river. He raised his hand even higher.

"Yes, Blue," Gemini nodded as his eyes fell upon the young Mancer.

"I just wanted to say I think I've found the Code you're talking about. I can show you all now," Blue said with a shrug.

"That's cheating. You must have gotten the memo," Surge-Overload pouted playfully with her short pig tails pointed up. "I have no idea what code you're talking about, but I can teach you all binary or any programming code if you want." She put her hands in the pockets of her baggy pants and hushed as she noticed that no one got the joke, or at least found it funny.

Gemini motioned his hands for Blue to lead the way and for the others to follow him. He was intrigued by Blue's resourcefulness and cunning as well as curious to see if Blue was really able to detect the Code already.

Nina and Surge-Overload walked behind Maia, who followed Blue closely. Maia didn't seem too disturbed by this lesson at all. She actually was the most confident, for once. She smiled as she followed the group with a look of awe on her face as if she were experiencing a completely different time and place. The realization of Maia's powers made Surge shiver a bit because she knew for a fact that her friend was no longer walking with them in the present. She'd witnessed this ability herself in the battle that destroyed this city. The blast from a huge Dragon she had witnessed just moments ago while holding Maia's hand was enough to make her want to forget the massacre that had happened many years ago in this now tranquil place. She still couldn't shake the feeling that there was a lot this ancient city was hiding, like the secrets were living shadows creeping behind them all as they followed Blue toward the river.

It wasn't long before Blue led them down a path along the side of a chasm. There was a river which didn't seem to end as well as some of the most magnificent natural sculptures any of these young people had ever seen. Three large stones, easily the size of large homes in America, sat in the middle of the chasm surrounded by the river water. The one on the left rested in the shadow of the chasm, choked by mysterious ivy that seemed to hug it like a silky thread. The

one on the right was partially covered in a shiny moss that stretched all the way down to the river, and its crest was imbued with a metallic undertone as the sunlight bathed it. The one in the middle was the largest and most attractive, as it was made of many different shades of minerals and seemed to glow like a mound of gems, even in the shadow near its ivy-covered neighbor.

“Wow, they're beautiful,” Nina breathed as she stopped walking to stare in awe at the stones. She had traveled all over the world in the last few years and had grown an appreciation for the many stones that inhabited the Earth. They brought her peace and told her stories that she would never forget. The stones also were her confidants when no one else was there to listen to her cry. These were by far the most intriguing stones she'd ever come close to, and she stared with a wide-eyed, open-mouthed expression.

“You'd think you just saw a unicorn or something, Nina,” Surge said with a giggle and a tug on Nina's cargo shorts. “Come on, let's see what Blue wants to show us ‘cause I'm still confused at how a rock is going to be binary coded?”

Blue walked toward the stones as if he weren't being followed. His short black hair was touched by a faint breeze as he made his way across the water. His blue eyes squinted at the reflection of the sunlight on the stones and then adjusted as he moved closer. He didn't realize he had walked on water to get to the stones until he turned around and saw everyone else on the banks of the river. He looked at them, embarrassed that he had absentmindedly used his own powers of speed to walk across the water as easily as walking across land.

Gemini held his hand up to make sure Blue stood where he was. “Jayde. Juno.” He motioned for the Asian juggernaut and the OZONE assassin to take the others to the stones.

Juno reacted first and grabbed Nina's waist, then leaped across the water as if she were jumping over a puddle. She jumped so high that the kids stared in awe. Nina closed her eyes as if she were going to crash into the stones on a death-defying roller coaster. When they landed gracefully, Nina took a step from Juno with her heart still racing and said accusingly, “You could have warned me! That almost scared me to death!” Her pout was diffused, and she began to blush as Juno simply smiled.

Maia stepped into the sunlight that was near her foot. She felt the warmth of the light on her black-streaked blond hair wash over her skin and willed herself to

be in the sunlight near the stones. It looked as if Maia was turning into a thousand tiny stars as she reappeared on the other side of the river instantly. She surprised herself as she looked up at the sky, smiling, and her body reformed from golden stars back to flesh. She looked at Blue, who was obviously proud of his friend for becoming more proficient at her abilities. Then she blushed and looked at Surge, who stood on the river bank next to Jayde.

“Are you ready, girl?” Jayde asked Surge-Overload.

“Umm, I think so,” Surge said. “But are you going to jump like Juno, or teleport-star-sprinkle-thing like Maia, or just zip across like Blue did? I'm excited.”

“Neither,” Jayde answered as she held Surge's small hand and jumped toward the water. “Control over one's body makes the elements easily adaptable. Remember that.”

Surge felt like she was being lifted off the ground as if she weighed absolutely nothing. She was somehow following every step that Jayde made as the Asian woman gracefully tip-toed on the water like she gaining momentum from invisible stones, hopping from one to another with an anti-gravitational step. With a few of these moon steps, they were miraculously on the other side of the river. Surge jumped up and down happily at her normal weight. She knew for a fact that they had defied physics yet again.

Gemini took a step onto the water, and a wave carried him across as he glided effortlessly. The kids watched in awe at the display of power. Gemini walked on the shore as if nothing had happened. “Now that we're all here, Blue, please show us the Code?”

“Oh, ok, umm, so if I look at these rocks hard enough...” Blue began to strain as if on focusing an invisible stimulus. He took a step closer to the stone in the middle. “I should be able to. There!” Blue pointed at the center of the large piece of earth. His blue eyes glowed as he saw spinning runes in a circular pattern form in his sight. His blue eyes glowed as the runes formed in his line of sight, spinning in a circular pattern. The electric blue runes were spinning clockwise on an outer wheel as silver runes were spinning slowly in an inner wheel closer to the center of the stone. “I can't really read them all, but I can understand some of them, if that makes any sense. Like that one says ‘Soulstream,’ and this one says ‘time.’ ” Blue's fingers tried to follow the strange language as it spun slowly away from him. He turned to see the puzzled look on Surge and Nina's faces.

“Did you happen to drink the water before you looked at the rock?” Surge started in with her sarcastic banter. She didn't really believe Blue's ability to see beyond her own perception until she actually saw the alien looking runes as plain as day for herself and gasped, “Oh my god!” She touched the rock, trying to see if the runes had a texture or energetic signature she could measure. “They don't have any signature? How is this possible?”

Maia broke her silence and answered, “It's the language of Magick. It exists within everything you've ever known. It takes a Supernatural eye to see it and a higher level of enlightenment to comprehend it. This lesson I can teach if you don't mind, Gemini?” She turned her full attention to her mentor. Her pretty Latina features were only exaggerated by the beam of sunlight shining on her face.

“Be my guest, Maia,” Gemini said proudly as he took a step backward, closer to Jayde, whispering, “They are not quite ready to meet the Witchbreed, but soon.”

Jayde nodded as she looked at the kids take a step closer to self-enlightenment.

Nina felt the excitement that everyone was charged with around her. She moved her dirty dish-water blond hair out of her eyes and stared at the amazing stones up and down, not seeing anything except the odd ivy and glowing moss. Then she decided to do what she did when she was confused. *Feel*. She closed her eyes, listened to Maia's words and tried to feel the intentions behind them.

Maia took a short breath, knowing that all attention was on her and that she didn't want to mess it up. “The language of Magick is the foundation of reality and all dimensions. It has been translated into a Code that is so encrypted, even the most knowledgeable of Supernaturals spend lifetimes practicing and studying its great mystery.” She saw that everyone was accepting her speech and wanted to show them what Blue saw in the stones in a much more literal sense. Maia raised her hands, the fingernails alternately painted black and pale pink. Her palms started to glow as she pointed them at the stones. A faint white light shot from her palms and onto the large stones.

Nina kept her eyes closed, but could feel the runes now. She knew this emotion. It was true, this was what everything felt like to her, though she could not put a word to it, let alone describe it to anyone. She felt that everything Maia said was completely true. She opened her eyes and gasped. For the first time, she saw

thousands of runes surrounding the stones in all directions like gears in a clock. Some sets of runes were a myriad colors while most other sets of runes were one unified color, all spinning peacefully. She had no idea what any of them said, but she knew her life would never be the same after this moment.

Maia said, “You see, this is the Code. We may be able to see it, but there is only one class of Supernaturals that has mastered it, the Wicasht, also known as the Witchbreed! In other lifetimes, they were the ones who taught us how to translate this tremendous amount of information and use it to our advantage, how to master our own immense powers and understand the universe in general. This is the key to the Soulstream and to all of our powers.”

Juno smiled as she saw the wave of enlightenment wash over the kids, their sense of reality shifting from the human level to a more evolved version, especially Nina, who probably suffered from the *Veil of Ignorance* more than the others. Juno suspected Nina’s condition was more self-inflicted than cast upon her, but something was definitely blocking this Mancer’s vision, preventing her from remembering these lessons. *I'm sure Gemini has noticed this as well. Something stronger than the Veil of Ignorance is burdening her powers. I'm just glad I finally found her, thanks to these kids, so I owe them all a debt I hope I can repay.*

Blue said to Maia, “So what you're saying is that we need Witchbreed teachers to translate this Code. My next question is, where do we find Witchbreed?”

Maia turned her attention from the stones and looked over her shoulder directly at Juno. She pointed a soft finger at the OZONE Agent.

*

“Kaery?” Ahlina asked in the cafeteria quietly, “Do you remember when you asked me what I did with all of the Braintech laptops I stole?”

Kaery looked at the food on her tray, puzzled, then back up to her concerned friend. “Yeah, I was just kidding though. I don't really need to know.” Kaery smiled while contemplating whether she was going to eat the mystery meat and gelatin vegetable matter on her plate. “What I want to know is how people eat this stuff.”

“Kaery, listen to me. I think I need to tell you something.” Ahlina sounded desperate.

Kaery looked into her friend’s slanted green eyes. “What's wrong, girl?”

“Ok, so I don't know why, but for as long as I can remember, I have been dreaming of this city that was under attack by these huge monsters. I know you're looking at me crazy, but listen. The place was overrun by these werewolf or werecat-looking monsters, and I saw that Asian lady, Jayde kicking major ass, but I couldn't do anything, so I awakened a Dragon that did more damage to the city than the monsters, and a lot of people died.” Ahlina was waiting for Kaery to laugh, but it never came so she continued, “Ok, so I couldn't—or more like didn't want to sleep, and that's when I got into MMORPG's, you know, the massive multiplayer online role playing games where I can escape into random dungeons and country sides, blowing stuff up.”

Kaery nodded and said, “I remember that was about four or five years ago.” When Ahlina nodded, Kaery whispered, “that's when you met that guy Surge what's-his-face, right?”

“Overload,” Ahlina said, “and I think it’s the computer science teacher to be honest. She's wicked hot and über smart!”

“Wait, you think your teacher is the cybergod hacker online?” Kaery asked, almost laughing. Then she noticed Ahlina pulling away and said, “Ok, so what does any of this have to do with your laptops?”

Ahlina looked around suspiciously, “Well I started seeing these weird symbols like hieroglyphics all over the online world, and I started seeing them on the computers.” Ahlina raised her right hand with chewed fingernails. “When I touched the laptop with my palm trying to feel the runes, something happened, and the thing blew up right under my hand.”

“What the?” Kaery gasped, looking at Ahlina's hands as she knew she was telling the truth.

“That’s why I wear a glove on this hand most days and/or some other cute hand wrap. I've noticed it getting worse.” Ahlina looked like she was going to cry. “I touched my cell phone, and it literally melted. Kaery, I'm scared.”

Kaery focused on her friend's right hand so intently, she thought she was looking for a pattern in her fingerprints. She almost stopped staring when she saw

the words *Chaotic Disruption* spinning around Ahlina's wrist. She went to touch Ahlina's right hand, and Ahlina retreated. "I'm not scared of your hand, Ahlina. Let me see it. Maybe it's something that can be explained."

Ahlina pulled her hand out of her pocket and anticipated Kaery would grab it quickly, so she dodged her friend's attempt, and her hand accidentally landed in Kaery's tray of food.

Both girls looked at the tray as the gelatin turned into a pile of broccoli and tomatoes. Kaery smiled and said, "That's not so bad." A moment later, a chicken formed from the mystery meat and jumped off the table, running through the cafeteria. With wide eyes, Kaery said, "We need to talk about this somewhere else." A random cheerleader screamed as the chicken chased her through the rows of lunch tables. Kaery and Ahlina ran out into the hall where Star was looking at herself in a mirror.

Kaery grabbed Star's arm and ran down the hall saying, "I'll explain later, but we have to get out of here." The three girls started to run down the east hall when Scape nearly slammed into Kaery.

"Whoa, what's going on?" Scape asked, puzzled.

"No time to explain! Meet us at Golden Gate Park after school," Kaery responded as she ran out of the doors with both Ahlina and Star trying to keep up on each hand.

Chapter 19

STOW AWAY

(Somewhere in the Atlantic: 1513 A.D.)

En route to the colonies of South America, she found a way onto the slave ship as a deckhand. Ahlina fled from her home and made it to Portugal. She cut her hair even shorter than it was and wore a hat and baggy clothes like the local vagabond sailors. This was no game, as she knew these were the scum of the earth, using people as cattle for their own profits. If they found out she was a woman, she knew worse things could happen to her, so she resorted to no eye contact, always keeping her head low and following orders the best she could. The ships were easy enough to maintain, but the trip with so many people below was the issue. There were dozens of slaves who did not last the entire trip due to starvation, disease, neglect, or some other inhumane act.

Ahlina was enlightened already and was forbidden to use her powers, but if worse came to worst, she'd blow them all up and put them out of their misery. She used her martial arts training from other lifetimes to carry loads that were three times her body weight, which made her an asset to the captain, who thought the skinny boy was more useful than half the deckhands. This attention was not overlooked by an overseer named Ratkin. Ahlina couldn't imagine why anyone's mother would name her child after a rodent, but after watching him for a while, she noticed the twitch in his nose and the jagged overbite reminiscent of the rats in the ship. She giggled to herself when he wasn't looking, and she realized the Captain was the one who named these people like property.

She wore bandages on her right hand up to the elbow, and no one knew why, so they nicknamed Ahlina 'Wounded.' She didn't particularly hate the name, considering her past, so she kept her mouth shut and answered to it. There were worse jobs on the large ship by far, like the peg boy, barely a teenager, who sat on a wooden peg while the ship sailed, so that the men could have their way with him when the seas were calm. Ahlina would have much rather killed herself than be subject to such a fate. There was a keeper below named Retchmaw the Lasher, or just Lasher. He was an especially vile and disgusting creature of a man from the desert who had been hired to keep the slaves below in line. Ahlina tried to stay away from him because she wanted to spit anytime he was near. Today just wasn't

her day. She was called by the Captain Emilian, a noble from a family in Portugal called the Shandor, who supplied most of the ports with weapons and rare commodities, making them rich and powerful. For centuries the Shandor family had changed their trades to match the demand; lately their trade had been people.

“Wounded, come here,” Captain Emilian said with an air of arrogance and contempt that meant he never wanted to repeat himself.

Ahlina lowered her hat on her head and hid her face as she bowed to the captain. “Aye, Captain,” she said in the lowest voice she could muster.

“I need you to assist Retchmaw the Lasher today when his assistant Narles needs to change shift. I heard you have a soft spot for these slaves, and I want to teach you a lesson that they are nothing more than animals. These are good men doing their job as you do yours with the deck every day.” The Captain looked at her bandaged hand and asked, “What happened to your hands, Wounded?” Ahlina was so scared of the day the Captain would ask about her hand that she simply hid the bandaged arm behind her back and said one word, “Burn.”

“Very well then, off with you,” Captain Emilian said with an undertone of pity.

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“We’ve been here for four days, and I don’t think half of these men are going to make it. They haven’t given us food in two moons,” Scape said to the dark slave next to him. “What’s your name? Look, you can talk to me; I’m not going to hurt you. I may not be African, but I was captured in Persia and sold, just like you. Oh that’s why you’re not speaking; we don’t speak the same language.” Scape rolled his eyes at his own ignorance and dumb luck.

“He’s not speaking because he’ll get whipped to death,” a man with smooth dark-brown skin said to Scape as his light-brown eyes watched Narles the Snitch leave his station. “He’s changing shifts, so I can say something to you. Every time you get these people to speak, you get them whipped, if you haven’t noticed. And they don’t understand a word you’re saying. I’m Khenebu by the way.”

“Nice to meet you, Khenebu, I’m Scape,” the muscular young man said smiling, as he couldn’t move very far with the shackles on his ankles. “Are you from Persia?”

“No, I’m from a small village on the Ivory coast,” Khenebu answered almost matter-of-factly. “Why do you ask?”

“Because the only language I speak is Persian,” Scape said. “And, well, you speak to me quite perfectly.”

“Now that I think about it, I don’t know how I understand you,” Khenebu said confused. “Shhh, here comes another overseer.”

*

Ewm was a pale Romanian boy who had been adopted by a poor medicine man. He watched as his adopted father was robbed and brutally murdered by bandits who stole the few coins that were in his purse. They laughed as the small boy cried over his father’s lifeless body. “I curse you for what you’ve done!” Ewm spat through his sobs as lightning struck in the background. The bandits smiled and shrugged at the creepy orphan.

After the bandits left, Ewm followed them to a nearby camp where they all slept near the dying fire. He used some of the poisonous tree frog serum his father had told him about to taint their water supply. Slowly but surely, the thieves’ health seemed to deteriorate as they made it back to their lair. Some even began to believe in the boy’s curse. Ewm waited for his time to strike. He walked into the lair as they all lie paralyzed with tears rolling down their cheeks.

The ten-year-old stood over their bodies with a smile they could never forget. A sinister gaze came over his moist eyes that bordered on insanity. Ewm straightened his already-neat black hair and rummaged through their spoils. He’d always been a scholar, as his adopted father had called him, preferring to gain knowledge rather than play with the other kids. He had memorized his father’s small library, including all of the rare books on medicine and linguistics, within weeks. He saw treasure chests of gold and jewels in the bandits’ lair that were worthless to him; nothing interested the young boy until he came across the book that would change his entire life.

“My name is E-w-m, pronounced ‘Oh mm,’ and you’ll have to remember that name when you give the River Man his coin and tell him who sent you. I’d like you all to know that a simple frog was the catalyst for your curse, and his simple neurotoxin has paralyzed you so that a small child like me can seek revenge

for his innocent father.” Ewm put the large book in a leather sack as he took a warm hooded scarf from one of the smaller men, then grabbed a coin for each of the thieves from the many chests that littered the room.

After placing a coin into each of their hands, he said a prayer and set an antidote in the center of the room among their treasures, which they had thought were more valuable than human lives. “This antidote is your true treasure and salvation. If you don’t ingest it in time, your bodies will permanently shut down, and you’ll need to pay the River Man. The world is better off without your kind killing innocents, but I’m not like you. The paralysis should slightly wear off in a few hours. The problem is there’s only enough of the antidote for maybe two of you.” The young boy sat in the room full of paralyzed thieves whose eyes stared at him silently, though their souls were screaming in agony.

Opening the ancient book, Ewm gasped as he somehow knew how to read the strange text: “This is the Language of Magick.” The boy sat for hours, enthralled by the words of the book, learning what he could before realizing that he had to run for his life. He would never let anyone take the book away from him. When he stood up and looked into a mirror, he saw an image that terrified him; his eyes were no longer dark brown but had changed to a blood-red. He saw glowing runes spinning around the pupils, but he didn’t look very long before grabbing a small amount of supplies and a bag of coins, heading to the port city, Porto.

After three days of hiking and reading the book he knew was sacred, Ewm found out about a war between Supernaturals that no one had ever talked about before. He learned that Magick truly exists and that he was a Wicasht, also known as a Witchbreed. Ewm became obsessed with the book, intent on learning as much as he could about what the Soulstream was. The book was never out of his reach, and he had the growing suspicion that someone was following him. The young boy kept running without looking back. When he reached the fishy-smelling port city of Porto, he soon saw the same types of low-lives who had killed his father and countless others, all hired by nobles to carry out terrible crimes against humanity. He didn’t want to speak to any of them, let alone ask for safe passage to another country. He saw boys his age taken upon these large ships and raped as if it were an everyday occurrence. Ewm stuck to the shadows for days and slept only for minutes at a given time, trying to move often so no one would find him.

The ship he chose to stowaway on was very similar to the others, nothing really special in particular, except it was named Relíquia, which translated in

Portuguese to ‘Relic.’ He took this as a sign and snuck aboard the wooden vessel the night it was going to set sail. As he climbed aboard the ship, he looked back to see hooded figures moving through the city toward him. Ewm felt as if they were after him, but then dismissed the thought as simply paranoia when he found a shadowy part of the ship to hide in. He could barely sleep as he heard screams and cracking whips from the deck below. He hugged the leather sack and tried to stay out of sight, hiding in any crevice that would support his small frame. His hunger led him to a half-full barrel of stale hardened bread. Ewm was so hungry that he slid into the barrel and shared the bread with the rat that was already inside.

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Ahlina walked down the stairs to the pit of the ship. The smell almost knocked her off her feet as she slowly grabbed the rail and held her mouth instinctively with her gloved left hand. She got to the bottom of the slimy stairs to see at least thirty men and ten or so women staring at her intently. Their white eyes screamed for hope in the darkness, but she could not deliver, as she was trying her best to stay off the radar. *In this moment, I know that we’ll never be Royals. We are all destined for darkness in a world that can allow this kind of injustice.*

“Wounded!” A loud man snarled her name from within the shadows. He walked toward her wearing a filthy tunic that had blood spattered on it and grime from who knows what on the sleeve. His teeth were hideously discolored and disgusting as he smiled a foul grimace.

Ahlina put her head down and simply said, “Aye.”

“So you’re taking over Narles’ shift? Good, ‘cause I was getting tired of that slacker anyway.” All of a sudden the Lasher pulled out a whip that had small hooks you might miss if you weren’t examining it closely.

Ahlina was afraid he had found out who she was and was going to attack her. She looked around for safety when she saw two men whispering with each other. One looked Persian and the other obviously African. She also saw a man next to them who wasn’t rowing because he was nearly dead. There was nowhere to run, as the staircase was behind the foul beast of a man whom Ahlina was prepared to kill if she had to. She reached down toward her bandaged hands when she saw the Lasher spin the whip in the air. Ahlina dodged the whip and lowered

her body into a fighting stance on the warped wooden plank that she was standing on.

A quick snap of his wrist, and the whip sliced through the air and past Ahlina's head as fast as a snake bite. The sting was just as deadly as it hit the whispering man from Persia across the chest. His smooth tattooed skin was now bleeding as he yelped aloud. Another crack slashed the man next to him with the neat dreadlocks. His head whipped backwards in a painful grimace as his arm was raked by the barbed whip.

As she looked back at the now bleeding men, Ahlina did everything in her power to prevent herself from running over to their aid. This was not the way to treat anyone, and she despised everything about this cursed ship the Relíquia.

"No one talks, they row! Ok, Wounded," Lasher started speaking as if he never harmed anyone, "So your duties are gonna be to make sure they aren't dead. If they are dead, they become shark bait. If they are almost dead, let me know. Got it? Good!" He scowled at the slaves as the deckhand stood up. "Quick reflexes. You're gonna need them if you plan on keeping these animals in check."

An uncontrollable cringe came over Ahlina's body as a gasp escaped her mouth in the undeniable sound of disgust.

"They disgust me too, Wounded," Lasher said with a phlegmy cackle. "I just had to get used to their smell. Once you get past the black skin, they almost look like something."

He has no idea how wretched I believe his existence truly is. I'm not disgusted with any of them. I'm disgusted that you call yourself a human. Ahlina, just keep your head down and do your job. You only have a couple more days before the ship arrives at the colony, and you'll never have to see his filthy face again. Don't take off the bandage and melt him. Don't destroy the ship. Just nod and do what he asks. "Aye," she said simply through gritted teeth in her imitation of a male's voice.

"That's what I like about you, Wounded. You know what to say. Narles talks too damned much. Anyway, go check on them, starting with that one over there. He looks half-dead." Lasher pointed at the man next to the Persian who looked like he had fainted.

"Aye."

Lasher turned around and walked into the darkness where there seemed to be a cabin Ahlina had never noticed before. In the darkest part of the ship, the slaves

crept away from the shadows as if they were alive. Lasher flinched at the slaves as if to hurt them and took great pleasure in their fear as he disappeared into the cabin and shut the door behind him.

Ahlina tried to keep her balance as the ship swayed for a moment. Her green eyes adjusted to the darkness quickly as she walked toward the injured man. She stepped over the African, then the Persian, apologizing by habit as she took her glove off and examined the man. She felt his sweaty skin and found there was a faint pulse. She spoke Portuguese, “When was the last time you all ate?” No one responded. Then she said aloud in an ancient Chinese dialect, “Great, they don’t understand what I’m saying. For someone who’s enlightened, how the hell do you get yourself in these situations, Ahlina?”

“Who is Ahlina?” Scape said, smiling shyly up at her.

Khenebu elbowed Scape, causing his shackles to rattle.

Ahlina looked extremely shocked, knowing she was speaking a dialect no one here was supposed to understand, not even the noble captain. “How did you understand me?”

“I don’t know, but me and this guy can understand you, right, Khenebu?”

Scape nudged the slave next to him, who didn’t say a word or even look up.

“I won’t hurt you,” Ahlina said as she took her ungloved hand off the dying man.

The cabin door slammed open at that instant. “Who’s out there talkin?!” Lasher screamed.

All of the slaves cowered in fear at the loud voice that pierced the darkness. Not knowing what to do or say, they all lowered their heads as to not draw any attention to themselves.

“It was me.” Ahlina stood back up on the warped wooden plank in the middle of the ship so Lasher could see her.

“Wounded, why are you talking to the beasts?” he spat.

“I wanted to know when they ate,” Ahlina said in response to the ridiculous question. She looked back at the now very familiar faces of the black slave and the Persian slave, then whispered to herself, “Khenebu and Scape.”

“Go get them bread. There is a barrel on the deck. You may have to scoop out a couple rats, but it’s a good enough meal for them to eat. And what of that one over there?” Lasher pointed a grubby finger at the man with the faint pulse.

Ahlina looked at the man, not knowing what to say. “He’s dying.”

“Good, bring him here,” Lasher said with a sinister expression, as if he wanted the man to die terribly.

The man was twice Ahlina’s size, but with her martial arts skills, she lifted him and his heavy shackles, balancing on the beam and walked toward Lasher. The man was breathing faintly, but he was suffering from internal bleeding based on what Ahlina knew of anatomy. He was dehydrated and also whipped into a stupor. She felt sorry for the man and didn’t know how to ease his pain as she carefully walked him to the villainous Lasher.

“I’ll take it from here. You go get the rest of ‘em bread,” Lasher commanded as he grabbed the young man and threw him roughly into the dark cabin behind him. He looked at Ahlina until she started toward the stairs. The door closed, and Ahlina heard a gut-wrenching scream followed by the tearing of human flesh. No doubt it was the young man. Ahlina looked over to the Persian and the African, who somehow seemed more familiar than anyone she’d ever met, then she turned back to the stairs. She simply could not process any more of this horror.

Ahlina ran as fast as she could to the upper deck and took in a deep breath of salty sea breeze. For the first time ever, she found the fishy air refreshing and rejoiced at the fact that she was no longer in the hellish pit of this ship.

“Seems I was right, about you being a little soft on them down there,” Captain Emilian said smugly, “didn’t take long before you came runnin’ topside.” His handsome face was slightly more charismatic than those of the crew, and his style of dress was definitely more fashion-forward, but it didn’t change the eerie feeling that touched every man he spoke to.

His pirate-like speech pattern reminded Ahlina of the vile crew when she’d pretended to be a boy just to get passage to the New World. She stood up straight, but kept her head low as she spoke in her deepest voice while trying to maintain her composure and take the pity out of her tone. “I was simply ordered to get them bread, Captain.”

“Is that so? Well, off with you then.”

“Aye, Captain.” Ahlina turned on her heels, and as she did, her senses told her to dodge an attack, but it was too late. The Captain was fast, and he moved behind her so closely that she could smell the wine on his breath as he spoke into the back of her neck.

“There’s something different about you, Wounded. I could use someone like you in my entourage. Remind me to introduce you to my family when we get back to Portugal.”

Did the Captain just sniff me? Oh, no, I need to get out of here as soon as possible. Ahlina simply nodded as she took off toward the poop deck to find the bread she was supposed to pick rats from and feed to the slaves. When she turned the corner, she overheard a sailor yelling down to the Captain from the crow’s nest.

“Captain, there is a ship following us about a league East. It has been for some time now. I thought it was en route to a different destination until it started back our way, sir.”

“What kind of ship is it?” Emilian looked into the horizon. “Already less than three nautical miles away and traveling at thirty-five knots? It’s moving faster than the wind would allow.”

Ahlina gazed in awe at the Captain’s strange ability to track the movement of the ship as he whispered to himself, “Magick.”

Emilian’s realization caused him to stand at attention and call for the men to prepare for combat. “All hands on board! We have a pirate ship headed straight at us!”

Ahlina was shocked that pirates would attack slave ships, considering most had little cargo besides the captives and some fine gifts for the colonies. Usually there was nothing of much value to pirates. “But then again, those guys would sell their own mothers for profit,” Ahlina whispered as she found the barrel of bread and all of the men scrambled past her toward their stations in the front of the ship. *I have to help Scape and Khenebu get free. We have to get off this ship.* As she opened the barrel, a bright light came soaring over the sun-setting ocean sky and dropped quickly toward the ship. Ahlina wasn’t even noticing the figure hunched over in the barrel as she stared upwards to see what the light was.

A small boy’s voice said in gasping awe, “Fireball!”

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Ewm sat in the dark barrel as quiet as he could. He didn’t want to get the attention of any of the deckhands because he knew they especially didn’t like children. In the bottom of his stomach, he could feel that something was incredibly

wrong. He tried to take his mind off his situation and crack open the barrel for just enough light to read his new obsession, the old book. As soon as he opened the book, he saw Runes of Magick forming on the pages as if they had been waiting for him specifically to unlock their mysteries.

The Runes translated themselves with no command from Ewm, telling the tale of a Great War. Sky, the Mancer and Goddess of Magick, along with her husband, Aegis, the blue-eyed God of Gods, forced a coven of Wicasht to perform a dangerous spell of epic proportions. The Spell of Enlightenment, which was meant to make innocent humans into Supernaturals, almost tore the world apart in a single night, breaking Pangaea into pieces and causing blood to rain from the skies. The Coven of Unity was then forced to reverse the spell and cast another on the once peaceful humans. They cast a spell called the Veil of Ignorance on every human who would be born from that day forth so they wouldn't be able to see or comprehend Magick ever again.

This is the truth. Somehow I know this for a fact. My father never told me of anything like this, but I can feel it's the truth. Ewm flipped page after page, memorizing every Rune until he came upon a list of spells. "Wow," he whispered to himself as he watched a drawing on the page become animated, showing the effect of a spell. The flames were easy enough to conjure, as he only had to say a few words. Ewm dared not speak, remembering where he was. Yelling from outside interrupted his read as the deckhands scrambled to complete the commands of the smug nobleman, Captain Emilian.

"We are definitely under attack!" Captain Emilian said with certainty. "All hands on deck!" The attractive Captain looked for his commanding officers. He saw Yanoro tucking his tunic into his britches and wiping his face disgustedly as he walked through the doors of the slave pits and stood next to Emilian. "So she needed your 'expertise of the tongue' again, I see?" Emilian smirked.

Yanoro blushed and looked out to sea, ignoring the question and obvious slap to his ego. His shoulder-length dark brown hair blew in the wind as he realized what he was looking at. "Emilian, erm, I mean Captain Emilian, is that what I think it is, a pirate ship?!"

"That's not a normal ship, if it's even a ship at all," Emilian said aloud, more to himself than to Yanoro. His mouth opened in awe at the dark smoke that surrounded only the black ship as it sailed far too fast for these winds. There seemed to be thunder and lightning booming and striking within the dark clouds.

Thinking his level of belief couldn't have been any more disrupted, Emilian saw a large fireball catapulted into the slowly darkening sky. The only ball of fire larger was the sun itself, which seemed to be sinking into the sea to hide from the inevitable battle.

Emilian saw his men scramble back and forth, trying to decide what course of action to take. He hadn't been one for losing his cool, and today would definitely not change that. Besides, he was more afraid of what was in the bowels of the ship than he was of any pirates at sea. Emilian breathed in deeply, looked around at the panic that was striking the souls of the crew and returned his gaze to the sky before saying, "Damage control, prepare to put out the fire. It's too late to steer the ship. Get the cannons ready for return fire. Take cover!"

Ahlina saw how brave Emilian was in the face of impending doom. She also saw the face of an obvious stowaway. The child was no older than nine years of age and was staring into the sunset sky at the enormous meteor that was descending upon the ship. She heard him announce there was a fireball, so she wasn't afraid of what was behind her, but she did take a step back as she saw the boy's eyes begin to glow. His already dark-red eyes were now a true reflection of the flames in the sky. He was holding a book almost the same size as his torso, and she could have sworn she saw the pages of the book begin to flip themselves as he stood up in the barrel with the salty air blowing through his dark hair.

"Kid, this isn't a place for you," Ahlina said to the seemingly possessed little boy.

"My name is Ewm, and that's a fireball. Not just any fireball, but a Greek flame. It's meant to keep burning even after it explodes its oily flames all over this ship." He did not smile, but spoke as if he were reading a passage on the fiery globe itself.

Ahlina turned her attention upward and saw what the boy was looking at. The spinning Runes of Magick were on this weapon of destruction. She'd been almost fully enlightened before she deceived the Captain and made her way aboard the ship. Magick was a thing that she had to learn through trial and error. She had learned most of her skills from a Monk named Jonuss, who told her that in every lifetime she would have difficulty controlling her powers. He taught her a very useful form of spellcraft called Mimic Casting. All Ahlina had to do was watch a spell being cast and raise her right hand, which was bandaged for this very reason, then apply pressure to her palm or forearm. By doing this, she could repeat a spell

she'd seen in an instant. She didn't know how this was going to help her now, considering she hadn't seen the spell of the fireball being cast.

Ewm released the book, but somehow it floated in front of his small frame. The pages stopped at a spell called 'Greek Meteor' where a picture of a flaming orb began to form, similar to the one in the sky. The Runes of Magick on the page manifested themselves in reality, and Ewm started to speak the words, "Miscreo Ignemitus." His hands lit up like the sun, and a blinding light shot forth from his left palm toward the sky in the direction of the fireball. A searing heat blasted into the air and was gone as fast as it had been conjured.

Ahlina watched in amazement while this small boy cast one of the most powerful spells she'd ever seen. Her palm began to light up as Runes of Magick began to spin violently up her fingertips, wrist and forearm, then back down again. From underneath her bandages, the Runes kept repeating a shivering vibration and light show that she could see clearly. Ahlina looked at her glowing arm, and then at the boy who looked like he was going to pass out from exhaustion. She turned her focus toward the sky and saw what looked like two suns about to collide. The fireball from the boy was a crimson hue that seemed to make the ocean glow like boiling blood. It was larger than the one coming from the dark ship, which was a blinding yellow.

Without losing any momentum, Ewm's red fireball smashed into the yellow flames and engulfed them with explosive force that rocked the sea underneath, along with both ships. Ahlina was in awe as their lives were saved, but she quickly felt the burning Runes from underneath her bandages as they seared through the cloth and outward around her palm and forearm. Scared to cause unanticipated effects, Ahlina pointed her palm out at sea toward the other ship. Without saying the words Ewm had recited, Ahlina just wanted the burning to stop and thought about the red fireball that was still in the sky, making its way toward the black ship. In that thought, a large pink ball of flames ignited the very air, and instead of flying in a catapulted volley, shot in a straight line across the water toward the black ship at blinding speed. Ahlina fell backwards into the barrel with Ewm.

The barrel tipped over, but not before both Ewm and Ahlina watched as two huge explosions nearly destroyed the ship across the water from them. The resulting force rocked the Relíquia almost completely sideways. Ahlina instinctively turned her back to the blast and wrapped her arms around the boy. She could feel his shallow breathing on her collarbone, but the heat did no damage to

her back. She sat up while the ship was trying to rebalance itself on the chaotic waters, her arms still wrapped around the boy.

“Boy, are you alright?” she said, still not looking at him, but rather staring at the flaming ship. The clouds looming on the horizon seemed to appear angry, growing with terrifying speed.

“It’s Ewm, pronounced ‘Oh mm,’ and I’m fine.” He noticed the fading Runes on Ahlina’s forearm and reached to touch them.

With martial arts reflexes, Ahlina parried Ewm’s hand and pulled her aching wrist away from him. “Don’t touch me.” She breathed heavily, staring at her flesh as it slowly lost the pink glowing Runes of Magick. She then looked back at the boy and said, “Either you’re Witchbreed or Broken, but either way, you’re really lucky we pulled that off?!”

Ewm sat up and said, “Wicasht, and I only recently found that out through reading this book.” He gripped the large leather bound book with a large eye on the cover with extreme intensity as if to never let it go. He gripped the large leather-bound book with extreme intensity as if to never let it go, its blue eye shining in the sunlight. “They aren’t finished fighting, and I believe I’m the one they’re looking for.”

Of course you are, Ahlina thought to herself. I can’t even get across the damned ocean without some Supernatural hook up along the way. This is starting to piss me off. I know Jonuss would tell me to go retrieve the slaves who are definitely Supernaturals. It’s the only way we could’ve understood each other. Ok, next plan of action is to try to hide the kid while rescuing the slaves below. Yeah, not even close to being easy. My dumb-ass luck. Ouch, that ship is in bad shape. Whatever it is, it doesn’t look like it’s going to stop chasing this boy. The clouds around it are starting to light up and crackle with every thunder clap. How am I going to get all of them into a life raft and off the ship? I don’t know, but I’ll start by hiding the boy.

“Ewm, can you stand?” Ahlina said calmly.

“Yes. I think so,” Ewm said, now whining like a small child in contrast to the assertive tone he took when casting his Magick. His eyes even changed back to a red that was softer than the glowing dark blood color they once were.

“Good. You’re going to have to hide, okay?” Ahlina looked around at the other barrels that must have exploded in the pandemonium. “Try to find

somewhere close to here so I can find you when I come back.” She pointed at the door to the crew’s food storage room.

Hopping gracefully to her feet, Ahlina walked over to the door. She didn’t want to touch the door with her right hand, so she reached down with her left, which was still gloved. The door easily opened, and inside was a dark room that was small compared to any of the other rooms on the ship. It was covered in debris and shattered glass from crates, barrels and jars that had tipped over and broken. The smell of pickles and something sweet filled her nostrils. The gunk on the floor was sticky, but at least there were burlap sacks Ewm could hide behind while she proceeded on her suicide mission to save strangers.

Ewm ran over to the corner with no instruction needed. He clung to his book, and before she knew it, he had disappeared into the shadows.

“I’ll be back, kid.” Ahlina fixed her hat and closed the door behind her, but when she turned around, Narles the Snitch was standing in front of her.

“Why are you coming from the food pantry at a time like this, Wounded?” Narles’ suspicious tone seemed to hiss at her.

“I’m following the Captain’s orders to feed the slaves! Do you want to take it up with Captain Emilian or should I tell him you had something more important for me to do?” Ahlina watched as the deviant’s expression jumped from curiosity to fear in an instant. Apparently this large rat was no different than the slaves he was helping to transport and was trained to be subservient. He said nothing in reply. “I didn’t think so,” she continued, pointing to the food pantry door, “I was in there; I heard a loud explosion, and the ship rocked sideways, so everything is broken.” Ahlina was proud of herself for thinking on her feet. She had always been quick-witted, but this was the first time she had used her wits to save someone else’s life. “Don’t you have something better to do than question my orders from the Captain?”

Narles would have been a ruggedly handsome brunette if it weren’t for his terrible hygiene and black-toothed smile. He sneered at Ahlina, but the story made sense, so he scrambled past her without further inquiry and took off running toward the crew’s nest where the Captain asked him to retrieve a report. He was suspicious of almost everyone, but Wounded seemed to bring about a sort of paranoia.

Trying to catch her breath as soon as Narles was out of sight, Ahlina ran toward the slave quarters entrance. She saw the other crew members running

around in a panic, but all glad to be alive. Emilian was screaming at everyone to put their backs into their work, for the mysterious ship was still in pursuit. The sun sank into the ocean, and almost just as soon as the light left the sky, the door to the quarters flung open in front of Ahlina.

She took a few steps backward at the sight of a woman in beautifully crafted boots, their metal tips embroidered with mysterious symbols like nothing Ahlina had ever seen before. The woman's hair was a dark brown, and her lips were painted dark plum to match her expensive jacket and britches. She did not seem to be affected by the rocking of the ship or the slippery surface as she walked with an unnaturally graceful stride towards Emilian and Yanoro. Ahlina knew this was a Supernatural, yet sensed nothing but death on the noble lady. The specter of a woman looked back to the door of the slave quarters with an air of suspicion, but she was too late; Ahlina was already below deck. She could still hear Emilian discussing the state of affairs with the mysterious woman amidst the cracking of thunder and lightning. She continued to walk down the slimy steps, a funky smell making her cringe as she entered the filthy purgatory of the ship to find Scape and Khenebu.

She saw both handsome men still chained next to each other. Scape was trying to get his balance as he fell over onto Khenebu. They both spotted Ahlina at the same time, smiling as if she were an old friend. Ahlina felt the same nostalgia the closer she got to them but couldn't place her finger on the why of it. She knew that Supernaturals were attracted to each other according to Jonuss. Sometimes that was a good thing, but in Ahlina's case it had created mostly bad experiences. Even now she was questioning why she was risking her life to save these two. She decided to trust her instincts and went over to them quickly.

"I have to help you both get out of here," Ahlina said, trying to figure out how to free them from the shackles that were as thick as her ankles.

"Why did you come back?" Scape asked, surprised to see her.

"I heard explosions," Khenebu said before Ahlina could answer the question.

Ahlina looked truly perplexed and answered Scape, "Because I don't believe it was your destiny to reach those shores." She smiled at him while trying to break the shackles with a shattering downward punch from her left hand.

"I don't think you're strong enough to break them. We've tried for days now," Khenebu said as the hope began to leave his eyes. He realized Ahlina didn't

have the key and had come down here unprepared. Then he gasped as he saw her reach back with her right hand. She brought the hand down as gentle as a feather and watched, the metal crumbling as if it were made of sand. *How?* he asked subconsciously.

She answered aloud, “One down, and one more to go.”

Scape’s legs were finally free, but he couldn’t believe it. He felt the bloody bruises on his ankles. He saw Khenebu was yet to be free, but he trusted the girl to break the shackles after her display of martial arts, which had amazed them both. The other slaves were huddled in corners, dead or passed out from when the ship rocked. Scape turned his attention back to Ahlina, and as she was trying to free Khenebu, he saw standing behind her the villain who had held them under the ship for so many days, beating some into submission and others to death, the Overseer, Lasher. Khenebu looked up, horrified as Lasher twirled his barbed whip behind Ahlina, but he couldn’t warn her in time, a crack piercing the air before she was struck across the back.

Ahlina screamed as the initial shock from the whip made her eyes glaze over. The hat she’d been wearing flew off into the darkness as her hands landed on the bottom of the ship. Ahlina was a trained martial artist, and she cursed herself for not paying attention to her surroundings. She didn’t know where the pain came from until her senses returned and the stinging in her back reminded her of training she’d done with the monk Jonuss in the ice-cold mountains of China. Her green eyes squinted through the tears and the pain as she heard the villain talk behind her.

“So you have a soft spot for these slaves, huh? Well I think it’s about time I showed you what I think of sympathizers!” Lasher snarled at Ahlina as he kicked an innocent slave in the face on the way to her. “You don’t like that pain do you, Wounded?” Lasher let out a disgusting cackle that sounded more like a wheezing cough than a laugh as he kicked Ahlina in the ribs, sending her flying into one of the wooden beams. “You wretches need to see what I do to anybody disobeying my word down here in the ship!”

Ahlina slammed against the wooden beam and slid to the grimy floor. She caught herself as all of her senses returned. “Touch me, or any of them again, and you’ll die here in your world of filth.”

Laughing so hard he almost seemed to be having a seizure, Lasher twirled his whip and struck Khenebu in the chest. “Is that what you wanted to see? One of

them bleed? You're next, little boy," Lasher spat at Ahlina as if he were talking to a punk teenager he was going to teach a valuable lesson to. Before he could twirl his whip again, he heard a loud boom from outside and screams from top deck. "What in the hell?"

Ahlina slapped her palm on the floor, using the momentum and force to spin herself up to her feet. She stood in a fighting stance that only few had ever seen before. Her hair in the front was slightly longer than that in the back and hid her vengeful eyes in the dark. Though her limbs looked delicate, she'd been able to withstand tremendous beatings in her training. She used her hatred for this man to focus on what she knew she was going to do. She was going to kill him.

Lasher spun surprisingly fast in her direction and lashed his whip multiple times in her direction as she dodged his attacks untouched, leaving him to strike at the air as if he were fighting his own shadow. He had drunk some of the Shandor's blood, which made him stronger and faster like they were. His mind was so clear after drinking their liquid curse that he didn't crave food, nor was he distracted easily. He ignored the sounds of the fierce battle above his head, focusing his attention on this boy he was fighting, who was actually faster than he was somehow. Lasher continued to swing his barbed instrument of death until one of the slaves stood up and got in the way.

Scape looked like most of the other Persians with his striking features, dark hair and exotic eyes that looked as if he were wearing eyeliner when he wasn't. His muscles were tempered in the desert, as he was a blade dancer who had a horrible knack for gambling. The very game that got him enslaved was the one he had promised his lover he'd never play again. For breaking this promise, he felt this was his fate. Since he had nothing else to live for, he had to help the girl who had risked her life to save his sorry one. He sweep-kicked Lasher, sending him crashing to the slippery wooden floor and adding more grime to his already disgusting tunic as his back boomed against the hard surface.

Lasher was about to punish the Persian for interfering when his whip was suddenly intercepted by a delicate forearm. Far too delicate to be a boy's was the hand that grabbed the barbed whip with such power that Lasher couldn't regain control.

He tried to pull with all of his strength, only to be yanked toward Ahlina. She brought him up to his knees so he could get a good look at her face.

“You piece of shit. You won’t inflict any more pain on anyone else. You’ll be dealing with your own soon enough.” Ahlina wrapped the whip around Lasher’s neck and slung it over the beam above her. She snapped his kneecaps with one swift motion as she lifted him by his neck with the whip. She saw the keys on his belt and left him there hanging as he desperately gasped for air, unable to hold himself up with broken knees. “I’ll take these.” Ahlina took the keys and threw them over to Khenebu.

Scape helped unlock Khenebu’s shackles while the ship rocked back and forth again. Finally his new friend was free. They both stood up and turned to see Ahlina staring into the eyes of the one person everyone in the pit of this ship had wished dead at one point or another. Scape walked behind her and slowly placed his hands on her back. “Please don’t do this. He’s not worth it,” Scape said, looking into the same eyes that had savagely watched the suffering of the slaves on this trip, and countless ones before.

Ahlina pulled her hair out of her face so that Lasher could get a good look. “A woman gave you mercy.” Once she saw the look of shock on his ugly visage, she side-kicked him, breaking a rib or two and sending him flying into the shadows.

Khenebu was unlocking another slave’s shackles when the ship rocked so hard the keys flew from his hands and slid under a woman’s feet. The woman snatched up the keys, attempting to free herself and those around her. Then the door exploded with a dramatic force from top deck as Ahlina said, “We don’t have time. Let’s go.”

Scape and Khenebu dashed up the stairs behind Ahlina, noticing her delicate features for the first time now that her hat and gloves were removed. They wondered who she was exactly, but like her, felt a trust and nostalgia that they could not shake. Once they reached the top of the stairs, they saw burnt bodies on the deck and a moon that shined almost as brightly as the fire that was quickly engulfing the ship.

Ahlina was shocked by all of the dead bodies and the damage that had been done, but it didn’t stop her from pursuing her goal, which was to find the boy and get off the ship. “This relic is going to see the bottom of the ocean,” she said while making her way to the storage pantry.

When Ahlina opened the door to the pantry, she called for Ewm. “Come out, boy. Let’s go.” She took a step into the room and called for him again, but no

answer came. "It's ok. Everything is going to be alright now. Come out, Ewm." Ahlina started to take another step forward when a kick came so fast she didn't see it coming until it connected with her chest and sent her flying through the door and onto the top deck, the unrelenting force finally letting up after her body crashed against a wooden barrel.

A silky and seductively evil voice was beckoning from the pantry. "It would seem you are the ruin of my ship. How appropriate. Stowaways bringing doom and gloom upon us." She spoke with a predatory ease that brought chills to Scape's spine. "How rude of me, I'm Sasha of the Shandor, General to Chass and Executioner for Prince Lord Ka. I'm also the owner of this wretched barge. Though it seems unnecessary to formally introduce myself to people who are going to be dead within moments, I feel it's etiquette." In one hand she held Ewm, who clung to his book like his life depended on it.

Scape knew there was someone or something that Lasher kept feeding the slaves to. He had no idea it would be a noblewoman who looked like the tales of the Vampyl he'd heard around campfires. "Vampyl." He said one word that caused the woman to tilt her head slightly.

"So you know of my kind?" Sasha said, circling Scape faster than the speed of darkness before throwing the boy to the ground and placing a silver-heeled boot on his back as if he were a rodent and she a great cat playing with a toy. "Do tell what you know of us Vampyl," Sasha hissed.

"I know that you are undead. You also drink the blood of the living to stay beautiful," Scape said defiantly at the abomination in front of him.

"That's right, and I'm going to enjoy plucking every vein from your body for my blush, but go on," Sasha said. "I'm running out of patience and time before those damned Witchbreed break my spell and follow us into these treacherous waters. So, again I ask, go on!"

Scape didn't know much more, but based on what she just said, knew they could use Magick. "Please leave the boy alone. I don't know anymore."

"I do," Khenebu said, stepping next to Scape. He noticed the look on Sasha's face as he stepped toward her. It went from confident to downright fearful as she lost the ability to move. "I know that I can see, hear, speak to and control the dead." He took another step closer. "I know that Scape here is right. You are dead.

That means you'll be paralyzed until I say so. I can see why these people are scrambling in fear every waking second of being on this ship." Khenebu was now so close that she could feel the warmth of his breath on her cheek as he spoke.

Sasha's dark brown hair was frozen almost as stiff as her bones. Suddenly lacking control of her body, she was in a state of utter horror knowing that Witchbreed had been on her ship the entire time, and she hadn't known. As the African with the neatly-twisted dreadlocks turned out to be a necromantic Witchbreed, she screamed inside, but no sound came out of her mouth. She'd fought Witchbreed monks just a few minutes prior to this, losing most of her crew and almost losing her life until she escaped, using her Blood Magick to shift reality in elaborate illusions. After evading the Witchbreed monks from that dark ship, she felt like she had something to brag about to her master, Chass. Now she realized this Witchbreed could destroy her any moment. Again she wanted to scream, but couldn't do anything.

"You're probably finding it hard to speak," Khenebu said calmly. "I will grant you the ability to speak in a moment. When I do, you tell your men to let us go. Am I clear?"

Sasha hadn't felt this helpless in her entire existence as an immortal. The only beings who could scare her like this were Chass and Prince Lord Ka, if she would ever meet him. She was finally able to speak again. Letting out a small shriek as if she were testing out her vocal chords, she formulated the words, "Emilian and Yanoro, you will let them all go."

Ahlina stood up and stretched until she heard a crack of relief in her neck. She was astounded that this was all happening and actually hadn't even seen a Vampyl in person before today. She walked over to Sasha and stood very close to what looked like a beautiful doll or a hauntingly real statue. Her pale skin was cold and smooth. Sasha's lips were full and stained with what could easily be blood. The more Ahlina looked at the undead creature, the more she felt a combination of fear and pity. She gazed into the red eyes of the Vampyl assassin, searching for remnants of the Soulstream, but could find none. "Her soul is in the Soulstream. This is just an imposter. The blood that reanimated this corpse is tainted by a powerful Dehmn, or what humans call demons."

Scape walked over to Sasha but kept a safe distance. "You're right, Ahlina. Her soul is gone. The Runes of Magick written on her tell me she's about to use Shadow Magick and Blood Magick, accelerating her agility while also creating

reality-bending illusions. Until now I didn't believe these things existed, but I suppose if Witchbreed exist, so do they." Scape looked back at Khenebu, "Do you mind?"

Khenebu almost laughed at how easily he was able to control Sasha. "I've only encountered a couple of your kind, but unfortunately, they did not survive." He moved his hand like a puppeteer, and Sasha's foot lifted off Ewm.

"Thank you," Scape said as he helped Ewm to his feet while carefully watching Sasha. She stood in an awkward position with her knee locked at a ninety degree angle in front of her. "Where are the boats to get off this ship?" Scape looked at Khenebu as if asking him to let her speak.

Khenebu made a gesture with his lips, and she copied it identically. "I'll kill you all for this--" Sasha's sentence was interrupted as her mouth snapped shut.

"No, I don't think you'll be killing any of us today," Khenebu corrected her, smiling. "Now, please be a noblewoman and answer this gentleman's question. It's only etiquette."

"I know where they are," Ahlina said quickly. "Let's just get out of here." Ahlina sidestepped Sasha and passed through the shattered door of the pantry. She grabbed a few sacks of food that seemed too heavy for one of the deckhands to carry, but she lifted them with ease. "This way." Ahlina gestured to her friends to follow her as she walked out to see Emilian and Yanoro glaring at her while Narles looked like a rabid beast waiting to lay his life on the line for the chance to kill her.

Ahlina went to the rowboats and told everyone to jump in as she filled them with sacks of food. Once the four of them boarded the small boat, Ahlina realized that she knew all of them from another lifetime. Khenebu, Scape and Ewm were part of her Coven of Unity. She'd only had dreams up until this moment, but now it was so clear that it frightened her. "Coven of Unity," Ahlina said the words with clarity and peace. As soon as she spoke the words, the three males were instantly focused on their memories, which they were remembering at an alarming rate. Images were flooding back to them so rapidly that it seemed as if they were in a trance, and Khenebu lost his control over Sasha just as fast. He could see Pangaea and the Goddess Sky making the decision to change the humans on the planet into immortals. He saw the war break out as well as his contribution to casting and reversing the spell which put the world in its current state. As he sat in the boat in a trance, regaining his memories, the deckhands were now in a commotion.

Sasha leered over the edge of the ship with hatred only the darkest tales could conjure. She did not order them to attack the small boat, but Narles took it upon himself to shoot a harpoon at them.

“You’ll die today, he growled. “You won’t get away from my master, Captain Emilian!” Narles shot the harpoon through the night sky with a whaler’s accuracy.

Ahlina saw the harpoon coming toward the slowly drifting boat, about to make impact, when she deflected it with a palm strike, sending the large spear out to sea. She turned to the ship with a wicked glare.

Sasha saw the glare with her heightened Vampyl senses. Upset that Narles would make a move without her command, she ran up behind him so fast that he didn’t see her. She grabbed the back of his head and ripped into his jugular with long fangs as sharp as diamonds. The crew watched fearfully as blood sprayed, painting the deck of the ship and their faces as she held him up with one hand before tossing his body overboard, too disgusted to feed on an insubordinate peasant. After watching him splash unceremoniously in the Atlantic ocean, she looked up at the sky and let out a shrill scream that made her entire crew drop to their knees. Some of them fainted.

Scape woke from his trance with the same memories the others shared, of past lives where he was a powerful Witchbreed. He placed his hand over the side of the boat, and before Ahlina could give him the oar, he whispered to the waves, “Spirits of the water, guide us to land.” He lifted his wet hands upward, and the boat moved swiftly into the darkness until it crashed upon the shores of North America.

(San Francisco: Present Day)

“So that’s who the new guy really is!” Ahlina said to Scape as they watched Khenebu walk smoothly down the hallway. Ahlina pulled out a cigarette and struck her Zippo lighter.

Scape didn't even look at her as he grabbed the cigarette and smashed it under his boot heel. He continued to stare at Khenebu. *So we met on a slave ship in another past life, and now we meet again.*

FIGURE IT OUT

Jayde sat up from her meditation. Her piercing green eyes opened slowly as she absorbed the surroundings of the ancient city she once called home. She wasn't a sentimental person by any means, but the feeling of nostalgia could prove her wrong. If anything, she had never wanted to return to the Forbidden City, Zalomoni, but according to her mentor, Gemini, this was the only option.

The walls are as cold as the bones that are now dust in the very valleys that make up this forgotten place. I personally trained so many of our kind to fight as proud warriors, priestesses and monks for what they believed in, and look where that got them. I'm not one for second-guessing myself, but this was one of my greatest failures. Gemini would disagree and say it was meant to be, but I can't see how watching Spiraar devour thousands of Supernaturals, nobles and warriors I'd grown to love has any relevance to the current situation. I'm sure Gemini would say something like, 'Jayde, in the big picture, if it weren't for their great sacrifice, the Coven of Unity would not be united, nor would the Mancers kingdoms of human lore have ever existed.' Jayde sat up with a frustrated expression, and in her clarity said aloud, "He'd be right too."

Though this is a grove of extreme power and secrecy, I told him it's the last place on Earth I'd actually want to be. He knows this place makes me feel uncomfortable, and I can feel Kirari stirring restlessly in my chest, awaiting the chance to burst forth and sleep within the temple once again. I need to take my mind off this subject and find the Mancers that will turn the tables on the extinction of our kind and the Magick that must be preserved. Let me sense where they are. Breathing deeply, I should be able to feel the Ki that makes up the few living beings in this dead city. Of course, they are about to start mayhem in the Blacksmith's temple.

Jayde stretched her firm muscles and stalked out of the prayer circle within the dusty temple that had not seen life since before the Ice Age. Before leaving the once immaculate hall, she turned and bowed in respect. Her long black hair almost touched the floor in her deep bow, and she lifted her head in remembrance of the souls that used to clean this very place daily. A tear nearly fell from her eye before she caught it and looked at it, its transparent sheen alien-like on her finger tip. She

smiled for the first time in a long while and dropped the tear on the ground as if it were dew on a fresh blade of grass in the morning. Leaving the tear and the hall, she now had the conviction she needed to continue her mission and prevent her people's lives and deaths from being in vain.

*

Blue walked into the dark hall as if to guard Surge-Overload from any impending doom. Though he didn't know exactly how he was going to protect her, he decided that the best choice would be to walk in front of her.

Surge was so excited about finding this secret passageway into a dark cavern with Blue, that she failed to analyze the kind of danger she may have truly been in. She looked at the walls and the wonderful hieroglyphics. "Wow, look at the star charts! I bet Maia would totally get a kick out of this. And o-m-g, look at the paintings, Blue! This place was some sort of blacksmithing forge. I thought you were going to lead me to technology?"

"Shhh." Blue tried to quiet the ranting teenager. "Did you hear that? It sounds like something is in here with us."

"You're just saying that to scare me," Surge said, half-hoping Blue was joking for once. After realizing he was serious, she hushed and listened for the sound that alarmed her handsome body guard. "This isn't funny, Blue." Blue gave Surge a grave look that silenced her. He focused on the dark halls that seemed to be only dimly lit where there were Runes of Magick. The blue aura they cast on the cave walls allowed them to be read, though few were actually understood. The silence was both comforting and slightly creepy. Blue knew they were being watched. He acted as if he weren't paying attention to the stalker that must have been lurking in the shadows above them.

Both Mancers walked slowly as Blue tested booby traps throughout the cave. He sustained injuries from sharp arrows and crushing stones that retreated back into the walls. Surge was both afraid to move without Blue and intrigued as she read the Runes on the walls, confirming his suspicion that this place led to a Temple of not just forging, but technology.

Surge couldn't believe how much pain Blue could withstand. She thought he was going to die every time he triggered another trap. If she could make an educated guess, she would swear he was triggering them on purpose to protect her. Surge tried to tell him that each one was a puzzle, but Blue, too busy looking into the shadows, absentmindedly triggered yet another well-devised death sentence for any mortal. Each trap he walked through was one more demonstration of his immortality.

The Runes became increasingly mesmerizing as they told a tale of the Forbidden City of Zalomoni. There were thousands of Supernaturals that once lived here. The center of their civilization and culture was a dragon named Kirari that slept within the largest temple in the city. A blacksmithing Mancer by the name of Nadir had lived in this specific temple like a hermit. He didn't particularly like visitors, so he had designed creatures known as Golems to watch over his sacred space.

"Blue, this is some really cool stuff," Surge said as she read the Runes, not paying attention to where she was stepping. A stone was pressed delicately by her small combat boots, and before she could react, a long spear shot from the walls toward her head. Surge didn't even have time to scream before Blue dashed from his location in the large hall, grabbing her protectively as he ran as fast as he could deeper within the cave. When Blue slowed down, Surge looked back to where she had been standing to see hundreds of metal spears crossed over each other as if creating a deadly design. Upon further inspection, she noticed they formed the elaborate shape of an eye.

Blue asked Surge if she was ok. She caught her breath and said, "Thanks to you, I am." She looked intently at the spears and pointed at them as they slowly started to retreat back into the wall. "What is that?" Surge hugged Blue as she noticed the body of a creature impaled by the booby trap.

Blue followed Surge's gaze to the bloody mass. With its iron embrace, the eye that was once formed by the spears now held its prey, which looked like some kind of beast.

Unrecognizable as the thing was to Blue from this distance, he was quite sure it was what had been following them in the shadows. "That's our stalker! I knew we weren't alone here. I wonder if Jayde and Gemini know about this?"

"I'm sure if they don't, they'll figure it out soon enough. What is that thing? Looks like some anthropomorphic creature with human and beastlike features from

a fairytale, only way more scary ‘cause it’s huge!” Surge said, horrified, as the spears slowly slid out of the creature and back into the wall. It let out a loud screeching howl that echoed throughout the darkness as the final spear left its body. Surge jumped yet again, hugging Blue’s hips as he stood in front of her instinctively.

The creature began writhing in pain on the ground, and after a few spasms, stopped moving until it began to shapeshift right in front of them, becoming a large, lifeless insect. The blood on the ground pooled around the shrinking carcass like a pond with a dead fish floating belly-up, the prey remaining still in the center.

“It’s dead now, that’s for sure.” Blue said, slowly petting Surge’s back to calm her. “See, you triggering the booby trap accomplished my goal. Flush out the stalker.”

“I knew it! You were purposely setting off those traps.”

“Of course I was. I could easily dodge them, but I wondered if they would expose themselves,” Blue said, proud of himself, placing his hands over the wounds that had healed minutes ago, but were still sore as if someone had punched him.

“You’re stupid,” Surge said as if she couldn’t believe Blue would put his own life in danger to save hers. “And I didn’t mean to almost get impaled by hundreds of spikes, thank you very much.” She released his chiseled waist and took a step back. “What I really mean to say is, thank you.” She smiled up at him with her eyes closed.

Blue half-smiled back as he began to scan the room behind Surge, but before he could answer, he said “What in the F?”

Surge quickly turned her attention to what Blue was looking at. “I know I say this a lot, but O-M-G!” Surge gasped. “Looks like we found the machines the Runes were talking about, and they’re nothing like anything I’ve ever seen before!”

Blue and Surge stood still as they inspected the room full of large Golems staring coldly back at them. The stone and metal monoliths looked as if they hadn’t moved in centuries, but were definitely instruments of war and destruction as the Runes of Magick on their shells clearly stated. They were two-legged tanks with hulking arms and Runes of Magick written all over them. Surge recognized them immediately as the constructs Nadir had written about on the walls. “It never said

Nadir completed them though, or maybe I didn't get that far before you picked me up."

"Whatever you do, don't move," Blue said to the now-fascinated Surge quietly, as if the Golems would be triggered to kill them by sound.

Surge didn't move a muscle as she translated a word from one of the Runes aloud: "Femtotechnology."

*

(OZONE Base, Colorado Springs, CO: Present Day)

"Someone get me a report of Surge-Overload's damage right now!" Deme screamed at the Receptionists without discrimination. "I want to know what that little bitch did to our mainframes and intranet! I want to know all the lost files that were compromised and the data that was corrupted!" Deme didn't stop looking at the monitor as he barked his orders.

He had been getting chewed out since the death of the most powerful hacker the world had ever known, Surge-Overload. He thought that a recon mission to kill the threat would get him kudos, and yes, he received congratulations from his Commander and Chief, but in the same breath he got a mouthful of slander due to the damage that was already assessed. Deme hadn't failed at anything in his short but decorated career as an OZONE elite, and he didn't plan on making a habit of being ridiculed.

When the files reported an anonymous girl was responsible for the most notorious quantum slider hacks of all time, outsmarting even Deme's most intelligent Technomages, Deme almost lost his sanity from disbelief at what he was hearing. Of course the only person who got a good look at the girl and was still alive happened to be the most epic fail Agent, Narles.

"Do we have any progress on Narles' condition?" Deme stopped looking at his laser monitor with an obvious expression of annoyance. Before he could speak again, a neatly cut brunette Technomage by the name of Shadow Harvester announced, "Surge-Overload has stolen and deleted over three thousand files. They

include twelve Braintech files on the Nanotechnology of the Zenith Program, a top secret project meant to increase agent performance, which was supposed to—”

“Was supposed to turn even the weakest Soldier into an elite Supernatural hunter like Guardian,” Deme retorted, “Each Nano, theoretically, was a supercomputer with terabytes of information essentially replacing any and all cells. Granting our forces hyper-regeneration, cellular repair, weather resistance, and contagion immunity was the next step in OZONE evolution and new world order. That was the greatest invention Braintech had produced since its inception.”

Shadow Harvester’s gaze sunk to the floor in embarrassment. She frantically pulled up the field agents’ reports, knowing she needed to find some way to deliver good news. “Surge-Overload is dead, sir. Agent TJ identified a child’s remains at the site and verified that they were supernatural.”

“You’re confirming the elimination of a high-priority target without a full DNA scan and a coroner’s report?” Deme asked.

Shadow Harvester’s head sunk lower than ever.

“I didn’t think so,” he said, “now get back to your desk before you insult my intelligence a third time and end up like Narles, or better yet, like one of Agent Zeer’s sex puppets. Which sounds more amusing to you?”

The mortified agent had already returned to her desk before she could reply.

Deme stared at the screen before him as if trying to crush it with pure willpower. *There is no way to reproduce that nanotechnology without the specs and none of us can figure it out in this lifetime without the blue prints. At least the secrets died with her...hopefully.*

“God damn you, Surge-Overload!” Deme slammed his hands on the desk and looked down at his balled fists, knowing in some way or other he’d be blamed for the loss of such delicate intel. His young face twisted into a hateful grimace as he spoke again. “Give me the full damage report! And tell me when Narles is awake!”

Chapter 21

OLD ENEMIES

“It has come to our attention that an old foe has arisen.” The booming voice demanded attention from the coterie of allies gathered in a dark hall within the French catacombs, their ethereal forms seated around a sacred blood circle after traveling through the spirit realm, Oneira. “I, Prince Lord Ka will do anything in my power to assure you they will fall once more.”

A regal-looking female Witchbreed stood up to address the congregation. “With all due respect, Ka, your Vampyl can’t be sure it was Aegis they saw. I mean seriously—”

“With all due respect, Ophiuchus, the blood running through the corpse of one of my Generals was not human nor Witchbreed, it was the rarest of Supernaturals, Mancer!” Ka hissed at the Witchbreed heretic who dared challenge his words. He knew she was powerful, but he had an army of darkness that was all his own, and she’d be in for a hell of a fight if she mocked him again. “My General, Chass, reported who and what he saw. Not only was Aegis alive and well, but so was Isis.”

“Call me Ophi,” the blonde said nicely, with as much demand as the commanding voice of the Vampyl lord. “I have consorted with my coven, and we have not heard any news of this.”

“As much as I hate to agree with Prince Lord Ka, he’s right.” Nef appeared to be the youngest in the company, yet he was the oldest immortal in the room. “I was graced with the presence of one of our old friends, Gemini.” He smiled as if remembering their conversation. “He has no clue that we are indeed the ones who have created OZONE. Ophiuchus, he doesn’t even know you are still on this plane of existence, let alone alive. Zenith, he doesn’t know that you faked your death in Zalomoni. Osiris is still nowhere to be found, but his cults, ruled by Prince Lord Ka, have been tormenting humanity for the greater part of five thousand years. I, Neflym, am the only one he remotely knows about besides the one he killed, Enoch, my fellow brother of the First Immortals.” Nef stopped speaking, understanding that he was delivering information that the members of his coterie already knew.

“So we haven’t met in centuries, and all of a sudden I have been awakened to sit in a room full of Immortals who are so full of themselves, they let these Mancers slip right through their fingers,” Ophi said impatiently. Her blonde hair fell down to her waist in a cascade of gold around the mask she was wearing to hide her face. The vermillion mask was one of many she was known to wear, each of which had a serpent fashioned into its design in one way or another. She was looking at her allies who were more like liabilities than equals.

Prince Lord Ka was growing weary of these old wind bags. They were arguably the most powerful alliance in the world, and yet they could barely agree on the sky being blue, let alone what to do with the Immortal enemies that had recently been reborn and would inevitably challenge their power as per their birthright. “My legion did not let them *slip* through their hands. They were spared by the Mancers.”

“I do not doubt this is what happened, Prince Lord Ka,” Neflym said respectfully. “What we do next will decide the fate of OZONE.”

“Kill them!” Prince Lord Ka said abruptly.

“I second that motion.” Ophi raised her milky hand from under her elaborate robes embroidered with diamonds and sapphires.

For the first time since the formal introduction, Zenith spoke. She was a dark-skinned woman with hair that could be mistaken for a void in the time-space continuum. Her voice was quiet, and she always refused to repeat herself. Her white lips were a direct contrast to the rest of her dark physique and ominous essence, but forced all to pay attention to their movement. “I think it is a mistake to kill them now.”

Neflym could not hide his smile as he spoke. “I have thought long nights about this, and I agree with Zenith, we should wait for the right moment. Since Enoch is dead, and we are awaiting his replacement, it would seem we have a stalemate.”

“So I am not allowed to kill the Mancers?” Prince Lord Ka asked, unamused.

“That is correct,” Nef said.

“What about the Coven of Unity?” The dark lord’s rebuttal was that of someone who was withholding information.

“What do you mean?” Ophi turned her attention to Ka. “Speak, vampire. And I thought we were to refrain from using the name of that insolent coven in my presence?”

“My humblest apologies, Ophiuchus,” Ka said unapologetically. “It has also been brought to my attention that the Coven of Unity has been reborn.”

“Lies!” Ophi cried, stirring restlessly on her throne. To the onlookers it was the simple hatred she had for this coven that caused her outburst. Ophi however knew what this meant. *The Coven of Unity and the Mancers equal the end of OZONE, if properly directed. If Neflym is correct, then Gemini is playing a dangerous game of Chess.*

“If this is true, then we are in danger. All of us.”

Zenith spoke once more, “We must not allow the Witchbreed to return, for they will be the downfall of OZONE, as they were the downfall of Olympus.”

“Spoken like the wise woman you are, Zenith,” Neflym added. “Where is this proof, Prince Lord Ka?” Neflym smiled curiously at the Vampyl prince, awaiting his answer.

“This is the proof.” Prince Lord Ka raised his hand, palm facing the sky as a purple light began to swirl in the air above. This powerful sorcerer was ancient by all means of the word and had strong reality-shifting powers that made him formidable. He was currently using his powers of scrying to show the coterie what he wanted them to see. “This is a dungeon in one of my castles.” The dark light burst forth and surrounded the company, projecting the live image of a beautiful girl pacing about a dungeon cell. Her hair, as violet as the flowers on a spring day, danced around her, as if every follicle were alive. She was singing an enchanting song that caused small glowing flowers to bloom in this dark place where no life could exist for long, though they seemed to thrive in her presence and illuminate the torture chamber in which she was being held captive.

“Heaven!” Ophi shrieked. “How are your Vampyl coming across so many of these villains?”

“One could say luck,” Ka smiled without looking at the masked witch.

“Luck, bah! A fairytale we sold to humans,” Ophi hissed. “You will tell us soon enough. In the meantime, we need to kill her. Now!”

“If the Coven of Unity and the Mancers are reborn, then this can also turn out to be a perfect opportunity to turn them against Gemini and get them to work for us,” Neflym said. “Currently, most of our agents think these kids are dead. I

don't believe that for one second. Gemini is more cunning than to let them all explode in a Pagoda in Japan. The slap in our faces was the fact that he didn't have them posted safely in a Grove." Neflym paused with a gasp. "That's exactly where they are! We need to round up the Coven of Unity and keep them alive for now until we decide what to do with them."

"We need to find those Mancers, if what you say is true, and they are still alive," Ophi said.

"I have one of them so I will have my blood lines find the others. Better yet, I'll have them come to me," Prince Lord Ka said triumphantly.

"How do you plan on doing that?" Ophi asked.

"I already have one of them. That's all the bait I need." A sinister smile formed on Ka's face as he began to craft a master plan in his head.

"Not if I don't find them first," Ophi said, smiling under her mask. "I have waited over five hundred years to repay them for what they did to my face and to the rest of my coven."

"Vengeance won't be the path we take, Ophi," Nef said, nonchalant. "We tried countless times before. If we kill them, they'll only be reborn. If we have control of them while they are alive, we win."

"I can still have a little fun with them. Alive is all we need," Ophi spat hatefully.

"It would seem the race is back on to see how the world will end, this time." Nef laughed aloud. "May the best leader win!"

At his final words, all four entities disappeared, returning whence they came. The silence was deafening, but speaking to himself, Neflym said aloud, "Your move, Gemini."

Chapter 22

THE OTHER WOMAN

(Pangaea: 250,001,100 B.C.)

“Blue, you know how much I love you?” Kaery asked as they lay on the grassy field coiled together lovingly. The spring day was so beautiful that the words came out of Kaery’s mouth effortlessly. So distracted by the clouds in the open sky overhead, she continued without listening to his answer, “So much so, it hurts me inside to be in this situation.”

“Kaery, please don’t be like this,” Blue said so gently it made her heart flutter. He knew he loved her, and this was the conversation he had dreaded for the greater part of a thousand years, but he was willing to have it for the sake of the golden-eyed beauty in his arms.

“I know you have to be the God of Gods, or in our case the Mancer of Supernaturals, but I don’t understand my role. I just sit in the background, listening and watching as if I were a shadow.” Kaery almost came to tears.

Blue knew she was hurt, and it pained him more than battle to see her this way. “I don’t want you to feel like you don’t matter. You are my love. Nothing can change that.”

“I know you speak the truth, but it doesn’t change the fact that you’re married to Sky.”

“What would you have me do? Leave her? And go to some other unknown world where we can escape together and live by ourselves?” Blue asked sarcastically, but realized the error of his ways when Kaery let go of his grip and sat up.

“I don’t think this is funny.” Kaery was pouting as she looked off into the horizon at the large and majestic sun. “Use your powers and send me back to the Soulstream, please!”

“You know that even if my powers worked on you, I’d never use them to harm you!”

“I’d rather die than feel like this.” Kaery began to sob.

Blue sat up to comfort her. “You know that my wife is the will of the council and the will of the world.”

“But you love her.” Kaery looked into Blue’s sapphire eyes.

“Yes, I do. I mean, I have learned to love her, but I am *in* love with *you*.” His words were so genuine that he neither flinched nor stuttered. This only made Kaery’s eyes tear up even more.

She didn’t try to wipe the tears from her eyes. She only laid back into his loving embrace. He’d taken his armor off, and his bare chest was warm to the touch. In the embrace of the most powerful Mancer, Kaery should have felt like the most protected woman in the world, but she believed she was insignificant and vulnerable. She couldn’t turn her head to face him because she knew how emotional she was becoming over this situation.

“Why can’t we just run away?” Kaery asked the question knowing it was rhetorical. Blue was a Mancer who was meant to lead. His specific task was to rule the other leaders of this new planet earth. Blue was paired with a Mancer named Sky, who was actually beautiful and courageous, as well as cunning and generous. Kaery had already felt bad the first time she slept with Sky’s husband, but he continued to pursue her and had proclaimed his love for her many times. Sky had the power to see everything and control everything within a sphere around her. Currently the Sphere covered most of the planet, so there was technically nowhere the two could hide from her.

“The only reason we can even have our love affair is that Sky can’t use her powers on you, nor can anyone for that matter,” Blue said to Kaery, “Your Avatar armor that serves as your skin is the only thing that shields us from Sky’s ever-screaming eyes. I would be with only you if my marriage to Sky did not unify Pangaea.”

“Enough!” Kaery’s voice involuntarily rose to the sound of thunder crushing a mountain, causing every bird on the horizon to fly from location. It took her a moment to regain some semblance of composure as her voice returned to its normal pitch. “I’m sorry, but I just can’t think of any other option than for me to stop seeing you.”

“Please, Kaery, don’t do this to me! I love you! I always have. I’ve proven my love for you. You wouldn’t want me to break the world apart for the sake of our love, would you? If so, then let me know, and I will make it so.”

Kaery looked at Blue for the first time with a selfish glint in her eyes. Her pain was somehow overshadowed with something more rich and intoxicating, hope. “You would do that for me?”

“Without a second thought, I’d do anything for you,” Blue said as he pulled Kaery’s sun-touched skin towards his pale muscles. His black hair blew in the wind, contrasting her long brown mane. He was prepared for the inevitable destruction of the world to keep her at his side.

Kaery knew he was telling the truth, and the thought of her selfish act sickened her. She laid her head on his hard chest, listening to his steady heartbeat. It was a sound she would take to the grave with her before she allowed the world to be destroyed because of her mistake. She kissed his skin, and he moved to her touch as expected, in bliss.

Blue closed his eyes as Kaery kissed his chest and moved her way up to his neck. He held her head still, staring into her eyes that burned through him like the sunrise defeating the darkness. He rolled over on top of her, still looking into the golden orbs that helped him forget about the pressures of the outside world. He somehow knew that she was contemplating leaving him even after his confession. Before his heart broke, he kissed her. When their lips touched, it was as if it were the first time he’d taken a breath. Her sweet lips were so soft, he couldn’t think straight. He didn’t want this emotionally deafening moment to end, and as he said before, he was willing to sacrifice anything for this.

Kaery knew without a doubt that Blue loved her.

I can’t allow him to do what I know he is thinking, just for me. Sky had him first, and she will keep him. I will always love him, but from the shadows. His lips make me want to cry. His smell is musky and like the river. His black hair I can fall asleep in if I close my eyes. This is not fair to either Sky or my Coven who are brought into the middle of it, covering up my affair.

As much as he takes my breath away, with every second he touches my lips, I have to be strong. As much as he rubs my skin as if he were the rain that washed all my sins free, I can’t go on with this any longer. I love him! He knows I love him! I can’t stop crying. Wait—that’s his tear that has touched my cheek. I’m breaking his heart, and I don’t want to! Please give me a spell to forget this moment. I will be cursed for eternity with the thought of this man and every moment spent with him. His touch makes my skin melt. He doesn’t know what power he has over me. I feel so weak and at his mercy.

“Kaery, if you’d only trust me enough to know that I’d give up everything for you.” Blue kissed her lips and nuzzled her neck as if he were her pet. He never submitted to anyone, but under her spell he knew he had no choice. He was in love, and there was no God he wouldn’t kill to keep this feeling. His hands probed her body as if he were massaging unseen oil gently across it. He smiled as he heard her gasp in pleasure and sigh when he gripped her waist and pulled her closer. He wanted her as much as she wanted him, even though he could see the inner turmoil, feel her holding back for the first time. He decided to go further.

Kaery felt light-headed as he stroked her body like an instrument. His fingers were heavenly, and his strong body enveloped her as she surrendered wholeheartedly, no longer fighting to stay in control. Her breathing finally returned as she opened her golden eyes to see his deep blue ones piercing her very soul. She gasped again as she smelled the distinct scent of space and time being shifted around her. Blue was using his powers without even knowing it. Normally the musical hum in the air would have any one of the Supernaturals in his court paralyzed, mesmerized and terrified all at once but she was different. Her natural ability of immunity to Magick made her see the world from a different perspective.

When she opened her mouth to talk, she was interrupted by a breathtaking kiss that made her lose track of her thoughts once again. She silenced all logic to be within the embrace of the most powerful man on the planet. Her brown hair now floated around her as if she were flying. She didn’t open her eyes as she felt gravity lose touch with her body. If this was how he would kiss her for eternity, then maybe she wouldn’t mind destroying the world for this feeling. He was stimulating Kaery’s emotions simultaneously with her body, and she moaned under his touch. She had lost this battle, and she knew it.

Blue made love to Kaery as they floated off the ground. He was aware he was losing control over his powers, but did nothing to stop the moment. He would happily die here and now.

Her skin makes me want nothing more in this world. I want to be the only man to make her happy. I love caressing her skin and feeling her inside and out. The way she moans in my ears with every thrust and the pain I feel from her natural resistance makes my own power of the Soulstream reflexively try to protect my body. She doesn’t know that with every ounce of pleasure is a torrent of pain I’d happily take for her.

She's so soft, and her breath fills my mouth as if she were bringing me back to life. What of the life I never had control over and the one she was born into as a Wicasht advisor to the gods? I want her breath to either destroy me now or resurrect me as a normal man, qualified to be her lover. She shouldn't have to deal with any pain! If I could take all of hers away and blow up into oblivion, then I would. I know she wants to be free from all of this torment. She's torn between staying with me and letting the world die, or leaving me and watching as I love another woman. It must be as self-destructive as my powers. All I can do to take her pain away is to make love to her while flying through the sky.

Blue's hands continued to rub the soft flesh of Kaery's lower back and the base of her neck as they flew through the darkening clouds. The stars were ever-present, and Blue knew the universe was infinite, but for the first time in his young life, his immortal life, tears of anguish fell from his eyes as he finally understood that this could be his last moment with his beloved Kaery.

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Sky smiled as she had great news to share with her beloved husband. She had told him that she'd try not to use her powers to find him unless it was a dire emergency, but she really wanted to share in her revelation. She had consorted with the Oracles. They had told her it was possible to change every mortal on the planet into Supernaturals with powers over the universe. Sky's mastery over her spellcrafts was one of the many feats that made her the most qualified goddess of fertility, Magick, and Spheromancy.

She excitedly paced the large pyramid that she called home. With every step, she anticipated Blue's reaction to her good news. They called her a Spheromancer, which meant she could see in many directions at once while also controlling anything around her, including gravity, sound, space, time and regeneration, as if she were in multiple places at once. She was arguably the single most powerful being on the planet, but she would humbly bow to Blue's awesome powers over the Soulstream. Though her sphere was measured by the circle of

influence she kept, she felt her powers growing daily, and as they grew, her sphere covered most of the planet easily.

The only places Sky's amazing powers of detection didn't seem to work so well were places the planet created as conduits of Magick, called Groves. They were like sanctuaries of power that reflected her abilities. There were a few powerful entities on the planet that could block her powers, but that was narrowed down to a handful. Sky finally gave in to her excitement and used her all-seeing eyes to find her husband. She would search the skies and the seas as well as every volcano and sand dune to find him.

Sky smiled to herself as she looked all over the planet at once. She noticed everything from people hunting, praying, eating and exploring, to Supernaturals practicing Magick and developing new Spellcrafts. She took no time from her search as she blessed her followers with simple wishes, from changing the weather to a beautiful cascade of rain that would grant them food, to showing them lands that would be perfect to build upon. All of this was done simultaneously, as easily as blinking. She was awestruck at the beauty of Pangaea and couldn't think of anything that could ruin her day.

Not being able to find her husband was a rare occasion, but today was one of those days. She searched everywhere, which meant he must be in one of the Groves that she could not scry into, but had to physically travel to. This was no hard task as there were hundreds of these beautiful places all claimed by either Wicasht covens or Mancer kingdoms. There were the very few that were unclaimed, but she would not tell of their locations until she had explored them with Blue, an activity she so loved to do with her husband alone. Though she was the reigning queen of this planet, Sky was not known for her patience and decided to visit a lot of these Groves all at once, asking their masters and mistresses the whereabouts of her handsome king.

Sky travelled from the deep caverns of the middle of earth to the depths of the sea kingdoms. Her search was not fruitful. She decided to visit the Groves of the Avatars and the Wicasht next; they were always her favorite because of the life and lovely energy that emanated from every fiber of these places. It would seem that the Wicasht reveled in the fact that their powers were enhanced here. She had already spoken to many covens, but she had not visited the Coven of Unity just yet. Once she arrived at the humble Grove's outer barrier she spoke softly, asking for permission to enter.

“Dearest Coven of Unity, I, Sky, would humbly ask to enter your domain.”

Scape was inside the Grove speaking to animals when the winds from the East carried the elegant message from Sky. He stopped his conversation and smiled as he lifted his right hand and opened the Magickal mote that surrounded their home. He so loved the serene presence of the beautiful goddess. Her soft caramel skin was so healthy and majestic, you’d think she used Glamour Magick, though he knew she never did. Her long brown hair had streaks of blonde and red as it flowed around her like a veil of shining love. He was ecstatic to see her as he materialized from the very air itself, shifting from his air elemental form to the handsome man with naturally dark skin whom Sky recognized. He approached the entrance through which she walked, even though he knew she didn’t have to raise a foot to travel. This must be a special visit which she only made every hundred years or so.

“Hello, Sky, what have we done to deserve such an unexpected visit?” His reddish tan was almost darker than Sky’s brown exterior as he bowed while reaching out to kiss her hand.

“Oh, you are always such the gentleman, Scape. I enjoy your presence as well, though you don’t have to bow, and you know it.” Sky smiled and blushed at the gesture of the druid elemental of the Coven of Unity. He was always aware of his surroundings, as if on a smaller level, he possessed her abilities. Though he was limited to a smaller area of effect, he was a master of the very fibers of the four elements that made life on this planet possible: earth, air, water and fire. With his gift he was given something that even Sky didn’t have, the ability to speak with beasts and plant life, though she could easily heal and kill them just the same. “I’m looking for my husband, Aegis. Have you seen him?”

“No your Majesty, I haven’t seen him since he—” Scape silenced himself as he realized Blue was with Kaery. This was not going to be good. Unfortunately, Scape was not a good liar. He hated being in this situation, but Kaery told them not to tell if anyone came looking for her. “—Since he came here the last time you were here.” Scape continued trying to control his heartbeat and skin.

“Is that so? He has eluded me all day, which is abnormal. He rarely does this. Well, if you could tell him that I’m looking for him if he shows up to your Grove, that would make it a blessed day for me and all.” Sky smiled happily. “I shall tell him if I see him,” Scape said, smiling as he bowed his head again, politely looking at her perfectly sculpted bare feet.

“Please stop bowing,” Sky lifted Scape’s head up noticing his slight shiver, but saying nothing as she looked around the Grove all at once. “Are you sure you’re ok, dear Scape?”

“Yes. I am. I just feel like the Grove isn’t presentable to such a distinguished guest.” Scape smiled nervously.

“May I look around your beautiful home?” Sky asked politely.

“Of course you may,” Scape said, knowing that Kaery and Blue were recently lying in a field of grass. He dared not eavesdrop, as he was the only one who knew where they were. They’d left the Grove by way of flight, hours ago. But as Sky could see her surroundings clearly, so could Scape, and the lovers were no longer in the Grove, so he had nothing to worry about, unless they returned while she was here. His brow dropped a bead of sweat that Sky noticed.

She wondered if the Grove was under some sort of internal attack that Scape was forbidden to talk about, fearing his coven be harmed in some way. She whispered into the air so that only he could hear, “Are you sure you are safe and ok? Only you and I can hear this message.”

Almost forgetting Sky’s undeniably brilliant power over sound, Scape almost jumped out of his skin as the words intruded upon his ears. He settled down as he walked alongside the beautiful Mancer, eventually regaining his composure.

“As you know, Sky, we are still in the midst of retrieving the items we need for such a powerful spell as the Spell of Enlightenment. You know, just in case we are the *chosen* coven to cast such a grand spell.” Scape was happy with his wit.

Of course, no wonder all of the covens have been acting so nervous at my sudden arrival! They think I’m spying to judge their capabilities! Sky pondered the thought and smiled a big smile as she spoke aloud for him to hear, “I have full faith in your young coven, Scape.”

“I am honored that once again you have given us your divine blessings, but I’m not sure the others are so convinced. I mean, we have completed many missions to retrieve the rare items we need for a spell of that magnitude, but some of us have come up short. We’re not even sure the combination of ours Magicks is strong enough to deliver proper results, even after retrieving the items.” Scape actually spoke with true concern as he almost forgot how he was veering the conversation away from Kaery and Blue. Despite her long list of abilities, Sky was not blessed with telepathy, which saved his little slip of the tongue.

“You are ever so humble, dear Druid Scape.” Sky stopped walking and looked up at the large moon covering most of the space above. “Sometimes I forget how beautiful the world truly looks from Groves. Even the animals flying overhead are truly fantastic in the night sky. Diana, Mancer of the Moon, must be proud of her kingdom as she illuminates our beautiful lands below.”

Scape followed her gaze and did not answer the question that seemed more of an afterthought than a true query. He did however agree that the Moon was absolutely incomparable in beauty to all the sky’s creatures. His warm smile brought a cool composure that made Sky happy he was no longer nervous in her presence.

Sky did a silent check in the Grove and noticed that four of the Coven of Unity were unaccounted for. “Where is the rest of your gentle coven?”

“They are more than likely practicing Magick within their own sacred spaces inside our tree vault or wandering around the Grove causing mayhem.” He said the last part thinking of Ewm and Ahlina burning down a large part of the fields with a strange pink fireball once.

Sky was happy with his answers and decided not to take up much more of his time as he seemed slightly restless again. “I will bid you farewell, lovely Wicasht.”

“Witchbreed,” Scape corrected jokingly, “That’s what the humans call us, Witchbreed.”

Sky laughed for the first time. “Such a vulgar name, but somehow rolls right off the tongue! One day those poor souls will have the enlightenment that will correct their silly interpretation of the Language of Magick.”

“We can only wish for such a day, your Liege,” Scape said, looking at her beautiful brown eyes as he held her hands carefully.

Sky stood straight for a moment. She looked at the firmament above and whispered, “Your powers over the elements will not be your limit. I have unlocked another power from within. Each marking from the beasts will bring about a new ability you will be able to control uniquely. Thank you for your time, dear one.”

Scape did not know what to say. He felt his skin light up in the moonlight. He looked around and as she uttered the words, he was able to see something he had never seen before, the spirits of the animals clear as dew on the grass. “Oh, wow, Sky! I don’t know what to say or how to repay...” As Scape spoke, he realized Sky was no longer holding his hands, but had disappeared into thin air.

Her voice lingered like a laugh that caressed him. “No need to thank me. You are more than welcome, and enjoy the blessing.” Sky’s voice surrounded Scape as he walked over to the spirits of the land and sighed in joy.

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Kaery screamed in tantric ecstasy for what seemed the thirteenth time in a row. Her body had been quivering and shuddering uncontrollably for hours with her legs wrapped around Blue’s naked body. When she landed on the soft grass, she opened her eyes for the first time in what seemed like ages as they descended from heaven to earth. Blue looked into her eyes so lovingly that Kaery smiled, and a tear could not fall down her cheek fast enough for Blue to catch it and bring it to his soft pink lips.

“I will take this as a tear of joy that will give me the strength to tell Sky how I feel about you, Kaery,” Blue said so passionately, Kaery almost thought he was casting a spell.

“How do you feel about me?” Kaery replied with Blue still inside of her.

“I don’t want to be anywhere, with anyone, without you. Like you just made time stop as we traveled the clouds together. Like you are the reason that I breathe and bleed. Like you are mine!” Blue cried as he leaned in to kiss Kaery’s wet lips almost too hard.

Kaery thought to herself, *I can’t allow him to do this. I can’t be the reason the world suffers. I have to tell him now.*

Sky had just flown from the Coven of Unity’s Grove after blessing Scape for being such a loyal friend, only to see her husband float down from the night sky onto a field of grass near the river. At first she was filled with such joy at finding him that she almost instantly ran into his arms, until she saw who was already there. Kaery was not only being embraced by Blue, but mounted, as they made love in front of her. She wept from a distance as she listened to their conversation from where she stood. She forgot that Kaery was one of the handful of people who, like a Grove, was not affected by Sky’s Magick. “No wonder I couldn’t find him.”

Sky put her hands over her mouth as if she would be heard from a distance. She crept closer, but not close enough to alarm them.

For Sky, Blue's delicate and loving words to Kaery were like a spell that had been cast unto the universe. Her broken heart was now the reason a random storm brushed across the lands. She couldn't take any more, so she flew into the center of the storm, sobbing.

Blue stroked Kaery's hair and looked over his shoulder at the thunderous storm that began to crash across the once peaceful night sky, but before he could talk, a finger hushed him.

"Blue, we can no longer do this," Kaery whispered into his ear. She stood up and started walking toward her Grove. She didn't even look back to see the anguish on his face that was as harmful as the storm in the distance. Her heart broke, and she wept with every harsh and inevitably painful step. As she crossed the threshold of the Grove's Magick, the storm was no longer the music that overpowered her sobs. She fell to her knees, and with every bone-wrenching convulsion, cried, "Why?"

Chapter 23

TEACH ME HOW TO FIGHT

“How many times do I have to tell you, lead in with your left foot like this?” Crux said impatiently.

“Shut up, you little brat. I’m trying to get this,” Star said. “You’re a crappy teacher.” *Damn, my feet hurt.*

“You’re fighting like your feet hurt,” Crux said to the exhausted Star. “I don’t know why you insist on wearing those... stilts.”

“Gucci, they’re worth the pain. That’s why,” Star said, “Now shut up and teach me the stupid kick.”

Crux stood back and got into a fighting stance. He lowered his body, then leapt off the ground and did a spin kick as high as Star’s face. The twelve-year-old landed gracefully like a cat. “Like that.”

Star had seen the kick a dozen times before this and had only agreed to the lesson because Crux was right, she didn’t know how to fight, though she’d never admit it. She tried to mimic his stance and dropped as low as she could drop in her mini dress and six-inch stilettos. She jumped up and did a high kick with her long legs, surprising even herself. But as she landed, her heel turned to the side, and she crashed hard on her butt.

Crux cringed at the terrible looking fall, even though he was proud of her for trying. The kick looked legit, but before he could say anything, a female voice came from behind him.

“Whoa, that was painful looking, as in what the hell are you thinking? ‘Cause I’m uploading that feed to my site right now. #whatthefhellwasstarthinking, like right now.” Ahlina laughed so hard, she could barely press the buttons on her hacked smart phone.

Star looked up at her from the dirty patch where she had landed. The dust still in the air, she managed to pop up onto her feet with no visible dirt on her dress then said, “If you do, I’ll kill you, then post that video of you kissing that old guy when you were drunk. #ahlinaisaslut, now what?”

When Ahlina lunged toward her phone, Star did a pirouette.

“Okay, guys stop,” Kaery said, “What is going on here? Star, why are you doing jump kicks in Golden Gate Park wearing a club dress and heels?”

“You said you deleted that video, Star!” Ahlina cried out.

“I lied,” Star said coldly, “Now delete the video or I’ll post yours.”

“Fine, we delete at the same time.”

“Fine!”

Both girls showed each other their phones as the files were erased.

Kaery shook her head and asked, “Why is she doing jump kicks, Crux?”

Crux shrugged and replied, “If that’s what you call that. I’m trying to teach you all how to fight ‘cause there is something dark coming this way. You need to be prepared, or you’re going to get slaughtered, literally.”

For a moment, Kaery’s eyes glowed without the help of the sun. She knew Crux was telling the truth. “Ok, so you’re not lying about this getting slaughtered business, but Star’s training looks more painful than productive.”

“That’s how you learn to fight,” Crux said, chuckling, “No fighter ever learned how to brawl just by thinking it. There’s a lot of blood, sweat, and tears.”

“Sounds like a card you got on your birthday,” Star said, “And yes, I’m sure it sucked even then.”

“Come on Star, let’s take this seriously,” Kaery pleaded with her annoyed friend. Her ability to maintain a half-smile while dealing with this sort of bickering was a testament to her diplomatic nature.

Star simply nodded without objection.

Kaery smiled and turned her attention to the preteen who had a smug look on his face. “Crux.”

Crux focused his attention on the seventeen-year-old ‘girl next door.’ He saw how different these best friends truly were. Star was a tall all-American glamazon who only cared about her image. Ahlina had always seemed like a bored Asian punk girl who didn’t care about her image at all; and Kaery was the American mutt who cared about everyone liking her, so she always tried to keep the peace while staying fairly normal. They were three completely different girls whom he would never have guessed were friends, yet they impossibly loved each other as sisters. He felt the most comfortable with Kaery, until she spoke again.

“Crux, you wouldn’t happen to be talking about the Vampyl known as the Shandor, would you?” Kaery asked with a blank expression on her face.

All the blood left Crux's flushed cheeks as he looked into Kaery's eyes. He then realized what coven of Witchbreed she must have come from, the Anu. They were also known as the Banshees because the truth they spoke might as well have sent the listeners running with bleeding eardrums. He was instantly terrified and couldn't shake it. His greatest fear had just been brought to the surface, and he knew the girls saw it all over him. The Shandor were the most dangerous creatures in the underworld. They always eliminated their targets, and he happened to be one of their latest.

Ahlina opened her green eyes as much as she could, watching Crux's horrified expression. "Well, obviously, that's exactly who he's talking about." Ahlina tilted her head toward Kaery and asked, "What in the hell is a Shandor Vampyl? And how do you know that?"

Crux parted his chapped lips, barely able to speak through the dryness that made his throat extremely uncomfortable. His tone was quiet and lower than usual. "You're a Banshee." Crux looked Kaery up and down. "You guys are basically some cryptic psychic oracles or whatever who tell people the absolute truth, though most don't want to hear it."

Star agreed, "That's Kaery alright, though I'm not sure what a Banshee is. The other stuff is spot on."

"Try to keep up," Crux said to all three at once, purposely ignoring the question about the Shandor. "So all of you have formed some sort of alliance, but you're definitely from other covens. From the first day I met Star, she has been doing spellcrafts from the Glamori coven. I noticed that the first time I saw her. She can change the appearances of herself and others with potent illusions called Glamour. Most people don't call them Glamouri, but rather the Bitches, because of their narcissistic attitudes."

"Sounds like Star alright," Ahlina agreed.

Star didn't even turn her gaze from Crux, dismissing Ahlina's attempt to get under her skin.

Crux continued, "I don't know what Ahlina is, but I'm guessing it's something ridiculous because you pretty much don't do anything cool."

"Thanks, you little freak," Ahlina flipped Crux off. "I don't want to be some witch or whatever anyway."

"Witchbreed, and there's no doubt you're one of them. I just can't quite put my finger on which coven. Not like I'm some expert, but I know a few." Crux

walked around Ahlina, inspecting her like a dog without touching her for fear she'd try to attack him.

"Stop looking at me like that, you little creep," Ahlina hissed.

Crux gave a mocking laugh. "Yeah, I don't know. But anyway, I'm not some kind of mentor, so you all will have to find out on your own. I can teach you how to fight though. Maybe."

Kaery shrugged and said, "I've never fought anyone."

"Not in this lifetime, but I'm sure you have in another," Crux replied as if he were commenting on the weather.

Ahlina, Kaery and Star looked at each other with puzzled expressions. They'd all come to the conclusion that their perfectly synchronized dreams were memories, not just figments of their imaginations. It was impossible for them to explain how every memory was experienced as if they were living it all over again. They could smell the air, feel the temperature and see every detail. These were not just scattered memories, but shared histories relived.

Crux continued, "You all just aren't completely enlightened. I'm sure it's 'cause you're without your covens or something like that. I suppose you need to be together to achieve your full potential. Listen to me, my mom the card handler would be so proud..." He smiled off into the distance, then quickly regained his composure, continuing with a grave countenance. "So basically we have to trigger whatever it is that you all need to relearn and what you probably already know."

Star yawned, "I'm bored."

"Ok, let's get to it," Crux said, "If you can learn this kick, we'll move on to something more advanced."

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(Zalomoni: Present-Day)

Maia had been walking through the Ruins for hours, which could have easily become days had she not been aware of the Mancers time paradox. She knew that all Mancers were born with two definite things. Immortality prevented death from

time itself, though most could be destroyed by other means. Its companion, time paradox, caused them to lose track of time and, by extension, reality if they didn't meditate regularly, focusing on the here and now.

She had been wandering around the Ruins, taking in her surroundings through her Oracular Sight. The dusty walls somehow cleared up and showed themselves as they once were before the Ice Age. This city was beautiful and absolutely one of a kind. It was built in a valley deep within a Cliffside, overlooking a river running through a lush forest.

The main fortress where they had all been staying was behind a stone wall that must have been crafted by gods themselves, for it was the largest wall she'd ever seen. It had gigantic statues, now broken. With her Oracular sight, she could see the way the statues used to look.

There were four large statues that surrounded the city. The first that caught Maia's attention was one of an Emperor. He was handsome, a large crown of precious metals atop his head. In his eyes were Runes that read 'Human' and 'Emperor,' and in his hand was a spear adorned with large jewels sparkling in the sun light.

About a mile within the city was a second statue. Carved directly into the cliffside was a gigantic soldier with a large sword pointed to the ground. His bulky and ornate armor was marked with a Rune that read 'Jreamer.' The statue of a stunning woman directly across from the Jreamer was built into the mountain itself, her long dress flowing, her palms out with an orb suspended directly above them. On her tiara was a Rune that read 'Wicasht,' and on the orb were Runes of Magick that read 'Sunlight,' 'Moonlight,' 'Glow,' and 'Power Source.'

The most amazing of the four statues that guarded this city was the one of Jayde built directly into the wall. Her sword in her right hand and shield in her left symbolized the protector of this great city, her carved figure flying out of the stone itself. Her robes and armor terrified onlookers of the Forbidden City. She was ready to attack even a giant if it dared come near her home. A second statue of Jayde on the inside of the wall showed her praying for the safety of her people, an image that was as intimidating to enemies as it was calming to friends.

Maia's blond hair blew in the cool wind, the lonesome valley seeming like the only place in the world. The fresh air was like nothing she'd ever inhaled, but even in the tranquility of this majestic city, she couldn't shake the events that she'd seen with her own eyes. This place was both a wonder and a nightmare. Maia knew

she was standing on the remains of fallen Supernaturals whose spirits might never be at rest. She shivered at the thought and continued her trek, mapping the city as she tried to subdue her inherent fear of the unknown.

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After reveling at the beauty of all four grandiose statues, Maia took in a deep breath and tried to keep herself from looking at the past and the way the statues used to look, focusing instead on the present. She closed her eyes therapeutically, then sighed so heavily she stumbled. When she opened her brown eyes, she looked up into the sky to take in the most magnificent moon she'd ever seen in all sixteen of her young years.

The moon was not only enhanced in size and shape, but also seemed to take up most of the sky, as if the planet were somehow going to crash into the large meteor that had always revolved around it. Maia gasped so loud in surprise that she looked around to see if anyone had witnessed her reaction. It was as if she had never seen the moon before, and in many ways this was true. The blue and silver aura that radiated through the rest of the sky was so bright, it might as well have been a haunting sunlight.

Maia could see the stars so clearly, she thought this was some sort of illusion, but as a bird flew overhead from one side of the canyon to the other, she remembered that she was in Zalomoni once more, and there was life in this wonderful ruined city. She looked back at the moon, which seemed to be orbited by fragmented pieces of itself, but it wasn't getting any closer, so Maia calmed. She'd just never seen it so large and so vivid. The craters were like pores on a majestic face viewed through a microscope.

Taking a mental note of every detail in the night sky, Maia was taken off guard as a hand touched her shoulder. She jumped in alarm and almost fell until she regained her footing, shrieking alarmingly loud as if in a scary movie.

“Chill out,” Juno said, pulling her hand back slowly, fingering her brown hair with raspberry highlights. “It’s just me and Nina,” Juno said, pointing to the blonde beside her.

Maia’s expression was a combination of shock and relief that eased into complete comfort as she recognized the two beautiful women before her. She knew Juno looked as if she were in her mid-twenties, but upon further inspection, she saw Runes of Magick spinning in the mismatched eyes of the Witchbreed who was definitely thousands of years old. Maia could tell that Juno’s incredible lifespan was the result of an immortality spell she must have found or created. That part wasn’t clear, and Juno didn’t allow Maia to look into her eyes long enough to find out.

She turned from Juno, who must’ve known what Maia was doing, and looked to Nina, who stood innocent and quiet on the stone trail. For some reason, Maia had a hard time reading this one, which intrigued her to the point where she took a step closer, staring rudely into the woman’s crystal blue orbs. The Runes of Magick revealed that she was indeed a Mancr.

She’s a Neuromancer of epic proportions, able to control the emotions of not just people, but anything near her that has an inkling of life or blood. Only twenty years old, she’s lived a pretty rough life so far with all of the travelling, the lack of a place to call home. She had an abusive girlfriend in San Francisco whom she couldn’t forget, Natasha. Oh, and look at that, she thinks she killed her parents. Mother was a teacher and father a construction worker, no carpenter. She was in a car ride with them on Christmas Eve while they argued, and she cried to stop them from fighting when a deer jumped onto the road. The car spun out of control and flipped, throwing Nina out and pinning the parents inside. As they were engulfed by the flames of the resulting explosion, she felt their pain, every excruciating moment, until they passed.

Nina is fascinating as she somehow has triggered memories from other lifetimes like Witchbreed usually do to survive out in the wilderness. Oh let me dig a little deeper...speaking of other lifetimes, everyone has them. Wait what is this, these are hers, but something is wrong? Gaps in her lifetime’s history as if she somehow is able to block the Soulstream-imprinted information everyone has written on them. Instead there are these strange Runes in the place where her lifetime information is supposed to be. For the first time, I can’t read Runes of Magick. This must be some high-level stuff I don’t know about.

“Wow, Nina there are over two thousand years missing from your lifetime Runes! How did you manage to do that? I’m curious.” At this point, Maia was about to touch Nina’s face before she took a nervous step back.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Nina said, retreating behind Juno like a child.

“Oh I’m not going to hurt you. I just want to know what those Runes of Magick in that weird scaly language are.” Maia had an entranced glimmer in her brown eyes.

“That’s enough!” Juno said to Maia, stepping in protectively to separate the two females.

“I’m so...sorry,” Maia apologized hastily as she regained her composure, “I honestly don’t know what came over me.”

“You’re an Oracle,” Juno replied, “You see things that intrigue you, and you dig until you know everything about it.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Maia said, looking back to the oversized moon in the sky. “Since you seem to know more than I do, Juno, why does the moon look like, well that?” Maia pointed at the broken meteor in the sky.

Both Juno and Nina gazed upward. Juno smiled as Nina gasped for the countless time this evening, as if she were looking at the moon for the first time whenever her eyes left the ground. Juno couldn’t help thinking about how she was as adorable as an innocent child. She then turned her attention back to Maia, who noticed her adoring glances at Nina. Juno hurriedly looked back up at the moon and began to explain what she’d told Nina just minutes prior to Maia’s question.

“We’re in one of the few places on Earth that show the true nature of Magick. This is a Grove in which all Supernaturals are enhanced, and it’s in places like this that we are the most at home. To find one is a treasure in itself because most are lost, ravaged in wars or forgotten altogether. Here the effects of smog, pollution, and other toxins in the air don’t exist. The moon simply looks as it always has, unencumbered by any illusion or the Veil of Ignorance.” She noticed Nina gasp slightly again as she continued her explanation. “The night sky is truly marvelous when there is no labyrinth of false light to escape in order to see. Groves are hidden in Magicks so strong that only the chosen can hope to find them, the same Magick that can make one forget how to find the way back if they are gone for too long.” Juno took a step down the trail as if she had triggered a thought hidden for centuries, remembering when she lived in Zalomoni before the

Ice Age. Her sad memory of this once decadent and immaculate city was so detailed, it struck an emotional chord that Maia didn't have to be an Oracle to see. Juno turned her face away from both onlookers and walked down the trail as if on a mission.

"Where are you going?" Maia asked, walking behind the OZONE Agent gone rogue.

"She's sad," Nina said aloud, but to no one in particular.

"I noticed, but where is she going?" Maia asked, not taking her eyes off the power walking spy.

"I don't know," Nina replied, beginning to jog down the trail after her as if to plea for an answer.

Maia was no fan of cardio and decided to keep them in eyesight. She was now more interested in these two ladies than she'd ever been before. *Now I'm starting to see why Gemini didn't want me in the meeting with Juno back at the Pagoda! I wonder what Juno is stopping me from finding out about Nina. Why are they going into the fighting temple?*

Juno was taller than Nina by a couple inches, partly because she was wearing heeled armor boots attached to her Braintech high-grade utility suit that so happened to look like a cat suit from a comic book. With every long stride of her long legs, a memory of her training would peak in her mind. To bring herself out of a memory, she had to focus on something in the here and now like her suit. The more she thought about the technological innovation she was wearing, the more she thought it looked like a costume, out of character in contrast to the formal training she'd once received in these very walls.

As she walked into the dusty temple, this one much smaller and intimate compared to the others, she noticed the wall was still adorned with ancient weapons. She made a conscious effort not to touch them, knowing each by heart and unwavering memory. She walked to the center of the room and looked back at the panting Nina and even more out-of-breath Maia.

"Now is the time to teach you Mancers how to really fight," Juno said with a sadistic smile.

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“You guys are impossible!” Crux cried impatiently, annoyed beyond his twelve years. “I have been in this park for literally hours.” Throwing his thin arms in the air as if in surrender, he walked away from the three teenage Witchbreed. “You figure it out. I’m done for the day.”

“Crux, wait,” Kaery sat up from the ground with muscles so sore, she doubted she could stand without assistance from her friends, who currently looked as bad as she did.

“That was the worst kick I’ve ever seen in my life,” Crux muttered angrily to himself as he walked away. “I mean, even the time I broke my shin and had a cast on, I still kicked better than that.” His prepubescent voice disappeared into the shadows as he walked away.

Star struggled to stand. Her feet felt like they were on fire. “You’d think with all this Glamour Magick, I’d be able to figure out a way to make some comfortable shoes. Sadly to say, that little runt is right. We looked a hot mess. And not the tabloid type of hot mess.”

Ahlina had thought she was a better fighter than both of her best friends. However, after the training with Crux, she knew she was just as out of shape and in just as much pain as Kaery and Star. Her joints felt like they’d been hit by a bus, and she knew the feeling because she had been side-swiped by a MUNI bus while riding her bike on Market Street once. The bruise lasted for days. This was worse. *Somehow a little boy kicked all of our asses by teaching us simple techniques from some Kung Fu movie or anime somewhere.* She was perplexed in thought.

Kaery didn’t have to ask for help as Ahlina and Star both pulled her up to her feet slowly and groggily. “We’re pretty sad huh?”

“Understate much?” Star asked rhetorically as she concentrated and changed the appearance of her short dress to that of a small top and micro mini-skirt, the kind she had seen Sky in once. “We looked depressing. No, worse, like freshmen fashion.”

Ahlina giggled, knowing how badly most freshmen looked. They had those fish-out-of-water expressions on their faces and looked as if they were still dressed by their parents. She thought of her own outfits back when she was a freshman two

years ago, and it downright made her laugh. Star had a way with words that were bitchy and honest.

Kaery didn't quite understand how freshman clothing had anything to do with her terrible high kick technique, but it seemed to have Ahlina in good spirits, so she smiled. "We will definitely need more practice, then maybe we won't look like our mothers dressed us."

Star stood quietly looking at Kaery, shaking her head at the bad joke. Obviously her friend didn't get the sarcasm, but it made Kaery look even more innocent and adorable, so Star refrained from a rebuttal.

This revelation that Kaery didn't get the reference wasn't so easily passed up by Ahlina, who widened her eyes dramatically and said, "For someone who always seems to have it together, you tell the worst comebacks I've ever heard." Laughing aloud, Ahlina hugged Kaery's shoulders as she pouted.

They all walked out of Golden Gate Park and into the Richmond District. Typically it was very quiet in this part of town, the Victorian homes so close to one another that they looked like one long house separated only by welcome mats. As all three girls walked down the street, they heard the booming radio of a hip hop and dubstep mashup.

Ahlina shook her head without looking in the direction of the approaching car. "Douche bag alert."

Star turned her head slightly to see the car as it came screeching to a halt next to them. She saw the passenger clearly as he licked his lips, the stubble on his chin screaming teenage angst. "Eww. Why is the next generation of gas-guzzling, muscle-car-driving mentoids no cuter than the last?"

Four males exited the inappropriately parked car. The passenger was exceptionally sleazy with no shirt, and almost as thin as Ahlina, only much taller. His frame was a contrast to the muscular driver who spoke. "You chicks wanna ride?"

Star couldn't help but think the driver was cute, and she turned her gaze from him, saying, "Like we want anything from you losers."

"I'll give you something to ride," The passenger said as he skipped in front of the three teenagers, looking them up and down and licking his lips.

"I'll have to agree with my friend," Ahlina said, pushing the thin hoodlum out of her way. "You're so gross, and we don't want a thing from either of you. So get lost."

“Oh, you thought this was a request?” The driver said through a clinched jaw as he grabbed Kaery’s arm from behind, spinning her around to face him. Staring into her golden eyes, he said, “You’re kinda cute. So what’s it gonna to be, you comin’ with me or what?”

“Sorry, that’s not going to happen.” Kaery tried to pull her arm away but found the grip terrifyingly strong.

Ahlina, seeing her friend struggle to get free, sidestepped Kaery and positioned herself so she had direct access to her target. Kicking as hard as she could upward, Ahlina connected her steel toe combat boots to the balls of the driver with enough force to make him bounce off the ground on impact. He quickly released Kaery’s arm, and Ahlina stood in between them.

“Jake, you ok?!” the passenger asked, putting his hands on the driver’s back and bending over to face his friend.

“Yea, Jake, are your balls ok?” Star giggled as she stood posing next to Kaery as if she were in a photo shoot in the quickly dimming sunlight.

“You’re gonna regret that, you little skinny Asian bitch,” Jake coughed through gritting teeth as he slapped his friend away while he stood up straight. “Don’t let them go anywhere.” Trying to regain his posture, he never took his eyes off Ahlina with a death stare.

The three other males surrounded Star, Kaery and Ahlina like sharks in the Pacific ready to devour their next surfer in the wrong territory. The look in their eyes was so feral, the girls couldn’t help but to think how ironic it was that of all the days they hadn’t taken Crux’s training efforts seriously, this kind of scenario happened.

Star noticed the baggy clothes the other two wore and the sleeves of tattoos on their arms that looked like murals of random trendy art you’d see on the wall of any parlor. The only one with no visible tattoos was the passenger with the stubble on his chin and upper lip. He was obviously the youngest and possibly Jake’s sibling, now that she paid attention to his American trash features. Cropped brown hair and long lashes were a contrast to the slightly longer hair, short lashes and broad features of the two goons who hadn’t spoken a word yet.

Not knowing what to do, Kaery tried to think of something that would calm the violent men. She prayed someone would help them; a cop would drive by or maybe she would remember how to protect herself with one of the many self-defense throws and takedowns Crux tried to teach them earlier today. Caught off

guard with no help in sight, Kaery tried to keep the peace. "Please just let us go. We won't tell anyone."

"Even if you screamed, we wouldn't care. No cops come out to this neighborhood 'cause nothin' ever happens out here. You're getting in the car, one way or another," Jake snarled while staring at Ahlina with hatred.

"We're not afraid of..." Ahlina's words were interrupted by a jab so powerful, it knocked her backwards, stumbling toward Kaery and Star, who both instinctively caught her while almost falling over completely. Ahlina looked like she was in bad shape as blood ran from her mouth down her chin. Seeming to be in a daze, she fought desperately to regain her vision. A blue Rune of Magick formed on her palm that slowly burned its way into existence. The burning was familiar, but she couldn't quite place it, still jolted from the punch.

"I told you you'd regret that," Jake laughed as he stood over the three young girls on the sidewalk of the dark suburban street. They all seemed to be in shock. Not one of them had a smart remark or comment. He didn't know what was going on, but they had closed their eyes as if they were asleep. Eyelids fluttered in what looked like an introspective frenzy of shared nightmares. "What are these chicks OD'ing or something? I don't know what kinda game this is, but I don't care. You're not just gonna wish us away that easily now, girls. We're gonna have a lot of fun together." He motioned for his boys to grab them. "What're you waitin' for? Get 'em!"

Ahlina struggled to focus on her surroundings, her tiny frame still being held up by her friends, and as her eyes opened, Jake was no longer in sight. To her surprise, it was Juno, looming over her in the familiar walls of the temple, dressed in ancient Greek clothing with an armored breastplate that read 'Athena.' *Is this some kind of hallucination? Why are Kaery and Star looking so focused? How did we get here?*

"Ahlina, pay attention!" Juno commanded.

"Yes Sir!" Ahlina said automatically, as if used to being scolded. "I mean Ma'am. Or something."

"Come on," Kaery said as she and Star pulled her off the marble floor.

"Aren't you supposed to be better at this whole fighting thing than us?" Star asked.

"She is better than both of you," Juno said, "thousands of years ago in Zalomoni, she learned how to fight from the goddess of martial arts herself, Jayde.

You're better than this, Ahlina, you should be teaching these girls to fight, not me."

Ahlina couldn't shake the taste of blood from her mouth, and her lip stung when she touched it.

Juno continued her lesson, "You three are the protectors, guardians and advisors of Nina, or as the humans call her, Aphrodite. As you know, Greece has many enemies, mainly due to that bullheaded Mancer, Blue, or as the humans like to call him, Zeus, but either way you're the Witchbreed council on duty with first and foremost allegiance to Nina. No matter the odds outside, you will prevail, for this is a lesson you will never forget. Now is the time I remind you all that you can fight. Copy my battle stance, and it shall be so." Juno glided one foot forward and placed her hands out as if holding an invisible chalice in front of her with one hand and a delicate cloth behind her with the other. She looked into each of their eyes ferociously as she started to step methodically across the floor.

As if practicing for the thousandth time, all three girls mimicked Juno's movement identically as if to take on invisible foes who would soon regret they had upset this trio. Juno proceeded to move swiftly and changed forms many times, her flurry of attacks so fluid, the room might as well have been water and the girls, swimmers. Their movement was so beautiful and powerful that an onlooker would have been not only mesmerized, but terrified by their mysticism and agility. As if heaven somehow found a way to crash onto earth, they moved like a well-oiled war machine softly destroying anything in their path. The routine ended with all three girls low to the ground, breathing deeply and strongly, holding their positions until told otherwise.

Juno said, "Another day and I would have thought you all were actually warriors in my armies. I have full faith that you can protect Nina from any threat." She bowed low, and as she stood up straight, whispered. "Now get up and fight."

When Ahlina felt the rough touch of the passenger's hand on her shoulder, the eyes of all three girls opened simultaneously.

Their reality had changed in a matter of moments. No longer would there be sore muscles or bruised egos as this the awakening of something so fierce, the world had not seen its likeness in thousands of years. The awakened Witchbreed from the Coven of Unity had regained every repressed memory from the lifetime in Greece where Juno had taught them Supernatural combat techniques to protect the gods.

By the time the warmth from the young man's touch reached Ahlina's skin, Star was reaching her well-manicured hands up, snapping his fingers in four different ways, then yanking his arm over his head and out of its socket. Her six-foot frame in six-inch stilettos towered over him as she held his hand up tightly. He tried to scream, but before his lungs could gather the oxygen, she stood up with her back to him, her red hair like a blur, and gave an explosive kick backward with her right foot, sending him flying over twenty feet and crashing unceremoniously into the marble steps of a neighbor's house.

Kaery did the splits, crushing the right foot of each of the two nearest men with the heels of her skater shoes, then instantly hopped up, punching both East and West in the mid-section at once, causing them to hunch over. She placed both hands to her side, and with an upward wing-like swinging motion, she struck each man in the face with the back of her palms, jumping in the air as if using their faces to help her fly. From the force of her attack, one of the men flew into the muscle car, shattering the windshield and crushing the hood with the weight of his fall. The other flew through the window of a home, breaking through the glass as if he were falling through a shallow pond. Kaery landed gracefully in the same spot she had been standing in before her angelic uppercut.

Jake looked into the eyes of the green-eyed girl he had just assaulted, which had somehow changed. As he watched Star and Ahlina tear his gang apart within seconds using only a handful of fluid motions, he tried to catch the Asian girl off guard with another sucker punch, planning to make a run for it. His arm reached back to shift his weight, and he thrust forward. Ahlina seemed to be anticipating the attack for days, and he knew he was never going to connect the feeble punch, even as it was happening. He hadn't swung any slower than the first time, but somehow she was twice as fast as he was.

With all of his might behind the weight of his attack, Ahlina grabbed Jake's wrist with her index finger and her thumb. She applied a small amount of pressure and redirected his momentum toward the asphalt like a puppet she no longer wanted to play with. The man punched the ground so hard, it shattered every bone in his arm like glass. He rolled in the street screaming in pain before passing out.

Star, Kaery and Ahlina were all low to the ground in battle stances, stone cold expressions of understanding on their faces. The cool wind from the bay reminded them that they were no longer in danger as it gently nudged them back to the here and now.

Kaery looked from side to side at the broken goons littering the street, realizing what had just happened. She stood up first and declared, “I think we know how to fight now.”

Chapter 24

KIRARI'S WRATH

Juno took a defensive stance and looked at her two students as if they were from another time. She could see Nina as she had once looked before the Ice Age, dressed in custom-made light armor intertwined with a robe of the monks. Her hair back then was a long golden braid that touched her knee if it wasn't intricately twisted upward. Juno stopped herself from being drawn into a memory as she looked at the stark contrast to Nina's present appearance, an outdoorsy tomboy with short hair she cut herself with a wood carving knife. This young woman was wandering in the woods for years without as much as a blip on OZONE's radar. This was a feat and Juno was dying to find out how she did it.

Juno could appreciate Nina's fit frame underneath the dirty clothes as she stood still, confused. *She must have been hiking for miles every day, climbing mountains and hunting for food on her own, so she can't be completely helpless.*

Juno looked over to Maia and saw her in many other forms as well. In other lifetimes, this Goddess would have been surrounded by Witchbreed or other powerful council members. She usually wore elaborate headdresses with nothing but a loincloth and an embroidered cape, a far cry from the pink and black-layered emo girl she was in the present. These two were like all other Supernaturals who weren't Witchbreed, clueless until they were enlightened once again.

Knowing her work was cut out for her, she finally spoke, "I know that we've been at this for days, but you both are barely catching onto the basics of my attacks."

Nina was completely out of breath or she would have stopped Juno right there. *Days? There's no way we've been at this for days, it only felt like hours at most.* Nina's muscles however, were very sore and she knew why, because she had been hitting the stone floor more than Maia. She didn't understand what all this fighting was for in the first place. "Why are we fighting?"

"Remember those Soldiers in the forest that almost shot your head off?" Juno snapped unapologetically. "They are the reason."

Nina lowered her head in embarrassment. She almost forgot that Juno had saved her life in the woods from soldiers of some secret society she knew next to nothing about. Her shyness caused her to sink within herself slightly and remember the fear she felt that day when she had to jump into a waterfall, teleport to another city, find Gemini and save Juno. She ended up finding a group of kids who knew Gemini, causing a riot to attack the soldiers who were trying to kill them. Then she remembered Sky lifting everyone off the ground as if gravity didn't exist, then flying through the forest to save Juno. It all sounded like a trip someone would get from some good mushrooms or something, but now it was all real.

"Nina, pay attention," Maia whispered softly. Her long curly blond hair with black strips flowed around her in the soft breeze like a warm halo. She was intrigued by how similar Juno's training was to Jayde's. Juno had been scolding Nina, but the tomboy seemed to have spaced out for an uncomfortable moment while Juno stared at her patiently. *Almost too patiently.*

Juno nodded toward Maia for the interruption in Nina's withdrawal, then turned away from both students and lifted her hands to the sky. "I think I have a better lesson for the two of you to learn." She kneeled and closed her eyes with one hand still aimed upward toward a dusty wall of the room. In the language of Magick, she uttered softly, "By the Palm of the Prophets, show my past."

Nina and Maia gave each other quick glances and watched as the wall in front of Juno changed, losing its dust to reveal the ancient hieroglyphs underneath in pristine condition, and the longer they looked at it, the faster the wall seemed to reverse millenniums, the rest of the room around them also reflecting the shift in time.

Nina was beginning to panic when she felt the reassuring calm from a hand touching her own. She looked down to see Maia's hand holding hers.

"I've seen something similar with Surge," Maia said, "It's a glimpse of the past. Don't be scared. It's all just to show us what happened to this place. It's quite fascinating. Wow, Sky would totally grill me for saying that if she were here!"

"Silence," Juno's voice rang out, and though Nina could no longer see her, she felt her presence. Maia could see Juno walking out of the temple, beckoning for them to follow, but she was more intrigued by the use of Glamour Magick that created this astonishing illusion in the first place.

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(Ancient Zalomoni: Last Night of the Spiraar Attack)

Jayde was a sight to see. Her long black mane spun around her like the shadow on the dark side of the moon as she sliced another twenty-foot Spiraar in half. The shapeshifters were relentless, and she matched their onslaught with a myriad of attacks and parries. Her grace would have captivated her warriors' attention had they not been busy trying to stay alive. She knew that trying to stop the unlimited army of anthropomorphic man beasts with this formation in the middle of the courtyard was futile, so she gave commands while hacking and slashing any creature unfortunate enough to get within her reach.

"Juno, take your flank and secure Emperor Loiza's escape!" Jayde didn't bother to make sure Juno heard as she continued to seamlessly attack the wave, killing enemies by the dozens. She noticed a spin that Juno used to fight her way toward the Emperor's tower, four of her most trained Jreamers and Monks following closely behind.

"Guardian, Requiem for a Tower!" Jayde called once Juno was out of earshot, her blade cutting the arms off three beasts with one stroke as she spoke.

Guardian had watched many of his finest fall to these primal creatures, and with every kill, could feel himself getting stronger while his men seemed to be suffering from exhaustion. Only three people in the Forbidden City were capable of executing the task Jayde spoke of, and he was one of them, the other two being Jayde and the Emperor himself. The fateful words entailed the awakening of Kirari.

As if the roars and howls of the beasts were his queue, Guardian broke form and left his most prized teacher behind, knowing he had no choice to prevent all of his men from dying. These knights, monks, warriors and sharpshooters were the most skilled martial artists in the world as they had been trained by Jayde herself. If they perished, the arts would be lost to the world.

Guardian waited until he had the attention of his goddess and most admirable teacher, Jayde. He stood still on the battlefield not even fifty yards from her, and when they made eye contact, he smiled and kneeled respectfully.

Jayde returned the gesture and quickly regained her battle prowess as she knew her protégé was destined to die on this battlefield. A single tear fell from each eye as she swung the sword in her shredded dress and bloodied armor. Her devastating blows sent force from one beast to another, killing others behind it like a wave of raw energy. Jayde was no longer holding back, knowing she was now the only one on the battlefield with the servants of Gaia. She tried to understand why such a powerful and generally peaceful Mancer was still angry for something that happened so many lifetimes ago when the mountains were not yet formed.

Jayde couldn't ponder such things for long, as it was time for her to be the predator that these creatures would wish they'd never encountered.

Juno looked to the sky just outside the battlefield as she ran toward the Emperor's Temple. It was Zalomoni's most elaborate structure next to Kirari's Grand Temple in the center of the city. As soon as she thought of Kirari, the ancient protector, she remembered there were only three people able to awaken the Dragon. According to legend, he would protect Zalomoni from certain peril. This was more than the right time if anyone asked her. She sliced her way through more Spiraar as she passed citizens and members of the court being eaten alive by the giant predators.

Juno knew that Jayde had given her specific duties, and by custom and law, she was meant to follow through with them no matter what, but she couldn't help deviating from her path as a familiar voice screamed "Juno!" She signaled her men to continue to the Temple, most of which looked confused as they were to never leave her side in combat. She screamed uncharacteristically, "I said go! Protect the Emperor."

The three men gave each other a final glance before charging toward the Emperor's Temple. With longswords and spears, they applied what they had learned, moving with a hurricane of attacks toward the place where the ruler of Zalomoni was undoubtedly being protected until he reached a port rune that would take him somewhere safe.

"Nina I am coming for you, just stay alive!" Juno cried as the roars of the Spiraar and screams of dying citizens flooded the air. Juno blocked out the gut-wrenching noises as she carved her way to the prayer room. She knew that from

birth, Nina had been revered as a Mancer and Priestess of Zalomoni. Only recently had she been appointed High Priestess, but before that, she'd gone reluctantly to the outer realms of the city with Juno to prove she was more than just a pretty face with great influence.

Juno had taught her survival skills, and in turn, Nina had taught Juno something she never knew was possible, love and compassion for all life. She had just bonded with Nina and was not prepared to see her fall to these monsters. Rushing toward the prayer room, she saw a group of six women fighting with Magick and martial arts combinations clearly learned from Jayde. There were dozens of priestesses dead on the ground and even more Spiraar beside them. In the center of the room, Nina was surrounded by two dozen Spiraar, crying for the loss of life and paralyzed with guilt. "This is no time to die!" Juno yelled as she and Nina made eye contact.

Four Spiraar immediately pounced toward Juno. With the word, "Phantom," she split into four distinct versions of herself, each wielding a different weapon and dashing toward the snapping jaws of the horde. Her defiance was not wasted as they all fell with a series of slashes to their vital organs. She knew that Spiraar regenerate unlike any other Supernaturals, requiring Magickal damage in order to be killed. Reforming herself as one person again, she saw Nina cowering in the middle of the room, still crying.

"Ninala, do something goddammit!" Juno ordered her pacifist lover. As Nina stood slowly, she smiled. There were six Spiraar left, as two of her priestesses had fallen along with two more of the beasts. The others came rushing toward Nina with such blood lust, there was nothing Juno could do but watch and scream. She wasn't prepared to lose her, not now, not yet.

Standing up straight with a collected demeanor, Nina looked over to Juno as if to tell her 'it's ok.' She raised her hand to her heart and continued crying. Then she closed her eyes and whispered something under her breath. When she opened them, the beasts were but inches from her skin. She put her palm up and simply said, "Stop."

All six beasts stopped their attack at once and bowed as if she were Mother Gaia herself. Like puppies or kittens, they didn't even growl, more afraid of the golden-haired goddess than any bladed warrior in the court. Juno's heart almost stopped until she saw the display of power. Her eyes and mouth opened wide in shock as she crept forward as if not to alarm the creatures.

“Sleep,” Nina said gently. The predators not only slumbered, but transformed before everyone’s eyes into various prehistoric mammals commonly hunted for food or textiles. The Priestesses jumped in front of a hyena and an antelope, surrounding Nina protectively. “Don’t harm them,” she said, and they paused mid-attack, bowing in respect.

“I don’t know why you insist on giving me a heart attack, but we have to get out of here and get you to the Port Runes,” Juno said, trying to smile but feeling like that was much too close for her to celebrate; besides she knew what horror was facing them outside.

“I’m happy to see you too,” Nina said, “My love.”

Juno smiled and turned blushing head to the exit as she sheathed her sword and held Nina’s hand.

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Ahlina was trying not to scream as her hands trembled to the touch of the ancient Dragon. She knew that she couldn’t turn back now, as her sister would most definitely kill her if the Dragon didn’t first. The large scales were like huge shields only Mancers or Jreamers could dare to hold. She felt the rumble of the Dragon’s heartbeat like an earthquake pulsing beneath the scales. Ahlina looked up at the throbbing statue. She whispered as she placed her head on a scale near her hand, “Please help my sister. Zalomoni is in trouble. I know I’ve been selfish, and I wanted to leave, but I never will if you can save my people, I promise!”

A loud roar of a yawn filled the Temple, shaking the very foundation of the structure. Ahlina stepped back to avoid being squished by the Dragon’s sudden movement. She could see the Runes of Magick clearly for the first time in her life. They spun in a golden swarm around the scales that were rapidly shifting from stone to crystalline. The candles in the room and sunbeams peeking through the ceiling were reflecting off the scales, nearly consuming Ahlina.

She shielded her eyes as she saw the ceiling beginning to cave in around her. She didn’t know whether to run or bow as she was taught to do, but she did know

that this was her moment to redeem herself and help her people. She wasn't one of the three who were formally trained to awaken Kirari, but somehow he had listened to her prayers. "I'm sorry for waking you."

"No you are not," a surprisingly regal voice spoke back to Ahlina. Kirari's voice was deep like thunder clashing against a mountain in the distance, every syllable from the smooth tone filling her with hope. "And somehow you do not fear me, so what is it that you wish?"

As she began to speak, a large piece of the roof came crashing down from above. Even with all her martial arts training, Ahlina had no way to defend herself. She screamed and accepted her fate for disrupting Kirari's sleep, crouching low to the ground to brace for the inevitable. As a crash erupted, she jumped and squinted to see an outstretched wing blocking the rubble.

In all her years living in the Forbidden City full of gods and Witchbreed Magick, Ahlina had never seen such a majestic being. The veins in the wing were like rivers of liquid platinum, the crystalline scales on the other side almost transparent if it weren't for the light that cascaded through them. She could see the Dragon's blood flowing in many directions throughout the wing like a web of interconnected constellations. *This creature is unlike anything I have ever seen before.*

I am no creature you have ever seen before, Kirari replied telepathically.

Ahlina gasped in awe, "I'm sorry, I didn't...I didn't know you could do that."

You awakened me and said Zalomoni was in danger. I see the Spiraar are as angry as they were in the Great War. We can stop them, the Dragon answered.

Kirari's head lowered, and Ahlina could see the rippling muscles under his translucent skin. The fangs were large enough to bite through the wall that guarded the city. Then the scales before her shifted as if he was willing them to become steps.

Hurry, we don't have much time.

Ahlina scrambled to her feet and ran to climb the shimmering body. She tried her best to control her thoughts, but she couldn't help but dread what was coming. *I'm going to die. I'm going to die. I'm definitely going to die.*

You will if you don't hurry. Kirari waited another moment for Ahlina as a crystal cocoon was shaped by the scales on the back of his head. When she crawled

in, she could smell the clouds as the warm little space filled with fog and sealed itself off.

“Wait don’t lock me in here!” she cried.

Do you want to suffocate or lose your sight and hearing up in the sky? No more time to wait.

As if crashing through children’s blocks, Kirari jumped upwards, tearing through the spire of the tower and obliterating any sign that there was ever a Dragon sleeping there. The rest of the structure was so well made that it didn’t collapse on itself.

“Yep, my sister is definitely going to kill me,” Ahlina said almost as a curse on herself. *She told me not to go in that room, and look what I did. Whoa wait, we can’t leave Zalomoni. The fight is back that way—Wow it’s so pretty from up here.*

Ignoring Ahlina, Kirari soared up through the sky and above the clouds. He looked at the sun for a long moment and snarled before gracefully diving back toward the earth.

Screaming uncontrollably with excitement, Ahlina hurried to wrap her right hand in cloth before holding onto the soft meaty flesh of the Dragon that surrounded her. She could feel her adrenaline rushing, still certain that she was going to die any moment. She was one with the Dragon and could practically feel his blood coursing through hers. She felt his rage as he vowed to protect the people of Zalomoni as long as they remained peaceful.

The canyon that held Zalomoni was something Ahlina thought she’d never see from this distance. She had always wanted to leave, and her foolhardy plans were always trumped by her sister, the Mancer who had protected the city for the past few thousand years.

Your sister is Jayde!

Yes, Ahlina thought while screaming.

I see. She has kept her end of the bargain, and so must I. Let them feel my wrath. A thunderous roar filled the skies as it seemed Kirari was matching Ahlina’s wail with his own deafening crescendo of intimidation.

The City of Zalomoni was in sight and getting closer by the second. Kirari’s roar filled the entire city now, silencing the Spiraar for a brief moment in their wave of destruction. He swooped in on the city like a large bird and opened his mouth so wide, it seemed as if he were going to eat the temples. A smell of clouds filled the air, and a blinding light poured forth as bursts of white molten lava

erupted from the Dragon's mouth and enveloped the waves of Spiraar, instantly reducing them to splatters of molten ash.

Ahlina never knew this was the power of the ancient Dragons she had always lectured the children of the Monk's order about. She had thought that maybe she was exaggerating her story a bit, but nothing compared to what she was witnessing now. The wrath of something so pure was intoxicating her. For a moment, she couldn't see straight as the scales of the cocoon protected her from the blinding waves of light.

Kirari swooped over to a pack of flying Spiraar and tore apart their flesh with his enormous claws. The wingspan looked as if it could fill the canyon, his great shadow spreading fear to both sides of the battle. More waves of liquid light spewed forth, cleansing the city, but wiping away all life as well. Ahlina was both happy and terrified as she saw how many dead people littered the once serene cobblestone streets. The statues had scars from Spiraar claws digging into them as if out of blasphemy, and the once pristine temples had the same terrible marks covering their surfaces.

Ahlina found herself sobbing for her beloved home that was now nothing more than a cemetery. She'd failed to save it. She saw another wave of Spiraar rushing the city by the thousands. "Kill them. Kill every one of them!"

Kirari made a sharp turn in midair that seemed impossible for a body his size, then glided across the canyon base and back toward the wall. *I'll stop them. There is Jayde still fighting a large group of the creatures without so much as a bead of sweat on her pretty brow. But her men are all but dead. Wait there's Guardian returning to her side. He has four Jreamers left.* Ahlina was glad to see her sister and Guardian. She tried not to scream out her name, but she couldn't help it. As she spoke, it seemed as if Kirari and her were speaking aloud at the same time.

"Jayde I'm here." A thunderous announcement resounded throughout the canyon as Ahlina and Kirari flew past the battle and back to the wall. The Spiraar clawing their way up the facade were met with a smoldering death before they could roar in anguish.

The scales suddenly opened around Ahlina, who had to brace for the wind's impact so she wouldn't fly off. She lifted her right hand from the Dragon's back, tore the cloth away with her teeth and pointed at thousands more Spiraar approaching from the forest. She didn't know what she was doing, but she felt the

Dragon's breath sink into her being, and with explosive force, a second wave of light shot forth from her wrist. She was somehow mimicking the Dragon's breath, her deadly blast the color of vanilla sky with strands of pink. The Spiraar were being melted into the Earth by the hundreds, but before Ahlina could celebrate, she heard Kirari scream in pain.

The flying Spiraar had jumped from the wall and were tearing at the scales on Kirari's wings. The creatures were shifting into larger man-beasts, their only recognizable humanoid trait being the man-like arms studded with razor claws.

Ahlina felt Kirari's pain and pointed her hand at her enemies in hopes that she could remember how to harness the Dragon breath again.

Nothing happened, and Ahlina felt the wind leave her chest. As Kirari's scales were being torn apart, he flew even more rapidly, flinging many of the creatures off, but at least a dozen were still holding on.

*

Guardian saw Kirari flying over the city like a harbinger of death, every wave of the Dragon's light as blinding as a first look at the sun. The Spiraar didn't seem to be retreating as Jayde, Guardian and the last few soldiers they had left fought with a newfound vigor. Guardian wielded his large double-handed sword, Oblivion. He dashed and flipped in the air, crashing his heavy weapon down onto his foes, slicing them up and absorbing a fraction of their strength, speed or agility with every stroke. Spinning in circles, he hacked several beasts in half, their claws slashing at him until they lay still in pools of blood. Guardian stood over the carnage he had created and gasped as he watched his wounds heal almost as quickly as they had appeared.

"Ahlina is on top of Kirari. I don't know how, but she's pushing through their next wave. We have to take out this horde and secure the courtyard," Jayde said to her men. "Keep your eyes open and don't let your guard down. Melviel, behind you!"

Melviel was one of the first commanding officers and a favored student. Watching the Dragon fly over the wall in awe, he didn't see a monstrous Spiraar behind him. His quick reflexes were outmatched by the sheer speed and strength of the behemoth, whose claws pierced his armor, ripping into his back and tearing through his organs in one fell swoop. The last thing Melviel saw was the blinding light of the Dragon breath before he was tossed aside like a lifeless rag doll. His dual swords seemed to weep for him, falling to the ground dramatically slow as both Jayde and Guardian rushed the creature.

Jayde charged the lion-like Spiraar that had just killed her comrade, not a trace of fear in her eyes despite the stature of her enemy, which was now more than thirty feet tall. Sliding on the ground, she switched her blade so that it was pointed backwards, and once she was underneath the were-creature, she jumped straight up in the air with all her might, dragging the sword up its underbelly and into its snout. Guardian followed her lead, leaping into the air, diving toward the ground with his double-handed sword and splitting the monster in half.

A loud scream came from over the wall as Kirari screeched in pain. Jayde looked at Guardian, who knew in an instant to hold the position. She ran toward the wall so fast, Guardian became aware how much his teacher had been holding back during all those years training him. He smiled for a moment but turned to command his remaining soldiers. "Keep fighting!"

Once Jayde reached the wall, she smelled the disintegrated flesh of the were-creatures. Parts of the bodies that hadn't been completely engulfed by the Dragon breath were still smoking. She knew how powerful Kirari was, and she knew that he had made a promise to her, not Zalomoni. He was not going to leave her. Jayde made it to the top of the wall with ease and gazed in horror at the giant creatures on Kirari's back that were tearing away his scales and vulnerable under-flesh. Ahlina was now on the back of his head, several creatures approaching.

Kirari performed another dive-twist, shaking a few more Spiraar off his back, but he was still being attacked. He turned to fly back toward the city when he saw Jayde standing valiantly like the goddess she was in so many temples across the world. Her face was angered, and he knew that meant he should fly back to her as soon as possible. As Kirari flew with the speed of the wind, a huge tear ripped into his right crystalline wing. He was diving toward the city alright, but he had no control of his flight pattern anymore.

Ahlina felt powerless despite the victory she had achieved in stopping the waves of Spiraar, knowing she couldn't save Kirari. As they continued to plummet toward the chaos on the ground, she turned and looked over the wounded body of her friend, resolved in her only last ditch effort. *If you're going to sacrifice yourself for the city, then so am I! Open this cocoon thing Kirari.* The Dragon flesh holding her down wouldn't give way to her command.

I can't allow you to die, he said.

"It doesn't matter what you can allow me to do. Ask my sister, that doesn't work with me. I need to get these things off you. Let me go!" Ahlina was resolute as her tears flew off her cheeks before they could drip. She was never going to leave Zalomoni, but this was the moment her sister had talked about. The moment when she would have to fight for something greater than herself was upon her. She stood up as the cocoon opened slowly and was almost sucked into the air, the wind's force like a powerful vacuum. She used her training to brace herself with her feet and take full control of her body, scared out of her wits but not showing it.

Ahlina saw the feral beasts struggling against the wind as they made their way further up Kirari's back. She looked one defiantly in the eyes and pointed her arm at the approaching fangs as they opened to gnash her. *Do something! You don't ever work when I want you to!* "By the powers that be, three times three! Burst!"

A swelling from the inner part of Ahlina's forearm started to burn as Runes of Magick appeared and began to spin uncontrollably. She screamed in pain but held her ground. For a split-second, the glow of the Runes was extinguished, the Spiraar mere steps away from devouring her. Its mouth opened wide as it charged forward and swallowed a small beam of light projected from Ahlina's hand.

For a moment Ahlina thought she was already dead as the creature stopped its pursuit. The wind could have easily carried them both away were they not gripping the scales of the Dragon with all their strength. The Spiraar opened its eyes after a moment and let out a roar that almost knocked Ahlina off completely, but Kirari's under-flesh broke her fall. With wide-eyed confusion, the cat-like creature squealed, tilted its head to the side and exploded.

"Yes!" Ahlina cheered before eyeing the beast that was tearing at Kirari's wing and commanding again, "Burst!" The Runes of Magick swelled up painfully around her wrist. She held her hand in the direction of the monster while desperately trying to sit up straight in the torrential winds. A pink gas surrounded

the Spiraar, which stopped tearing at the wing to lick its paw, then fell into the air, its body crumbling into a thousand butterflies that fluttered toward the ground.

I don't think that would've been the tactic I would've chosen, but it was effective, Kirari scolded sarcastically, *there are three others.*

As soon as Kirari telepathically informed Ahlina of more Spiraar attacking his scales, he flew past the Great Wall, allowing Jayde to leap onto his back. As they descended to the Emperors Temple, Jayde confronted the beasts still ripping away at Kirari's flesh. She kicked one in the snout so hard, it was nearly decapitated as the neck was instantly broken.

As if she didn't need to balance herself on the winding path of damaged scales, she continued her attack. The next Spiraar snapped at her, but she flipped over its head and onto its back where she punched through its skull with her bare hand and squeezed, the beast's eyes rolling back as it released its grip on Kirari's under-flesh. The last enemy was near the tail, and Jayde dove toward it, striking so many times in mid-air that her target looked like it had been stung by a swarm of poisonous wasps.

Ahlina stood up and smiled, proud of her sister until Kirari's wing crashed into a tower, sending both women flying in opposite directions. The Dragon could no longer stop himself from the ultimate descent as he attempted to grab hold of the surrounding architecture, shattering it as easily as the temple he had been sleeping in.

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Juno ran steadily to the Emperor's Temple until Nina stopped in her tracks, looking up in the sky. "There's no time to sight see, Nina."

Nina slowly pointed upward. "Beautiful."

Juno looked up in the direction she was pointing to see Ahlina being flung from Kirari's back. He was already upon them, and there was nowhere to run. The huge Wyrms were destroying everything in its path. Juno knew she had only one chance to save Nina. With no other options, he used a spell. "Sylph's, I am not

worthy, but take this pure soul.” She then threw Nina into the air, leaving no time for her to object.

Feeling the force of Juno’s last attempt to keep her safe as she sailed across the sky, Nina was suddenly suspended above the city by countless hummingbird-like creatures that held her tight and fluttered their wings to prevent her descent. As Juno and her Priestesses smiled and waved to her, Kirari smashed into them, piercing the temple where the Emperor was housed. Nina cried silently over the city, her beloved protector and best friend having just perished before her eyes. Her devout followers shared the same fate as her lover.

Wavering high above the temples, Nina saw Jayde holding Ahlina’s body in her arms. Not once had she ever seen Jayde cry, but the woman sobbed nonetheless, as a mother would over a child gone too soon. Nina felt her pain from this height and couldn’t help but cry about the devastation brought by a single day. She wept for all the dead citizens, for all the fallen humans and Supernaturals alike. She sobbed for Juno and couldn’t do anything to ease the pain filling her heart. The Sylphs began to weep and lowered Nina to the top of the canyon where they disappeared into the clouds.

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Kirari took the form of a man. The muscles of his naked body were covered in scars, but he made his way to the sobs that would forever torment him. He saw Jayde crying to the point of losing control of her body and shaking with tremors. Ahlina looked as if all of her bones were broken, and Jayde was trying to set each one as if she could piece her dead sibling back together. The almond eyes were permanently closed, and her pale skin was bruised all over.

Jayde didn’t stop Kirari’s hand from touching her shoulder. “I should have let her go. I failed her.”

“You didn’t fail her. She was one of the bravest souls I’ve ever known. You taught her well. She was prepared to die just like you were.” Kirari’s smooth voice soothed Jayde only momentarily.

Her sobs took hold of Kirari’s heart. He looked at her for a long moment. The moon was full overhead, and the assault on Zalomoni had all but diminished. Kirari looked around, and with no audience, he whispered into Jayde’s ear, “If I give you some of my essence, I will not be able to keep this form. You must take me into you, and we will be able to revive your sister.”

Jayde looked up at Kirari for the first time. “You would give up your immortality for Ahlina?”

“I already have.” He gently placed a crystalline jewel in Jayde’s hand and told her, “You know what to do. But I must warn you. If I am awakened, I will only know wrath, for this is my love for you. You will not recognize me again.”

Before Jayde could object, Kirari spun into a tornado of crystal dust and reflective lights. As the dust surrounded her, a chill seized her that felt as cold as the moon. She closed her eyes, and when she awoke from what must have been a slumber, her sister Ahlina was all but dust in her lap.

Jayde cried again but looked at her hand and saw the crystal jewel. She tried to smile but could not form the simple expression. She stood up and walked out of Zalomoni, not to return for millions of years.

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(Present Day)

“That was so sad,” Maia said as she regained her focus from the Glamour spell and came back to the present, watching as Nina silently held Juno. “Oh I’m sorry; I’ll go find Gemini or something,” she said awkwardly.

Neither woman said anything to Maia as they stared into each other’s eyes. Maia tip-toed out of the room and turned the corner to see where the attack on Zalomoni had happened. The ruins were almost in the exact shape as they had been the day of the attack, only now covered in dust and ivy.

With a sigh and shaking her head to stay focused on the present, she whispered, “Kirari’s wrath.”

Chapter 25

New Assignment

It had been eighteen days since the incident in Union Square, and Guardian's memory of everything that had happened that day was still fuzzy. Even Psiel Agents classified him with the same delusional symptoms that over sixty people had suffered from since the night of the ambush on Surge-Overload. Apparently a Supernatural with a high level of psychological influence had led a small mob of people, including several OZONE agents and soldiers, causing a riot that ended in explosions and looting.

Guardian was briefed on his current condition, which felt like a hangover from hell. He didn't know why they wouldn't just let him sleep at his crappy apartment, instead insisting that he take residence in the Underbase until further notice. He had been drawn into a psychological wormhole of memories that caused him to jump off a fourth story balcony into an alleyway dumpster.

I must be delusional. I could have sworn I saw my niece, Cindy. No, that's exactly who I saw. She was with that woman, Nina from the Juno files. I wonder if the Psiel were able to see that memory?

"Agent Guardian, I'm glad you're awake. I'm Agent Zeer."

"I know who you are," Guardian said groggily as he sat up, ready to leave the room until he realized he was in a hospital gown.

"Please do take it easy. You almost died from the impact of the jump. Thank goodness you were in the dumpster when the C-4 went off because otherwise, you might be in the same shape as Narles." Agent Zeer was so polite, it almost seemed as if he were using his psychic abilities to gain his trust.

Guardian knew better. He was trained in many arts of persuasion; espionage and subterfuge were definitely his strong suits. He could hide his emotions from someone as easily as drinking a beer. He knew that with agents such as himself on the map, others could rarely be trusted, especially the Psiel. Zeer was one of the most elite interrogation officers in the world, using a combination of mentalist and telepathic techniques in torture. However, he had never known him to retrieve any information from a sleeping victim.

"I suppose you are wondering if I read your mind when you were asleep," Zeer said, his coy smile turning to a cautious smirk as Guardian slowly looked him

up and down as if he might tear the bones from the officer's thin frame. Retrieving his confidence once more, Zeer straightened his already immaculate black hair and walked over to a supply cabinet. As he pulled a drawer open slowly, he spoke with Guardian behind him still sitting on the bed.

"I apologize for the delay and the tests, but you know protocol, Guardian. We needed to find out what happened that night." He turned around with Guardian's combat-ready clothes, leaving them on the edge of the bed so as not to get too close to the assassin.

"So what happened?" Guardian asked as he stood up and took the gown off, not shy or embarrassed that another man was in the room as he dressed.

Zeer did not turn away, instead focused on every muscle on Guardian's body. This was an OZONE Agent, a perfect specimen. He looked like he was ready to run a decathlon before posing for a men's fitness magazine. He was definitely American, and as the model agent continued to dress, Zeer struggled to remember the question. "It's classified. I know that doesn't override your status. Basically, Narles failed to capture Surge-Overload and instead shot the wrong man, one of our own, a Technopath. Shot him fourteen times to be exact, killing the him and breaking 'the binding circle,' as they called it, where Surge-Overload was being locked in until one of you snipers made the shot." Zeer took note of the strange markings and tattoos that must have covered at least twenty percent of Guardian's body.

As Zeer talked, Guardian listened carefully while buckling every buckle and trying his best to seem preoccupied with his gears. Guardian knew what happened next, but he pretended to be on the edge of his seat in anticipation with the report. Not doing too much to alert the Agent, but simply to milk him for information in a reverse interrogation.

This was the longest conversation Zeer had ever had with Agent Guardian, the most polished and elite of OZONE's assassins. "Surge-Overload was believed to be identified."

Guardian looked up at him with a questioning expression. "Who is he?"

"He is a she. And, well, her face is unidentified as Surge killed every Technomage connected to the web in the binding circle."

"How?"

"She somehow made their computers melt and explode, which killed them all instantly." Zeer no longer smiled. His pale skin and thin Dutch frame was a

definite contrast to the large man looking at him, but he didn't flinch as he continued. "Narles made a mistake and started aiming his gun at everyone, including the trillionaire heiress, Sky, and other pedestrians in the busy shopping center." Zeer's voice was cool and collected as he straightened his black suit. He was already bored of this story. It had nothing to do with torture, so he sped it up and condensed the details.

Guardian looked puzzled as Zeer explained that he was under some sort of mind control by a powerful empath. This same power had caused a mob of random San Francisco citizens with no prior records of violence to tear at the flesh of their own Agent Narles before detonating a bomb.

Zeer tried to wrap up his story, "You were under some sort of mind control as you turned your rifle on other soldiers and some Vampyl that were perched on the rooftops in the shadows...before you went dumpster-diving. A dozen of our best agents died that day."

Guardian now understood what he had meant about the C-4. He almost regretted the next question before he asked it, but he asked anyway, "What happened to Surge-Overload?"

"She got away."

Trying not to let out a single sigh or allow his heart to change pace, Guardian turned to look for his boots.

A moment later, Zeer opened a nearby foot locker and came forward. He was strong for his size, but nevertheless he gave a slight grunt as he dropped the heavy black leather and metallic armory boots into Guardian's hands. Zeer enjoyed torturing people, displaying them in strange contraptions and suspension devices when they were near death. In their moments of pain and exhaustion, they always let their surface-level thoughts spill forth, providing any information he might wish to know. "The most peculiar thing is that we could not get a proper facial identification of the girl from you, the remaining Soldiers, Agent Grin nor that failure, Narles."

"Narles is alive?" Guardian asked as he slipped his boots on, "But I thought you said..."

"Yes, when the C-4 was detonated, he was under a pile of people attacking him, all of whom acted as a meat shield and stopped most of the damage."

"What do you mean *most of the damage*?" Guardian's green eyes met the dark grey eyes of the Psiel.

“I mean, he lost all of his limbs and suffered from internal bleeding and organ failure, but he’s currently in one of Braintech’s conceptual labs awaiting another inevitable surgery. Strangely enough, he’s already undergone over a dozen surgeries, and he’s still alive. Isn’t that miraculous?” Zeer’s face was painted with a renewed smile as if he were observing Narles’ pain that very moment.

Guardian noticed the expression change, and as he strapped up the second boot, he stood up straight, too fast, the headache returning with the nauseating pressure behind his temples. He placed a hand on the bed to steady himself. He knew never to trust a Psel; they always gave him a bad taste in his mouth, speaking from some self-righteous place, but dripping with the slime of hypocrisy. He knew Zeer was watching him and quickly regained his composure as he started towards the door. The agent stood in Guardian’s immediate path, and he didn’t want to hurt him, but he was prepared to remove this creep if he didn’t step aside.

“You might want to stay close as the Commander in Chief—” Zeer politely moved out of the way just as Guardian was about to bump into him.

“—Is already here, and he has the next mission for you, Guardian. Your weapons are in the car. I’ll brief you on the way.”

The Commander in Chief was a tall brooding man with an iron jaw that seemed permanently clinched from talking down to his men. He was burly with blond hair and a well-kempt beard. He towered over Guardian as he walked down the hall beside him with just as much, if not more, confidence.

Guardian knew that he could not refuse a request from his superior, no matter the cost or difficulty.

“I know you didn’t kill Surge-Overload, but just to let you know, Deme-god the Technomage did!” The Commander in Chief didn’t seem to notice that the news hit Guardian like a punch in the stomach. “It was actually quite brilliant, though I’d never tell him that. He tracked her down in Japan where our soldiers infiltrated and destroyed the entire compound.” The Commander displayed a sense of pride and certainty as he continued his briefing, all while Guardian was struggling to keep track of the conversation that now seemed like a disorienting blur of exchanges.

The floor slightly spun in vertigo, and the lights seemed to make the long hall extremely narrow. He knew he was going to be sick, but instead of reacting, he looked forward and didn’t say a word. His sinking lack of hope for humanity was all he could hear with each heavy step burdening his soul. He had failed his niece

in not providing her the peaceful world she so deserved. He wanted to grab the gun from the holster under the Commander's arm and go out in a blaze of glory, but he continued to walk beside the leader with no dramatics.

"We'll cover it up and say it's bio warfare, but you and I know better. And that's why I need you to go in and remove the Dehmn threat in Syria tonight. The Media Agents will guide the populace with a commotion about voting while you charge in unnoticed with the Sweeper Team. Am I clear?" The Commander waited for the consent he expected.

"Yes, Sir," Guardian spoke without completely understanding the nature of his mission, but he was sure he'd be briefed again along the way.

The Commander nodded as they continued their walk at a calm but steady pace. "Redeem yourself and kill them all."

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"I want to kill them all!" Sky said, utterly annoyed at the men in black suits who followed her around at all times.

"I understand you have been through a lot, Bunny, and you don't want your privacy invaded, but we can't lose you again." Her father spoke with such calm love that he almost made Sky forget what she was angry about.

"I'm not mad at you, Daddums, but I'm pissed as hell at these guys who burst into my room randomly whenever I drop my phone or a pencil or whatever."

"I understand and so does your mother." Mr. Bradford walked over to his daughter and gave her a kiss on the forehead as she pouted. "If they give you any more trouble, then I'll hire a new security detail, but get used to bodyguards, end of story."

"But Daddums..."

"No buts, just trust me."

Sky stood up and stormed out of her father's den. The leather chair didn't make a sound as her body seemed to involuntarily rise to its feet with no physical effort, defying gravity itself, but she was too preoccupied with her frustration to

notice. Her long legs strode gracefully out of the room, her micro-mini pleated skirt billowing around her as if it were alive. When she walked into the hallway, she saw another bodyguard standing against the wall in an expensive suit, looking neat yet uncomfortable. She sighed and walked up the stairs as quickly as she could. She stepped into her room, and the auto-hinges of the new poly-fiber synthetic smart door prevented it making a loud noise as she slammed it shut. “Ugh,” she said aloud, her last expression of rage diffused.

“Did I miss something, or did I miss out on your door slamming effort?” A sleazy voice pricked the back of Sky’s neck like a leech.

Taken off guard in her own room, she turned and said, “Eww! What are you doing in here? And stop looking at me like that!”

“No need to get upset, little lady,” Grin walked closer and reached his hand to touch her thigh.

“Don’t you dare touch me!” Sky demanded with her nostrils flaring.

“Such a pretty face, you wouldn’t want to ruin it with all that anger. I can overheard you screaming about how people are treating you differently at school and how your spoiled ass should be walking around so anyone can just kidnap you again.” Grin gave a foul smile with the teeth that were broken and yellow from years of tobacco use and probably bar fights.

“Don’t talk to me like that. You don’t know me,” Sky said.

“I don’t. I don’t know that your birthday is in a few days. Your favorite color is purple. Your favorite scent is jasmine, and you love those claw-foot bathtubs.”

“Google.” Sky squinted.

“I don’t know that you like Egyptian cotton sheets. You have a holographic assistant modeled after a girl at school you wouldn’t be caught dead talking to because your Mum would get mad... Am I getting close?”

“Gross, you’re a stalker!” Sky screeched.

“I’m worse than a stalker, little girl. I know you’re a Mancer! It’s only a matter of time before I pluck that beautiful little memory from your beautiful little head.” His slick brown hair smelled of cheap gel and grease from the pharmacy. His breath reeked of cigarettes, matching his wrinkled suit that wasn’t like the dapper attire of the other body guards. His very essence screamed predator and killer.

He made her sick to her stomach, a feeling she'd never received from a person's presence before. "DAD!"

"No need to shout, girl, you'll give me what I want sooner or later." Grin licked his lips with a thick coating of saliva that lingered about his mouth in a glossy wet film.

"You work for my Dad," Sky said, "and I forbid you to take another step. If you do, so help me, I'll..."

"You'll what? Scream for Blue like you do in your sleep?" His phlegmy laugh made her recoil until she hit the edge of her bed, sitting down unceremoniously.

"Stay away from me, you creep."

The moment Grin took another step, the door opened and Sky's father walked into the room frantically looking around as if he were coming to save her life.

"I can make your poor little Dad see what I want him to see. Just a quick lesson on how scary I really am. I'm a Psiel. That means all your little secrets? I can see them as clearly as you do, sometimes even better, because I'm in your head." Grin laughed so loud Sky started to cry.

"Bunny, are you ok?" Sky's father looked down at her. The room was suddenly filled with shadow. "Were you having a bad dream?"

Sky woke up to see her Jewish father sitting on her bed with her African mother behind him, both looking concerned. She hugged him with all her might and began to cry as her mother came closer to give her a hug. She finally felt warm, loved. Her eyes closed, but then she heard a phlegmy laugh that made chills run down her spine. The smell of cigarettes entered through the doorway as Sky opened her eyes, though she didn't want to. She could suddenly see in every direction at once, noticing every nook and cranny of her room in vivid detail. Her mother and father were standing by her bed as if they were frozen statues.

As Sky looked up, she saw her parent's happy faces, paralyzed and dull. In a panic she yelped "Mum! Daddums?"

"No worries, little girl! They'll be just fine. I just wanted to let you know that your little dream was no dream at all." Grin smiled the same disgusting grimace. "I will find out how you know Blue and what you were doing those weeks you were away with him. And guess what, your rich little parents are

powerless against me. Try to tell them, and I'll rip their minds apart so much, you'll pray for the days you were able to speak to them!"

"What do you want? Leave them alone!" Sky screamed.

"What do you mean, Bunny?" her father asked cautiously. "It's just your mother and I."

"I told you she needed a therapist," Sky's mother said with her customary elegance. It was almost as if she no longer empathized with her daughter, but only pitied her.

Sky frantically looked around the room for the smoking villain. He was nowhere in sight, and she realized she must look like a total psychopath. "I'm so sorry; I must have had a nightmare," she said, lying to mask the true fear she felt in her heart.

"No worries, Bunny. No one can hurt you." Her father pointed at the door. "Look we have a guard right outside your door."

At that moment, a wrinkled suit walked into the dim light, and Sky knew exactly who it was. She tried not to make any quick movements as she turned her head back to her parents saying, "Is it really necessary?"

"Until we find those responsible for your kidnapping, yes. The bodyguards are here to stay, so get used to it," Mr. Bradford said with authority as he kissed her forehead and walked out the door with her mother.

Grin smiled like a predator as he closed the door.

Sky sobbed, feeling like a prisoner in her own home for the first time.

*

Guardian began to breathe steadily in and out as if he were meditating, transporting himself to a peaceful spring day. He knew that, like every other mission, this one could be his last. When he closed his eyes, all he could see was the boy in the forest pleading for him not to shoot. His eyelids flipped open as soon as he saw the bullet enter the back of Isja's skull, a memory he just couldn't shake. Guardian was disgusted with what he'd done a few weeks earlier and had

questioned every mission since. This one was no different; he knew it was pure evil on the other side of this door, but he still doubted that what he was doing was right.

His firearms were, of course, custom-made according to his own, like mere extensions of his own body. With his heart racing, he placed both weapons to his lips and kissed them, then kicked the door down with such force, whoever was on the other side would've preferred to die on impact rather than face the wrath he was about to unleash.

Instantly, Guardian's mind was clear of anything but his mission. He knew this was a den of the Dehmn, which meant he would see unspeakable things, but he pushed forward anyway, using the skill that would help him complete this task, his deadly accuracy. There was a team of eight men and women awaiting Guardian's call to sweep the building, so he only had a total of two hundred and forty seconds before they would automatically storm in after him.

He had known for a while now that he was different, stronger and faster than the average Agent, even without his Braintech armor. His skills were only enhanced with every mission completed. With every kill, a small glyph burned its way onto or under his skin, as if he absorbed a part of each Supernatural target into himself, snowballing into something monstrous. This was no time to wonder about such things as he gracefully jogged around the dilapidated biohazard of a structure, making sure to track his path through the facility. He passed countless prisoners ravaged by drugs, chemicals, disease and other forms of Dehmn influence. When he identified them as a threat, he fired two shots into the heads of his first targets.

There were victims among the hostiles, but most were so far gone that it was no use saving them, so Guardian continued his trek. His hyper-speed guided him to the third floor of the building, shooting two dozen gun-carrying thugs along the way. His armored suit sustained bullet holes, but the outdated projectiles did little damage. He dodged hundreds of stray bullets as he pierced the skulls of another six tainted men, their eyes blood-shot from years of biochemical abuse, their skin bubbling with sores. This place was definitely going down one way or another.

He finally made it to the top floor, using laser-like precision to mow down all enemies in his path. He wasn't known as OZONE's deadliest agent for no reason. With training as both a covert operative and an executioner, Guardian was no rookie when it came to combat. With devastating kicks, he incapacitated two enemies guarding the final door and reloaded. One hundred twenty seconds and

counting; his compact clips could hold ninety four miniature rounds of lethal caliber. He ignored the gore in his wake, knowing these were the men and women responsible for releasing airborne toxins that, if left in the wrong hands, could annihilate an entire country.

Knocking the dead pair of foes through the door, Guardian saw a man standing in the center of the room with a suitcase in his hand. The man's skin was grey and his features smooth in contrast to the blood-soaked bodies of his comrades. Guardian aimed both of his weapons at the unarmed man and simultaneously performed an inspection, sensing that he was definitely Dehmn, or at least tainted with Dehmn blood like the Vampyl.

This was the main objective. Guardian had been briefed. This individual's name was Scag, the undying. He was an immortal who had been completely surrounded by the enemy on more than one occasion and always survived, unlike many other OZONE operatives. He'd never faced Guardian, and it was going to be the first and final meeting for one of them.

"Those petty things won't kill me," the grey man said, "But I'm sure you know that. He laughed as he straightened his buttoned silk shirt and clean slacks that stood out among the battle-weathered surroundings.

"Touch that briefcase, and I will shoot," Guardian said coldly. Two hundred seconds and counting. He was running out of time, and he didn't plan on having a long conversation with this target. In a way he was hoping the tall man would do what he knew was coming next.

Reaching down to grab the briefcase, Scag smiled and placed his hands on the cold platinum. His eyes widened with disbelief and utter shock as he watched his own hand waving back at him before it landed on the floor with a splatter of blood. The sharp pain was followed with a second shot that pierced the same arm above the wrist. Scag could only stare in horror as his bluish blood gushed from his wounds, sizzling and turning a bright red as it made contact with the dusty floor.

"What in the name of the abyss are you?!" Scag cried, his once arrogant visage now scarred with hatred and anger.

Guardian spoke in a chilly voice that could have ended lives as effectively as his firearms did. "Your end."

Looking deeper at his enemy, Scag saw the Runes of Magick swirling in and around his attacker. "A Jreamer! OZONE sent a Jreamer to hunt me! Sniveling bastards double-cross me because I won't give them my weapon. Nothing will stop

me!” Scag ran towards Guardian with blinding speed, his dirty nails quickly growing into talons strong enough to tear through the agent’s armor.

This was Guardian’s first and only injury sustained during the mission. Two hundred ten seconds and counting. Time was up. This had to be quick; he felt the acute sting of poison in his blood as he cartwheeled while shooting a hole in the chest of his target, who seemed to be growing in size. More bullets ripped through the silk-clad torso until a bloody mess of entrails spewed from the undying man. The sweeper team would be burning this building down in ten seconds.

Standing over the mortally wounded Supernatural, Guardian pointed the gun at his head.

“Even if you can kill me, it’s been five thousand years. I’m tired of this place anyway,” Scag gurgled, struggling to breathe, “You just wait until OZONE betrays you. It’ll hurt worse than any wound you can give me!” Scag cursed as he spat the words, making one final effort to attack with his right hand.

Guardian shot the hand off, then looked over the inhuman target. “They already have. That’s why I’m here.” Shooting three shots into the monster’s head, he didn’t miss a beat as he ran and grabbed the briefcase before diving toward the window.

The sweeper team below checked the time on the heads-up display of their Braintech helmets. They heard the gunshots and explosions from inside but were ordered not to enter the building until either Guardian gave a direct order or the clock struck two hundred and forty seconds. The eight Soldiers weren’t used to being accompanied by an elite class Agent like Guardian and most dreaded missions like this, knowing that they were all expendable and someone was more than likely going to die. The clock was at two hundred and thirty-nine seconds when a crash from the top floor halted their steps. It was Guardian diving toward the ground with a suitcase in his hands.

All of the soldiers knew that even the most advanced Braintech armor can only absorb so much damage. At that height, Guardian was plummeting toward certain death. They scrambled to help break his fall, abandoning their formation and running toward the building, but there was no way for them to reach him in time. A few soldiers stopped to watch the end of the legendary Guardian.

Rapidly approaching the ground as if gravity were forcing him to kiss the earth goodbye, Guardian knew better. He twisted mid-air and landed on his feet with such a crushing force that the concrete beneath him crackled and crunched

like egg shells. Multiple explosives detonated inside the building all at once, the facade behind him falling the moment he landed, as if his meeting with the ground was the cue for the structure's demise.

As if looking at a god or a hero out of some comic book, the soldiers stood still in awe, watching as the lead agent trudged through the smoke, ash and rubble like the grim reaper himself. His intimidating presence was something they were all glad to have on their side. He walked slowly and methodically up to them with the suitcase in hand.

Throwing the item at one of the soldiers, he flashed an approving look and continued his walk to the airship. He tried not to stop mid-step; his chest felt like it was on fire, and his stomach burned from the inside out. He coughed into his gloved hand, and blood filled his palm. Only one soldier saw. She wondered if the unstoppable Guardian was actually just a man after all.

The entire trip from Syria back to the U.S.A. was quiet. The soldiers had nothing to say in the presence of the elite agent. He had singlehandedly wiped out a terrorist organization that had been on the radar for months. Without knowing the full layout of the building, he had found the suitcase containing the bio-weapon of recent news and finished with a spectacular stunt dive, landing like a hero while destroying any evidence that the facility had ever existed.

When Guardian walked out of the airship, he was not expecting to be greeted with applause. Even the Commander in Chief was standing on the dock, clapping proudly. This was not what he wanted to see. His lungs felt like they were being boiled, and he had been fighting the urge to cough up more blood for the past eleven hours. He did, however, appreciate the mission, as it reminded him of his early days with OZONE. He just wished he could shake the feeling of betrayal that came with his first step onto the dock of the Underbase, the deception Scag had spoken of.

Without giving Guardian a chance to say a word, the Commander spoke, "We have your next mission prepared."

He could barely believe his ears. Had he just survived a near-suicide mission only to be sent on assignment again? His eyes must have given away his disdain as the Commander followed up his statement with details.

"You are to take it easy and become a bodyguard."

Great. They're gonna have me babysit a fat adulterous politician or some other royal pain in the ass. This is bullshit! Can't I get time to breathe? I want to

vomit all over his shiny shoes, but I have to control my willpower to continue walking at all. What did that undying fuck do to me? So much for the bastard being immortal. But I did absorb something dark from him. I just want to figure all this out. What's happening to me? They killed my niece, there's no one to trust and I'll never forgive them.

"Your priority as a bodyguard is Sky Bradford," the Commander said, "I'm sure you know who she is, but formality states—"

"You gotta be fucking kidding me?!" Guardian said insubordinately. Realizing who he was speaking to, he quickly added, "Sir."

"I'll excuse that this time, and no I'm not kidding. This is your next assignment until further orders. Am I clear?"

"But sir, this sort of thing is usually punishment for failure..."

"It's the call of duty! You may have completed your mission, but you know as well as I do that your orders are to be taken as seriously as they were in Syria. Am I clear?" The Commander stared down at his agent with the scolding eyes of a father.

"Yes, Sir," Guardian said as he squinted in pain both from the orders themselves and the poison coursing through his veins. Beads of sweat dripped from his brow onto the ground.

"You don't look so good," the Commander said as he called for the medical team.

Guardian nearly collapsed into a medic with his heavy armor, nearly scaring the frail woman. She checked his pulse and eyes. "He's poisoned," she said.

"Fix him, and put him back on assignment," the Commander said before walking away with a triumphant smile.

AENJELS AND ORPHANS

“I’m so sorry for your loss, Lisa. If there’s anything I can do for you, please let me know,” Orchid Bradford spoke sincerely to her dear friend in the parlor of the multi-million-dollar mansion.

“I didn’t know who else to call. I mean, I sent her to the same camp where we met.” Lisa was an OZONE Agent who usually didn’t allow herself to become so defeated.

“When did you hear that Cindy passed away?” Orchid took a seat on a couch that appraised for more than most people’s yearly wage. She crossed her smooth brown legs comfortably, accustomed to a life of glamour and luxury. She was the heiress to the largest diamond mines in Africa and wife to arguably the most powerful man in the world, Samuel Bradford. She hadn’t talked to her friend Lisa in some time, but when she saw who was calling, she had to answer. They both had daughters, and she would be devastated if anything ever happened to her own.

“Shortly after I heard your daughter was returned home.” Lisa’s sob was infectious. “I’m happy for Sky’s return.”

Orchid’s eyes began to tear up as she thought about her own daughter’s recent abduction. She didn’t know what to say to comfort Lisa. The pain of her loss was too similar. She’d been crying for days on end in Sky’s absence, but could never tell anyone of her sorrow. They both were a part of an organization that was as old as religion itself, the DOLLS, which stood for ‘Daughters of Lilith’s Last Scorn,’ a secret society of beautiful women who controlled and influenced the world. These elite femme fatales were trained to be the next wave of wives and mistresses to the most powerful men and women.

“I haven’t called you in so long, and again, I apologize. It’s just that I saw so much potential in my daughter. Rainbow told me she was sick and sent her home. I just never thought...” Lisa cleared her throat as she gained her composure, realizing the uncomfortable silence coming from the other end. She knew the oath she’d taken to avoid emotional attachment to her family, as the DOLLS were her first priority, but she couldn’t help feeling like the mourning mother she was.

After taking a deep breath, Orchid spoke in her regal tone. “You know as well as I do that our family is all but inconsequential. You need to have another child and keep Reynolds in line.”

“I know,” Lisa said sadly. She thought about how her husband was going to take the news.

“You haven’t told him have you?” Orchid asked with a moment of realization, noticing a shift in Lisa’s tone.

Lisa began to sob uncontrollably.

“Get your nerves in check, girl,” Orchid commanded. “When you married Reynolds, you knew you’d have to be strong. He can never know your true allegiance!”

“Yes, thank you for helping me remember that.” Lisa wiped away her tears.

“Just remember the mission at hand. I’ll see you at the masquerade ball in Paris.”

“I’ll see you there.” Lisa knew she had to listen to her instincts. One of the most powerful DOLLS was telling her to refocus. She regained some semblance of composure and uttered the customary goodbye: “By the mirror.”

“Your pain is mine,” Orchid answered before hanging up the phone. She looked out the window, and another tear fell from her eye. “I’m so thankful to have Sky back.”

Lisa hung up, knowing that her upcoming mission involved the transport of a young girl to the orphanage. She straightened her pencil skirt and blouse. Reaching in her purse, she felt her small OZONE-issued handgun and grabbed the tube that was next to it, applying a new coat of red lipstick while attempting to calm herself. *I’m part of two secret societies and trying to deal with the loss of my only daughter. No one is supposed to feel this torn. Have another kid, she says. As if I wouldn’t if I could. After Cindy, it’s impossible. Reynolds will be so hurt when he reads the report about the explosion.*

After a long sigh, Lisa stood with her head high. Her classic beauty was one thing she used to her advantage, but she was cunning and intelligent as well. She’d been sent to eliminate high-priority targets based on OZONE’s orders and also investigate paranormal activities, but to the outside world, she was just a house wife with a rocket scientist husband. This current mission had required her to assume the identity of a nurse who was empathetic to the loss of a child’s life. The mission was too close to home in her eyes, and she looked at herself in the mirror

to force her tears back to the abyss they had come from. She had watched a girl the same age as Cindy give birth to a beautiful baby boy who was promptly swapped with another child and taken by OZONE agents who assigned him to a family that Lisa thought was unfit, but as usual, she didn't ask questions.

She remembered walking down the hall of the delivery ward toward a particular room, painting a smile so natural on her face that no one could tell she was in pain underneath. She remembered the thin young girl rocking back and forth on the bed with her shoes and clothes on.

"Are you ready to go, Aiel?"

The girl had looked up at the nice smile of the nurse who was volunteering to take her to the new Orphanage. "Yes, but why can't I see my baby?"

"We've been over this, Aiel. I'm truly sorry for your loss. I can only imagine..." In that moment Lisa could not control her emotions, and she teared up heavily.

The pain was so evident that Aiel had jumped from the bed to comfort her own nurse. "You've lost a child, haven't you?"

Lisa had opened her eyes in shock as the girl hugged her. "Yes. Yes, I have." Aiel clasped her hand for a long moment.

"I don't know how to explain it," Aiel said, "but somehow I know my baby is still alive."

Lisa was silent, unable to look the mother in the eye.

"I'm ready to go now," she had said, reluctantly releasing her grip.

Lisa remembered the feeling. It had felt good to hug someone.

*

Ssiah hugged her knees in the backseat of the car on the way to the church as an orphan once again. Her biological mother and father had died when she was just a baby. She'd grown up in the system knowing that children were much like animals in a pet shop: some were picked, and others were lost. The woman who was supposed to adopt her had miraculously conceived a child, after Ssiah had thought she'd finally have a home after filling out all that paperwork. The woman

knew there would be the possibility of complications and had wanted to adopt, but at the last minute, she had called the social worker to tell her she could not go through with it. They had a healthy new baby boy named Isja. So just as before, Ssiah's hope for adopted parents was unrealized, and she was sent to yet another orphanage.

Ssiah was a charming little girl with hazel green eyes and lovely golden locks that made her look almost angelic. She'd been told that she was an angel by many, but none knew her secret. Ssiah had been able to speak to the Aenjelhn, which humans call angels, since the day she was born. They'd played with her in the crib and protected her from danger.

Always feeling safe, but never feeling like she was part of any home, Ssiah repeatedly asked why all this was happening to her. The Aenjelhn never answered with what she wanted to hear, but told her it was all part of a divine plan. This time after feeling hopeless, she refused to feel so defeated and smiled at the possibility that maybe one day she might meet her twin brother who had been separated from her following the death of their parents. "Is there a reason I am being sent to this church instead of the old home?" She seemed to sing the words to the Aenjelhn who sat next to her in the backseat.

The Aenjelhn was a large man who looked too perfect to be human. He appeared cheerful, though he was actually far from it. His ability to make Ssiah smile was waning today, so deep was her disappointment. He could not disclose what he knew without compromising his mission, so he simply replied, "You will meet new friends here."

Ssiah looked out the window. "You said that I would. Are they nice?"

The Aenjelhn nodded. His short black hair was something Ssiah always felt compelled to touch. He knew his appearance was appealing to her senses, as it was similar to that of her brother, and he kept the illusion up. Ssiah would soon learn her destiny and, with his help, live long enough to fulfill it. Her protection was his only mission, and he was not going to fail her.

The car stopped, and Ssiah looked at the church, suddenly filled with a sense of dread. "What is this place, Cassiel?"

"I will protect you," he said.

"You always do, but you haven't answered me! What is this place?" Ssiah pulled on the Aenjelhn's custom-tailored purple suit. She held his warm hand as she took in her unfamiliar surroundings.

“It’s a tomb,” Cassiel replied flatly.

The car door opened, and the driver who’d been listening to this girl talk to herself shook his head in pity. He smiled at the pretty face of the nine-year-old and couldn’t help thinking she looked like an angel. “I’m sure the nuns will take good care of you here,” he said, moving toward Ssiah. Flinching as if he were going to hurt her, Ssiah hid behind Cassiel.

“It’s ok, little lady, I’m not going to hurt you.” The man seemed kind enough.

“He won’t harm you,” Cassiel said warmly as he looked to the dark stone of the Edwardian-looking architecture before them. His bronze ring began to glow.

“Your ring,” Ssiah said.

“Oh yes,” the driver said, proudly displaying his wedding ring, “my wife gave this to me, God rest her soul.”

Ssiah didn’t say another word, feeling awkward. She didn’t like speaking to Aenjels when humans were present if she could help it. Cassiel had always told her that she was a Wicasht, that other people couldn’t see the things she could. She had tried her best to explain her experiences to others on many occasions, but no one ever understood her. She smiled at the driver and returned her gaze to Cassiel’s ring. *When his ring glows, a Supernatural is present. Maybe he’s right. Maybe I will finally make friends here.*

At that very moment, a luxury SUV pulled into the cobblestone driveway of the church and parked behind the taxi. The dust began to settle, and the doors opened as Cassiel’s ring lit up like a beacon. Ssiah and the Aenjelhn watched the SUV with suspicion.

A door opened, and Aiel stepped out into the chilly Bay Area breeze. Her quiet trip with Lisa had been quite nice. They had listened to music that she liked, which had made her smile for the first time in what seemed like forever, since her baby had passed away. When Aiel noticed the other young girl and her driver, a ray of sun broke through the clouds, and for a moment she could see the shape of a third person who was present, a tall well-dressed man. In an instant, the sun was blocked by the shadow of a cloud, and the man disappeared altogether, causing Aiel to shudder. It would be better if she didn’t tell anyone about whatever she just saw. The thirteen-year-old was not amused that she had been sent to yet another church to be ridiculed and teased, but she had no choice until she was old enough

to leave the system. “In five years, I’ll be able to get my own place and live on my own. Right, Lisa?”

“If not sooner, so don’t lose faith. But I’m sure someone will adopt you,” Lisa said smiling.

“Yeah, right. No one wants a kid like me. I’m not stupid enough to forget that.”

Lisa had no answer for her as she walked to the front steps of the church with her small bags. “Well, here we are.”

Aiel tried not to cry. She would love to go home with Lisa, but she didn’t know how to ask, so she didn’t mention it. “Will you come visit me?”

“Of course I will. I don’t live too far from here,” Lisa said, cheerful at the thought of checking on Aiel.

She gave Lisa another hug, burying her face in the soft white blouse and smiling. Then she turned as the unfamiliar voice of a man made her skin crawl.

“I am Father Bell.” This older gentleman had a wrinkly face and a strangely sinister tone of voice.

Lisa knew a villain when she saw one. She quickly assessed that this was an OZONE operative of a level she must not have been aware of. No wonder they wanted the girl here. “Hello, I’m Lisa, this is Aiel—” The man was impatient.

“—I know who you are. Girl, you run along and allow the nuns to show you the quarters.” The priest had a certain rudeness about him, his behavior changing drastically with every second. He was visibly repulsed by the little golden-haired child as she stood next to the black car, his gaze filled with inexplicable hatred.

The driver noticed his change in tone as he unfolded the documents in his hands. “This is Ssiah...”

“What is she doing here?” The priest demanded uncomfortably.

“Well Sir, this is where I was told to drop her off. She’s an orphan.”

“No matter... nuns! Show them to their quarters.”

The nuns rushed out of the church, looking worn out, as if the life had been sucked out of their once youthful bones. “Come with us,” they said.

The priest didn’t bother with formalities or goodbyes as he hurried away. Aiel looked back at Lisa in unprecedented horror as a nun took her by the arm.

Lisa saw the dread, but could do nothing to calm her other than call loud enough for the nuns to hear, “I’ll be back to check on you.” *I’ll make it my duty to*

check on Aiel and Isja. I don't know what mess they have been thrown into, but it's definitely out of their control.

With that bit of hope, Aiel smiled, but the smile was short lived as she was ushered into the church. "Up the stairs," the nun said.

When they reached the top, the nun barked at one of her inferiors. "Tell those god awful kids, Veronica, Melody and Ewm to come see to these new children."

The woman ran down the long stone hall. When another nun went to grab Ssiah, her hand was engulfed by a quick flash of light. She looked repulsed beyond words as she stepped back, holding her hand in pain and shrieking, "This... this way! Now!"

Through the stained glass windows of the building, Lisa saw the strange light from outside, but did not see what had caused it and figured it must have been the sun. She knew this was one of OZONE's facilities. Like most old churches that weren't in complete disrepair, this one was some sort of haven for Supernatural activities, one that, sadly, she had no clearance to investigate. Whatever this branch was, it was much older than her sect, and like most other agents and operatives, individuals in OZONE usually weren't aware of their comrades, or what capacity their position carried, unless that information was given. The churches had always made her uneasy because she could only imagine the terrible age-old things that their walls had witnessed. She knew that the walls of the Underbase held countless secrets both revolutionary and heinous.

Ssiah walked up the stairs without being touched by the withering nun escorting her. Cassiel was nearby, and she felt his warmth. She saw the girl, Aiel, being ushered down the hall like a criminal, then began to notice the countless paintings from centuries ago that hung on the walls. Feeling more anxious than before, she stopped at the end of the hall as the nun opened the door to the chapel. It suddenly felt as if gravity itself had cemented her feet to the floor, attempting to prevent her from crossing the threshold. The nun was growing impatient.

"Let's go!" she said.

Ssiah struggled to take a step, nearly losing her balance altogether. She had to focus on her feet with all her willpower for another moment before she was finally able to pull her feet from the floor and enter. When she walked into the chapel, a sudden and inexplicably certain thought filled her head as she said aloud, "Something evil is buried here!"

Chapter 27

SO UNLIKELY

Never was the kid who many people overlooked. He didn't consider himself exceptionally handsome like the bad boys or athlete types, but he knew he was not ugly. Most of the time you'd see him walking through the halls with his head down and his earbuds in, playing some angsty rock music, but today he was in absolute awe staring at Sky. He knew better than to interrupt the flow of things, especially the culture of high school that people tend to overlook. There were the popular kids and the ones who strived for something; then there were kids like him who just hoped to get through the day without being bullied.

His blond hair was almost white, and though the back of his head was under the hoodie as usual, his bangs stuck out in short spikes. Never was part of a program that allowed students from public schools to be attend this prep school, a privileged scholarship. He had been frequently bullied at his old school, but the guidance counselor had seen great things in him. She had even written an essay, supporting him as a candidate for the annual charity program of Pegasus Rose preparatory school. After touching the hearts of the counselor and many other faculty members, Never was accepted by Drakehawk Academy.

Sitting at his desk in the chemistry room, he looked back on all of the events that had led to this moment. He had ended up in this class, a trillionaire heiress sitting just a few desks in front of him, and he had just seen her repair the shattered glass of a window after everyone had watched the teacher being sucked out of the classroom by a force that seemed to defy all laws of nature and physics. Never would never be the same.

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His name was Nevin Hollows, and his family was not only poor, but slightly more dysfunctional than he'd ever truly admit. His mother worked the nightshift at a local diner and was currently dating some random guy she had met at a bar. He hated his mother's promiscuous behavior almost as much as he hated his own name. He had decided long ago that Never sounded better.

When he met Scape for the first time as his personal welcoming committee, Never realized this school was a little out of his league. It wasn't that Scape was rude or uppity, because he was anything but those things, though Never could tell right away that most of the other kids wouldn't accept him. Scape was actually the nicest person to date who Never had actually spoken to.

He longed to hang out with Scape and the kids who also looked out of place, particularly Kaery, Ahlina and Star. Although Scape was nice, there was rarely an opportunity to say anything to him because he was always surrounded by girls who glared at Never like they would at an alien. He kept his distance and watched them when no one was looking.

As far as Never was concerned, this school was full of girls who were completely unapproachable. He thought it was highly unlikely that any of them would take time out of their day to talk to a poor kid like him. The jocks must have smelled the poverty on him because they made sure he was uncomfortable as often as possible. John Spankston seemed to have a vendetta against anyone who was even remotely considered a rebel. Rumor had it he'd been beat up by one a few years ago and had never learned his lesson.

Never was not very tall, and though he might have had some wiry muscle underneath his baggy skater clothes, no one would ever notice. Everyone just saw the awkward guy with pale skin and white spiky hair. Most just ignored him after a simple glance, and he preferred that.

Today Never's greatest fear would be brought to reality; he was supposed to speak in front of the chemistry class. He dreaded his name being called, but the teacher was convinced he was one of his brightest students, even though he was definitely the shyest.

"Nevin Hollows, please come to the front of the class and present your project," Mr. Woodlands said cheerfully. "Everyone give him your undivided attention. That includes you, Sky."

Sky had been looking out the window at the clouds. She wanted to go home or do what most normal kids did, skip school altogether. But outside the door was one of her dad's henchmen. Not the creepy one, Grin, but another guy. She was so tired of being so overprotected, but had surrendered to the endless arguments about their presence. Her father had even told her that if she could get through the rest of the week with no incident, he'd let her take a day for herself. This was enough motivation to make her stop arguing.

"What? Oh yeah, I was paying attention," Sky said as she turned to the teacher and then noticed Never watching her. He instantly looked down at his shoes the moment they made eye contact. "I'm sorry; I didn't mean to ignore you," Sky said apologetically, "I mean, you can continue." She turned her back to the judgmental gazes of the onlookers.

Never didn't know why, but the blank stares of the students before him suddenly didn't mean much as he spoke confidently about his topic. "Run as hard as a wild beast if you will, but you won't get any greater reward than that destined for you." Never looked up from his note card and smiled awkwardly at Sky. "That's an ancient Egyptian proverb I came across, and it reminds me of what we're all doing here as mankind. All living things contain carbon in some form, and it is one of the most important elements on the periodic table because it serves as a building block for many other compounds that help us survive. Without carbon, we wouldn't have an atmosphere; we wouldn't even be here in the first place..."

Khenebu had been sitting in the back of the class doodling star charts of distant worlds because school was far too easy. He could literally do every assignment in his sleep. He was polite and didn't show any signs of fatigue, but he knew he was just going through the motions. His boredom sometimes took over as he wondered how the kids could have such frivolous conversations. Then sometimes he would think about it further; they were just humans who didn't have much of importance to say.

For the first time, he didn't look bored, but intrigued. It was at that moment he recognized the proverb from scriptures he'd studied in Egypt as a child. This young American boy's knowledge it caught his attention, and in an instant, he knew why. *I know him from another time. His name is Never, and by Horus' wrath, that is Isis!*

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“So you mean to tell me we were destined to meet each other?” Ahlina asked Crux, perplexed as she sat with him, Scape, Star and Kaery in Golden Gate Park.

“That’s exactly what I’m saying,” Crux said, eating his fourth sandwich.

“Wait, wait, let me get this straight!” Scape said after a long awkward pause, “You’re a Mancer?” He pointed to the nodding Crux. “And we’re Witchbreed?” Again Crux nodded cheerfully while swallowing his meal. “And all of these dreams we’re having are actually memories. And we’ve been best friends not only for these last few years, but in every lifetime before this?”

“Well, I’m not sure about every lifetime, but you guys are actually pretty famous the more I think about it.” Crux giggled to himself. “I mean you were—sorry—are the Coven of Unity!” After finishing his last bite of the buttery bread, he grabbed a large bag of chips and sat up enthusiastically, his excitement seeming to be a result of the snack more than the information he was relaying. “Look, I don’t have to remind you all about the flashback at the Pagoda. We’ve been over this, but I can go over it again if you want.” He ripped the bag open and started stuffing his mouth full of orange crunchy bits.

“No you don’t!” Star interrupted with the same disgusted look she always had watching Crux eat. “We know by now. We’re the gimps who listened to Sky and gave the humans powers. The humans almost destroyed the world, and we’re probably the reason everyone has such bad style now.”

“Yep,” Crux mumbled while chomping.

Kaery was tired of being quiet, and she was trying to understand it all. “Ok, so if this is the case, I’m not the only one who experiences every detail of those dreams or flashbacks or memories or whatever they are. I mean—every ray of sunshine, every breeze and the smell of every flower, am I right?”

Scape, Ahlina and Star looked at one another with the same expression, nodding in agreement.

“I suppose that answers it,” she said quietly. “Then Crux, I bet what you’re saying is all true because for some reason, it seems no one can lie to me anymore.

But that doesn't answer a few other questions." Kaery's golden eyes probed the munching preteen.

"Like, how he knew we were all going to learn Kung Fu, or whatever it was we did to kick those guys' asses?" Ahlina asked abruptly.

"You're gonna have to tell me that story again one of these days," Scape said to Ahlina before smiling at Star and Kaery. "I'm not one for violence, but that just sounds so cool!"

"Or, how you knew we would all meet and form this Coven of Unity?" Star asked, sounding more accusing than anything else.

"These are easy answers," Crux said smugly. "You always knew that fighting style because it was taught to you in another lifetime. And I'd also like to hear that story again 'cause I'm kinda having a hard time seeing Star do anything more than fall on her big butt in those heels."

Crux couldn't dodge the slap to the back of the neck fast enough. Star had definitely gotten faster, and judging by the sting he felt, stronger too.

"Ouch!" He rubbed his red skin, dropping the chips, but quickly grabbing them before they hit the ground. "I only knew you'd create the Coven of Unity because Gemini told me you would. That's why he had to bring you back home instead of training with us." He was still rubbing his neck with one hand, but was able to grab a handful of chips with the other and shove them into his mouth.

"I don't know how you're not fat!" exclaimed Star, sitting down on the park bench. She crossed her long legs and inspected her nails, bored.

"Did Gemini tell you what we were supposed to do next?" Scape asked, sitting up and focusing on the boy.

"He didn't say what your destiny was supposed to be, and he didn't say much about what you guys can do. He barely spoke about you at all to be honest." Crux gave a satisfied sigh as he continued munching.

"But he did tell you to spy on us, right?" Kaery asked matter-of-factly, prompting Crux to gasp and spit out his chips.

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“That was a great speech, Nevin,” Mr. Woodlands said in shock to the skater, the boy who was usually too quiet to formulate words in his class. “Very well done, indeed! You even have me thinking about why we all try so hard when it seems like we’re only here to die.” The skinny man clapped, and in turn, the entire class gave a round of applause. “Very good grade you have there, young man. Whoever is next, I don’t envy you. That’s a hard act to follow!”

Never was walking to the back of the room when he saw Sky smile at him warmly. Her brown eyes caught his pitch black ones, and she didn’t look away. He bumped into a desk and looked down at the student who’d noticed their gazes meet. “I’m sorry, man, I didn’t mean to—”

“—It’s perfectly fine,” Khenebu said charmingly, “You know, up until now I didn’t take you for an intellectual.”

Never blushed and sat down in his desk next to him.

“I didn’t mean that in any offensive way,” Khenebu apologized with a warm smile.

“No, I’m not really like that,” Never said, almost whispering, “Today was a little different.” He looked across the class and smiled when he saw the beautiful brown locks of Sky’s hair.

Khenebu followed Never’s glance. “Oh, I see.”

“Well, you know, she’s basically a goddess,” Never sighed, looking down at his note cards.

“That’s more correct than you know,” Khenebu said without a smile. “She’s a Mancer.”

“What’s a Mancer?” Never asked in a whisper, not wanting to seem stupid.

Khenebu looked around at the class as if they were all spies. “You can understand what I’m saying?” he asked in a dramatic whisper.

“Well, yeah,” Never said to the handsome African. He noticed how neat Khenebu’s dreads were, and when snickers from other students began to fill the air, he blushed again.

“Actually, that sounded like Arabic to me,” Mr. Woodlands said in his scolding voice as another student, Megan, stood awkwardly waiting to deliver her speech. “Do I need to separate you two?”

“No sir,” Khenebu said charismatically with a smile, sitting up to focus. “I was just intrigued with his Egyptian quotes is all.”

“Weren’t we all?” Mr. Woodlands smiled as he docked points from Megan’s presentation before it had even begun, knowing it wouldn’t be as enthralling as Nevin’s.

As Megan started again, Khenebu passed a note to Never. Never looked up at Mr. Woodlands, who was already bored, not paying attention to anyone else in the class. Never glanced at the fancy handwriting that looked a lot like calligraphy and read the note to himself: ‘I know what you are, and I know what Sky is. If you want to know more, meet me after class.’

A simultaneous gasp came from both Sky and Never. They looked at each other from across the room, causing Megan to stop her speech again, silence filling the room. He took his hands off the note and looked into her soft brown eyes.

There’s no way—I’m in the back of the class, and she’s way over there. But she’s looking at me and Ken as if we were spies or something. Oh no, Mr. Woodlands...

Mr. Woodlands stood up. As he walked to the window, he began to chastise the audience, interrupting class once again. “Now, I know you are all excited, and yes, that was a great speech from Nevin, but—” He suddenly stopped talking as his arms stiffened as if he were in pain. “But I don’t—” He tried to continue, but the obvious discomfort was showing in his face and made itself even more present as his expression went from discomfort to confusion.

Khenebu stood up as he saw Mr. Woodlands’ skin turn from its peach and pink tone to a dark grey, as if it was turning to stone. He stood up and stared in shock.

Megan started screaming as Mr. Woodlands fell backward into a window, shattering it as he fell out.

Sky watched as it seemed that a force from outside was pulling him, his skin was disintegrating right in front of them like ashes in a bonfire. She leapt up and yelled, “No!”

She rushed to the front and grabbed Mr. Woodlands by the wrist, but the flesh crumbled in her hand as he was sucked backwards out of the window. The other students panicked, some running out of the classroom, others trembling in utter shock. Sky was left with a mound of ashes in her hand as if she had pulled them from thin air, the window before her suddenly repaired as if it had never been broken.

“That’s what a Mancer is,” Khenebu said.

Never watched in silence. The whole event looked like something out of a comic book. He knew that he was changing, and he couldn't tell anyone exactly why, not that he had anyone to tell in the first place. Now, suddenly, he was starting to see just how likely it was that he would speak to Sky.

Khenebu ran to the window with Never following him. They both looked down to see what Never could only describe as an angel, its body made of stone, its glowing eyes sinister enough to pierce a soul. Its large form was definitely not human, though it had the shape of a statue that had been broken in many places. It stood still, watching them like a patient predator.

"What *is* that?" Sky asked as she looked out the window at the creature below, cowering behind Never.

"I don't know. It's looking right at us!" Never had no explanation, unable to fathom what was happening.

"It's an Etu Aenjelhn. A Dusk Aenjel," Khenebu said with a haunting disposition, "Able to steal souls and turn their remains to dust."

"How do you know that?" Sky demanded.

At that moment, one of her bodyguards rushed into the room. He did a perimeter check and watched as the seniors entered the hallway, screaming about how Mr. Woodlands had fallen. He was already annoyed that he had to take this position as Sky's bodyguard instead of his usual field work.

He was getting ready to pull his handgun when he saw Sky and the two boys staring out the window. As he approached, he saw the stone creature whose eyes he would never forget, its skin reminding him of the Dehmn he had killed in Syria. Watching the smoldering burn of its eyes reminded him of looking into the sun, except he couldn't turn away.

"How do you know that's an angel or whatever you said?" Sky asked Khenebu.

"Because I am the one who set it free from its prison," he said, "What remains of Mr. Woodlands is, regrettably, in your hands."

Guardian looked at the three of them, noticing what Sky was holding. Never was the only one to watch as the Aenjel faded into the shadows while the clouds overhead crept in front of the sun.

Khenebu looked back down to see the Etu Aenjelhn gone from sight. "It wanted a soul just to show me that it's here. I have to find it."

"No. You have to come with me," Guardian said coolly. "All of you."

“We’ve been walking in Golden Gate Park for hours looking for some stupid imaginary Grove, and my feet hurt,” Star said, annoyed. “Answer her question. Did he send you here to spy on us or what?”

“Ok, yes, Gemini asked me to keep an eye on you,” Crux admitted, rubbing the cheesy dust from his hands. His confident sandy Mohawk was a contrast to the fearful expression that crossed his face as he confessed to Kaery. “Well, kinda. I didn’t know that it would be like this. I just took the opportunity to get away from that god-forsaken island. Then he gave me some cryptic speech about how if I wanted to leave, I’d be led to you all. I was to help you, like you are to help me stay alive.”

“Are we supposed to believe this brat?” Star erupted with fury, “You’ve been spying on us from day one!”

“Not like that,” Crux explained. “I didn’t figure out why I was here until the day I tried to show you how to fight.”

“So that’s why you wanted to show us how to fight, to protect you?” Ahlina asked.

“No, well, yes, but not like that,” Crux replied, trying to backtrack.

“Who are you really running from?” Scape asked.

“My cousins, the Shandor, and even the Petshas. I told you they are Vampyl and Spiraar shapeshifters,” Crux retorted, on the verge of tears.

“I believe him,” Kaery said firmly.

“Well, are we all supposed to just believe his story?” Star asked. Her short skirt and crop top made her anger seem a little less frightening.

“Yeah, Kaery, think about it. What were we supposed to think with all of this happening at once?” Ahlina asked, leaning against a tree. The moment she touched it, time seemed to slow. Then a faint howl came from deep within the woods. She was enthralled by what she was witnessing. The sound of the howl revealed an invisible barrier that led to a part of the woods she had never seen

before, and she'd lived in San Francisco for most of her life. She was reluctant to tell the others of her find, afraid they'd think she was crazy. They were all standing near her, but obviously could see neither the barrier nor the mysterious trees that stood behind it.

"Guys, I think I see something," Ahlina said so low it might as well have been a whisper. No one heard her, too preoccupied with the discussion.

"I believe him, too," Scape said, walking over to the cornered Gypsy boy. "I don't think he would lie to us. Besides, our lives have been just a bit more interesting ever since he walked into them."

Kaery was so proud to be Scape's friend. "You're right. It's unlikely he's here for malicious intent. I would know. He seems to be leading us where we're supposed to be. Like a lucky charm." Trying to raise her friends' spirits, she exchanged looks of dread with Star and Ahlina as the three of them noticed a dark figure lurking among the trees. "What is that?" Kaery couldn't take her eyes off the creature, a black wolf with a crescent moon of silver fur on its chest. It was larger than any wolf she'd ever seen, and its big green eyes looked almost human.

"That's a Spiraar," Crux said as he produced several small objects from his pocket and prepared to launch them at the beast.

"So I'm guessing that's the Grove he was talking about?" Ahlina pointed past the wolf to the invisible barrier that was now revealing itself with the elegance of light waves rippling on a hot day.

Chapter 28

SURGE'S GOLEMS

“Don’t you think it’s a good time to freak out, Blue?” Surge whispered as she stared into the eyes of the living monoliths.

“Let me figure something out,” Blue said, more frustrated that he’d got them into this situation than anything else. “They seem pretty slow. Just by looking at their size, I mean, they’re probably slow, so we can make a run for it?” Blue was unsure of how to get out of this predicament safely. He was not fully aware of what these Golems were capable of, and he dared not cause any alarm for fear they’d attack his fourteen year old companion. Surge was physically weak, even by human standards. As if she’d never gone outside to play with the other kids, let alone participate in Physical Education at school, her body was frail and lithe.

Blue weighed his options, and he didn’t think he had enough time to grab Surge and risk her life running back into the booby trapped tunnel where the dead creature was lying. As he thought about the situation, he heard a familiar voice speak to him as if someone else was suddenly in the room with them.

“Blue, how typical of you to mess things up like this.”

He did not bother answering because he’d already thought of that himself. Instead, he looked at the design of the large stone and metal guardians in front of him, knowing that the showdown had already started the moment they’d trespassed on this sacred place.

“You can’t get out of this by running like you always do. Or by punching, for that matter, which was always your second go-to.” The female voice was calm, but in Blue’s eyes, it was not helping the current situation.

“What do you expect me to do then, Charity?” Blue asked, “Are you going to tell me that Mom and Dad are disappointed too? I’m sorry, Ok?” The familiar atmospheric smell entered the room as he prepared himself for battle.

Surge looked shocked at her friend’s sudden screaming. “What? Mom and Dad? I didn’t say anything!” She instantly began to think of all the files she’d ever come across on the internet that dealt with mental ailments. She had come to

understand that she could recall just about anything that had ever been saved on a hard drive as well as every component that made up the information. She had quite literally memorized the internet. She watched Blue talk to himself as if he were a mental patient.

Charity began to speak in a much sweeter tone, knowing her brother always responded well when she was calm and patient. “I’m sorry, Blue, I didn’t mean it that way. You did a good job saving Crux, but now you have to make sure nothing happens to Surge. She may be the one person who can stop OZONE for good.”

Even though Blue couldn’t see his sister, but he sensed her presence and heard her words, deciding to sacrifice himself in order to save Surge. “You’re right, and I think I know what I have to do.”

“What? Wait, Blue, what are you talking about? Who are you talking to?” Surge asked desperately as she saw Blue take a step forward toward the machine.

His forehead became slick with sweat despite the cold temperature of the cave. He was going to face the living creature and buy Surge some time to get out. “I’m sorry, Surge, I didn’t mean to get you into this kind of trouble. Run as soon as the things attack me.”

Before Surge could open her mouth to object, Blue took off running toward the living tanks. She saw a blur of attacks as he punched and kicked the walls of metal and stone in reckless abandon. His fists seemed to glow an electric blue, his eyes reflecting the same color as he swung through the air screaming. The Golems were a lot faster than they had thought, seeming to anticipate Blue’s next move as he ran between them in a streak of light. The action was happening so fast that Surge was amazed she could see anything at all.

The Golems of metal and stone had eyes that glowed mint green as golden steam spewed from the crevices in their large joints. Their arms morphed into crude weapons as they swung at their foe, but Blue managed to evade every strike despite their attempts to sabotage his next step.

Surge continued to watch, noticing something peculiar in her study of the battle: the Golems were getting smarter with every attack Blue tried. These machines must have been forged by a genius. They were not only anticipating his every move, but they were also changing their strategy according to his attacks, and they’d catch him off guard eventually.

“Blue, watch out! They are adapting to your attacks!” Surge screamed as she watched the chaotic fight.

Like an owl, one of the Golems turned its head 270 degrees, stalking Blue with precision, stopping its pursuit only when the other thirty Golems seemed but a second away from intercepting the trespasser.

Surge had nowhere to run. She knew the booby-trapped hall they had come from was suicide. A Golem stomped toward her, its large fist raised above its head ready to crush her. The Golem was easily fifteen feet tall, and judging by its expandable joints that moved fluidly with bursts of steam, it could stretch to even greater heights. *What kind of steam punk nightmare is this? Wait—Wait, that’s it! The steam is coming from the fuel source.* She looked back at the enemy as she ran, noticing Golden Runes of Magick barely visible through the large cracks in the body of the stone giant. *Runes! They say a whole lot about the engineering of this thing. Too bad it’s about to kill me.*

In what must have been an instant, Surge studied every file in her mind on Femtotechnology, the means by which subatomic particles had stimulated the otherwise inanimate Golems, altering their cellular structure and giving them life. The only metal that could sustain such a force was called Electrum. Surge opened her eyes, but it was too late, and the Golem’s fist came crashing down on her.

Blue was dashing toward Surge through hundreds of swings and slices. He had heard her warning about the adaptability of his enemies, but realized during his relentless attacks that she had no place to run. He’d have to destroy these creatures if they were going to make it out alive. Dodging a series of energy waves that shot from the Golem’s open palms, he managed to survive yet another attack from the inhuman protectors of the cave. He desperately tried to make it to Surge before the Golem closed in, his heart nearly jumping out of his chest as he saw the stone arm plummet at an alarmingly fast rate. Even he’d be obliterated by the force of something that large and powerful.

“NO!” he screamed, knowing it was too late.

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Jayde made her way through Zalomoni quite easily with long a stride that was unique to residents of the city. The Grove that this place had been built on was a canyon she had personally discovered thousands of years before the Ice Age. It had been pioneered by Supernaturals, created to be their sanctuary.

Jayde knew this Grove, like many others, was a sacred place that Gaia held dear, as it was one of the rare places Magick flowed easily and unrestrained. She also knew they were playing a dangerous game as Gaia no longer favored too much power being locked in one place for very long.

Like the early years of the planet, Pangaea was now full of powerful beings who took their environment for granted. They had egotistically cast the powerful Spell of Enlightenment, giving humans the ability to use Magick, which caused a rift that nearly destroyed Earth in a single day. That night when the moon was full, Gaia had created her own guardians and protectors, the Spiraar.

With a wave of unbridled passion and rage, these man-beasts overran the earth, destroyed everything in their path with but one order from their goddess. As the first Mancer who had evolved into the very essence of the planet, Gaia had become a Titan with only one objective, the preservation of Earth. Everyone instantly became her enemies, and in some cases, they had to be cleansed from her planet.

This was the tale of the Mother Gaia and her retaliation to regain control of what was hers. The shapeshifting Spiraar took every shape, from small insects to large mammals of proportions the world had never seen before. They were not only palpable foes for the powerful Supernaturals who had already existed, but they were also a threat to the newly enlightened humans. They purged the lands of any and all life until a balance was restored.

The Spell of Enlightenment had been reversed, and a Veil of Ignorance had reclaimed the omnipotent powers of the humans, making them once again ignorant and innocent. Gaia stopped the war she had waged, vowing that she'd resurrect her peaceful beasts if the balance was ever disturbed. She did not want too much power concentrated in one place ever again, and so began the Age of Kingdoms.

The Mancers, Wicasht and Jreamers were forced to separate their vast realms into smaller domains. This appeased Gaia as she sent her Spiraar only as messengers and protectors of the remaining Groves while also cleansing the lands of tainted beings that the humans had released upon the Earth, like the Vampyl,

who were a product of their fear. The Spiraar still had a vicious instinctual hatred of these undead and unnatural immortals.

Jayde was not a Mancer who had survived the Great War, but upon her rebirth, she had vowed to protect her people with her last breath. She gathered as many as she could find and claimed the canyon Grove as their home. The amount of power she brought together led to frequent battles with Spiraar who were sent to restore the balance. This was a battle Jayde knew she could win, as the social structure of her city was a peaceful one. She prayed to Gaia, stressing that her people were pacifists, wanting nothing more than to remain within the city without disturbing the outlands.

Gaia seemed to be appeased until some curious citizens ventured too far from Zalomoni, deciding to claim the surrounding lands as their own. The egos of her once proud warriors became their own downfall as they breached Gaia's laws.

"Too much power is what corrupted my people," Jayde said quietly to herself as she hurried into the cave and carefully made her way through the intricate hallway to the blacksmith's. She didn't trigger a single trap, as she already knew the patterns of these safeguards. When she reached the end of the hall, she saw the horrific inevitable scene that was playing out too quickly for her to prevent. *One of Nadir's golems is about to kill the girl! Even Blue can't reach her in time, and neither can I!* Jayde started toward Surge, but a moment later, the Golem's fist came down upon the girl with enough force to leave her in pieces.

Jayde thought of the time she had been introduced to these Golems with Guardian, how the Magickal machines had wiped the floor with some of her best Royal Guards. This was not going to be a pleasant fight, but vengeance for Surge was the only option at this point. She stopped almost as fast as Blue did at the next revelation.

The Golem did not smash Surge-Overload after all, its attack halted as if the small girl were a wall stronger than the stone machine itself. From the moment its giant fist made contact with the top of her head, she somehow had control of this inhuman creature's every function.

Surge turned around dramatically to see Jayde standing behind her. "It's wonderful! They are machines!"

Blue was still being attacked when Surge's Golem went into defense mode, leaping over him to oppose its former brothers in arms. A desperate battle for

dominance ensued, the Golems attempting to suppress the traitor when Surge approached them.

Blue reached grabbed her arm. “I don’t know how you survived that attack, but I don’t think you should interrupt them.” His kind eyes would have stopped her if she wasn’t so resolute on what she had to do.

“I have to do this,” Surge said reassuringly while gently pulling away from Blue. “Trust me.” She ran into the middle of the fight.

Even Jayde was confused about how this girl hadn’t been killed by the first Golem, that was until focused her eyes on its body, reading the Runes of Magick that were glowing in the stone skin. “She has somehow reprogrammed the Golem to do her bidding,” Jayde said, “It’s her power.”

Blue looked at her and then back to Surge while the Golems fought like age-old enemies, flinging metal and stone in all directions. Some were firing bursts of golden plasma while others were tearing each other to pieces. Despite the havoc being wreaked around her, Surge stood composed beneath the feuding creatures. “I should go in and help her,” Blue said, readying himself to dash into the fray.

“Trust her,” Jayde said wisely. “Maybe it’s her turn to save us?”

After sustaining so much damage, the exoskeletons of the Golems had been shredded, revealing the Runes underneath that were began to emit gold and blue steam. In a matter of seconds, the hard flesh of each creature began to repair itself, chunks of shrapnel reaffixing themselves to the giant bodies as if they were magnetized. Surge lightly touched each machine as she courageously weaved her way through the chaos. As if a virus had been spread from Surge’s hands, the Golems become obedient, infecting the few that were left uncontrolled until every last one of them was standing still like a statue. Surge skipped among the giant feet of her quiet minions.

“What just happened?” Blue asked, puzzled.

“They won’t hurt us anymore,” Surge said as one of the Golems lifted her onto its shoulder. “See?” She knocked on its head with her knuckles. “I’ve learned more from them than I did from those OZONE files I stole. I think it’s about time you told us about what really happened here, Jayde.”

Jayde simply nodded and said, “As do I.”

*

Deme looked over the damage report for the hundredth time, trying to further analyze each step Surge-Overload had taken to retrieve the files. The floating holographic screens before him were scrolling through the seemingly endless list of files believed to be compromised, displaying information according to his whims. He had almost missed the cat and mouse battle he was so frustrated about just weeks ago.

He stood like a statue in his minimalist apartment, techno music blaring. He needed the ambience in order to concentrate on the overwhelming threat. The agent list was bad enough, but once he noticed that files detailing OZONE's latest technological achievements were also stolen, he began to smile like a madman. She had easily outwitted the entire organization as if they were all a bunch of unsuspecting suckers in her game of poker. He knew she had fun toying with them, just as he would if he were in her place. He stood still, staring blankly ahead, his simple black garments fluttering from the air conditioner's breeze in this sterile environment.

His mind could barely fathom how much damage one hacker had accomplished in so little time. Even though he was furious, he was equally intrigued. Deme sipped his coffee, placed the cup on his ergonomic desk and began to stand on one leg without taking his eyes off the files.

She had accessed prototype blueprints that no one else in the world knew about. If a genius like her had been able to harness even a fragment of that technology, she could've practically run the world.

"So this is the power of a Mancer? Thank god we killed her!" Deme laughed to himself.

*

“Lisa, please stop crying. It’s not your fault, hun.” Reynolds looked at his sobbing wife and tried to stay strong for her. “She—she ditched camp to answer some ad for gamers in Union Square. The cab driver confirmed he dropped her off, and well—we found her luggage and—”

“Stop! I read the damn report.” Lisa was a naturally charming woman, seasoned in psychological analysis and always in control of her outward expression, today her training was all but lost as she, trapped in this painful moment, just wanted to forget her identity as an OZONE agent. “It’s my fault!”

“You can’t blame yourself.”

“Yes I can! I was the one who forced her to go to the camp. I was the one who told her to meet new people and get out there.” Lisa’s eyes were so red and sore that it hurt to open them. “I should’ve let her stay in her room. I should have...”

“It wasn’t your fault she ran right into some covert mission that ended in explosions.” Now his eyes were tearing up, but he kept them out of Lisa’s sight as he hugged her. He too was trying to forget his allegiance to the organization that he knew must have been responsible for his daughter’s death. His tears couldn’t be held back any longer. *No father should feel this way.*

“I know what you’re doing, and I love you for it, but I know who’s to blame here,” Lisa sobbed into her husband’s button up shirt. “I’ll never be able to live with myself.”

“She’s in a better place,” Reynolds said, having nothing else to say in an attempt to comfort her, though at the same time he was starting to believe what she had said, contemplating her level of responsibility for his only daughter being dead. His once hopeful soul was already growing more bitter each day, and now his favorite person had left the planet much too early. “She’s in a better place.”

Chapter 29

FALL OF OLYMPUS II

(391 B.C.)

Kaery stood still for a long moment while she thought deeply of the troubles she faced. Blue was making a terrible decision to harm his own people while Nina was threatening the Supernatural society that the Coven of Unity had taken an oath to protect. The jasmine and rosemary-infused water filled her senses as she focused on the here and now. There were decisions she had to make, and she had to be hasty. The natural balance was in danger, and in a moment of clarity, like a sweet dream, she realized what she had to do, destroy Olympus.

“Oh, Kaery, I need your assistance,” Nina said gently, as if the air around her was filled with fairies. She calm, more in control of her feelings today than she was most of the time. With Kaery’s blessings, she was going to take her people into a new era where everyone would love one another. This was the greatest day ever.

Kaery walked into the room where Nina was preparing for her appearance. She didn’t normally do this sort of work, deciding what costumes Nina was going to wear. That was specifically a Star role. When she looked into Nina’s eyes, she saw through all the smoke and mirrors. She had to turn away, so she focused on the garments, sorting through some dresses until in the corner of her eye she saw a man standing at the other end of the room. Without missing a beat, she assumed her combat stance.

“Whoa, Kaery, I apologize for the informal arrival. I’m just the messenger.” Hermes spoke in an elegant voice that was almost too smooth for his image. He was a strikingly handsome man, and like most gods of Olympia, adorned in gold bands that were no doubt blessed with powerful Magick. Hermes was one of the rare Gods who was specifically blessed with artifacts created by the Coven of Unity, the winged boots he loved so much for his cross-dimensional travels.

Kaery and Star had known that Hermes was a Cronomancer who could travel between dimensions, but he lacked control over his amazing power, so Ahlina had stepped in with her powers of the Daeva, and with the Coven’s permission, created the boots with Star determining their aesthetic. Ahlina had

truly focused her intentions on the boots, and like a spontaneous miracle, the artifacts were created.

Hermes caught Kaery staring at the gifts he treasured most. “I still adore you all for these lovely instruments, but that is not what I came here for. Zeus wants me to deliver a message to Aphrodite at once.” His smile was humble and genuine.

Nina was still naked, but just as comfortable in her bare skin as she was in her gowns. She walked in front of the protective Kaery, placing a loving hand on her shoulder. “It’s ok. Please continue, Hermes.”

“Zeus would like all the humans to mate tonight, so bless the festivals with your most potent love potions. He has an announcement to make tomorrow, but wants everyone to enjoy themselves this eve,” he said, bowing slightly at the naked goddess.

Star came running into the room upon hearing the announcement. “Oh, my goddess, why aren’t you dressed?”

“Tell him it shall be done,” Nina said. “Oh, and I have a few announcements of my own.”

“Of course. What would you like me to tell him?” Hermes asked.

Kaery’s body was still tense, even though she was no longer on high alert. She was terrified that Star would find out this way and had to interrupt the message. “Well wouldn’t you like to keep that announcement a secret, your highness?”

“Oh, the intrigue! I must admit, I do like your style, Kaery. Tell him I will make my announcement before I make my departure to Egypt.” Nina smiled as Star dressed her diligently.

“As you wish.” Hermes smiled at the women, and with a flash of his white teeth, was gone as if he’d jumped into a Port Rune.

Most of the gods of the courts relied on the astounding artifacts the Covens created for them. The Coven of Unity was one of the favored Witchbreed communities, even worshipped as gods like most Mancers. Their artifacts were legendary and arguably the means by which the gods maintained control of humanity.

“After today’s ceremony, I would like to request that Star be taken to Egypt with you,” Kaery said, her back still turned.

Nina stopped looking in the mirror and went to Kaery, “Are you sure?”

“You’d do that for me?” Star asked in shock, “I mean, I know how you’re always the one who gets chosen to go.”

“I insist. Is that ok with you, Nina?” Kaery looked over her shoulder as she prepared to walk out the door.

“Well, of course, that’s the least I can do,” Nina said, confused at the informal request. As part of the festival, she was supposed to announce her entourage. Usually it was one of her maidens, if not all three, and then there was always her lover, Juno. Nina simply looked happy for Star, who was ecstatic about the recent events. By the time Nina looked up to say something to Kaery, she was already long gone.

*

Kaery was out in the hall with her back to the wall, out of sight. She didn’t want to speak with Nina at the moment, and she didn’t want Star to see her sob.

I can’t allow this to happen. I love Blue, and I love Nina, but they must know the error of their ways. They didn’t take our warnings humbly, but instead they have abused their subjects. Nina has always thought her gift was the ability to bend the wills of entire armies. Yes it’s an astounding skill, but her true power is the capacity to channel pure love from the Soulstream into a womb, creating Supernatural children.

There’s no guarantee that any of the Supernaturals will have a baby with powers, as some have gifts and others don’t, but Nina is our guarantee of being blessed with a child at all, and she handles this responsibility as whimsically as she handles her feelings instead of thinking of what’s best for her subjects. Well that’s enough! I know what I propose next will hurt the kingdom of Olympia, which I’m also loyal to, but I cannot sit idly by and watch Blue destroy the mankind simply because he can, nor can I allow Nina’s decision to go unpunished.

I’ll see Blue one more time and see what he has to say. I’ll give Nina the benefit of the doubt, but if she strays, she will force my hand. I will destroy the city

that I've held together with my love and strength for hundreds of years. Stop crying, Kaery! This is the time for you to be the strongest you've ever been. Now get to Blue and hope he isn't really planning to unchain a Dehmn beast that will end innocent lives. Releasing a Kraken on his own people like a tyrant... Either way, I will make my move at the Witching hour.

Kaery regained her composure and continued her trek to the God of gods, her secret lover, Zeus.

*

Ahlina was kneeling as she prayed in Argos with the loyal followers of Aphrodite. She'd happily visited many cities throughout the day with her newly mastered powers of teleportation. This was her last stop of the journey, to bring hope to the young maidens here, Supernatural and human alike.

Though Hera was revered in this city, the festival for Aphrodite was unmatched in praise and festivities. This was one of Ahlina's proudest moments as she accepted the prayers of the locals. They were mundane and humble wishes, and though Ahlina knew that Nina had the power to wash away their fears with unwavering love, she just smiled peacefully and tried to focus on the sincerity of each plea. Overall it seemed there just wasn't much happening here in the midst of human society, not much that was of concern anyway.

Forcing herself to have some patience, she continued listening to the prayers as High Priestess. The soft music of harps and lyres kissed the air, the anticipation becoming contagious as cheers from the surrounding streets began to fill the temple. *I miss my lover, Hermes. I can't wait for Nina to announce that I will bear a child for my beloved. It seems like forever, but it's only been a hundred years, all finally coming to an end. Supernaturals deserve to have children like these humans. Our births are as random as my powers, but it's about time we had the same luxury as these peasants who have no idea how wonderful it must be to have a child at will. Ugh, Nina, hurry up and make the announcement already. I've done everything you've ever asked for, listening endlessly to the prayers of your*

followers. I really miss Hermes! She maintained her smile as she continued her duties.

Of all the problems Ahlina had to listen to today, she did not want hear about anymore relationship issues, or even worse, libido issues. Her ears were already overflowing with them, and at this point after thousands of requests and acknowledgments, she was starting to loathe her job. That's when she knew it was high time for the ceremony to start. As she kept her respectful demeanor in check, a very poor young girl walked up to her in the temple.

Let me guess, she wants a love spell cast on her boyfriend, or better yet, she wants to make suitors of the men who ignore her. I can already hear her asking Aphrodite to bless her with an enchanting perfume. Ok, stop being judgmental, Ahlina, you have a job to do. Just listen to her petty concerns.

The girl's hair was the color of wheat on a breezy spring afternoon. Her skin was fair, but unwashed, as if she had endured hardship to reach the temples of the great Goddess of Love in Argos. Like a lot of the peasants, this woman did not know the formal etiquette expected of temple visitors, nor had she brought a gift for the altar. She looked distraught, her innocent eyes holding something distinct from what Ahlina had seen in other worshippers today, the look of hopelessness.

From the moment Ahlina made eye contact with the girl, she wanted to help her. After gathering some semblance of composure, the girl finally spoke.

"I'm sorry, High Priestess of Aphrodite. I am a simple girl from Carthage." She was out of breath, on the brink of tears.

"You've traveled far, child," Ahlina said, keeping her regal disposition but showing sympathy. "You don't look like you've had much to eat." She signaled to one of her priestesses.

"I promise I did not come all the way here to beg for food."

"I understand, but you shall eat while we speak, young one."

"Yes, Mistress."

The priestess returned with a tray of warm bread, cheese and wine, making no effort to conceal her pity as she saw the fear and fatigue written all over the girl's face. Ahlina quickly dismissed the priestess and took a mental note to reprimand her for her obvious judgment. But then she thought, *I did the same thing just moments ago. What has happened to me? I love my duties as High Priestess, even if most human wishes are predictable and frivolous. This girl is different. She may be a peasant, but something tells me that she isn't completely human.*

“Please kill my baby,” the girl said, sobbing through a small bite of the moist bread.

Ahlina’s look of shock displayed the fact that she’d never heard anything like this in all of her years listening to prayers as she took a step back from the young woman. “Excuse me? What kind of request is that?” Her green eyes looked the girl up and down in suspicion.

“I don’t mean to sound ungrateful, but I woke up pregnant having never courted a man. My mother and father think I am cursed by the gods for this.” Her small hands parted her sandy colored robes to show a baby bump.

The sign of the girl’s early months of pregnancy made Ahlina smile. “Why do you think this is a curse?”

“I’m sorry, Mistress, but I don’t know what else to call it. I have not made love to a man, yet here I am. I’m not married, and now I’ll never be.”

“What is your name, and who accompanied you on your journey here?”

“My name is Dido, and I came with my childhood friend, Mathos.” She motioned to a shy young man standing at the edge of the temple. “Please come.”

Ahlina immediately noticed the look of adoration in the young man’s eyes. She did not want to alarm him, but for the very first time, she could see the Runes of Magick at work, nurturing this innocent affection. She smiled as the man kneeled. “You love her.”

He looked so surprised to be put on the spot that he could only look up at the girl silently as if he’d never told her himself. “Yes I do,” he said.

Ahlina smiled and walked to Dido. “May I?”

The girl was still in disbelief about Mathos’ feelings for her, but she agreed.

Ahlina knelt before the girl, placing her ear to the soft belly. She closed her eyes and listened for a few awkward seconds, detecting the second heartbeat. She thought of the baby she so hoped Nina would announce at today’s festival. And it was then that what could only be described as a miracle occurred. A little voice was suddenly audible, singing from within the womb. Ahlina’s eyes shot open in surprise, but she kept her head on Dido’s belly.

“What is it?” Dido asked at the gasp from Ahlina.

The Priestesses surrounded them so as to block onlookers from witnessing anything further. The soft melody reminded Ahlina of her walks through the open fields full in the morning sunshine, of the colorful butterflies that sat on the flowers. She immediately knew that this was a Supernatural child. This girl was

carrying a Mancer, and judging by the power signature she distinguished, he was a new one. She reluctantly lifted her head from Dido's bell, unable to stop smiling at the song she would never forget. "The Earth Song."

"I'm sorry, Mistress what does that mean?"

"This is going to be a baby boy," Ahlina said happily. "I do not want to alarm you because this baby is definitely not a curse, actually more of a blessing than you know. The Gods favor you."

Mathos smiled as he felt the heavy burden of the uncertain journey finally being lifted from his beloved Dido's shoulders.

"How is that possible?" the girl asked, breaking into sobs.

"The Gods work in mysterious ways," Ahlina said. "I don't believe you should destroy this baby. It is not the will of the Gods."

"What am I to do? No one will marry me with this baby. How am I to take care of—"

"I will marry you," Mathos said, proudly interrupting her concerns. "I mean, will you marry me?" The simple young man was strong, his hands showing the toil he'd endured in the farmlands his entire life. He was not eloquent with his words, but he loved this girl like no one else on the planet could.

"I give you the blessings of Aphrodite, Goddess of love. You two are to be wed with the full blessings of Olympus," Ahlina said with a big smile.

"How is all this possible? How do you love me?" Dido looked deep into the blue eyes of her most trusted friend.

"I've always loved you."

"But my parents..." Dido looked away from Mathos to Ahlina. "You said I have the blessings of Olympus even without my father's approval?"

Ahlina simply nodded in contentment, then approached the couple, and joining their hands, she said, "You are blessed, child, and so is your unborn son. What will you name him, Mathos? As you are the child's father from this day forth."

The young man could hardly hold in his tears of joy as he held Dido's hand, saying without hesitation, "My son's name will be Isja."

*

Hermes travelled through time and space with more grace than any other being on this side of the universe, holding his ever-tedious responsibility as the Messenger of the Gods. His powers as a Cronomancer were enhanced by his beloved fiancée, Ahlina, and her Coven of Unity. He'd just recently delivered Kaery's message to Zeus, who seemed to be disturbed, reluctant to withhold the Kraken he was resolute in unleashing upon this city. Hermes knew that his beloved would be in Argos, and he refused to let her be harmed.

The constellations were always a beautiful light show to Hermes, as he knew them all very well. The darkness of empty space during teleportation was his place for freedom and solitude, yet it never lasted long enough. When he arrived at the steps to the Temple of Aphrodite, a beam of light began to shine in the sky. He looked back to see that the gods had temporarily broken through the Veil of Ignorance, using one of Kaery's artifacts no doubt, and it was at this moment that Mount Olympus, floating in the heavens, was being revealed to the humans for the first time.

"Oh no the ceremony is beginning." Hermes quickly ran up the steps to where he knew Ahlina must be. As he entered the structure fit for a king, he saw Ahlina holding the hands of a young man and woman, giving them prenuptial blessings. He didn't want to interrupt the lovely moment, but he had to get Ahlina's attention. As he approached, a priestess made his presence known.

"Oh benevolent messenger of the Gods, Hermes, to what do we owe the honor of this grand visit?" Her formal etiquette prompted Ahlina to turn around cheerfully.

"Remember what I said," she told the couple, "and take this as a token of appreciation from Aphrodite." She motioned for another priestess, who brought a wedding basket full of wines and candies blessed by Nina. The parcels would be enough to make this young girl forget about her troubles and rejoice in the blessings she had earned, their contents infused with Nina's spells of love, affection and sexuality.

Ahlina turned to see her proud lover, always excited to see the curly hair and toned muscles that made her feel small. His loin cloth was simple, but very much in tune with Olympian garb. She reached up to touch his face, but quickly stopped,

knowing that she was still within the temple where such displays of affection were not appropriate. "Love, you never show up to these ceremonies. What has changed?"

"I have grave news." The lines of worry carved their way into the god who was usually calm and collected.

She tilted her head to the side. "Grave news?"

"Yes."

She looked to the caring smiles of her priestesses. "Your Highness, the ceremony has begun. Aphrodite is giving her speech now," one of them said.

"I'll be outside in a moment," she said, "Please go listen to the speech." As they exited, she looked into Hermes' eyes and asked again, "What grave news?"

After everyone was ushered outside to see the spectacle of the god's mountain in the sky, Hermes spoke softly, "Zeus is planning to release the Kraken on Argos."

"What!" Ahlina almost shrieked in horror, "Why?"

"He believes the humans have faltered in their worship of him, giving their allegiance to Aphrodite, and he must therefore teach them a lesson."

"Why now? And what about the Love ceremony?"

"He wants Aphrodite to deliver the good news to the humans and give them her blessings of fertility and affection, but he will release the Kraken at dawn after their night of endless love."

Ahlina was now appalled, fearing for the people of Argos. "This is crazy. What did Kaery say?" After looking at the confusion on Hermes' face, Ahlina backtracked as she realized she may have just divulged more information about Kaery's love affair than she should have. "I mean, did Kaery tell you anything about what Nina was going to do? She couldn't possibly know..."

"Aphrodite doesn't know. It was clear that I wasn't to tell her."

"This is terrible. And to think there are new Supernaturals about to be born." She was terrified for the couple and that miraculous baby Mancer she had just blessed. Nina's voice resounded from where everyone was gathered for the announcement, no doubt amplified by Star's Glamour and Kaery's Projection Magicks. "No matter what, can you do me a favor, my love?"

"Anything you desire," Hermes said.

Ahlina held his hand as Nina spoke in the background. "Can you take that couple to Carthage after the ceremony?"

“Well, as much as I don’t enjoy travelling with humans...” He stopped speaking as he looked into the fearful green eyes of his lover. “Yes of course.”

She smiled like a child and kissed him deeply. “Thank you. Now let’s go hear Aphrodite’s announcement.”

As she ran out to the entrance, Hermes effortlessly followed, taking small steps through time and space to keep up.

“I can’t allow you to stay here. It’s much too dangerous.” His concern for her was intoxicating.

Trying to catch her breath from the wave of excitement and bad news, Ahlina agreed. “I’ll leave as soon as I hear the announcement of fertility.”

He stepped out of her way and allowed her to enjoy the festivities as per her duties, looking after her to see the hope radiating from her soft pale skin as they joined her priestesses on top of a hill with a clear view of the announcement taking place in the sky.

Nina’s speech was full of care and compassion. “You are all in my heart, and for this reason I have blessed many gifts for you to indulge in to your heart’s content. May everyone be more than blessed with passion and fertility. This year the seasons are looking highly in your favor.”

The cheering from the millions of people in the Mediterranean filled the air. They praised this goddess as if she were the life’s blood of the planet. Nina knew that she was but only one goddess in Zeus’ court, but her popularity outshined most of the others combined, as she was the representation of all that the people wanted to be: beautiful, graceful, compassionate and full of love. Her presence would bring not only hope, but the blessing of procreation. She stood at the steps of her temple on the mountain with Star’s Glamour enhancing her image in the clouds for all to see. She smiled as she waited for the cheering to die down. When it had finally subsided, she spoke again with Kaery’s Magick amplifying her voice so that everyone from the countryside to the coast could hear her equally. “This next announcement is one that I know you Supernaturals have been awaiting for over a decade. I know there’s a lot of excitement to have more of our kind bless this world.”

“Damn all this excitement. What’s your answer?” Ahlina whispered under her breath as she held Hermes hand.

Hermes knew Ahlina was excited about this news because he too wanted a son or daughter, and they both knew Nina had the power to bless them with a

child. This would be the gift that Ahlina and Hermes would revel in forever as they would finally share a life. Hermes was just as excited as she was to hear the news and wanted to be right here to see her face when she was announced as one of the chosen few.

Nina's golden hair flowed around her like the clouds that drifted about the sky, her image unforgettable in the this moment of glory. She continued her speech, "For my answer is, I will not bless any Supernatural births this cycle! We have enough gods and goddesses to worship, and we need to make sure their kingdoms are full of peace and love before I can allow any more of us to enter this world. After the war, we'll have another Love ceremony, and then we'll revisit this issue. Until then, all be merry and make love until you cannot anymore." She sent a wave of emotion that caressed the skin of all the people of Olympus.

Ahlina and Hermes had already teleported to the steps where Nina was finishing her speech.

"What?" Ahlina asked, looking at Nina in contempt. Hermes knew she was upset.

"I'll do as you asked," Hermes said, trying to smile as he felt his lover's disappointment.

As Ahlina watched Hermes vanish, she turned to Nina.

"I understand you're disappointed. I would be to," Nina said kindly.

"Then why would you make such a decision? We deserve children. Unlike the humans who obviously don't understand the luxury." She spoke insubordinately, causing Star to stand up, but she wasn't about to be reproached. "Don't even think about saying anything to me, Star. I have helped wash the floors of the temples where Supernaturals and humans alike worship you daily, Nina."

For the first time in many years, Ahlina addressed the goddess with a name other than Aphrodite. Star was also in complete shock at the unexpected news, but she'd never thought Ahlina would speak to their goddess this way. After all, she was among Aphrodite's most loyal followers, but everyone knew how badly she'd longed for a child.

Kaery knew the pain that her friend felt. She had tried to speak some sense into Zeus before this announcement, but his ego had gotten in the way. Normally Kaery would stop her friend from stepping out of line, but today was a reality check for Nina, who had caused great disappointment with this selfish choice she'd made. And to be quite honest, Kaery agreed with Ahlina.

“How dare you speak to me in such a way,” Nina said as she walked down the steps to her flying chariot that would take her to Egypt. Stopping midway to squint at Ahlina, she said, “I understand you’re passionate about having a child, but this world is too violent, and our kind is only contributing to the problem. Not that I have to explain myself to the likes of you. You need to know your place, Witchbreed!”

Kaery, Star and Ahlina gasped. The goddess had never spoken to any of them in this manner, and she was obviously resolute in her decision.

Clearing her throat unnecessarily, Nina turned her frown into a smile and said, “Since Kaery wants to stay, and you need to cool down, Star will accompany me on this trip to Sky’s court in Egypt.”

For a brief moment, Star forgot about the argument and jumped up for joy. She looked at her disappointed friends and realized why Kaery was so distant. *She had already known what Nina’s announcement would be.* “Thank you, your Majesty,” Star said, bowing politely as she followed her to the chariot. Star turned to her friends and shrugged with a whisper, “What? I hate kids anyway. I’m sorry, but I can’t miss this party.”

“I will forgive your insolence this time, for you have shown dedication to your duties,” Nina said to Ahlina, who stood quiet as Kaery squeezed her arm before she could give a final rebuttal.

The chariot was elegant, comprised entirely of Magick so that humans couldn’t see it. The rosewood was shiny as it glowed in the sun. This was one of the flying chariots led by a beautiful breed of red Pegasus. Their reddish-brown manes were the color of the sunset, their orange eyes mesmerized by binding Magicks that kept them in this realm until they were summoned again. As restless as the wind, they whinnied as Nina and Star boarded the chariot.

Star looked back at her friends whose blank expressions showed the injustice they felt had taken place today. At least she knew what was on their minds.

Nina seemed unaffected, as no one could challenge her decision, not even the almighty Zeus himself whom she technically served under. She was excited to see her best friend Sky and tell her about her last ten years of lovers. As she sat in the chariot’s cushioned passenger area, she ignored the emotions that seemed to radiate from Ahlina’s skin. The pain she felt was nothing compared to the pain she herself had once endured when a Supernatural whom she had brought into the world unexpectedly died. It had been an unbearable experience, and she did not

want to see more of her kind perish, so her decision was final. She refused to look back at Ahlina as she spoke to Star. “This trip is going to be unforgettable!”

“Yes it is!” Star said enthusiastically, knowing her friends were upset, but they’d get over it eventually.

*

Kaery watched without the usual smile on her face as the chariot flew swiftly away into the sunset. She knew what was going to happen next, and before Ahlina had the chance to cry or shout her feelings, she spoke. “Look at it this way, Ahlina, you won’t feel bad that this place has to come crumbling down to earth where it belongs. We must call the coven at once.”

Ahlina tilted her head slightly and looked surprised, but didn’t understand what her friend meant as they gently locked elbows while walking down the marble hall together. She wanted to speak, but her confusion was answered when Kaery uttered the words.

“Now you see why Olympus must fall.”

THE SPIRAAR AND THE GROVE

(Present Day)

With looks of utter terror, Ahlina, Scape and Kaery all backed away from the large wolf. Star seemed as unfazed as Crux, who was holding his hands in fists so tight, they were shaking.

Kaery looked around as if trying to find a place to hide from the large beast with her friends. She thought about the possibility of escaping, but she could tell there was no way they'd ever outrun the large canine. Its thick black fur gave it the appearance of a shadowy phantom, the crescent moon on its chest glowing slightly. She barely held back a scream, terrified of further provoking the beast.

"I tried to tell you guys there was a wolf stalking us when you all were arguing," Ahlina said, clinging tightly to Scape's arm as she looked around for an escape route. "What the hell is a wolf doing in Golden Gate Park anyway?"

"That's a wolf?" Star eyed the hulking four-legged beast in disbelief. "I could swear I've seen joggers with bigger dogs."

"Star, trust me it's a Spiraar," Crux said, his voice wavering.

Star looked to Crux as they all continued to take blind steps backward. His tone was so serious that she turned her attention to the large black creature and made sure to keep up with her friends' steady retreat.

"We can't run from him," Scape said fearfully, "The moment we turn our backs, that thing will rip our heads off."

"Thanks for that visual," Ahlina said, now even closer to tears.

"Scape's right, nobody run," Crux said while staring into the twitching eyes of the dark predator only a few feet away, "And I'm sorry I forgot to mention, it can understand us." The Spiraar had taken the form of a legendary wolf that was easily the size of a horse on all four paws. The beast neither snarled nor flinched before its young audience, but it looked alarmed as if wondering how these kids had noticed its presence in the first place.

"You are the guardian of this Grove?" Kaery asked in a low voice.

The black wolf focused its attention on her, staring her up and down, then giving a slow nod.

Ahlina grabbed Scape's arm even tighter. "Oh my god, it understood her! Did you see that?"

"*It is a he,*" Scape said calmly, no longer fearful of the wise-eyed wolf.

"How do you know that?" Ahlina whispered.

"My name is Rook," the wolf said in a regal manner. His mouth barely moved, but the sentence was easily understandable, and his deep tone of voice seemed to answer Ahlina's question.

"The language of Magick," Crux said. "So it is true. You can understand us?" He didn't lose his grip on the marbles in his hands. He was more than aware of the sheer power of Spiraar. The Petshas had many among their ranks whom were cousins of his. They had a fierce nature that was only rivaled by the Vampyl Shandor. The Spiraar, however, were usually peaceful until disturbed. According to the Petsha teachings, to trespass on one's Grove equaled provocation.

"Who is your leader?" Rook asked.

The teens exchanged glances, puzzled. Star didn't dare step forward because she knew for a fact that she couldn't care less about such trivial roles. Ahlina didn't understand the question among friends. Scape thought of the whole thing philosophically and couldn't come up with a sufficient answer, and Kaery remained quiet, afraid to say the wrong thing.

"Why do you need to know a leader?" she asked after a moment of silence.

"I ask because your leader is the one who will challenge me for the right to enter this sacred place," the wolf said.

*

"I am glad you accepted my invitation to train them," Gemini said, peeking through the brush at the group of young Wicasht being cornered by the great foe.

“I have not agreed just yet, my old friend.” The earthy man to Gemini’s right was blending in with the very environment the longer he stood still, his figure covered in what looked like an intricate robe of leaves and flowers.

“Gauntlets, we came all this way because they need a teacher. I cannot teach them the ways of Magick like another Wicasht can.” Gemini looked at the profile of his old friend and realized how much different he looked now that centuries of Magick practice had taken their toll on his appearance. He had once been a very attractive young man, who, with his coven of powerful Wicasht allies, formed a brotherhood. They became the Coven of Avatars, each of them from coming from a different origin coven and having a passion for specific elements. The Coven of Avatars created the first immortality spells and later became the first group of Wicasht to evolve. To this day, their transformation had the Supernaturals puzzled and envious of their great power.

The wrinkles that lined the face of the Avatar showed not only age, but wisdom that was beyond even Gemini’s comprehension. Gauntlets had chosen to become an Avatar, which meant he had endured unspeakable trials and fought fierce battles with higher powers in order to receive his title. This was truly one of the most powerful beings on the planet.

Much like Isja, Gauntlets was a peaceful soul. As far as Gemini knew, his hermetic ways had allowed him to master the uncanny Earth Magick, and he was unrivaled in its depth. Years of practice were represented by his long grey hair with stones, bark and bones woven into its braids, and while it was matted in some areas, most of the locks flowed gracefully in the fall breeze. Gemini was as intrigued now by his friend as much as he’d ever been. He knew that Gauntlets might not be the most eloquent individual, but he was wise beyond words, and when he spoke, he would be listened to.

“I see that the Coven of Unity is starting to reunite,” Gauntlets said, his stone-grey eyes watching the young Wicasht continuing to back away from the Spiraar in uncertainty.

Gemini simply nodded toward the face off.

“I will agree to train them once I see where their instincts have led them,” Gauntlets said with a warm and hopeful smile. “If they choose love, then I will choose them. But if they choose selfishness, they will be left to fate.”

“But Gauntlets, these children may make a mistake. If they don’t get your unparalleled training, then the mission is lost.”

“Your mission, though noble in nature, still has its flaws like everything in the wild.”

“Yes, but at least I’m trying to counter this inevitable apocalypse, unlike the Great Council or any of the other orders,” Gemini said in frustration. He had a deep feeling that the world’s fate was in the hands of a few children, some of whom were standing before him now. The Witchbreed were the ones who could tip the scale on this war.

“I understand your position, Gemini, trust me I do, however I will not spend a moment training the wrong people again. You remember where that path led last time?” Gauntlets asked, looking upon the handsome Mancer who had not aged one day since Pangaea. “Time looks nice on you, good friend.”

“Time is what I’m running out of.”

“Then this next battle will decide what happens to the rest of the world.” A stone and a piece of bone woven into Gauntlets’ hair began to move on their own, grinding together as he observed his prospective students.

“I know you’ve cast powerful Magick to protect them this long, but I hope you know what you’re doing,” Gemini said in a whisper.

“Hope is a great path to take.”

*

Crux thought to himself while changing his footing, *I could leap to a high branch and launch missiles upon this wolf. One clean shot, and I should be able to pierce its skull before it can attack any of them or catch me. If they die, Gemini would never forgive me. I suppose this is the real reason I was sent to keep an eye on them. Besides, I’m the closest to the Spiraar, and I have the most training. They said they remembered how to fight, but I don’t think they’ll be able to take on a Spiraar. They regenerate faster than any of the Supernaturals, using special powers granted by the animal spirits that came before them. Gaia favors them, so they are just as powerful as any other Supernaturals in the hierarchy.*

A bead of sweat ran down Crux's forehead. He could smell his soggy scalp as his blond Mohawk moved gently with the breeze. His palms were so uncomfortable and sweaty, he skipped the nursery rhymes he might otherwise have sung to calm his nerves and immediately blurted out the words.

"I am the one you want to fight." His voice cracked as he spoke, but like his Uncle Loiza, he did not falter. He glared directly into the eyes of the large wolf that hunched his back with a snarl, the eyes seeming to glow a silvery blue as the sun overhead retreated into the clouds, leaving a shadow to loom over the park.

Kaery saw Crux standing up for them, ready to die. *Does this boy really think being a martyr is his calling? He's stepping forward to be eaten alive for our sake, and I can't let this happen! I may have only just recently remembered how to fight, but I will not let someone so young step in to die for me!* She looked up to the dark sky, and as she did, a ray of sunlight broke the clouds, warming her cheeks and kissing her eyelids. She opened her eyes with a newfound understanding of her role.

"I am the leader of the Coven of Unity. If you must fight someone, it's going to be me," Kaery said, still watching the sun as if it might be the last time she'd ever gaze at it.

"No, you can't!" Crux yelled, turning his gaze from the giant wolf and staring at Kaery in her moment of strength and bravery. Her skin was glowing as if she were blanketed in a spell he'd never paid attention to before. "Kaery, I can win this fight, but I don't know if you can."

"I won't allow you to die for us," Kaery said, looking down into the terrified eyes of the Mancer boy.

"Maybe he's right Kaery," Star said in a voice that seemed to be more haunting than she intended. She regained her composure after hearing the uncharacteristic fear in her tone. "I'm just sayin', he seems to know how to fight whoever's dog this is. We have no clue."

"I know you're worried about me."

"She's not the only one," Scape said with Ahlina stepping to his side and nodding.

"You will all have to trust me," Kaery said, smiling with such warmth that it brought a few of them to tears. "I don't know why, but I know that I can't let him die today. This is my fight alone."

"Are you sure?" Ahlina asked with her hands on her friend's shoulders.

“I’m sure. You’ll have to let me go. And I hope you all know I love you more than you know.” Kaery’s golden eyes seemed to glow brighter by the second. She placed a hand over Ahlina’s and patted the top of it as if to say ‘now, let go.’ Ahlina did not want to let her best friend die like this. She turned to say something.

“I know what you think we’re going to do, but I tell you again to trust me,” Kaery said as she walked past Ahlina; she didn’t have to make eye contact to know she was crying.

“Kaery, may the spirit guides protect you,” Scape said with tears in his eyes that hadn’t fallen just yet.

Star took a step back and assumed a battle stance just in case the creature got the upper hand of her friend. She knew she was acting like a stone cold bitch, but the truth was that she didn’t want to lose Kaery, and she knew at least a dozen ways to snap this beast’s neck. The more she thought about it, the more managed to calm down. *So does Kaery.*

With every step Kaery took, a storm spread itself further across the horizon. She knew that she could very well die in this battle against the Spiraar. She had only been in one fight, and that was very recent. But she also knew that the memories playing over and over in her head would be her secret weapon. She remembered how to breathe deep into her lungs and harness the muscles that would allow her to strike the fastest. She remembered Juno’s countless attacks and the counters. She stood next to Crux and looked down at him with another warm smile. “I’ll be fine. I won’t allow you to be hurt.”

Crux heard the enlightenment in Kaery’s voice and saw the confidence in her eyes that had been long lost for ages. She was somehow using a form of self-enlightenment to stay focused. She patted Crux’s shoulder the same way she did Ahlina’s. Her touch was so soft, but it had an invisible wave of heaviness that felt as if it could smash Crux’s very soul. He stood still, knowing this fight was truly out of his league. Scape’s hands brought Crux back into his chest safely.

“I am the leader. Now, what is it that you want?” Kaery asked assertively.

“If I defeat you, then I choose whether to eat your friends or banish them from this place, never to return again,” Rook said with a hiss of tactic.

“And if I win?”

“Then you will be the new masters of this Grove and decide whether my pack and I live or die.”

“Pack?”

“There are more of us in the woods watching you right now,” Rook said, “You fight for your family and so do I.”

“Understood,” Kaery said defiantly.

Ahlna looked around the woods, trying to spot the other Spiraar. “I don’t see anyone,” she said in a whisper.

“I’ve felt their presence since the moment the wolf began speaking,” Scape said. “Very powerful guides in these woods.”

“Life or death? I choose life either way,” Kaery said, her voice rising in volume as she took the same fighting stance as Star, “Come at me.”

*

“She did it. She chose life,” Gemini said, pleased as he witnessed the selfless act of the sixteen-year-old girl. His long black hair cascaded down his back, and his silver eyes were alight with pride for her and the rest of his Mancers.

“Indeed she has. The first lesson has already been completed,” Gauntlets said without looking at Gemini. He watched as the wolf’s fur seemed to rustle like grass in a strong breeze. “The fight is upon her. If she survives, then I’ll train them.”

“We could stop this.”

“If we do, then she fails her lesson.”

Not knowing what Gauntlets was strategizing, Gemini gave it a rest and decided to place his faith in fate. *May you win, child. The world is depending on it.*

*

Rook pounced so fast, the heart of every young Witchbreed skipped a beat. His ferocious speed was blinding, and Kaery didn't see him appear behind her until it was too late. The Spiraar's jaws snapped toward her head, their spread so wide that they could easily rip her body in half with but a single bite. It seemed as if the fight would be over before it even started.

As if all the stars in the universe aligned at this very moment, Kaery saw the world quite differently for the first time. She watched the Crescent Moon Time Step technique step that Rook was using, watching him run in slow motion, noticing each instinctual gift that had been given to him. The Runes of Magick ran through the very fibers that made up this man-beast and were also visible in the clouds above.

The entire forest was full of strange lights as the Runes of Magick ran through every blade of grass, every leaf of the trees and plants. It was breathtaking, so beautiful that Kaery almost forgot she was in battle. She dropped low into the splits, then rolled backwards in one fluid motion until she was underneath Rook, and the next moment right behind him.

The jaws snapped with such force it scared her friends. Crux turned away, unable to watch Kaery being devoured. The tears that were in his eyes flew onto the dry soil at his feet as he grabbed his marbles. He didn't know how to tell his new friends to run and let him take this creature on, so he turned as if to attack. With wide-eyed anticipation, he looked upon the most unexpected sight. Kaery was now behind the wolf, and she straight-kicked him in the tail bone, sending him flying toward a large tree that stopped his flight with a heavy crash.

The dust from the Grove floor formed a cloud around Rook as he recovered and shifted into a two-legged creature easily twenty-feet tall with razor-sharp claws. His enormous chest heaved, large enough to swallow a car. The black fur was still as dark and thick as ever, and his glowing eyes tried to pierce Kaery's to no avail as he dashed toward her, ripping up the soil in his pursuit.

Kaery used combat techniques that had long been lost to the world, her movement a flurry of misdirection, parries and side-steps that allowed her to glide past every attack. As if she could see every move Rook was going to make three steps ahead of time, she evaded his every strike.

Rook howled and tore through the air as if fighting an ancient war, though none of his moves connected. He soon realized Kaery was light on her feet, deciding to use some of his innate abilities to summon the elements. The roots on

the ground shifted the closer he got to Kaery until they reached up and ensnared her feet like vipers. This was it. No more dodging his attacks. She was very quickly becoming immobile.

Kaery was too focused on the body movement and muscle motion of the wolf to notice the branches and roots of the nearby trees shifting around her feet. Her shoe became snagged and she looked up to see the jaws of the Spiraar surrounded her torso in one bite. There was no dodging.

Rook's jaws snapped on Kaery's body and tore her from the roots, sending her shoe flying into the forest. He slung her like a ragdoll into the trunk of a tree and then slammed her unceremoniously onto the forest floor.

With a simultaneous gasp, all of Kaery's friends watched in horror her bones must have been snapped, not to mention the wounds inflicted from the rows of monstrous teeth. The moment was so disheartening that Scape fell to his knees whispering, "No!"

"It looks like your leader has been defeated," Rook said in his giant two-legged form with the torso of a man, his large head peaking down into the forest at his prey.

The kids were silent. They could not believe Kaery was dead or dying, and there was nothing they could do about it. Lightning struck in the background. The storm was getting closer, and the winds were picking up. Star and Ahlina stood next to each other in their fighting stances, realizing it all might be futile. Right as they gave each other a signal to get ready, six wolves of various sizes walked out of the shadows.

Rook continued, "You have trespassed onto sacred grounds, and for that violation we will choose whether you live or not."

Kaery felt as if she were hit by the BART train and fell into the ocean from a cliff. The tree somehow stopped her impact, and she felt like it had caught her. When she landed with an ungraceful crash, the world around her was blurry. She just knew she was going to die from the wounds of the bite, but she didn't feel any broken bones. Looking down at her hands, they seemed to glow a golden color as if the sun was shining on them. She saw her t-shirt was shredded, but her bra was intact, and there was not a single puncture wound on her body. *How could this be?*

There was no time to question her current state, which as far as she could see was miraculously untouched. She ran as fast as she could up the back of the large beast and clotheslined him to the ground with so much force, it seemed as if a tree

had fallen in the forest with a thunderous crescendo. Like a gymnast, she did a back hand spring off the furry beast and landed near her friends with her back to them, her clothes shredded to the point of nonexistence. She didn't seem to be bothered by the fact that her bra was the only top she was wearing, and her jeans hung on her legs in ribbons.

"I said, no one is hurting my friends!" Kaery's voice boomed throughout Golden Gate Park as lightning struck overhead and a curtain of rain came pouring down. Her purple bangs flowed like a wet waterfall in front of her eyes. She shook and breathed deeply, still in her fighting stance. She looked around the forest at the wolves hiding in the shadows.

They backed into the forest slowly, seeing their alpha on the ground in severe pain. Bones crushed and trying to regenerate, Rook attempted to stand, but couldn't. He knew this was no ordinary Witchbreed; he'd killed plenty in his lifetime. They were manipulators of Magick, but most couldn't concentrate when he moon glide attacked them in his initial surprise. This one had somehow dodged his superhuman speed and his primal bite. When he thought of that bite he tasted blood in his own mouth. *This can't be. Some of my teeth are shattered. As if she's invulnerable.*

Kaery stood up with her back stretched, heart racing like never before. She balled up her fists and said, "Please stop this fight. I don't want to hurt you anymore. I'll do whatever you want as long as you don't allow them to hurt my friends. I don't know if they'll listen to me, but I know they'll listen to you. I beg of you." With her fists slowly becoming soft hands again, she kneeled down to nurse Rook's wounds.

Rook winced at the pain of her touch, Then he saw the golden light upon him, an extension of her hand like sunshine on a cold day. In the midst of the pouring rain, the warmth healed him faster than he had ever regenerated. "Why would you heal your enemy?"

"Because I don't believe you are my enemy," Kaery said as she healed the broken limbs of the large beast. She could feel the repair happening at an unnatural rate underneath her palms.

Rook shifted into a naked man right before her eyes, his ribs broken, the crackling sound audible over the rainfall. His tanned sand-colored skin was visible underneath thick black wiry hair covering his chest, forearms and legs. His eyes

were a soft greenish blue, staring at Kaery like she was something foreign. “Who are you?”

“I am Kaery. These are my friends.” She could not find the energy to smile as she spoke her truth. “I just don’t want them to be hurt.”

A deep and familiar voice invaded the conversation as Gemini walked into the rainfall. “So must it be.” Gemini smiled a white smile that seemed to make everyone feel more at ease.

Kaery looked up from the now human form of Rook and took her hands off his ribs. Like the Runes of Magick Kaery now saw everywhere, the figure in front of her was glowing with sheer power that radiated from his inner being like a beacon in the darkness. She was forced to pay attention to the second figure whose energy signature was the same as Mother Gaia’s.

“Meet your new advisor, The Avatar Gauntlets,” Gemini said.

“Rook is the guardian of this most revered Grove,” Gauntlets said as he came walking slowly from behind a tree. His steps seemed to be guided by the lay of the land. The dark moss-colored robes he wore looked like blankets of grass and wet earth. “He and his pack have done a wonderful job thus far.”

“Who is she?” Rook asked Gauntlets, bowing in respect.

“She and her friends are the true owners of this Grove. They are the ones you were trained to look for when the time came. She is Kaery, and this is her Coven of Unity. They set claim to these woods long before humans lived in this area, casting the Magick that allowed the Grove to be hidden for so long. Now they are back to reclaim it,” Gauntlets answered respectfully.

“What’s going on?” Star asked, stepping out of her stance and walking like a model to stand next to Kaery. Ahlina followed and stood on the other side of their best friend who would have died for them.

Gauntlets’ wise words cut through the rain like the sun rays that had parted the clouds for Kaery. “Great question, that will be answered in due time. But I will tell you, your training starts right now, and you’ve passed the first lesson with flying colors.”

PROLOGUE TO BOOK 3

ONE YEAR LATER

As Sky was beginning to waver in hand-to-hand combat, barely dodging the attacks of countless OZONE Agents in the desert sand, Maia knew she had to do something. Standing atop a dune and focusing her intellect, she telepathically disoriented the agents, causing them to falter in confusion. Gaining the upper hand, Sky circled her enemies with lightning speed and grabbed them one by one, throwing them high up into the air in rapid succession. With the agents now lying motionless in the sand or plummeting toward certain death, Sky stopped in the middle of the battlefield to rest. Maia tried to call out the mysterious figure as it crept up behind Sky in this moment of vulnerability, but her cries weren't heard. It was inexplicably difficult for Maia to send even the smallest telepathic image in this place, and she didn't know why. Before Sky could turn to defend herself, the Stealth Assassin emerged from his reflective camouflage and struck with precision, knocking her to the ground and leaving several slash marks on her chest. As he raised the glowing steel blade above his head, charging it with Rune energy for a swift execution, it was clear he was no ordinary assassin, but a Jreamer. As Sky closed her eyes to welcome the final blow, she was suddenly blinded by a flash of light, her ears beginning to ring. Without concern for the gunfire directed at him, Blue raced across the battlefield to Sky's aid as she lay in the sand, staring at the ashen shadow of the vaporized Jreamer. As Maia was watching the scene in disbelief, she noticed a small moving shadow on the ground and looked up to see a flash grenade sailing toward her. As she reached out her hand in a futile attempt to deflect the blast, everything went black.

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Maia sat against the dune in the hot desert with tears in her eyes. The pain was unbearable as she nursed the burn that had rendered her hand unrecognizable. The sky was blocked by a cloud of dark smoke that loomed like a sickness over a hospital patient. She could no longer see the stars in her palm, the once soft flesh now charred, and she cried at the thought of what it once looked like. Shaking uncontrollably, she tried to clench her blistered fist shut so she wouldn't have to look at the horror of her wounds. Feeling helpless in this moment when her friends needed her most, she mustered what little courage she had left to help them.

Sky was sitting next to her with slashes across her torso that she was somehow unable to heal. She was not the same brat Maia once knew in school, but a powerful woman who fought for her right to exist. Now her life's blood flowed from the fatal wound in her abdomen as she stared at the horizon in anguish.

When Maia looked to her strongest friend for comfort, her hope was lost. Blue was barely able to focus on anything but the pain in his own ragged body, which was covered in bruises, burns and bullet holes. Although he was physically tougher than Maia and Sky, the antimatter rounds of the OZONE agents and smite attacks of the Jreamers had left him nearly incapacitated. There was still determination in his burning blue eyes to complete the mission, though he knew just as Maia did that this was all futile. OZONE was too powerful, and it was a fact.

Time seemed to stand still as Maia went over the last year in her head and tried to understand where things had gone so wrong.

This can't be right. We've worked so hard for this moment, and the odds are totally against us. What did Gemini miss? What did I miss? Were we destined to fail like this? I should have seen this coming, but my foresight...why did it suddenly become so limited?

We have to go back for the body. Poor Crux—but how will we have a proper burial when we ourselves are lying in coffins? My friends...they depended on me to find the answers that would get Surge-Overload out of that OZONE compound...when it's my fault she was captured in the first place.

This is all such a mess. We should've run like Crux once told us to. Now look at us! Are Gemini and Jayde really not coming back? How could they have been bested by another Mancer? What would Gemini do right now? I can't keep asking these questions...He would want me to come up with solutions. Oh no, Blue

is getting ready to attack, but we aren't ready. We're going to join our friends in death...maybe they'll welcome us to the underworld, Juno and Nina too.

How do I tell Blue that I've lost faith in this plan? How do I help Sky when it seems our healing powers are useless right now? Gemini had such faith in us...Gemini...I can't let him down. If Blue stands, then so will I. Our fate lies on the other side of this wall of sand, and there's no escaping it now.

Maia looked down at Sky while attempting to bandage her wounds. Her goddess friend was smiling despite the fact that she was staring death in the face. She watched as Sky and Blue's eyes met, lifetimes of love expressed in their affectionate glances.

Seeing Sky this strong makes me feel even more insecure than I did when I first laid eyes on her in high school. After all this time, Blue still loves her, and now they're going to die together. But what about Kaery? He'll never get to see her again. This is impossible. It's not supposed to be like this.

As if guided by the same fleeting burst of energy, Sky and Blue stood up together in silence, she using one hand to stop the blood flowing from her abdomen. As if forming a discreet pact, they looked into each other's eyes, Blue giving an assuring wink as Sky kissed the air. Then he reached to Maia, helping her stand.

Ouch! My legs were singed from the explosion too? Nothing to do about it now, time to face the end.

Wait, this can't be! How did we overlook them before? This fight is already over, and those missile blasts are only getting closer. I'm sorry, Mamí, I should've said 'I love you' more often. I'm sorry, Crux. There's no way we're going to survive this, and with our deaths, the world will be doomed. It's all our fault. All of this destruction is our fault. It's my fault!

The next wave of the OZONE army launched a hail of missiles that ravaged the desert terrain and engulfed the Mancers, instantly disintegrating their flesh and obliterating the very shards of the Soulstream that had created them as an opaque white light swept over everything in sight.

(Present Day)

Gasping for air, Maia opened her eyes. Tears running down her cheeks and tremors running through her body, Maia gazed about, noticing the probing eyes of those around her as well as her own reflection in the marble floor. The ancient architecture of this familiar temple in Zalomoni and the concerned looks from her friends should have brought her comfort, but she couldn't muster the words to tell them how they would inevitably fail their quest.

Her friends were safe, watching her for some answer as to what the future held, but she was silent, unable to shake the gruesome images of their individual deaths that came with each glance.

She felt a strong sense of déjà vu as if she were reliving the nightmare from her childhood, only this one had been much more personal, much more painful to watch over and again.

"You all die again?" Gemini asked. Maia's grim expression confirmed his suspicions. "We must be missing a part of the equation. What is it?"

Despite analyzing every aspect of the plan countless times before this, it wasn't until this moment that Maia finally made a realization that caused her to rise to her feet. She suddenly knew that the Coven of Unity was the missing piece. Her soft voice still rattled with fear, she answered, "The Witchbreed!"